Kingdom of Ash

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31434809.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F, F/M, M/M, Multi

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra)

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Blood and Violence, Explicit Sexual Content

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Part 1 of Tapestry of Time

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by Faded_Glory

Summary

The First Ones are not done with Etheria. Adora and the princesses must unite one last time to bring a lasting peace. As the past and future collide, Immortal Forces seek to control the Fate the Universe.

Notes

This is going to be a long one. So get some snacks and buckle up, its going to be a wild ride.

Prologue

A new beginning...

The sun had fallen into the far off horizon long ago, taking with it the warmth and light of the day. Leaving the sky above dark, with an eternity of sparkling stars as the only source of light. Catra had watched each star come alive as night descended. Leaning against the smooth bark of a lone willow tree that grew at the edge of the hillside, that they had set up camp on. Its thick, sinewy trunk grew upward proudly at the very crest of the hill. Thousands of slender branches reach towards the sky, still heavy with elegant leaves that hang down like a natural curtain. Just starting to lighten in color as the cool season had just begun. Catra glanced fondly down at her love, sleeping softly beside her. A small, satisfied smile slowly pulling upon her lips, as she played idly with Adora's loose blonde hair. Combing thru the strands tenderly with her claws, brushing some stray locks that had fallen over her cheek, back behind Adora's ear. Catra couldn't have asked for a better outcome. After surviving the Galactic Horde and releasing the magic trapped at the Heart of Etheria. Adora was finally hers, they were going to finally be together, like she had always wanted. It had been a long, hard struggle to get here. But she never felt more content in all her life.

Adora had curled up beside her, in her maroon traveling cloak. Her hair splayed loosely around her shoulders, as she slept on her side. Since the final battle, the blonde was never very far from her. Making up for all those lost years when they had been separated, Catra assumed happily. Adora was curled up fitfully against her legs. She had her hands curled under her chin, her fingers just touching the side of Catra's thigh. The soft sounds

Adora made while she slept comforted Catra. She had missed these gentle moments of physical contact with her so much...

Then the blonde moaned and jerked her feet lightly as if running. Catra sighed and smiled softly with amusement. Petting a hand soothingly down the back of Adora's head, cradling her nape tenderly.
“Who are you fighting now, dummy.” She laughed quietly, as Adora calmed under her soothing touch.

The evening had been quiet, filled with soft laughter and small talk around a warm fire. A comforting routine they had shared for the last several weeks. They had taken their leave of the others the morning after the final battle. Wandering slowly back to Bright Moon ever since. Needing time alone, to rekindle what had been lost between them. The once unshakable bond broken for those long years by the war, was slowly being reborn into something more solid and far more intimate then before. Catra basked in each day with Adora and had sought solace every night in her arms. But for the last few days, the nights only brought anxiety and bad dreams. So she had been pretending to sleep, waiting for Adora to fall into her deep slumber, before crawling out of her embrace. Settling beside their bed to wait out the night. It was stupid but she just couldn't handle the nightmares. With the constant threat of battle no longer hanging over her. She was once again dwelling in the quiet, contemplations of peace. Her thoughts spiraling into the what ifs of her future now. Agonizing over her past mistakes and the hypothetical consequences that still hung over her head like a hangman’s noose. The weight of the guilt and regret she lived with each day, manifesting in her dreams. Punishing her harshly when she was at her most vulnerable. She would not be able to last many more days without sleep, but they would be safe in Bright Moon soon. It would be a lot easier to hide her night terrors when she had her own room. She hated sleeping alone, but she had gotten used it over the years. If she needed to be separated from Adora for a brief period to sort out her issues then she would. She never wanted to

burden Adora with her problems, they were hers to deal with. She had earned each and every one of those hidden wounds. She wondered if Adora would even allow her to have her own space? Back in the Horde it had been Catra crawling into Adora's bed almost every night. Needing Adora close at least as close as was allowed to feel secure when she slept. She had always been scared at bedtime, never trusting the shadows. Always on edge for threats, never able to relax unless Adora’s scent was surrounding her.

Catra smirked, proudly. Leaning the back of her head against the smooth bark to contemplate the stars above. Ever since Adora had saved her from Horde Prime, the blonde had never truly left her side. Sleeping just outside her tiny quarters on Darla and beside her in her own bedroll during their time hiding in the Whispering Woods, while in the Rebellion. Since the last battle at the Heart, Adora had begun to cuddle with her when they slept. Catra loved it! Being this close, snuggling, kissing and just being love sick idiots. It was everything she had dreamed of and more. For the first time in her whole life....it was perfect.

Catra sighed and smiled softly, knowing how much Adora loved her, needed her...it was the best feeling. But her contented smile soon faded into melancholy, showing weakness, being vulnerable was still very hard for her. She really did not want to burden her with her issues. She could deal with this on her own...

A low howl echoed in the distance. Calling out into the still night for an answering call. Melog's ears perked up at that uncommon sound. Snapping their head up from the warmth of Catra's lap, that they had been dozing on. Fully alert in seconds, their ice blue eyes glowing, scanning the rolling hills of the valley below. Their whole demeanor suspicious of the unknown forest that sprawled below. They had set up camp on the rim of a low valley on the outskirts of the Whispering Woods. The grasslands that sprawled just before the forest were lush and vibrant. The meadow in the valley below a carpet of wildflowers, alive with the dancing glow

of thousands of fireflies. Fluttering and floating amid the blooms, small nocturnal animals rustled amid the flora. Their timid sounds a gentle noise, compared to that unearthly howl that had just shattered the calm of the night. It had been the beginning of the hot season when they had returned to Etheria. Months had past as they fought Horde Prime, freeing countless towns and villages. Slowly unravelling his hold over the people. They ended his occupation at the tail end of that season. Now the nights were becoming cooler as the next season began to settle in. They had built a fire that had warmed them and lit the shadows beyond their camp in a soft glow. Now it had turned to coals, the dim light it gave off was pathetic and it filled Melog with fear.

“It's ok.” A soft, drowsy voice responded to their nervous energy. As a calming hand stroked low on the back of their long neck.

Melog glanced sideways finding their master's mate slowly rising from her own slumber. Her long blonde hair fluttered away from her back in a cool gust of wind. As she tossed her maroon cloak aside and sat up. No longer dressed in her red jacket. Having tossed it into the fireplace back in their room, when they were staying at the inn at Erelandia. It had been ruined by the Guardian Beast, the side of the jacket slashed and soaked in her blood. It had been the last remnant of her time in the Horde. Adora was finally ready to let go of the past and start a new life. She still wore her grey pants and white cotton, compression top with the long sleeves. That she had tailored back at Bright Moon years ago. It was similar to the old cadet uniform from the Horde, but she felt comfortable in it and was yet unwilling to try something new. So Catra had mended the rip as best she could, sewing was not her strong suit. The thread work was sloppy but tight and Adora was grateful for her efforts. Adoras red combat boots were gone. Replaced by a dark leather, calf length travelling boots that now adorned her feet. Scuffed and muddy from long days of travel. She clipped a military issue utility belt around her waist that had numerous pouches. Then swung her maroon cloak over her shoulders, pinning it in place around her neck with her wing pin. Then wrapped a thin belt that clipped over her shoulder, on top of her cloak, that had a leather sheath for a

quarterstaff. She had taken a discarded metal staff from their hidden compound before they had left for Bright Moon a couple weeks back.

Melog chuffed in solidarity, craning their head upward as Catra shifted and moved to stand. As alert to the noises as them. Her heterochromatic eyes scanning the valley intently, her ears twitching nervously, tail snapping violently. Determined to find the source of that mournful howl. Her sense towards danger was as keen as theirs. That sound vibrated against her skin with a malicious hunger. It was the sound of a predator. Melog could see the thin layer of soft fur on the back of her neck standing up, which only heightened their unease. They had been sleeping fitfully upon her lap, as she had been keeping guard over Adora for most of the night. Catra had not been sleeping well and was keeping it from her mate. They would let her try and deal with what was bothering her for now. But if sleep continued to elude her, then they would have to intercede, in their own way. She was exhausted and that made her weak, if she went into battle tonight she might make mistakes that could cost her, her life. Melog snarled softly at the thought of losing her. They had been alone for so very long, to finally have a connection to someone. They could not lose that kinship, she was the most important person in their life. They would never allow her to die! She was theirs...and they had vowed to her back on Krytis that they would always be with her, always protect her.

Catra had changed her outfit somewhat as well, when they had stopped in Erlandia for a few days, for Adora to rest. She had soon found out then, that wielding She-Ra took a lot out of Adora. After absorbing all that magic only to release it back onto the planet, she had slept for days. They had hid out in an inn during that time, simply enjoying each other's company. It was then after many long talks, that had been well overdue. More than a few tears shed between them and lots of cuddling. They decided that it was time to start over. With a fresh slate and leave as much as they could in the past. Trading their old clothes had been

symbolic, so they had gone to the garment shop, Adora had hid in, weeks earlier from Horde clones. The left leg of her old thigh high leggings had been shredded anyway, thanks to her battle with the Guardian at the Heart. So now Catra wore black leather leggings that hugged the top of her feet, a thicker leather band wrapped around the middle of her foot protecting the soft underside. Leaving her clawed toes and heels bare. She was still not sold on footwear, feeling that they only held her full movement back. She was more comfortable being able to use her claws for climbing and sprinting. Her leggings had added leather padding along the sides of her thighs and knees that looked very much like the scales of a snake. She had kept her auburn sleeveless style tunic with the short black collar. Twin belt pouches criss crossed off her slender waist and over the sultry curves of her hips. She had found her old whip from the Crimson Waste months ago, in the rubble of the old horde compound. That the rebellion had taken over in the Whispering Woods. Glimmer had blasted it away with her magic during their battle years ago. Leaving the cord frayed and burnt and totally unusable. But Catra had hidden it away under her pillow, back at her sleeping bag. Unwilling to part with it, even though it was useless. It was something she cherished, along with the fond memories of true freedom. She shared with Scorpia. Netossa had noticed her one evening, picking at the frayed cord in her lap, while the rest of the Rebellion were relaxing by the fire Glyph. She offered to repair it, as her first act of friendship. Catra had tossed it to her, with a nonchalant quip about it not really meaning much. But if she really wanted it, she could have it. Netossa had merely smiled knowingly, given it back to her during their celebration party, after Horde Primes defeat. She had strengthened the bone hilt with molded steel and re-braided the cord with her magic strings. Now the whips slender cord glowed a pure and brilliant white. It was the most meaningful present she had ever received. When Netossa had offered it to her. She had stood stiff and unsure as to what to do. But taking Perfuma’s word to heart, she opened herself up to Netossa. Giving her a tearful grin of gratitude, snatching the whip and then hugging her briefly. Before freaking

out about her sudden affection and running off. Catra smiled fondly down at her new whip, attaching it to her belt securely.

“You both need to relax, it's just some of the magical beasts waking up.” Adora sighed, casting them both a knowing smirk as she pulled her hair up into its signature ponytail. Bending down and grabbing her long metal bow staff and tucking it at her back in it's sheath.

“With all the magic returned to Etheria, the animals hibernating in the deepest parts of the Whispering Woods are coming alive again. It would only be a matter of time before all the magical creatures of Etheria returned to their natural habitats.” Adora stated confidently.

“Why is it that I am not at all comforted by that.” Catra quipped, with a thin, sarcastic smile. Pressing her hands to her hips in subtle protest. There were already animals that lived in the woods right now, that could give them trouble, some would even attempt to kill them on sight. Wondering what other strange beasts that had been sleeping for a thousand years would be like, did not make her feel any safer.

“Well if it will make you feel better we can go check it out.” Adora shrugged, her blue eyes dancing with curious excitement. Forcing Catra to follow as she went jogging away down a thin, well worn herders trail. Bounding down the side of the valley without a single care.

“That does not make me feel any better!” Catra called back with irritation. Groaning then chasing after her. Melog huffed and cantered after them both, their ears swivelled as they sought to keep track of the howls.

“Why must we always go rushing off without a plan?” Catra commented, scanning the trees nervously. As they entered into

the heavy tree line. The Whispering Woods was known for losing travelers, who did not stay on the well known trails or roads that twisted through it. Many strange tales had spread throughout Etheria about the Woods being sentient. That the trees were alive and moved when you were not looking. It was a huge mysterious forest that spanned over the Kingdoms of both Bright Moon and Plumeria. Full of grand, ancient wonders and mischievous magic, that liked to play with the unwary. It was also said that vengeful ghosts walked the deeper glens, luring travelers to their own deaths. One must be cautious and alert at all times while inside the ancient forest. Because the magic of the forest liked to play tricks and torment travellers who wandered to deep. The lights of the moons and their numerous smaller satellites were barely enough to see by, even out in the open. With the heavy forest now wrapped around them, thick and impenetrable. Even Catra's night vision was of little help, she could barely see two inches in front of herself. Melog mewled beside her, snapping their head back and forth having just as much trouble.

“Why do we need a plan, when we have She-Ra?” Adora laughed lightly, casting Catra a cocky grin. Finding her beloved grimacing in annoyance. Which only made her laugh more loudly.

“You can't depend on the power of She-Ra to magically solve every little thing.” Catra groused.

“But she's pretty amazing...right.” Adora commented back with an arrogant grin.

“Urghhh....yes...She-Ra's awesome.” Catra blushed, admitting reluctantly that she had a crush on Adora's alter ego.

Adora smirked, her eyes twinkling proudly.

Catra stopped in her tracks, forcing Adora to turn and get serious.

“What I'm saying is. You are not all powerful, Adora. I wish you would stop rushing into things.” Catra growled.

That statement caused Adora to slow, she turned to face Catra's concerned frown. Quickly halting to stand apologetically before her.

“I'm sorry...” She sighed, rubbing the back of her neck nervously. All the bad memories of nearly losing that great power and her life at the Heart flashing in her mind. She had been scared, confused and unfocused. She barely had a handle on that powerful current of magic. Her link to She-Ra was so unsteady and nearly cost her everything. If it wasn’t for Catra, she would have died at the Heart.

“Look, I get your pretty damn powerful. But neither one of us has the power to see the future. So we need to be a bit more cautious.” Catra approached her softly, cupping her face with both hands.

“I am not going to live without you anymore, got it!” She chastised moving into Adora’s space swiftly. Cupping her cheeks and then gently, pressing her forehead against hers.

“Got it..” Adora giggled, kissing Catra's button nose sweetly. Spinning around and then jogging off playfully.

“Ugh. You are incorrigible!” Catra howled, wiping her nose with her wrist. Then chased after her into a clearing. That strange howl pierced the night, long and sorrowful. Followed by an echoing call from somewhere else, nearby.

“Starting to rethink this plan...” Adora moaned, as she pressed her back against Catra's. Melog curled themselves around the young women, calling forth their powers. Their body dispersed into a clear mist and in an instant they all became translucent, as Melog cloaked them.

The underbrush just behind them rustled, twigs snapped and leaf litter exploded onto the path. As a small Thaymorian dashed out of the bushes. Lithe and agile, its hooved feet almost bouncing

over the well worn path. Dressed in a tattered light blue poncho, with an orange threaded pattern accenting the shoulders and baggy black shorts, that hung just below it's knees. It turned mid stride wielding a metal sling shot. Squinting one large, soft blue, almond shaped eye to take aim at something behind. It's antler's were not fully grown, still two sharp points, covered in velvet. Jutting out of a wild mane of light blonde hair. It's right, long ear, hung low near its shoulders, twitching upward as it kept track of what was chasing it. While the left ear was torn at the tip, the rip nearly severing the ear into two halves. It had long since healed but the disfigurement must have hurt. The muscles and nerves were damaged, so the ear was left useless, to dangle low over its shoulder.

“Leave me alone!” They squealed into the night, their movement lithe like a deer. As they twisted their torso and pulled back on the sling. With a high pitched whistle the stone released from the sling. Seconds later a sharp yelp resounded from the forest, followed by more howls. The young Thaymorian never missed a stride, racing towards the invisible trio at full speed. Slamming into Catra full force, it bounced off of her, landing with a yelp on it's backside.

Catra cried out in both alarm and pain, as she hopped back into view. Clutching her injured foot that had gotten trampled upon. Glaring and hissing down at the young Thaymorian, as she struggled to regain her composure. Adora cast her a sympathetic look before dashing to the young Thaymorian's side.

“Are you alright?” She asked, her voice trailing off in fear as a giant beast leaped from the tree line. It was huge and bulky like a bear. It's red eyes glowed menacingly down at them, saliva dripping from its long snarling jaws. The head was similar to that of a wolf but ten times the size. With no ears or tail to speak of, it was just massive, well packed muscle and covered with a mat of thick black fur. Large spines protruded down its back, that stood up, trembling with pent up energy as if ready to fly from it's body like razor sharp projectiles. It had four powerful paws that had

long claws now digging into the earth as it crouched down preparing to spring forward to pounce on them.

Melog yowled and turned bright red, their mane snapping in warning like a living flame.

“Get away from them!” Catra screamed in panic, lunging for the beasts powerful neck. Her claws fully extended as she landed on the back of its neck. It snarled and arched, attempting to buck her loose.

Catra dug her claws in deep, hanging on tight as it tore off into the forest with her clinging desperately onto it's back.

“Adora! Help!” She wailed in fright as the beast disappeared into the trees. Melog snarled and raced after the beast.

“And she gives me crap about rushing in without a plan.” Adora growled, shaking her head in disbelief.

“Stay here. I will be right back.” She turned back to the stunned Thaymorian. Motioning with the flat of a raised hand for him to stay put. Then raised her hand above her head.

“For the Honor of GraySkull!” She shouted, calling her power forth in a flash of pure light. She no longer needed to use the phrase to summon her weapon or her magic. It was just a bit of posturing to instill confidence in her abilities to protect the young Thaymorian. The eternal magic of Etheria flashed to life within her eyes. It’s brilliant glow coursed around her raised arm as the manifestation of her sword of protection appeared in her hand. A confident if smug smile pulled upon her lips, as she hovered just off the ground. Welcoming the surge of pure magic, into her body and soul. As she became Etheria's savior....its most powerful warrior...She-Ra.

The Thaymorian stared in awe up at She-Ra. Overwhelmed by the aura of pure, unrestrained magic pulsing from her body. Standing tall before the young deer hybrid, resplendent in her white and gold armor. Her skirt snapping in the ethereal wind of her magic.

She-Ra’s expression was fierce, glaring with determination towards the forest. The unbelievable amount of power she gave off, caused the Thaymorian to shiver and cower before her. Releasing a held breath of relief as she tore off after the beast. The Thaymorian clutched their small chest as their heart was hammering both in residual fear and exhalation at their salvation.

The sword of protection glowed with a radiant silver light, illuminating the forest for miles. She-Ra crashed through the trees, her long legs covering more ground in seconds then any living Etherian could accomplish. Her boots were pounding the earth, as she leaped over fallen trees with ease. Her hearing was more keen as she followed the sounds of battle. Her eyes sharper, as she focused several yards ahead. The dark bulk of the beast was stampeding through the forest, throwing itself against trees attempting to dislodge the feral cat currently clawing every inch of its face and neck. She-Ra’s lungs burned for air, as she frantically knocked stray branches aside with her forearms. Her golden bracers rang as the branches splintered and exploded under the onslaught. Desperate to gain more ground, as the beast reared and bucked, watching in horror as Catra went flying through the air. The beast roared in triumph, the fearsome sound splitting the night. She-Ra exploded into the dense glade of long grass a few moments later. Finding the beast howling and snarling, it's left eye gored out by Catra's claws. Several spines jutted out of the tall grass around Catra. With its arsenal spent, the Beast's back was now bare. It was circling the cat-woman who was now crouched before it, glaring murderously up at it. Her face was smeared with the beasts blood. Her clothes were torn in several places, a deep gash ran down her right side. Her claws were dripping with ichor.

“Catra!” She-Ra screamed, rushing the beast with her sword over her head.

Catra snapped her gaze to her and then nodded briefly, dashing away on all fours. As She-Ra's war cry got the beasts attention. Clearing the distance across the glade in seconds as the beast

reared to confront it's new threat. Catra rushed across the glade to Melog's prone body, which had a long spine protruding from their stomach.
“It's gonna be ok.” Catra whispered brokenly, “Why did you have to jump in front of me...” she glowered down at them. Melog was barely breathing but they opened one of their eyes and hummed out a soft purr, seeking to alleviate her anxiety. If this was their time to die then they had accepted it. At least they had been able to fulfill their promise.

The beast was fast, more agile then She-Ra had assumed. It reared up and back handed her before she could strike. The force of the blow, sending her flying backward and crashing to the ground. With a painful moan, she slowly sat up, clutching her head as the world spun and tilted.

“Adora!” Catra wailed, then hissed in fear as she leaped away with Melog in her arms. As another beast bounded into the glade. It's snarling maw of sharp teeth threatening Catra, glowing red eyes searching for the source of it's hate. Their eyes locked on Catra, as a third eye began to open from the center of its forehead. It glowed a brilliant blue before a scream of power building up inside shattered the air, as a blue beam of light shot out. It tore through the ground, sending huge clumps of earth skywards as it exploded towards Catra. She screamed in both alarm and utter terror, as she leaped backwards with Melog now draped over her right shoulder.

“Run!” Catra screamed, disappearing into the trees that were now set on fire from the beam of light.

She-Ra had barely regained her feet when a sudden flash of light to the right engulfed the trees. Her sight was taken in the blinding illumination as the beam ripped through the forest. The violent explosion that followed hammered painfully in her ears, she vaguely heard Catra's warning. Seconds later the concussion of the blast sent her tumbling against a tree. Her connection to She-

Ra faltered and the warrior's spirit faded. Leaving a very shaken and disorientated Adora behind. Adora could barely focus, unable to reform her sword, she crawled into cover behind a set of granite boulders. As whirling walls of flame exploded on either sides of her rock shelter, giant pieces of wood and other earthen debris hurtled overhead. As the beast continued it's onslaught of laser fire upon the glade. Streaming trails of choking smoke filled the air. Unable to summon her transformation, as her mind was churning with fear. Adora began her frantic search for Catra, as the beasts howled in desperation behind her unable to track down their prey. She was desperate as well and partially blind and deaf from the explosion. Her rage flared, blocking her even further from her powers. She stumbled through the forest, swallowing her terror, holding back her tears as she tried to calm down. She needed to focus, to harness her emotions so she could call She-Ra forth. But it was hard, her mind was spinning with fear and anxiety. She couldn't see through the smoke and every breath burned her throat. Yet she called for that power, hungered for it. It was there just out of reach, she needed She-Ra. Needed that power, that speed to save Catra.

Adora had never been enough... she was nothing without She-Ra...

She wasn't a hero...She was the sacrifice...

Grim memories of offering herself up to Prime in some desperate attempt to save Catra. If it hadn't been for She-Ra, Catra would be dead. She and her friends would have been captured and chipped and Prime would have won.

Then again, offering herself to the Fail Safe....because Shadow Weaver had convinced her there was no other way. She had come to terms with her fate then, as the Heart loomed over her. She would die there so that the magic would be set free. Adora had never mattered, she was merely the vessel She-Ra used to save the universe and she was alright with that. She was grateful enough to wield that power, to be a force of good in the universe. To be needed...

Focusing deep inside herself, she took slow, calming breaths. She needed to stay on task or else they were all dead. Thoses beasts were hunting them, she could sense them patrolling the trees just out of sight. For an instant she touched it, that unbridled power of pure magic. Then just as swiftly it flew out of her reach.

“Damn it....not now!” She snarled, balling her hands into fists as she ran without any plan through the trees. Right into the path of the partially blind beast.

She stood heaving for breath as the beast reared up, howling into the night. Adora screamed with rage and unsheathed her bow staff. Spinning it before her in an attempt to scare the beast off or shield herself from its striking claws. It swiped at her, its huge claw was lightening fast. Adora cried out in terror and ducked, rolling away. It's aim had been off, shaving the air above her head giving her an opening to dodge. Its glowing red eye burned into her, its giant mouth of sharp teeth snapped at her. Adora had no time to react as it lunged, wrapping a huge claw of it's other paw around her waist and picking her up with one powerful arm. She screamed in panic as her legs dangled uselessly. Its massive jaws split open to devour her, its hot, fetid breath seared her face. She screamed in anguish, writhing in it's death grip. Staring in terror at it's huge fangs as they glistened in the moonlight. With all of her strength she summoned her magic once again. This time it obeyed, with a blinding flash of light the sword appeared in her hand. She-Ra swung with everything she had, severing the breasts arm at the wrist. Then kicked out with her right foot, spring boarding off its gory stump into a back flip to land on trembling feet back on the ground. The beast arched and howled in pain, as She-Ra screamed and plunged her sword deep into it's unprotected chest. The light in it's good eye went dim as it collapsed to the ground before her. The Sword of Protection faded away as the beast died.

Adora collapsed, exhausted and in pain from summoning She-Ra. The glow of the burning forest flickering over her face. The smell of burnt fur and vegetation filled the air as the night turned quiet. She bowed her head in remorse, so many innocent animals had

perished in this blaze. What the hell were these beasts? She had never seen anything like them?

“Adora...” Several minutes passed before Catra's faint voice echoed to her.

Adora cried out in relief, scrambling to her feet to find Catra at the edge of the trees. Leaning tiredly against a weathered trunk, an arm wrapped around her waist. The gashes on her legs and side looked painful and she grimaced whenever she moved. Each breath she took looked labored, as if perhaps she had bruised or cracked a few ribs.

“I'll heal you right away.” Adora whispered brokenly, as tears streamed down her face. So thankful that Catra had survived.

“I'll live...Melog needs it though.” She stated, not wanting Adora to waste her strength. As Adora wrapped her arm around her waist and allowed Catra to lean against her. Shouldering some of her weight as they limped into the woods, heading towards Melog.

“What happened to the other beast?” Adora questioned.

“It just stopped and laid down a few miles back.” Catra shrugged.

“Let's help Melog first then we can go check out the other beast. I think I killed the one back there.” Adora groaned in pain, She-Ra might heal her wounds when she faded. But the residual ache in her muscles and lingering exhaustion of wielding her power could still wear her down.

“Lets not...and just say we did.” Catra muttered, casting Adora a grim look as she realized that she was tired and in pain as well. Adora had been being selfless again, hiding her pain wanting to help Catra to the detriment of herself. Catra would not allow it, she was doing just fine before. She adjusted herself, taking Adora's arm from her waist and wrapping it around her shoulders. Adora sighed in acceptance of her aid, as she leaned against her now. Laughing bitterly, at Catra's words of wanting to avoid her

responsibilities and take the easy way out. Adora shook her head and cast her a small reproachful smile.

“I really do not want to tangle with another one of those nasty things any time soon. But we need to make sure it's not going to just get up one day and attack any nearby villages.” Adora stated softly.

“Right, right...” Catra nodded, conceding to Adora. Still needing that subtle reminder to keep striving for the greater good.

They moved into a small clearing, Catra led her silently to the tall, reed grass that grew near a softly moving creek. Melog lay within the dried stocks near the muddy shore. Catra had hid him just in case she had to fight the last beast.

'Ok...lets do this.” Adora gave Catra a hopeful grin as she knelt beside Melog. Catra knelt on the other side, cupping the alien cats face in her hands, her expression grim, eyes full of tears. Melog's chest was barely rising, their breath had become shallow and their mane had begun to dim. It now clung to their neck, its normal flowing nature grown still. All colour was draining from their body, becoming a dull greyish purple.

“Hurry, Adora. I think Melog's dying.” Catra cried, tears now flowing freely down her cheeks as she cradled their head in her lap.

Adora put a hand on the spine protruding from Melog's side from their stomach, calling forth her magic. Her other hand was pressed against their ribs as she spoke in a calm, reassuring voice.

“It's going to be alright, Melog. I got you now, everything is going to be, ok.” She took several long, deep breaths. Focusing on her magic, summoning it forth from deep inside her soul. She would not let Catra down. She grimaced in concentration, as she sought to grasp onto it. Then in a flash of light, She-Ra purification aura

took hold over her. Her warm light enveloped Melog, vaporizing the spine instantly.

Her healing coursed through the magical cat. Her Etherian magic interweaves with the wild magic of Krytis that lived inside Melog. Repairing their wounds and strengthening them in ways they had yet to see. Melog mewed plaintively asking She-Ra to stop. Her power felt strange, it didn't mesh with theirs. It coursed thru them, like a million tiny sparks, sending their whole being into shock.

Catra understood and reacted quickly. “That's enough.” She shook She-Ra's shoulder briskly.

She-Ra snapped her eyes open and pulled back, her magic fading away. Leaving a very exhausted Adora behind.

Melog breathed deeply then rose to a seated position, shook their head then swiftly sneezed.

Catra grinned and flung her arms around Melog's neck in relief.

“Are those going to be permanent?” Catra asked casually as she pulled back.

Adora's smile soon evaporated as she glanced down to find a pair of wings just like Swift Winds now adorning Melog's sides. She stared down at Melog totally stunned for a moment before responding.

“I have no idea....” Adora mused softly.

Adora had used the last of her strength to heal Catra. Now the feline was crouched down near the edge of the tree line, wearily scanning the broken trail ahead. The beasts had made a fine mess of the forest. They had smashed through the trees like two Horde tanks. Leaving a swath of burnt trees and deep gouges dug in the

ground in their wake. It would not take much effort to track down where they both lay.

Adora glanced upwards as heavy clouds scuttled over the Greater moons. Her hope at tracking down the dormant beast fading, as cold drops of rain fell upon the back of her neck.

Adora quickly pulled up the hood of her cloak, shielding her head from the coming rain.

“Looks like we're going to have to postpone that hunt, princess.” Catra groused, jogging to Adora's side. Adora lifted the side of her cloak, offering the shorter woman shelter. Catra passed her a thankful smile as she cuddled in close to Adora's side. Wrapping her arms gently around Adora's waist, as the blonde shielded her with her cloak.

“Lets go gather up our little Thaymorian and find some shelter.” Adora stated, as the rain began to fall.

Catra merely nodded.

They moved slowly back into the trees with a slightly distracted Melog in their wake. They were having a bit of trouble adjusting to suddenly having wings. Their balance was a little wobbly, as they sought to tuck their wings up tight to their body. Running would be an issue for a while, but jogging they could manage. With a disgruntled growl they flicked their tail up, trying to center their balance as they trotted into the trees.

By the time they back tracked to the Thaymorian, it was huddled under a bush soaked from the rain. Adora crouched low and hustled the little deer hybrid under the other side of her cloak.

“Sorry it took us so long to get back to you.” She apologized.

“She-Ra say stay, so Finn stay.” He offered in a sweet voice. Peeking up from her side with wide, innocent sky blue eyes.

Adora moaned at the cuteness. She was in love instantly. Catra rolled her eyes, digging a few claws lightly into the flesh of her hip to get her attention. Adora squealed and snapped her gaze sternly down at Catra, who was hunched in her cloak. Her arms wrapped around her waist and resting her head against the side of her breast.

“We are not keeping him.” She stated firmly, scowling up at Adora. Adora thrust out her lower lip in an endearing pout

“Where are you from kid?” Catra asked, glancing around Adora's breasts down at the kid. Hopeful that it was nearby so they could just drop him off.

“Nowhere.” Finn huffed.

The kids gruff, negative response took both women by surprise.

“Then where were you headed before those things came after you?” Adora inquired.

“I've been taking on jobs between Erelandia and Elberon, since I lost my home.” He sighed.

Catra moaned at the reminder that she had been a Horde Soldier during that first raid. Thaymor had been sacked at least once more by the Galactic Horde. She wondered if the Thaymorians had tried to rebuild since then?

“So where is your family then?” Adora prodded gently, now worried about the answer.

“Dead.” He stated, holding onto her side a bit tighter.

Adora instinctively wrapped an arm protectively around his small shoulders.

“Ok, then. You can stick with us as long as you want then.” She blurted out, not even glancing down at Catra for consent. As she could feel the smaller woman now shivering against her, small

moans escaped thru tight lips, as she tried to hold back her tears of remorse.

The faint light of the moons were hidden behind a heavy blanket of clouds, as the rain beat down upon the Whispering Woods. The air had become freezing as they moved briskly through the gently rolling hills of ancient forest. They didn't speak, Adora had her hood pulled up over her head, scanning the way before them, for any kind of shelter. Finn was trotting under her cloak, his small hands clutching her hips tightly. Catra shivered against her other side, ducking her head out impatiently from the cloak, to look around from time to time. But she hated getting wet and hissed and quickly ducked back under Adora's arm. Her tail was swishing in agitation, swinging the hem of the cape back and forth behind them. Melog padded into view a few meters ahead, having gone scouting a while back. Their ignited mane glowing a brilliant blue, mewling excitedly at Catra.

“Follow Melog, they found a cave on a small trail just to the north.” Catra grinned.

“That's great, lead the way. Melog!” Adora called happily. Jogging towards the magical cat as they led the way.

The old forest that once pressed up against them began to thin. As the ground started to rise, a more rocky trail came into view. The trail was thin and twisted up the side of a barren, battle scarred hill, now covered in scrub grass and loose stones. The wind began to pick up, roaring down upon them. Sending the cold rain like a sheet of ice against them. Adora wrapped both Catra and Finn tighter against her with her strong arms. Grimacing and turning her head to the side as her hood was flung back by the wind. She squinted against the rain's painful onslaught, gritting her teeth as her skin began to sting and burn from the freezing pellets. She stubbornly forced her eyes open, barely able to follow the faint light of Melog's glowing mane. As the base of a granite wall suddenly rose up right in front of her. She sucked in a

thankful breath as the pale glow of Melog's tail swished out of view into the cave. It was completely dark inside, it smelled damp and musty like the catacombs beneath the waterfall back at Bright Moon. Melog stood a few feet away, their mane and tail glowing softly. Illuminating the small, cramped cave, in a pale blue effervescence. As Finn dashed eagerly out from Adora's cloak. He was digging in the deep pockets of his shorts. Presenting them with a set of flint and steel with a proud grin.

Catra already had some tucked away in one of her own belt pouches but she was just too tired to comment. She would let the kid have his heroic moment, even if it was rather pointless. She moved swiftly about the cave along with Adora. Using Melog's meager light to gather large stones, dried wood and leaves. Soon they had a small fire started, filling the interior with flickering light and warmth. Adora was quick to lay her cloak out flat upon the earthen floor to dry. The smoke curled up around the roof and was sucked out of the mouth of the cave by the howling wind. Catra sat herself down before the fire, pulling her knees up to her chest and wrapped her arms around her legs. Her ears drooped and her tail swung limply around her ankles, wet fur shimmering slightly in the firelight. She was shivering and glowering at the fire. Her eyes were unfocused, heavy with exhaustion. Adora settled down beside her, releasing a long, thankful sigh. She was so very tired her whole body was throbbing with a bone deep ache from not only She-Ra, but also from trudging through the cold rain for the last hour.

Finn sat on the other side of the fire, drawing in the dirt with a stick by the flickering light. He quickly got bored with that and crouched near the flames, poking his stick into the coals.

“Stop that!” Catra shouted, not wanting him to accidentally kill the fire or worse send a flaming log his way and burn himself.

Finn stood up and rolled his eyes, flinging his stick against the back wall of the cave. It whistled and made a dull thwack in the darkness as it struck the back of the cave.

“Relax Cat-lady.” He yawned. “I know what I'm doing around fire.”

Catra merely glowered at him.

He ignored her and yawned even bigger.

Most of the night was gone and the sun would be up soon. Figuring they should try and get a little more sleep. Adora decided to take things into her own hands.

“Lets get you settled, then.” Adora rose and picked up her cloak. They had been warming themselves for a long time it should have dried. She snapped the cloak out twice, making sure the last of the moisture was gone before crouching beside Finn.

He turned in confusion, as she wrapped her cloak around him. Ushering him down onto the ground and tucking him in tight.

“Get some sleep, Finn. Ok.” She smiled warmly down at him. The Thaymorian was wide eyed at first, not knowing how to react to such sudden kindness. Adora’s mothering was surprising but not unwelcome. Finn hummed and snuggled deeper into the cloak, with a nostalgic smile. “Thanks, She-Ra.” he sighed, closing his eyes.

“My name is Adora.” She brushed her finger's tenderly down his dirty cheek.
“That's pretty...” Finn responded in a breathy sigh, falling asleep.

Catra watched the tender motherly moment between Adora and Finn with mixed feelings. She never voiced her opinion about it, knowing it was tainted by her toxic upbringing by Shadow Weaver. She had never known that gentle, unconditional loving touch from a parent as a child. It made her angry and very sad at the same time, knowing that she had missed something very important. Instead she watched the fire, spell bound by its warmth as Adora snuggled up just behind her. Laying down on her side and resting her head on her bent arm. Melog began to purr,

their rumble was low and vibrated with subtle intent. Catra's eyelids grew unbearably heavy as they fluttered closed, she felt her chin nodding forward, as sleep tried to claim her.

“No!” She snapped her head up, refusing to give into Melog's subtle coaxing to go to sleep.

Melog yowled in displeasure. (You need to sleep) Their deep, soothing voice echoed in her mind. (Let me help you. I am here, Adora is here. Even if the bad visions come. You are safe...You will never be alone again.)

“I'm scared,” Catra hissed back, glancing down and behind. Finding Adora was already fast asleep, the heat of her breaths were even and soft against her lower back. Thankful, that she could still hide how much of a coward she was.

Melog rumbled a more insistent purr. (You were reckless tonight, your fighting was slow, sloppy. If you do not get rest...it won't be me that gets hurt next time. It could be you...or your mate!)

Catra groaned and flicked her tail in anger, glaring back at Melog. Who was several yards away near the back of the cave, their sleek body mostly concealed in shadows. She could just make out their ancient blue eyes, glowing at her sternly.

Catra moaned in dread and settled down next to Adora, curling up against her chest. Adora instinctively draped an arm over Catra's side, drawing her lithe body up against her. As Catra's breathing slowed, succumbing against her will, as Melog's low purr forced her to fall asleep.

He had been so enraged by her betrayal, barely keeping his cool. As he sat stiffly on his throne, staring down at her with a cold expression. That was a mixture of both disbelief and immense disappointment at her behavior. He had been confident that after

his demonstration at what happens to those who he deems impure was enough to curb her insolence. He would need to purify her now,, bring her to heel so that she would be of proper use to him. With her hands bound behind her and forced to kneel before him. All Catra had to fight against him was her own arrogant snark, it would be her final act of defiance. Throwing his own words back in his face.

"As you have said...We Etherian's are so emotional!" She shouted back with a bitter, maniacal laugh. Barely finishing her insolent remark, before he had finally lost his precious control. Jumping up from this throne with a malicious snarl, he backhanded her violently across the face. Her mask went flying across the dais, ringing away into the darkness. As her head snapped to the side by the concussive force of his strike. She spat up blood, the point of her fang slicing the side of her lower lip. Chuckling harshly with self satisfaction she threw her head back with a wide manic grin. Glaring defiantly up at Prime as he seethed over her. Her vision of him was blurry with tears, her head throbbed painfully as her heart hammered in her chest with rising terror. She had faced death many times over the last few years, but it had never been more certain then right now. She had even welcomed the peace it would bring. She had messed up her life so thoroughly, lost everything and everyone that ever mattered to her. Thanks to her anger and cruelty she was completely alone and no one was going to come to her rescue. This was the punishment she deserved. Yet, she couldn't help the overwhelming fear that washed over her. Her heart was hammering against her chest in time to the pounding throb in her head.

"It is unfortunate, but all beings must suffer to become pure..." Prime whispered vehemently, quickly regaining his calm. As he rubbed the flat of his hands down the sides of his thighs, smoothing down the wrinkles in his white robes. His expression evening out to that placid calm, that infuriated Catra.

"Little sister...you will be useful to me yet." Horde Primes velvet soft voice echoed, just beyond the haze of rage and fear that had come to define the whole of her being. As he leaned down and

cupped her cheek. A smirk of triumph upon his face, taunting her, as she was roughly hauled back to her feet. The guards escorting her away from his presence, at a rapid pace. With her ears ringing and head swimming from Primes assault, she was left dizzy, her feet stumbling forward, as they led her down the corridors' to her fate.

Prime, looming over her . Having backed her up at the edge of the reconditioning pool, his arms were folded over his chest. As a smug, triumphant smile slowly spread over his stern, aristocratic features.

His acolytes were hovering out of sight in the darkness beyond, their voices chanting.

"Cast out the shadows, Cast out the shadows!"

Catra's heart was pounding in her ears, as terror and helplessness held her in its iron grip. Then Prime's hand lunged out, grasped her around the neck and hauled her off her feet. She cried out in renewed terror, as his finger's clenched around her throat. The metal claw on his index finger, piercing her flesh. She could feel the wet trickle of blood, trailing down the back of her neck. As he slowly squeezed tighter, cutting off her air and forcing her to make weak, gurgling sounds. As her legs kicked uselessly, her torso writhing at his mercy.

A mercy that would never come...

"You belong to me now, little sister." He snarled in her face then tossed her roughly backward.

She struck the green liquid and sank immediately like a stone. The water was strangely thick, pulling her down. She raised her arms over her head and kicked upward with all her might. Twisting and pulling at the ropes binding her wrists, as the heavy, cloying liquid tried to drown her. Her instincts were screaming at her. To claw threw the viscous matter to the surface. It was sad and ironic.

That even now, she could not accept her fate without a fight. She crested the surface with a gasp, darting her gaze around the deep shadows that surrounded the pool. As the eerie chanting continued to echo from within that darkness. The only person that remained within the light was Prime. He stood at the edge of the pool, offering her a calm, arrogantly benign smile with his hands clasped demurely before his waist. Patiently waiting for her to succumb in the purification process. She could see her arms outstretched, her gloved hands curled in agony. As lightning sparked violently around her, exploding threw her. As the toxic waters of Horde Primes purity bath burned her skin, wiping away all that she was. She could hear her own piercing screams, her strangled cries echoing as if from far away. It was the worst pain she had ever experienced. Every nerve in her body was set on fire. The searing agony of viral tech, now crawling through her veins. That would soon numb her body, so that she would be more malleable to the procedures that awaited her. The tech infecting her body would eventually activate, so Prime could control her mind and body after the chip was implanted. Millions upon millions of tiny invaders, penetrating her body, violating every aspect of her. Taking away her free will, her voice, her thoughts, her life... all of it lost to the unending pain until there was nothing left of her. All she could do was scream and flail in that glowing green pool until she was pulled beneath its surface again and all went white.

When next she awoke, she was greeted by the stinging cold against her bare skin. The thin layer of her fur was soaked, the electricity from the bath still humming over every inch of her naked body. The room she was locked up in was shrouded in darkness. She could not see them, but she could hear them. Primes clones were moving around her, behind her. An ever present threat, that hummed unseen all around her. It made her gasp in fright, as she felt them draw close. Her pulse to quicken with rising, unrelenting anxiety. She couldn't move, laid bare before them. Forced to stand upright, on some strange open

cage. Her arms were shackled to two curved metal arm rests. Her legs restrained into broad metal cuffs in the rounded floor of her cage. Her back pressed against cold metal that only went as high as her shoulder blades. The sounds of machines whirring and beeping, driving her increasingly towards panic. An oppressive presence moved around her, lurking just behind. Then the loud, abrasive hum of equipment assaulted her ears. Her hair was being sheared, the weight of it falling away leaving her neck bare and unprotected. She could feel someone hovering behind her shoulders. The ghost of their finger's brushing lightly against the back of her bare neck. The slight pull of her skin as the stranger sliced into her flesh. She tried to scream to writhe, against what was happening. But she found she couldn't move, her body didn't respond. The odd pressure of wires and metal being inserted beneath her flesh. Made her shiver, her mouth opened and closed, gasping helplessly. Her mind was sluggish, unable to grasp onto any coherent thoughts. She could hear the soft clicks of the chip being assembled just out of view, behind her neck . She wanted to scream, desperate for her body to move. But it was limp and not responding to her commands to move, to flee, to fight. Anything to stop what was happening against her will. Her heart hammered painfully in her chest, as panic set in. She was helpless, her body broken and completely at their mercy.

A mercy that would never come...

Then a sharp pain exploded down her spine, as the chip connected to her spinal cord. This time she screamed and arched her back off the metal, at a violently sharp angle. As the most excruciating pain ripped through her. She quickly blacked out, grateful for the respite from the unrelenting agony of being awake. It was then she had dreamed of Adora...her beautifully sweet smile. Her soft, blue grey eyes. So full of understanding and forgiveness. Her gentle hand outstretched towards her, offering salvation. Catra's deepest, most heartfelt wish had come true... Adora had come for her. As soon as Catra clasped her hand, Adora had drawn her up off her knees, pulling her into her chest. Her

strong arms embracing her tightly as Catra broke down, sobbing loudly against her shoulder. Wailing her apologies over and over again, as if that was enough to absolve her of her sins. In time her sobs eased, her tears falling silently down her cheeks. It was then Catra had drawn away from Adora, staring down nervously at being so weak and vulnerable. Only to have the woman cup her wet cheek with a tender hand. Drawing her close, pressing her lips against hers lovingly. The prospect of finding hope and love, with Adora, was a soothing balm upon Catra's wounded heart. Adora had come, she did not hate her. Catra had thought she had lost everyone, that no one cared about her. The dream had been so vivid, so pure and perfect. She honestly believed it was really happening. Adora had saved her and taken her away from this hell...this darkness...this pain....

"Little Sister..." Primes voice filtered softly through the euphoric haze of her dream. The slow realization that she was still shackled in Primes lab, that it had all been just a hopeful fantasy. Shattered her so completely, her chin dropped to her bare chest and she gritted her teeth, as heavy sobs rocked her body. Everything hurt, with a bone deep penetration that was beyond anything she had ever experienced before. She was a battle hardened soldier, she had endured pain far greater then most but this....this defied all reason. It felt as if her very soul had been stripped bare and lay, flayed, broken and bleeding before Primes scrutiny. She could feel him, standing before her naked body. Barely lucid she could smell his stench. It was vile. Like decay...something wholly unsavory. He had defied death for far too long, until he had become something unnatural. The dry smell of rot clung to his skin like a thick musk. Making her scrunch up her nose in disgust. She blinked sluggishly, rocking her head drunkenly from side to side unable to focus her eyes. He looked down at her, his multiple eyes taking in every inch of her body. His gaze was purely clinical, he was neither revolted or enticed by her. To him, she was merely a tool to be assessed.

"I have not met a creature like you for over a thousand years. You stood up to me and seemed to have no fear of doing so, even

though you knew that I would win. You were willing to give up everything...just to defy my will."

"You will never have her..." Catra could hear herself whisper, too exhausted to shout, too exposed to be cocky. "She' safe...safe...I would give up my life for her.....always." She slurred weakly, her entire body humming with residual agony from the implantation of the chip. Wallowing in the misery of losing that beautiful dream life, she had experienced briefly. She was at peace with her choice to sacrifice herself, she had fulfilled a sacred promise and in the end that was all that mattered to her.

Catra gasped and cringed in fear, as Primes long bony fingers brushed lewdly down her cheek. The metal claw of his index finger dragging down with malicious intention. Moving lightly down her slender neck and gripping the base near her shoulder fiercely for a moment. His green eyes staring down at her burning with a cold fury. Catra moaned as her air was suddenly constricted, squeezing her eyes shut. Then he chuckled and clutched that hand to his chest as if wounded. "Now, now, Little Sister. "He cooed, regaining his composure.

"I know you had hoped she would have come. That she would have saved you from my light. But as you can see, it has been days and she has never shown. She never cared for you...never loved you. She has completely abandoned you, now."

Catra whimpered piteously, her lips stretching into a bitter, broken smile. As she forced herself not to cry openly. Prime gripped her chin and forced her to meet his steely gaze. She quickly concealed her weakness behind a heated glare. As she was forced to look up at him, she was determined to remain defiant until the very end. Even as her heart finally shattered, knowing without a doubt that she did not matter. That the person she cared for more than anything in this world. Had left her to endure this hell and that she ultimately deserved it!

"I believe it is time to relieve you of all that pain." Primes eyes flashed a pure white, gleaming with a frightening intensity, his

smile was cold and calculating.

Catra's eyes flew open in abject terror as they began to glow green. She could hear her anguished cries ripping from the throat, echoing in the darkness, but could do nothing to fight against him. Her body lurched in the restraints, her defiant cries were growing weak and pathetic, as tears streamed down her face. Prime ripped away what was left of her tattered dignity, revealing the truths that lay deep inside her heart, violently penetrating her vulnerable soul.

Breaking her in every way a person could be broken.

He invaded her mind, touching every memory of Adora that had once been cherished. The gentle moments of comfort in Adora's bunk, when the rest of the squad was asleep. The joy of running the halls of the Fright Zone and wrestling as children. The hidden moments when Adora had found her hiding spots after being punished. Holding her close, soothing her pain and making her feel wanted.

"NO....you can't have them...their mine....she's mine!"Catra heard her soul cry out. As the memories faded into the light.

The years passed as they grew up, her feelings for Adora becoming more complicated and more passionate. Those awkward moments of adolescence filled with blushing, hopeful smiles, almost touches and yearning for Adora. Keeping that love hidden behind a fascade of playful banter and fleeting touches of her tail. Their long talks at dusk up at the very top of the fortress on their platform. Sitting side by side, their pinky fingers almost touching, almost entwining. Sharing secrets, bright laughter and dreaming together about the future. Promises to never leave each other, to always protect one another whispered in the twilight. Catra screamed in agony as Adora's face began to fade. Her beautiful smile, that had always given her hope. That one day they would be free of the pressures of being soldiers, of going to war. That one day they would be in charge and then she could

profess her love without the worry of punishment. That one day Adora would want her, love her...in all the ways she craved.

“Don't take her away! Please...don't take her...” Catra pleaded brokenly, knowing it was pointless, knowing she could do nothing to fight against his will.

“ Dear, little sister. She has caused you nothing but pain...you need to let her go. You need to come into my light so that you may be saved.” Primes voice was soothing, intoxicating. As he dove deeper into her memories, pulling forth the torment of being rejected again and again. By the only person she had known as a mother. Of striving for acceptance, for affirmation, for scraps of affection, but always being shunned and over shadowed by Adora’s greatness. Of being abandoned by the one she loved on the Plains of Thaymor. The grief and the ever growing rage, of not being enough for anyone. That she would so easily move on with her life, find happiness with new friends and leave her behind without a second thought. Of being scared and resentful, at how unfair she was being treated. As Adora stood by and watched, as Shadow Weaver punished her when they got caught in her sanctum as children. Of being humiliated by her during training sessions when they were older. Of never being good enough to be praised for anything. Perfect Adora.....Worthless Catra....

Prime was striping away all her defence's as he admired her broiling rage for never being good enough for anyone. At having everything she ever wanted taken from her. The years of abuse at the hands of Shadow Weaver. The ache of her broken heart, the jealousy, and the wrath that were her only companions during her time in the Fright Zone after Adora left. Her misery, loneliness and constant fear on his ship. Her contempt for him, for Adora, for Shadow Weaver, for Hordak, for everything and everyone who had ever hurt her....rejected her....left her. Her own self loathing, that had festered and slowly consumed her. Until all she craved was death... He tore everything away from her, leaving her shivering and utterly and completely violated.

She felt a warm liquid surrounding her, it was soothing against her skin, after how raw and bruised her body felt. She slowly opened her eyes. Able to focus for only a moment, she could vaguely see her bare hand pressed up against a glass container. She was trapped beneath more glowing green liquid, as if she was in some kind of alien womb? How she was breathing it, she could not understand. What lay beyond the glass was unintelligible. She felt an odd fleshy appendage connected to the back of her neck, that trailed into the back of the container. Her unconscious mind was screaming with rage, hate and revenge for what had been done to her. Prime had forced himself inside her, destroyed who she was and left nothing but a mindless husk behind. Unable to deal with the trauma of what had been done to her. Her rational mind locked itself away. Replaced by a delirious, confused state of being in which dream and reality blended. In time her eyes closed, too tired to remain awake. She existed now, only in this pale light, as peace and tranquility reigned supreme. Then the rush of memories of countless clones overwhelmed her mind as she struggled to regain consciousness. All she could see, feel, remember was the unrelenting cog of war. The endless deaths of thousands upon thousands of civilizations. The countless worlds laid waste by the Galactic Horde, for over thousands of years. The endless waves of clones and bots, flooding worlds and burning them away to ash, for the Glory of Horde Prime. The trauma of countless eons of violence and bloodshed, shattered her will completely.

She was so very tired...now...she craved the oblivion that was Primes light. In which only her body was alive, but her sense of self would be gone forever.

Her true self had retreated, Catra lay hiding in the deepest parts of her consciousness. A traumatized spirit drowning in sorrow and regret at the suffering she had caused. Her life had been a mistake...she was a failure. She had wanted so desperately to be seen as worthy. Taking the path of fear and intimidation to get what she wanted. Since love had always eluded her, confused her, made her feel weak. She could not make Shadow Weaver take pride in her accomplishments, she could not achieve Hordak's

trust or respect. She was heartbroken and so very tired of enduring one rejection after another. Of being abandoned, forced to fight for everything she had ever wanted only to have it taken away. So she had given into her darkness...again and again because it was easier. She had betrayed Entrapa...sent her to die. Pushed Scorpia away, unwilling to trust her heart to anyone...even though she had been the only person that had stayed by her side, the only one who had believed in her...Scorpia had deluded herself that there might be goodness inside of her. But in the end she lost it all, in the end there was no one who cared about her. Adora had never loved her...she had left her, broke her...never needed her... this turmoil shredded her heart and left her soul dead. She no longer cared what became of her. She had destroyed every relationship she ever had. There was no one who cared about her anymore. The harsh truth was she had mattered to no one.

She was a monster....and all she did was hurt people...

Yet she couldn't seem to grasp onto even those tortured emotions for long. All of her sins slid away into that shared void of the other clones, leaving her in a strange state of mindless euphoria that wasn't real. She wondered if perhaps this was her proper punishment, to relinquish all control to another. Perhaps in this way she could atone...

It was Catra's small, cries of distress that called to her. They were so desperate and full of sorrow, that Adora was instantly roused from her sleep. Her blue eyes fluttered open, then she gasped in fright. Finding Catra had pressed herself up tight against her front, as if trying to hide. Her face was tucked just under the crook of her neck. Her breath was hot and shallow, as she panted for air. Strangled cries and heart breaking sobs issued from her trembling frame. Her arms clutching desperately around Adora's back, seeking something to hang on to. Her hands curled over Adora's shoulders, claws flexing and retracting. Adora was not as oblivious as others thought. She had come to her own conclusions

over Catra's nightmares. She believed Catra was reliving her days of torture at the hands of Prime. Adora had witnessed Catra endure these night terrors before. She had them almost nightly just after her rescue from Primes ship. Adora had spent weeks holding her at night, comforting her. Gently drawing her awake and reassuring her that it was all over, that she was safe and that they were going home. It had been months since she had that last nightmare...at least as far as Adora knew. Adora cringed at the sharp pain of her claw tips poking into her flesh, but quickly pressed a soft kiss to her temple. "I'm right here...I love you...please come back to me." She whispered lovingly into her ear. Catra merely moaned in her sleep, her ear flickering and then pressed them back against her head. Her whole body quaking with the turmoil of her emotions.

Catra slid deeper into her own mind, imprisoned there. As her body wandered Horde Primes ship. Pleased to wear the robes of an acolyte, she sought only to obey and bask in the praise given by her Lord, when she completed her tasks to his satisfaction. She was a part of the Hive mind, a soulless drone. Seeing nothing but what the Lord Prime wanted, hearing only his thoughts above the thousands of other voices of his little brothers. Catra no longer existed and as scary as that might have been, she could no longer care about it either.

"My you are quite the pathetic little kitten now?" Double Trouble crouched before her, As she cowered naked and alone. In a world of pure white, her face cast downward seeking to avoid them. They leaned down and ducked their scaly face into view, refusing to be ignored. That same self satisfied smirk firmly in place. They offered her their hand to help her up. She ignored them for a moment then reluctantly took their hand, her eyes were uncertain, scared, searching theirs for answers.

“Look at yourself, sweetie?” Double Trouble spun her around by the shoulders.

She yelped, suddenly overpowered by their forceful pushing. Her voice faltered into a strangled cry as she was confronted by the corrupted version of herself from the portal. All the terrible memories of what she had done flooded through her. Her selfishness at being willing to destroy everyone just to change the world to suit herself. Her pain and rage at Adora when things didn't work out to her liking. How she couldn't deal with the trauma of both loving and hating the same woman. Her fractured self burned and vaporized before her. Replaced by the new, broken version of herself. Wearing the white robes of Horde Primes clones, her hair cut short, her eyes turned sickly green. Her once pained expression softened and turned to complacent stone. All that was washed away, leaving nothing, not even her name.

Catra would give anything to have that pain back...anything was better than not feeling...it was like being dead while still living...

“Is this what you truly wanted?” Double Trouble asked sadly.

“No!” Catra screamed, twisting out of his grasp and lunging for him. Double Trouble merely smirked and laughed as they danced out of her reach fading into the white world beyond.

Leaving her once more cowering and wailing against her self made prison unable to escape.

“It is time to heal....time to let it all go...” A softer, elegant voice echoed to her from just beyond the white. A tall silhouette stood just on the boundary of her consciousness. Long hair fluttered around two majestic wings, before fading away.

Catra gasped and her eyes snapped open. The sudden shift from sleep to being awake was frightening and jarring. Adora's scent was the first thing she recognized. It was soft and warm, it always

reminded her of sunshine. It was the first sense to begin to ground her back into reality.

“I got you...I'm not letting go.” Adora sobbed against her ear, her arms wrapped tight around her back. A hand securely holding the back of her head, pressing her face against Adora's breasts. Adora's other hand petting soothingly down her back. As Catra sobbed brokenly against her. The pain and heartache she was releasing was so powerful that her whole body was convulsing with the act of purging it from her soul. She felt completely shattered inside. She had never cried so hard in her life, clutching madly at Adora's back. Her claws digging into the flesh on Adora's shoulder blades as she soaked the front of her shirt with her tears.

“I got you...I love you...I got you...” Adora began repeating, crying herself. Her finger's now tenderly stroking the back of Catra's head, her other hand pressed flat against Catra's shoulder blades pushing the feline tightly against her neck. As she kissed Catra's forehead, her temples, her cheeks, her neck, any place she could find. Seeking to soothe her with her words, her touch and her love.

In time Catra began to calm down, she grew quiet and soon the tears were flowing silently down her face. Her eyes were distant, still dealing with the trauma of her past sins and what Horde Prime had dealt her. Pressing her face against her beloved's neck, taking several trembling breaths, until she felt ready to face Adora again.

“Sorry...” Catra whispered in a broken, raspy voice, slowly pulling away just enough to press her forehead against Adora's. Adora cupped her cheeks with both hands and smiled warmly at her.

“I never want to hear that when I'm comforting you. You have nothing to be sorry for.” She whispered, directing her chin with a hand. Pressing her lips sweetly against hers, the passion and understanding unmistakable.

In time Catra turned away from Adora, her back now pressed up against Adora's front. The blonde's strong arms still wrapped securely around her waist. Laying quietly, lost in her own thoughts. Catra glanced around, watching the shadows from the fire dance upon the stone roof and dirt floor. Catching sight of Melog curled up nearby, one eye open watching her protectively. The vibration of their purr turning to one of comfort, resounding threw the cave. Their new wings now curled around their lithe body giving them more warmth. On the other side of the fire, wrapped up in Adora's cloak was their new ward. Finn was curled up tight, knees tucked against his chest. His sweet face relaxed as he slept, breathing deeply. He seemed to have slept straight through her less than dignified break down. She was very thankful for that. Adora had held her lovingly during the worst crying jag she had ever had, soothing her fears and comforting her in all the ways she needed most. But she promised herself that no one else would ever see her so vulnerable. She felt embarrassed and angry at herself. Her cheeks heated as she chastised herself over being so weak. Then her thoughts fell upon the guilt of being involved in the attack that had killed Finn's parents. It weighed heavily upon her heart. Some days all those sins from her past, that lay festering in the back of her mind, seemed to crush her. How was she supposed to heal herself from all that? How was she supposed to atone for it all? It seemed so unobtainable...

“....things can never be easy.” Catra moaned, brushing a finger under her eye to wipe away a stray tear.

Moonstone

The cool wind rushed through Adora's cloak. Making it snap and whip violently at the backs of her legs. As she walked a narrow path of scorched earth, that wound around the edge of a small glade. The clumps of tall grass that had survived, was huddled around the thick base of elm trees. Yellowed and wilted, their tips blackened by the flames that had torn through the forest last night. She lightly brushed her fingers across the scars, gouged into the rough tree trunks as she past. Those beasts had really made a mess of the forest. They had burned down great swaths of the vegetation in this valley, tore up the ground and smashed down acres of ancient trees. The miles upon miles of destruction reminded Adora of a Horde attack and that left a very unsavory taste in her mouth. She had believed that all this fighting was behind them. That now, they could focus on the future without worrying about threats. They had been planning a trip into space to help other worlds reclaim their magic. Whimsical plans forged around a fire glyph with all her friends, during the victory celebration. The rebellion had held the night after their last battle. But those plans would have to be postponed. It seemed Etheria was still not completely saved.

The clouds above were thin, glowing pink and orange, illuminated from beneath by the rising sun. Catra hadn't spoken a word all morning. Her face was a mask of sullen contemplation. She had doused the fire and headed out of the cave with Melog on her heels at dawn. When Adora had awoken a little while later, she found her sitting just outside, petting Melog absently. She sighed and moved quietly to sit beside her on the hillside just beyond the cave. Offering her support and comfort with her silent presence. Wrapping an arm over Catra's shoulder. When she felt the tip of

Catra's tail brush against her thigh. Watching the sun rise over the forest below. Catra released a tired sigh, slowly resting her head against her shoulder.

“Your nightmare last night, was it about Prime?” Adora asked softly.

“Yes...but it was also more than that.” Catra offered, her eyes diverting towards the distant valley that stretched below. Adora waited, wondering if she would reveal any more of the torment her mind had put her through last night. But Catra refused to offer more than that, silently brooding. So they sat there in silence, Adora accepting that it was just too painful for her to open up about it now. The fear and grief was still too fresh and speaking about it would only aggravate the wounds. She was still trying to heal. So Adora merely held her close, as they watched the sunrise, until Finn's bright chatter from inside the cave alerted them that the kid was awake.

Now, Catra stayed several yards ahead of them refusing to look at either her or Finn. She was brooding and that never led them anywhere productive. It had been months since Catra had broken down like that, not since their time on Darla, just after her rescue. When her trauma had been so raw and fresh. She had been too exhausted both emotionally and physically to hide her pain. She had allowed Adora to see her at her most vulnerable and accepted her comfort willingly. In the last few months, Catra had time to rebuild her walls and once again hid behind them. Unwilling to show weakness of any kind.

Adora huffed, she had wanted to try again to get her open up more about the nightmares. Just as they headed out onto the trail earlier this morning. But the dark scowl Catra wore on her face deterred her. She would give her some space. Adora had years of practice, being patient with Catra. Delicately, whitling down her defences until she opened up about what was bothering her. They would have time back at Bright Moon for a proper discussion. So

she focused her attention behind her. Finding Finn trotting through the tall grass, oblivious to the destruction or merely ignoring it she couldn't tell. He was battling the air with a long stick he had found earlier, pretending it was a sword. The sweet innocence of it made Adora smile. Lots of bad stuff had happened to him years ago, but it seemed he never let it get him down. He had a rather positive, if pragmatic personality and that had protected him from the harsh realities of the War.

“Do you think they will like me at Bright Moon?” He asked. “I could be useful...I've done almost every kind of work.”

“I don't think Queen Glimmer approves of children working at the castle.” Adora stated.

“But why would she want to keep me around, if I wasn't useful?” Finn groused, his expression souring into melancholy.

Adora turned and crouched low, grasping his small shoulders and forcing him to stare up at her.

“You are worth more than what you can do for others.” She explained, “That was a hard lesson, I had to learn.”

Finn was confused.

“What do you want out of your life?” Adora asked softly.

“No ones ever asked me that?” He stated, his eyes searching hers.

“You think about that and let me know where you see yourself in the future. ” Adora stood up and ruffled his hair affectionately, before returning to the path.

“Over here!” Catra's voice called out from beyond a corpse of burnt bushes just ahead.

Adora broke into a run with Finn trotting close behind.

He came to a sudden stop, when he saw the beast laying in the burnt out clearing ahead. His eyes flew wide in terror. Glancing nervously between it and Adora as she approached the great monster without any hint of caution. Finn kept his distance, watching as both women inspected the still body of the beast.

“What do you make of it?” Adora inquired, standing beside the beast. Brushing her fingers over her chin in contemplation.

Catra scratched her head just behind an ear nervously, squatting beside a massive paw near its face. Her eyes narrowed curiously, noticing a thin metal collar wrapped tightly around its neck, nearly invisible within all the heavy fur. Melog was crouching near the beasts muzzle, sniffing lightly. Then pulled back as if revolted and sneezed.

“That Melog is allergic to this thing.” Catra smirked up at Adora, her tail swishing merrily.

“Be serious.” Adora admonished.

“Do you remember seeing a collar on the other beast?” Catra asked, pointing out the collar.

“No...but it was dark and...kinda fighting for my life...so...” Adora responded with a nervous chuckle, contemplating heading to the dead beast next to confirm.

“Well, it doesn't look like anything we'd see here in the Whispering Woods. I mean the animals here are all rather...” Catra trailed off trying to find the right words.

“Wimpy?” Adora offered, thinking of all the gentle magical creatures that now roamed the woods.

“Less dangerous...” Catra corrected. “There are a few that can be rather bothersome. Like the giant boars and lets not forget our

favourite....those huge freaking spider beetle, things.” She shivered and stood with a grunt.

Adora smirked, remembering fondly tangling with the last spider beetle thing...it had been that monster's attack that had brought Glimmer and Bow into her life.

“Your right, This doesn't look like something native to the woods.” Adora nodded her agreement.

“It's to deadly...” Catra mussed, “ Most beasts around here are not capable of shooting energy beams out of their heads!” She stated loudly, tapping her forehead with her fingertips for emphasis.

“Could it be from Beast Island.” Adora asked, as the thought brought a cold lump in her chest. They had run into a lot of different monster’s during their rescue of Entrapta. Each monster more deadly than the next.

“Ok....lets work that out then.” Catra huffed. “Beast Island is somewhere in the Growling Sea far beyond Salineas borders. Do you think this thing or any monster could swim all the way to the mainland?”

Adora shrugged, “Maybe? The First Ones used it as a dumping ground for corrupted tech and biological hazards, they didn't want near their settlements. The signal from the beacon at the center of the island was keeping the monsters on there. It affected people differently though...” Adora swallowed, unwilling to revisit the terrible memories of her time there. Catra paid her a confused, if concerned look. But Adora quickly schooled her features not wanting her to see how upset thinking about Beast Island made her. “If it stopped working they might just leave? Whatever terrible things the First Ones created for their wars, that didn't work right or were uncontrollable were left to rot on that Island. But they never died. We know the stories, Catra.” Adora groused, crossing her arms over her chest.

“I know, they scared the crap out of me.” Catra shivered.

“Well, you never had the honour of actually going there.” Adora spat back, defensively. Instantly wanting to take back her cruel words. As Catra cringed as if she had been struck and wrapped her arms around her stomach.

“I'm sorry....If I hadn't sent Entrapta there then you would not have had to go save her.” Catra moaned, casting her eyes to the side in silent self -reprimand.

“Catra, no...I'm sorry. “ Adora thinned her lips in irritation at herself and quickly sought to give Catra some reassurance. She was just about to wrap her up in a hug, when Catra rolled her shoulders out of Adora's grasp, not wanting to be touched and backed away.

“No, don't worry about it. I'm fine. I've dealt with that, Entrapta forgives me and I've moved on.” Catra raised her hands in a warding fashion towards Adora. Walking around the Beast to put some distance between them. She needed some time to gather herself and push down all the self loathing now plaguing her. She crouched low, over the monster's belly and ducked her face out of view behind it's furry elbow. Taking a long shaky breath, she closed her eyes and tried to calm down.

Adora nodded sadly, her arms falling limply to her side. Catra regretted so much of the pain and hurt she had caused others. Adora's comment had been callous and unthinking. She was still dealing with the trauma about her time on Beast Island and had unconsciously vented. She admonished herself, she had been thoughtless. Catra was dealing as best she could and needed support, not reminders of her mistakes. Clearing her throat Adora returned her attention to the beast. It was absolutely still, the rising and falling of its chest was imperceptible. It had its eyes closed and the central laser eye had faded away into it's long fur. It could be frozen or in some sort of hibernation? But why?

“This ones not dead, it looks more like its sleeping?” Catra's voice was soft and contemplative, as she squinted her gaze at it's chest. Her keen eyes catching the slight ripple of its fur as it breathed.

“But why?” Adora sighed.

“I have no idea, but it stopped when you killed the other one. Perhaps when you killed it's mate it could no longer function?” Catra's answered. “Maybe they are connected...like a Hive Mind. They might hunt in pairs? We heard far more than just two of these things last night.”

“Thinking that there is more of them out there in the woods only makes me feel worse.” Adora scrubbed a hand down her face.

“We should get Entrapta out here, she could tell us for sure if this thing is from Beast Island or First Ones tech...or whatever.” Catra stated, moving down the beasts flank, raising her arm over her head, brushing her fingertips along its backbone of long spines. Thinking back to the Arctic Reach, when they had tangled with two serpent bugs that were protecting a First Ones artifact and they turned out to be tech and not organic. Since the virus she used on Adora had corrupted them as well. Catra cringed at that horrible memory and sighed heavily. She had hurt Adora so much...because of her unchecked rage, her foolish pride..she would spend the rest of her life regretting her past actions and making up for them.

“ADORA!” Swift Winds voice exploded overhead. Before the gust of wind from his beating wings bombarded the ground. Sending Adora's cloak snapping behind her, as she craned her head upward.

“Swifty?” She called back in concern. Fear and anxiety washed off her steed in waves.

“Bright Moon's under attack!” He shouted as he landed, prancing in place for a moment. He was so worked up and full of nervous energy he just could not stay still. “I've been looking everywhere for you!”

Adora didn't hesitate, dashing to his side and leaping onto his back.

“Adora!” Catra called in concern, rushing to her side. As Finn darted up to Swift Wind, ignoring his fear as he did not want to be left behind. Adora leaned down and grabbed his outstretched arms, lifting him easily up behind her onto Swift Winds back.

“Hang on tight, ok.” She commanded, gently.

Finn nodded and rocked his body forward. Wrapping his tiny arms tight around her waist and pressing his body firmly to hers. His heart was hammering against his chest, in both fear and exhilaration of flying.

“We gotta go now!” Adora shouted back, Catra merely nodded as Melog came up beside her. The cat huffed and stretched their wings.

“Melog has wings?” Swift Wind observed.

“Yes. Yes, he does.” Adora muttered back, her voice low and exasperated.

“Think you can do this?” Catra asked Melog nervously, stroking the cat lightly down their back, for reassurance.

Melog mewed back confidently, watching intently how Swift Wind beat his wings to take flight.

“That's new....right?” Swift Wind acknowledged pedantically as he observed Melogs new wings.

Adora took a deep breath and rolled her eyes. She regretted what she had done to Melog but she didn't know how to reverse it either.

“You got this....” Catra mounted Melog and leaned down, wrapping her arms around their neck as they leaped into the air. Beating their wings as hard as they could, not prepared for the sudden power and speed their new wings could produce.

Melog yowled in fright as they soared high into the sky, struggling to maintain their balance with Catra's now lopsided weight on their back.

“You don't got this!” Catra screamed in fright, squeezing her eyes shut tight as she dug her heels into Melog's sides and wrapped her arms more tightly around their neck. As Melog promptly lost control, their once majestically soaring flight turned into a massive, out of control loop de loop towards the ground.

“Catra!” Adora screamed, as she watched Melog and Catra crash into the bushes far below.

“We'll catch up!” Catra called back, as Adora nodded and urged Swift Wind to fly.

Catra was sprawled on top of the shrubbery, she glanced bitterly to her side. Finding Melog's butt jutting up out of the branches beside her. Their tail standing straight up and puffed out in both anger and fright. She turned back to watch Swift Wind disappear into the distance. Then she glanced sourly back over to Melog's ass and flopped her head back in defeat. “Maybe.”

The sun was high overhead as they soared over the stony peaks of the mountains that sheltered Bright Moon. Diving low over the valleys, that were filled with thick orchards of fruit trees towards the Castle. The air was warm and filled with the sweet, clean scent of clear water. The wide clearing amid the trees were full of tents and wagons, a familiar scene, as a steady stream of refugee's always rested just outside of Bright Moon. Before heading deeper into the Whisper's Woods for other villages and

towns. A few Etherian's caught sight of her and pointed and called to her in greeting. Adora waved back, thankful they had not been dragged into the battle at the Castle. The vast body of water, known as Half Moon Lake was close only a few more minutes away. Then the white parapets, bastions and elegant spires of Bright Moon would be in view. Swift Wind banked hard over the sparkling water, pumping his wings as he prepared to dive low over the long, elegant bridge that spanned the bay, connecting the castle to the forest. The Castle and Bright Moon village, sat on the island in the center of the lake, was always majestic to behold. The brilliant white stone of the castle was carved from the upper crags, of Sky Dancer mountain. It was the tallest mountain in all of Etheria and it dominated the back of the island. A beautiful sparkling water fall cascaded behind the castle, crashing into the lake alongside the domed outlying buildings of the lower bastions. The stone of the main castle was glowing a brilliant white in the midday sun. The rough upper reaches of the mountain loomed behind the smooth spires and battlements, which was a natural barrier that protected the castle and sprawling village below. Bright Moon village was an eclectic array of buildings. Of various sizes and shapes, domed in design and built along the foothills and natural beaches that surrounded the mountain.

“That's a big snake....I mean that's a really, really, big snake!” Adora exclaimed as they flew over an extremely large serpent that was now curled around the balcony. Of the grand golden pillar that held the Moonstone. Adora squinted her eyes trying to make out more detail as to the size and shape of that serpent. It seemed very familiar, it's scales were paler than before? Its overly large, bulbous head, with its four fins was tucked under a heavy curl of scales. It's one solitary blue eye was half closed. It looked lifeless, just like the beast back in the forest. One of Netossa's massive nets of light was pinning the serpent to the dais. A small contingent of Bright Moon guards surrounded the serpent, their spears still pointed towards it. Silver helmets gleaming in the sunlight, the wind tossing their long lavender tassels like flags behind them. She noted the Commander of the Bright Moon

Guards, Juliet standing just before the serpent's massive head. Tapping urgently on a tracker pad, gathering data.

Adora was shocked to find that the Moonstone itself had grown dim, it's once luminous pearl sheen was now grey and dusky.

She spun her gaze back to the castle and sucked in a cold breath at the vast amount of damage. As Swift Wind dove towards the main garden behind the central keep of the Castle. Whatever had occurred in the last few hours, the battle had left the castle in a very battered state.

“This place does not look safe.” Finn moaned, clutching onto her hips more tightly. As a resounding crack and rumble echoed nearby. Finn snapped his head to the side, to the broken row of spires that stood just beyond the garden. Watching in horror as the roof of a nearby tower gave way crashing sideways and tumbling into the water below.

The walls of the many towers were gouged by massive teeth, the archways and grand stained glass windows of the main keep in front of them were smashed. Massive chunks of rubble and large pieces of glass were scattered all over the cobblestones. The huge, sprawling garden was utterly destroyed, the serpent's coils had dug huge grooves throughout the flower gardens. Flattening the lone marble gazebo and several decorative fountains. Adora wondered idly if Shadow Weaver's Garden got destroyed as well, as Swift Winds hooves clicked smartly on the stone as he landed.

“Swifty...” Adora gasped in horror at the incredible amount of damage as she dismounted. Finn never left his seat on Swift Wind. Feeling safer on the steed, he merely shook his head briskly when she offered her arms up to help him down.

“This way, hurry.” Swift Wind clamped his teeth onto the hood of her cloak and dragged her backwards into the castle.

The war room was a flurry of activity, with several castle guards running about tending to the wounded. It looked like the castle staff and soldiers had sought refuge in here after or during the battle. The central table was alight with a holographic map of Etheria. Some of the alliance was already moving around the table, scrutinizing the map, the tall chairs long forgotten behind them. Glimmer briefly looked up as Adora approached, giving her a small half smile before refocusing her efforts on the map. The Queen looked haggard, her pink sparkly hair was a wild mess. Her lilac eyes looked tired but unshaken by the last battle. Gripping her staff far too tightly, her knuckles white with the strain. Her cape was discarded somewhere on the battlefield. She stood only in the torn remains of her soft lavender tunic and darker leggings. Glowering down at the map that had several red sigils flashing over different parts of Etheria. Plumeria had an icon, so did Salineas and Bright Moon.

Nettossa and Spinerella looked pretty beat up, leaning heavily against their chairs.
"There are just too many of them..." Netossa moaned, as Spinerella wrapped a comforting arm around her wife's shoulders. Adora noticed their neighbouring fiefdoms, that were just north of Bright Moon had sigils as well.

"I never thought I'd miss fighting Horde bots!" Spinerella laughed, deflating into her chair in exhaustion.

Netossa laughed softly and nodded in agreement.

"The Kingdom of Snows has just been attacked!" Bow charged into the room, waving his tracker pad over his head. Adora's eyes flew wide in surprise to find the archer, no longer wore his tunic. His chest and arms were lightly mauled. Dried blood smeared his abdomen and his pants were torn in several places. His arrows and bow were still draped across his bare chest.

"Bow...are you alright?" Adora gasped.

“I'm fine, there just scratches the blood isn't all mine.” He waved off her concern, glancing with regret towards several bandaged guards.

Adora followed his gaze, heaving a guilty sigh towards the hurt guards, sitting against the walls of the War room.

“Damn it! There everywhere!” Glimmer slammed a fist on the table.

“Glimmer, what is going on!” Adora gripped the queen's shoulders and forced her from the table.

Glimmer stood shaking with rage, glaring up at Adora with tears threatening to fall.

“Within the last twenty-four hours several kingdoms have come under attack by Serpents. Every kingdom has something different. We don't know how to fight them?”

“That's your kingdom's guardian beast out there. It was the serpent we fought in the catacombs under the castle during your coronation.” Adora flung her arm angrily towards the grande doors in the direction of the Moonstone.

“My Rune Stone has stopped giving me magic so no more teleporting, no more light blasts. I can fight without it, but still. Mermista and Perfuma have stated that the same thing has happened to their Rune Stones. So I am certain poor Frosta is powerless right now, as her castle is getting attacked!” Glimmer screamed back, her rage unfiltered towards Adora. As if all of this was somehow her fault?

Adora scrubbed a hand down her face in frustration. “Catra and I ran into two beasts we think are from Beast Island out in the woods.”

Netossa and Spinerella both nodded.

“We have been clearing out strange monsters from our own kingdoms for the last couple days.” Netossa stated, wearily.

“There are reports of Pooka hunting in the streets of Seaworthy.” Bow tossed his tracker pad on the edge of the table and sat down in a chair heavily. “Chibits roaming the prairies of Thaymor. Scorpers in the Talon Mountains. Razorfins hunting in the Meadowlands. Who knows what else have escaped beast island!“ Bow tossed an angry arm towards the general direction of the Moonstone. “ I have no idea what is going on! The Guardian Beasts of our Kingdoms are laying waste to our castles and the Rune Stones have stopped working.” Bow declared, his voice rising and cracking as he got more and more worked up.

“The serpent was going for the Moonstone...it tried to eat it!” Glimmer cried, gripping the collar of Adora's shirt, her eyes wide and frantic.

“Why?” Adora cast the Runestone pillar a frightened glance. The golden pillar gleamed just beyond the large, vaulted windows of the war room. The midday sun beaming into the War Room through the shattered stained glass windows. Whatever damage Prime’s bots and clones had done to the palace during the early days of the occupation. Was modest compared to the destruction the Guardian Serpent had inflicted upon the Castle in one night.

Then suddenly screams of panic echoed from the pillar, followed by a deafening roar. Adora pressed the palms of her hands to her ears, as the roar threatened to burst her eardrums. As she ran for one of the large arching windows. Glimmer moaned, raising her staff as she charged a magical attack. Racing after Adora to the same broken window. Bow notched an arrow, running after Glimmer with Netossa and Spinnerella right behind. They had all endured that ear splitting roar last night when the Guardian had attacked. The sound brought a cold lump of dread deep in their stomachs. They made it to the large arching window just in time to watch in horror as the Serpent broke free of the magical net. The strings white light faded and with a burst of sparks it evaporated. The massive serpent reared up, sending the guards

scrambling to get out of its way, otherwise they would get crushed by its incredible bulk. It opened it's massive jaws, tiny razor sharp teeth shone briefly in the sunlight, before it swallowed the Moonstone whole. Then promptly curled up in the center of the balcony as if it now owned it. Gazing drowsily off towards the tree line of the Whispering Woods, falling asleep with a proud, contented smile.

Glimmer screamed, igniting her staff, preparing to leap out of the window to retaliate. Bow stood in silent wonder, his bow slowly dropping in submission. There was nothing they could do.

She-Ra glowed beside him, a steading hand gripping onto Glimmer's shoulder holding her back. As the massive serpent curled up in the center of the dais where the Moonstone once was.

It had happened so fast....

A transmission crackled over the map as the scared face of Castaspella flickered into view.

“Glimmer!” Castaspella screamed into the war room.

The fear and complete panic in her voice, drawing them all from the windows and back to the map.

“Auntie?” Glimmer moaned. “Don't tell me, Mystacor is under attack.”

“No, but people from all over Etheria are flocking to our gates, they want to be trained. Cause suddenly they all have magic! Others for protection, there are reports coming in from all over that Etherian's are disappearing? Strange monsters are lurking and hunting outside their villages? We can't handle this many. What is going on!” She exclaimed, before screams and what sounded like an huge explosion echoed out behind her. Then the transmission was abruptly cut off.

Adora, Glimmer and Bow passed each other frightened looks.

“I'll go to Mystacor and help my sister deal with the masses.” King Micha's deep voice resounded in the room. Drawing everyone's attention instantly, he had been leaning against a pillar nearby. Watching in silent horror as the Serpent ate the Moonstone. But he knew it was useless to intervene. He was a Master of Sorcery, possessing higher mystical senses that were attuned to the flow of magic of the planet. Ever since She-Ra released the magic stored at the Heart the planet. Healing, growing and reclaiming all that had been lost for the last one thousand years. Etheria was entering into an era of great change , he could feel it. A renaissance if you will, of magic.The ethereal power that surrounded them was so much more potent, it hummed all around him, vibrating against his skin. Its aura was much more robust and vibrant; it pulsed in the air like a living thing.

His outfit was slightly different, with an ornate silver breast plate that was now scratched and dented. The half moon medallion he wore was securely tucked under the armour. His grey cloak was even more tattered then before, his gauntlets and boots were splattered with black ichor. He had added different types of power stones to his staff, making the various bulbs on the head shimmer like a prism. He had been remaining out of sight. Close enough to offer advice but not completely a part of the meeting. Wanting to give his daughter the space she needed to take charge. To be Queen...

He had been given several weeks to reconnect with her and he had found his daughter had a strong, indomitable spirit more than capable of leading. He was so proud of her! He had no problems being her advisor and nothing more. Angella had done an amazing job raising her without him.

“I'll report back what I find.” He moved briskly to Glimmer's side and pulled her into a quick hug. Offering her comfort and reassurance.

“Thank you, Dad.” Glimmer sighed and slumped down in the Queens chair, as Micah left the room. She glanced up at her mother's portrait, etched in the back wall of the grand room. Her somber visage offered no solace, so Glimmer squeezed her eyes shut. Allowing only a couple tears of frustration to trickle out.

“Glimmer...” She-Ra had faded as there was no need for her aid. So Adora placed a comforting hand on Glimmer's shoulder. Drawing her away from her grim contemplations.

“Sometimes, Adora. It's just so hard...” She whispered brokenly.

Adora stood solemnly, wanting to take action, but holding herself back. Glimmer already felt powerless. She didn't need She-Ra coming in and taking over. Adora trusted in her friends abilities to lead, to do what was best for everyone, she just needed a moment to collect herself.

“Bright Moon can't offer much for relief, we are still recovering ourselves from Primes Occupation.” Bow advised Glimmer, placing a comforting hand on her other shoulder. She offered him a small smile and squeezed his hand.

“OK.” Glimmer took a deep breath and jumped back to her feet. “ Netossa, I need you to go to Salineas and report back to me what really happened and what Mermista needs. Spinerella, I want you to go to the Kingdom of Snows and check on Frosta, give me a full report. Bow, go to Plumeria and make sure Perfuma and her people are alright. The only Kingdoms not reporting attacks just yet is Scorpia and Huntara...and Dryl....but they also do not all have Rune Stones?” Glimmer's voice drew quiet at the mention of Entrapta's Kingdom. Could all of this be her fault? Some experiments with First Ones tech gone terribly wrong. She was reaching...she knew she was, but she was also desperate to find answers.

“Adora and I will head to Dryl....Where's Catra?” Glimmer's eyes suddenly went wide, glancing around Adora in realization that the Cat was not there.

“I'm right here...barely.” Catra's voice snarled out from a busted window near the back of the War Room. First her bare arm was flung into view over the bottom ledge, then a clawed foot and leg as she crawled into the room. Her fur looked windblown, her tail fluffed up from constant terror. Branches and leaves stuck out of her short hair, her face was marred by dirt and her expression was less than impressed. A panicked mewling echoed out of the window and she spun back and leaned down, hauling up a very shaken and exhausted Melog. As soon as they had all four paws on the ground. The magical cat, howled and bit their wings in frustration. Then yelped, regretting their sudden act of rage as it hurt, these things were not normal but they were a part of them now.

“Melog has wings now?” Bow commented, his expression puzzled.

“It's complicated.” Adora responded dryly, bowing her head and pressing her fingers to her forehead in exhausted frustration. She had no real idea how her magic worked...or magic in general. So when her magic misfired and did things she never intended she found it humiliating. After having this magic for nearly three years, you would think she would wield it properly by now and not look like a bumbling idiot!

“Hi.” Finn finally spoke up, giving every adult a meek wave from his seat upon Swift Winds back.
“The kid's a stray, Adora picked up in the woods.” Catra stated dryly, sauntering across the room still picking twigs out of her messy hair.

Finn gave her a glowering look, as she walked past. He did not like being referred to as ‘kid’ or as some lost animal. He crossed his arms over his tiny chest and huffed in indignation. “My name is not kid, Cat lady!”

Catra smirked, giving him absolutely no respect. “My name's not Cat lady, Kid.” She responded pointedly. Finn stuck out his tongue

in annoyance. She responded in kind, sticking out her own tongue towards him.

Adora groaned at the animosity rippling between them, their relationship was not starting off well. But what did she expect, this was Catra. She didn't try to get along with people right away...enjoying the verbal cat and mouse far too much to be cordial.

They had been traveling for over three days, trying to get through the woods. Heading south towards the range of mountains that held the mining kingdom of Dryl. Hoping to reach the summit of the Talon Mountain and the Crypto Castle as quickly as they could. Glimmer was mourning her powers feeling that they were gone for good. She had withdrawn, verging on wallowing into a deep depression for the first day or so. Now she was just irritated with everything.

“I am not used to this anymore!” Glimmer howled, as she shuffled wearily behind Adora. Dressed for long days of travel. She wore a pair of dark lavender pants and a lighter violet tunic that tied behind her neck. A long gossamer white cape with hood. With long white, fingerless gloves and dark knee length boots. Shouldering a huge backpack, with her staff jutting out of the top flap.

“I used to be able to teleport anywhere! I never had to recharge anymore...my life was easy!” She shouted, flinging her hands up in frustration. “Then poof...I lost those powers.” She grumbled. Adora placed a comforting hand on Glimmer's shoulder, as they had all been listening to her rant about her lost powers for days. She had been supportive, comforting and reassuring, offering Glimmer whatever she needed. Catra had been aloof ever since her nightmare, she offered Glimmer concerned looks but nothing more. She was just uncertain as to how to help her, so just let Adora handle it. Being the good, caring friend wasn't something she was used to, she was honestly out of practice. She had only

acted that way to Adora and that had been many years ago. Now she just felt awkward and nervous about showing care and affection to anyone but Adora.

Swift Wind had flown ahead, scouting the forest for danger. With so many kingdoms under attack by monsters from Beast Island, travelling overland was very treacherous. Leaving the small band of travelers to walk the worn paths through the woods.

Adora had taken the lead as the day wore on, her eyes darting at every sound. Glimmer stomped tiredly behind her. Melog was padding softly beside Catra, dragging their wings on the ground. Grumbling and snarling at them. Catra took up the rear, scanning the thick, overgrown trees warily. Her ears swivelled to listen for danger, tail snapping in annoyance. While Finn pranced around them all, without a care in the world. Singing at the top of his lungs and dancing around. He had refused to stay in Bright Moon without Adora. Stating that he would be safer with She-Ra. None of them could refute that logic so Adora had reluctantly let him come along.

Catra lunged out with an arm just as he skipped in front of her, snatching him up by the scruff of his poncho and lifting him off his feet. She pulled him in close to her face and snarled.

"Stop.....Why are you like this?" Her irritation with the happy go lucky kid was at its breaking point. His loud, carefree antics were only going to draw unwanted attention from the wild life and monsters alike.

"Because I am a Thaymorian, not some grumpy, Cat lady." He responded, promptly kicking her in the knees with his hooves.

Catra cried in pain and released him. He landed gracefully on his hooves and cantered up to Adora for protection.

"Catra...stop picking on Finn." Adora chastised, as Finn reached up to clasp her hand. Giving Catra a smug grin over his shoulder before taunting her by sticking out his tongue.

Catra took a deep breath, hissing it out through clenched canines. “Little kids are so annoying.” She growled under her breath at Melog. Who was now glowing a bright orange, their mane snapping in response to her seething anger.

As the day drew on, the forest was beginning to thin, slowly giving way to rolling hills. They were moving onto the Plains of Thaymor. Finn had grown quiet, staring down at his shuffling hooves with grim melancholy. Catra noticed how despondent he had become. As she spotted the overgrown remains of the war scattered around the landscape. Guilt rose in her throat like bile, creating a painful lump, making her swallow several times as if that would dislodge it.

It had only been a few weeks since She-Ra had healed the planet. Channeling the magic stored in the Heart back into the atmosphere. Magic had fallen like snow for several days, as the planet absorbed its lost power. Healing the dead and desolate areas affected by the war and First Ones tampering. Bringing back the lush grass and wild grain back to Thaymor. But she did not have the power to take away the discarded metal remains of the Hordes war machines. Burnt out tanks and troop carriers still hid amid the tall grass. Grass covered domes dotted the hills, that were the remains of Bots. Scrap metal of all shapes and sizes jutted out of the fields. The exploded parts of Primes mechanical armies. That first swarmed the planet before it was occupied by clones. Abandoned farms stood decaying along the hills and the rubble of Thaymor lay in the distance. The broken buildings and towers of the village jutting out on the horizon like a barren skeleton.

“I don't want to go this way.” Finn whined, pulling on Adora's hand. Glancing around the tall grass anxiously.

“Finn, we have to travel through Thaymor to reach the Talon Mountains.” Adora crouched down, “We don't have a choice, I

need you to be brave. Ok.” She sought to console the young man, giving him a warm smile of understanding.

Glimmer sighed, scanning the dense prairie ahead sadly. She had yet to rally the kingdoms together to repair the damage of the war or clean up the mess left by the Horde. She-Ra had released the stolen magic and the land had grown lush and full of life once more. But the signs of war still remained, in the scattered pieces of metal and broken war machines that still littered this place. There had been so much to do, but all that was set aside for now. They had to deal with this new crisis instead.

“We're close to Thaymor...aren't we.” Catra stated softly as she came to stand next to Glimmer. Taking in the scattered debris of the war with regret.

“Yes...I don't know what we are going to find. There was nothing left of Thaymor after the Galactic Horde invaded, the people that survived fled. I heard some went to Plumeria, others remained in the Whispering Woods. I don't even know if any of them have tried rebuilding again since the War ended.” Glimmer placed a comforting hand on Catra's shoulder. As the Cat slowly bowed her head, her eyes were moist, tears threatening. Then just as quickly as Catra's sorrow and regret took hold. She squashed it down with the only weapon she had.

“Whatever!” She snarled and rolled Glimmer's hand off her shoulder and glowered at the ground. Stomping off ahead them all before breaking into a full run across the prairie.

“What happened?” Adora asked in confusion.

“I don't know.” Glimmer responded in shock.

“Catra, come back!” Adora shouted, as Melog charged up the hill after their master.

Catra could be extremely fast when she wanted to be, she was out of sight in a matter of seconds.

The cool wind rushed over her face, howling in her ears as she pushed her body to its limits. Pumping her arms and lunging forward with her legs. Needing to move faster, to feel that painful burn in her lungs. Catra had quickly abandoned running only on two legs. She was much quicker on all fours. Melog charged beside her, passing her a confident, yet toothy grin. They had figured out how to run, tucking their wings in tight to their sides.

(*Where are we going?)* Melog chirped.

Catra understood their words, their deep, rumbling voice echoing in her mind.

"I gotta get to Thaymor first. I gotta make sure the sight of it is not going to hurt Finn. I've hurt that kid enough." She stated, worried at what she was going to find. She still had hope, that perhaps they had rebuilt some of the village since her attack, since Primes Invasion. Perhaps they had dismantled the tanks She-Ra had destroyed so long ago. When she had been a part of the raiding party that sacked Thaymor. Maybe the villagers had buried the bodies of their dead? Maybe...maybe it would be, ok?

Tanks and war machines overgrown with grass greeted her first, then a field of stone cairn's that stretched out of sight. She never broke stride, her eyes flew wide and she sucked in a sudden, shuddering breath. Knowing that the dead lay beneath those piles of stones and it hit her hard. With a growl of self loathing, she snapped her gaze back to the rushing grass. As it whipped against her face and body, like thousands of tiny lashes. Leaving scratches and welts upon her bare arms, neck and face. She ran full speed towards the shallow ravine that the crumbling remains of Thaymor lay within.

Dead trees still bordered the ravine, blackened husks who's barren branches still reached towards the sky. Their roots clutching desperately onto the moss covered boulder's and clay hillsides that once hid, and protected Thaymor from the wide, open

prarie. Catra descended quickly into the ravine, rounding a bend further on. Coming across the broken walls of outlying farmsteads. She stopped briefly to look mournfully at a large chunk of mortar. A beautiful mural was once painted upon the walls of this building. Thaymorian's in full tribal dress were dancing under the moons. The colors were somber but vivid. What was left of it was marred by black soot from the Horde Tanks blasts. The rest of the mural lay shattered upon the ground, only the barest of foundations remained of this building. She had been so blind...so driven towards something so meaningless...

“I was such an idiot!” Catra snarled, turning away from the mural and pounding her fists repeatedly into a bare piece of wall in impotent fury. Blooding her knuckles in the process.

More rubble, more broken war machines and burnt out bots greeted her as she jogged deeper into the ruins. Moving through the outlining buildings, her heart burning with regret.

As the heart of Thaymor lay ahead.

As she crested the a small rise the overlooked a gully within the ravine. She was not expecting to find an encampment of ex-horde soldiers. Dull grey tents were set up amid the rubble of the village. The red sigil of the Horde snapping upon the sides of the tents. Troop carriers, supply trucks and skiffs were parked amid the tents. Horde militia roamed around, each member wearing bits and pieces of their old armor. Some were patrolling just outside the makeshift camp, they still had their rifles and stun batons. Keeping guard over the camp, just as they had been trained.

“This is far worse...” Catra groaned, scrubbing a clawed hand down her face. With a snarl, she stalked low through the grass on all fours. Creeping forwards down the hill. Not wanting to be seen by the guards. Melog stalked beside her, cloaking them both as she slipped unnoticed into camp.

Catra moved silently into the camp, stalking behind the bulky square hull of a cargo hauler. Her ears twitched at every sound, eyes scanning the movements of the guards. The guards changed every half hour so she just had to find a break in the patrols. It didn't take long, soon she moved thru the perimeter into the first set of tents. Lurking behind a stack of crates, scanning the camp ahead for the commander's tent. It would be larger and have the Force Captain's shield on the sides. These people were not traveling around Etheria without someone commanding them.

"Do you think we'll be safe here?" A female lizard hybrid with pale blue scales asked, her voice was soft and filled with worry.

Catra poked her head over a crate, never having really thought much about how the ex-Horde Soldiers would be fairing after the war. The female lizard looked thin, dressed in a pair of black horde issue military pants and a white tank top, fingering the trigger of a stun baton. A burly human Etherian stood in front of her, still dressed in full armor. Holding his helmet against a sturdy thigh, his haggard face could be seen. He had dusty blonde, wild looking hair that hung over his shoulders, with dark blue eyes that were sunken from stress and lack of sleep. He had a square jaw, dusted with a well forming beard of dark scruff.

"Well, we are pretty far away from any villages, towns or cities. So maybe...I hope so. I am so tired of running. All of Etheria hates us. " He stated.

"With just cause." The female lizard crossed her arms. "Changing sides at the last minute and fighting with the rebels against Horde Prime does not give us a pass over what we did to these people under Hordak for years."

"I have no problems with avoiding all of Etheria, if they want. I just want to find a place to settle and be left alone." He groused.

Catra moved on, understanding their feelings to a degree. She hated what they had done to Etheria under the Hordes banner, and hated herself for commanding those raids. For trying so hard

to win. Never truly understanding the pain and death she was causing. She had been so angry, so hurt and so focused on out manoeuvering the Rebels. Intoxicated with the idea of finally being able to prove herself, that she was powerful, worthy of respect...of praise. Also, she had wanted to make Adora hurt for abandoning her. Prove to Shadow Weaver that she was better than her precious Adora. Show Hordak that she was a powerful ally, more useful than Shadow Weaver. Caught in that power struggle, needing to do whatever was necessary to survive. Driven to win at all costs.

She had been an absolute monster.

She turned and slid down the crate, thumping the back of her head against its side in sad understanding. She had been spared the stigma of being an ex-horde. When they first got back to Etheria. She had hidden herself in a cloak along with Adora and the rest of the Rebels back during Horde Primes occupation of Erlandia. Then spent months hiding in the Whispering Woods, freeing villages and towns from his clones. After the war, they had hid out in the inn back at Erlandia a few weeks back. Only visiting that one shop. But the owner was already in debt to them for saving the town. Since then, she and Adora had managed to avoid any other towns or villages while on their way back to Bright Moon. Now she wondered if that wasn't by design...on Adora's part.

At first, Grizzlor stood frozen, not knowing what to do. As Catra swept the dusky green tarp of his tent flap open. Breezing into his tent as if she owned it. His first instinct when confronted by Hordak's second in command, was to come to attention. As soon as he snapped his hand up to his forehead and went rigid. He scowled and cursed under his breath. As a smug, self satisfied smile crossed over the Cat woman's face.

“What do you want?” He growled, hunched over a paper map on a long table at the back of his tent. He had very little in the tent

besides a cot and a blanket.

“I want you to leave.” Catra crossed her arms over her chest and leaned against the thick central metal pole to the tent.

“Not happening.” Grizzlor responded, seeking to ignore her by focusing his attention to the map. “We have been persecuted and chased out of every village and city on this side of the continent. We are done running.”

“Look, Grizzlor. As I see it. We can do this the easy way...or the hard way. Please choose the hard way. I've had a very frustrating few days and really need a bit of a release.” Catra snarled, scrutinizing her claws with a warning grin.

“You, truly have no loyalty...to anyone...” Grizzlor sighed, taking both large hands and brushing them across the heavy fur along the sides of his face. As he rolled his neck, seeking to crack the bones and relieve some of the tension in his burly shoulders.

Catra merely shrugged as if she didn't care, but his words hurt.

“We were your people....first!” Grizzlor snarled. “We thought we were fighting to make Etheria better...that our lives were worth something. But you didn't care about your soldiers, you threw our lives away like they didn't matter. Raid after, raid...after raid..in a pointless effort to gain more territory.” He sighed and walked around the table.

Noticing with pride how her ears drooped and her eyes drew downward in shame. He pressed on, “We pushed forward... on your orders. Taking Salineas...SeaWorthy...Erelandia..Elberon and so on...towards Bright Moon... While the casualties on both sides started to mount. Some soldier's couldn't handle the stress...they defected. Others gave up, they just refused to fight...Yet you forced us to keep pushing forward...your orders were merciless...Catra...We were exhausted...in every way... but you didn't care!” He growled, stalking around the table. Watching Catra intently, now sensing danger. Her eyes narrowed, her

breathing was shallow. The muscles of her forearms and thighs tightened. He pushed on regardless, needing to be heard. Not understanding that her reaction was not rage but regret.

“Then Horde Prime showed up and the war we had been fighting became pointless. We abandoned our posts and sought to fight alongside the Etherians. They were fine with that, as long as it was us dyng and not them. Then when it was all over and we thought we had earned a place among them. They show their true, ungrateful selves.” He leaned casually against the front of the table, crossing his own massive arms over his uniform.

“There is no place for us among the Etherian's. So, I decided to find a place away from them and make it ours!” He roared. “We are not leaving.”

“We decimated this place! Killed their people and scattered what remained of them. They had tried to rebuild, but our first attack left them weak, vulnerable and allowed Horde Primes forces to finish them off!” Catra roared, releasing her claws and stalking towards him. “There is a whole field back there full of graves ! I will not allow you to desecrate this place....it's sacred ground to the Thaymorian!”

Grizzlor huffed. “It was war...” as if that gave him a pass to do as he pleased.

“They were innocent civilians, this place was never full of Rebel insurgents!” Catra shouted, trying to convince him how callous his actions right now were being.

“Killing innocent people, never bothered you before.” he stated matter of factly, throwing in her face how much of a monster she had been.

Catra lost control, she screamed and lunged at him. Tackling Grizzlor over the table and sending him to the floor. Crouching on his barrel chest she clasped a clawed hand into the ample fur at his throat. Squeezing just enough to draw blood and constrict his

breathing. Her other claw poised over his face to strike. His beady black eyes widened and rolled back in terror.

"I am done talking." She growled in a threatening whisper, bent low over his tiny ear, hidden in the mass of wild fur over his head. "I will burn your camp to the ground and kill every one of you! Or you pack up your troops and leave. Your choice. I will give you half an hour to get out of here." She jumped off of him and slashed her way out of the back of the tent.

Grizzlor sucked in a deep breath, rolling over and grimacing in embarrassment. He had always been rather strong and intimidating as a Force Captain. But Catra...the sheer rage and unbridled fury she held inside that tiny frame...it frightened even him.

The late afternoon sun was falling behind the distant hills, allowing the air to cool. As Catra watched the Horde packing up the trucks and tearing down tents. She had climbed to a higher vantage point atop a decaying stone watchtower that sat on the edge of the gully, atop a tall hill, a few miles out from the village. Most of the lower floor was intact, but the south wall was crumbling. Large stones having shifted and tumbled away to litter the ground around the foundation. The two story, heavy stone walled structure, would have been a cool place. The local farmers would have used the bottom floor to store the harvest. While shepherds would climb to the top to survey the land, keeping track of their herds. Thaymor had been a peaceful kingdom, they never had much use for a militia till the Horde showed up. But then it was to late to rally a defending force.

Melog had remained at her side, keeping them hidden. She was lounging on the flat stones that rimmed the roof. One leg drawn up to her chest, resting her chin upon her knee. While she dangled the other leg over the edge. Mindful of the shifting stones on the floor beneath her, as only half of the roof was structurally sound enough to support her weight.

“This was where it all went wrong.” She sighed, glancing down at Melog with a pained expression. Her eyes were moist with unshed tears and ears drooped with remorse. Melog raised their head, feeling the turbulent emotions now churning inside her heart. They turned their head, acknowledging that they were listening.

Catra swallowed and blinked away the tears. Lightly scratching a claw on the weathered stone as she struggled to admit how terrible she had been.

“The Horde took me in...after Adora found me in a box somewhere in the Fright Zone. They taught us the Princesses were evil, that they were destroying the planet with their magic. That Hordak was some kind of god, that was sent here to bring order and peace.” Catra laughed bitterly. “We were raised by a Sorceress....Shadow Weaver...she was harder on me then Adora. At least that's what I had thought, turns out Shadow Weaver was just as cruel to her, but just in a different way. ” Catra tried to lighten her description of Shadow Weaver but it turned her stomach. “Actually the woman hated me...I was useless, a burden, insolent, worthless, a distraction to Adora. But I felt she loved Adora though, always praising her, dotting on her. I never realized how much pressure Adora was under growing up, thanks to that vile woman's ambition. She thought nothing of me, so I was able to do as I pleased most of the time. Adora...she had to be perfect. She had to be the smartest, the strongest, the most capable cadet. I used to try so hard to get Shadow Weaver to acknowledge me, I hungered for her approval. Waited like a pathetic fool for any scrap of praise...even a small touch of kindness, but none ever came. I couldn't do anything right and I was just a bad influence on her precious Adora.” Catra clenched her fingers tight in unspoken rage. Her claws dug into the stone, gouging out deep grooves. She released her fingers, watching the stone dust and shards flutter away to the ground. Destroying things when she was upset always made her feel better, it released the pain like syphoning poison from her wounded soul.

Melog whimpered and stood up, bracing their front paws on the stone rim and nuzzled her hand. Wanting to calm the rage and

grief now boiling up inside of her. Catra paid them a grim smile, stroking their head as she watched the dust kick up as the carriers began to file out of Thaymor.

“Good choice.” She stated, satisfied that she had done good. She leaped down from the platform and sauntered off into the prairie to meet up with Adora once again.

She had expected them to just be a few miles out from Thaymor by the time she got the place cleared out. After not seeing anything but rolling prairie for nearly an hour and no sign of them. Catra had no choice but to track them. The light of day was fading into muted colors upon the horizon, when Catra finally caught sight of them. Adora had taken the more risky trail through the lowland marshes. It was considered a dead zone. Too dangerous to travel through. The bog was murky and overgrown with weeds. Hidden sink holes and pitfalls dotted that wetland, laying in wait for anyone dumb enough to try and cross it. That deadly swamp had taken the lives of more than a few travelers and merchants over the years. The dead trees jutted out from the edge of the marsh, strangled long ago by toxic black vines. A garish green fog, hovered over the swamp. Making it even more difficult to find a dry, solid path to follow. Now most people knew to avoid that area and travel though Thaymor village instead.

But not Adora...it seemed. She was still charging ahead, heedless of the danger.

“What are you thinking...you idiot!” Catra snarled, casting Melog a worried look.

Adora was leading Swift Wind sluggishly along a narrow trail on the far side of the swamp. They had managed to get to the other side, but it had taken the whole day. The horse's legs and stomach was fully caked with mud. Finn was riding the horse, no doubt, too tired to walk anymore and so was Glimmer. Sparkles

sat behind Finn, staff in hand, illustrating that she was being vigilant.

Why didn't they just fly over the swamp...why would Adora lead them across it? It made no sense?

Catra was at the top of a large hill, from this height she could see into the distance. The water was murky almost black, thick patches of swamp weed floated on the surface.

The trail knitted in and out of small corpses of dead trees, a thick fog was rolling in from the center of the bog. Catra scanned the rolling landscape beyond the marsh for places that would be safe to spend the night. She noticed a large standing rock a few miles past the swamp, with a small grove of living trees surrounding it. It seemed safe enough, at least it could be defended if any monsters from Beast Island stumbled upon them during the night.

When she scanned back to keep track of Adora her eyes locked on something....movement. Unsure as to what she had seen, she stared hard at the spot just north of the bog where the fog was blooming. Her tail twitched in agitation, while Melog growled, picking up on her roiling emotions. When she saw it again, passing silently just behind a cluster of rotting trees. There was no doubt that something....was stalking her friends.

“No....no,no,no....” She muttered, dashing down the hill. Keeping the moving shadows in sight, as they moved in and out amid the trees, hiding within the fog. Then other movement snatched her attention. Catra's eyes searched and flew wide in horror. Behind Adora, just to the right of her position. There were others.

Three...no...four...smaller shadows...slithering along the ground. They were moving in unison, with stealth and precision. They would stop, assess Adora's position. Wait, creep forward, in minutes they would be upon them along with the fog.

Shadows of Eternia

Catra sprang forward and started running, Melog galloped beside her as they charged down the hill and into the lowland marsh. Her lungs were quickly protesting as the musky haze from the rotting plants assaulted her nose. The air was thick with the scent of decay and it hung like a toxic cloud. She started to pant for breath, along with Melog as they ran down the muddy bank of the marsh, the softened, moss covered ground squelched in a rapid crescendo under her pounding feet. She could just make out the ruts Swift Wind had made when he had plodded through earlier. The holes were already full of murky, stagnant water, fetid and green. She kept a close eye on Adora and Swift Wind, as they made their way deeper into the underbrush, on the other side of the swamp. Fighting down the urge to call out, knowing that it would only draw more attention to them and her as well. She did not want to provoke an attack. She needed to move faster, clear the distance around the bog before those shadow men attacked. She drove herself headlong down the marshes edge, looking for any sort of drier trail to take. Her feet were starting to sink deeper into the mud and she was slowing. With a snarl, she leaped out of the mud, claws extended towards the base of a nearby dead tree. The trunk was wet and slippery but she dug her claws in deep with all four limbs and scrambled up to the lower branches. Leaping forward to the next branch, bounding in a strategic way threw the canopy. Melog whined and stretched their wings tentatively as they watched their master disappear in the distance. They were unsure if they could take to the trees as gracefully with these stupid wings...but they could fly.

“Swifty...are you sure you heard someone calling for help?” Adora asked, glancing nervously around the rotted overgrowth that surrounded them.

“Yes...I definitely heard someone calling...they were in trouble...” Swift Wind responded, his voice faltering into doubt. “At least I

was certain...now not so much.”

Glimmer made a disgruntled sound, “I really do not like it here.” She glanced around cautiously.

Finn's one good ear twitched, as Swift Winds ears swiveled. Both of their eyes flew wide.

“I can hear them!” Finn shouted, jumping up onto Swift Winds back. He balanced himself on the horse's rump, scanning the dead groves of trees intently.

“I can't hear anything...” Adora grumbled.

“We have to go deeper in.” Finn nodded. Swift Wind nodded in agreement.

Glimmer groaned, adjusting the grip on her staff. Giving Adora a stern, determined look. Adora nodded, raising her hand over her head. She closed her eyes, reaching for that familiar warmth that lay in the very core of her soul. The indomitable light of She-Ra engulfed her body, her power rushing threw her. In a flash of pure white, She-Ra stood tall and proud before them. Her sword held aloft, as her glowing blue eyes focused grimly upon the dark interior of the swamp ahead. They slowly moved off the boundary of the marsh and headed into the trees. It took only a few paces before the skeletons of long dead trees surrounded them. She-Ra stopped for a moment, noticing the thick black vines of bog weed that had grown around the trees, as if strangling the life from them.

“These vines....remind me of the vines on Beast Island?” She mused, with trepidation. She picked her way towards the dead stand of trees carefully. Branches snapped and leaf litter rustled under her boots. The vines were thick and looked like a tangled mass of dead snakes on the soft ground.

Glimmer waved a hand over her nose. The air was more humid in the trees and it stank of rot. A thick green fog was rolling in around them, it clung to the trees making them slick. Hesitantly,

She-Ra touched a vine twisting up the trunk of a tree. It wasn't the same...more rigid and slimy. The vines on Beast Island had been rough, dry and incredibly strong. These may have been the same but these were long dead. Swift Wind picked his way through the overgrowth after She-Ra. His eyes rolling in fright the deeper they went. Glimmer clutched her staff tight, watching over them all as She-Ra led the way. They moved slowly, twisting their way deeper into the trees. Visibility was decreasing the further they went, She-Ra kept a sharp look out not trusting her surroundings at all. Anything could sneak up to them without much notice with the fog obscuring their sight and the deep cover of dead vegetation all around them.

Finn had pulled the hood of his poncho up for protection, no longer caring about hearing the voices in the swamp. He was growing more scared by the second and his other small hand was clutching tight to the hem of Glimmer's cape. The fog that surrounded them began to glow, at first it wasn't perceptible but the deeper they went the stronger it grew. Until they were engulfed in a sheet of sickly fog, glowing with an eerie green light. It pressed against them on all sides, like an impenetrable wall. She-Ra backed up against the front of Swift Wind. Glimmer jumped down from the horses back, ready to take on whatever threat lay within.

“I don't like this...” Glimmer commented, nervously.

“I....think maybe...this was a bad idea?” Swift Wind moaned.

“If someone is lost in here and calling out, we have to keep going.” She-Ra took a deep breath, her heart was hammering in her chest. The urgent sense of danger lurking nearby, was humming across her skin. She squinted into the fog, it was like glass, shimmering and distorted. But she could see through it, see the dead trees beyond...and something more...slender shadows shifting in the underbrush.

“There's something in there?” She-Ra stated cautiously, moving slowly forward. Hoping it was the lost traveler that had been

calling out.

“Are you sure about this?” Glimmer groaned, moving forward with her.

“Swifty stay here!” She-Ra commanded, as both women moved off into the gloom.

Swift Wind whinnied with distress when she moved off, shaking his head anxiously from side to side. His orange mane flew wildly, as he stomped his legs. His hooves gouged the ground, he didn't like it here. Not at all!

“Don't go to far!” He screamed desperately into the heavy fog now rolling in all around him and Finn. His wings fluttered nervously, as the Thaymorian pulled out his sling shot, tucking a stone in the hammock.

Glimmer stuck close, her staff poised across her chest in a protective manner. The circular crown of the staff, glowing a vibrant lilac. As the power crystal inlaid in the star shaped hilt flared to life. While She-Ra moved a few paces ahead, glowering at the green haze pressing around them. A deep unearthly hum began to resound from the depths of the fog. At each step the sound became louder, deeper, more discordant. The green light became more solid, the trees began to fade. She-Ra snapped her head back in fear, finding Glimmer only a few feet behind starring in raptured awe at something in the distance. While she could make out nothing. Noticing that Swift Wind had disappeared behind the sheet of shimmering fog. A sudden cold feeling of terror settled over her.

“Glimmer...we have got to go back.” She reached for Glimmer's hand. Finding to her horror that the Queen had vanished.

“Glimmer!” She-Ra shouted in terror.

Glimmer shuffled slowly through the haze, what little light the evening sky had given was gone now. The sky was dark, as if she was now moving through a void. The glow of her staff was not even powerful enough to penetrate the gloom. Illuminating her stricken face in an eerie half light. The strange humming was now vibrating in her chest, calling to her. The muted green light that had been glowing around her a minute ago. Had now deepened, as if she was now staring into a dark mirror. She stood still, watching the forms moving on the other side. Inky shapes, some tall and lithe, others small and stout. Glimmer felt an odd sensation as she stared into the fog, her mind wandering down strange paths. This felt familiar...but darker... The humming took on the vague sounds of voices. They were speaking all at once, what sounded like thousands of voices...

"Hello..." Glimmer spoke tentatively. She suddenly felt a pang of longing mixed with confusion, then a profound loneliness. Followed by a timeless solitude coiling around her, drawing her away from Adora...from Etheria itself. The fog was like looking through murky water, as one shape drew away from the others. A solitary figure moved closer, the shadows movements were elegant. As if floating upon the ground. It was tall and thin with long flowing hair and majestic wings sprouted from it's back. It was then that Glimmer saw her....her mother. Standing just beyond the murky fog, her eyes were sad, her arms outstretched, beckoning her forward. To cross that boundary between this reality and the one she now lived in. Glimmer's heart pounded, as her mother called out her name. Her voice was full of sorrow, her arms desperate to hold her only daughter.

"Mom!" Glimmer cried out, her heart felt as if it was going to tear from her chest with yearning. It had been so long since she had seen her. She thought she was dead and never coming back. She wailed for her mother again, reaching through the fog. Needing to be touched, held by her. To feel that safe, comfort only her mother could provide. She never noticed the dark vines slithering out of the fog, along the ground towards her. Glimmer tried to go to her, tried to step through that metaphysical boundary that separated this reality and the one beyond. But something had a

tight grip on her arm. Irritated, she snapped her head back, ready to fight. Finding it was Catra, eyes, wild with fear. Glimmer did not care, she screamed furiously at Catra.

“Let me go!” She wailed, seeking to rip her arm away.

Catra's claws dug in instinctively, her eyes darting to the ground as the vines crept back into the concealment of the mist.

“No, way. Sparkles.” Catra pulled at her, digging her heels into the wet ground. Forcing Glimmer to back away from the fog. Fury roared to life inside Glimmer, her rage and despair was unrestrained. She struggled to be free, as Catra continued to drag her away. The panic and complete despair at losing her chance to be with her mother again, shredded her heart as completely as if her death had just happened.

“This is all your fault!” Glimmer wailed, kicking out and digging her feet into the ground.

“She would still be here, if you hadn't activated the portal!” She snarled and fought, forcing Catra to wrap both arms around her middle.

“I hate you! I hate you! I hate you!” Glimmer craned her neck back, screaming in Catra's face. Catra grunted and pulled, arching her back to dislodge Glimmer's feet from the muddy ground.

“Horde Scum! It's not fair! It should have been you...” Glimmer snarled.

“You should have died...not her...I want my mother back!” Glimmer scratched her nails down Catra's face, clubbing the side of her head repeatedly with her staff. She was screaming and barely lucid, when the green haze faded away and the dead remains of the bog came back into view. Reality came back with a sudden jolt, Glimmer was appalled at what she had done, what she had said. It had been like she had been possessed, by some dark vengeful spirit. That had been feasting upon all her worst qualities as a person. Fueling her hate, her resentments and her

desires for revenge. She was heaving for breath, shivering and totally exhausted. Catra still had her arms wrapped tight around her middle, dragging her out of the marsh. Glimmer craned her head back, swallowing hard, as guilt burned in her stomach. Catra's mismatched eyes were hard, focused, staring ahead at the fog, or glancing behind to make sure their course out of the swamp was clear. But tears were streaming unchecked down her cheeks, blood trickled from her left temple where Glimmer had clubbed her numerous times with her staff. Her right cheek had long scratches, angry and bleeding from her nails.

“I'm sorry....I'm sorry...” Catra panted, never easing her grip on Glimmer as she dragged her down the wet bank of the marsh.

“I'm ok...” Glimmer sobbed. “ You can let me go.”

“No...I'm not letting go until your safe.” Catra responded, her voice was soft, raspy and barely audible.

Glimmer nodded, turning slightly in her grip so Catra could help her walk. She was too overwhelmed to speak anymore. The sight of her mother had filled her with such a devastating grief and so much regret. They had parted on such bad terms, she wished more than anything to go back in time and not fight with her. To tell her how much she loved her and that she understood her worry. Then sudden terror clenched her chest.

“Adora's still in there!” She snapped her head up, turning out of Catra's grasp. Intent to go back in there and save her best friend.

“I got this Sparkles...that place can't really hurt me....much” Catra growled, then finished her sentence under her breath. Before she placed two fingers in her mouth and whistled.

Swift Wind descended a few meters away near the water's edge. Finn whooped with joy on Swift Winds back. As Catra guided Glimmer to the horse's flank.

“Get her out of here.” Catra commanded.

Swift Wind merely nodded and took flight, as soon as Glimmer was settled on his back. Glimmer had wanted to question how the dark magic inside the swamp didn't hurt her...but it quickly dawned on her. Back on Primes ship, they had had many conversations. Some were light hearted banter, some deep, others were depressing. As they both dealt with their common betrayal of their friends and shared quest for power. One more poignant one, had been about their mothers...She had explained point blank how Catra had killed Queen Angella. Glimmer had purged all the hurt and festering anger she had towards the Magicat until she had nothing left but acceptance. Catra had remained stone faced through it all, on her side of the forcefield. A heavy silence reigned between them for a long time, until Glimmer turned to face her. She swallowed hard and then forgave her. But the devastation and regret shimmering in Catra's eyes, was unmistakable. She had disappeared into the ship for many days after that tragic confrontation. Before loneliness and remorse drew her back to Glimmer's cell. She then confided in Glimmer at least a little bit about how brutal and cold her upbringing had been with Shadow Weaver. How the woman had sought to make her strong, a weapon. Her neglect and cruelty. Grooming a single minded ambition for her to claim power and influence within the Horde. To prove to everyone that she was worth something. She had then apologized in a roundabout way, for all the hurt she had caused her due to the loss of her mother. Catra had also explained, if a bit, cryptically how Shadow Weaver had used all kinds of magic on her. To try and control her growing up. Because she had been wild, stubborn and disobedient. Glimmer surmised she must have punished her with this type of dark magic as well. The realization sent a very unpleasant shiver down her body. That darkness had fed on her magic, her life force. Keeping her docile by lulling her with her longing desires, her unresolved guilt. If it hadn't been for Catra she would have died in that dark fog. That horror was followed by an unbelievable amount of guilt over how she had treated her. Catra truly was one of the strongest, bravest women she had ever met. If this dark magic is just a hint of what Shadow Weaver had used on her. The true extent of the torment Catra had endured as a child and survived, must be truly awful.

“Oh...Catra...I'm sorry.” Glimmer whispered, watching in awe as the woman leaped into the trees. Bounding back into the fog, moving from branch to branch to stay above it's magical effects.

“Where is she, Melog!” Catra called, scanning the sky above the dead canopy of branches for her feline partner. The sky had turned dull as the deeper shades of twilight took hold. Melog had taken to the sky unable to take to the trees. They made a wide circle overhead, yowling as a pillar of white light exploded a few miles ahead.

“Adora!” Catra screamed, leaping through the trees in a desperate attempt to reach her in time.

Iridescent green glow surrounded her, it pressed against her like a living force. She-Ra stood her ground, sword held before her in a shielding manner. She tried to find Glimmer at first, shuffling through the fog cautiously, calling out. But her voice was swallowed by the fog as she became more disorientated. Lured further and further away, until she was completely lost. Her power and speed were useless here, blind and helpless, she was trapped in the fog. She had grown more and more frustrated and lashed out with her full power. Slashing at the fog in massive arcs of pure light. Her magic would only illuminate a dead world devoid of anything, it was as if she had left Etheria entirely. She was alone....truly alone...Her heart sank instantly along with her focus on She-Ra. As sorrow and futility bit deep into her heart, her transformation faded. Leaving a very frightened and defeated Adora behind. This numbing helplessness had taken a heavy toll on her confidence. These dark emotions, of worthlessness eating away at her, was just like on Beast Island. She took a shuddering breath falling to her knees as silent tears began to fall down her cheeks.

“I'm a failure...I'm not strong enough...” Adora moaned, bowing her head.

“It's my fault this is happening...I made a wrong choice...I endangered everyone...Glimmer's gone because of me...I'm sorry....I'm so sorry, Catra...” She sobbed brokenly. Her cloak hung heavy over her shoulder's, soaked by the damp air. The hem and lower half stained brown from the mud. Her white top was clinging to her, soaked with sweat. Her skin glistened with the physical exertion she had spent, blindly running and attacking the fog. Fatigued by the intense effort needed to keep a hold on She-Ra, her muscles were on fire, legs trembling. As self-doubt and terror ate at her resolve. Her ponytail had pulled loose and stray strands of blonde hair was plastered across her sweaty face.

“I am such an idiot.” She groaned, lowering her head in defeat as she crumpled forward. Her knees squelching into the damp ground. Ignoring the moisture now seeping into her pants. She could see the shadows, wavering just beyond the sheet of green light. They were whispering to her, keeping her company in the lonely void. Somehow their hushed tones calmed her, made her feel less afraid. Her muscles relaxed as she sought to curl up on the ground. Suddenly she was very, very tired. She wanted to hear more, it was as if they were singing...she wanted to understand what they were saying? The once overpowering feeling of alarm began to fade. As the need for peace, for rest over took her reason. The shadows behind the green light shimmered comfortingly. She would have no more need to worry about the future, her actions, consequences or ....the mysteries of her past. The constant pressure of always succeeding would be lifted. No more overwhelming responsibilities or a suffocating destiny. She would be free of it all... Adora's eyes fluttered closed as she laid her head on her crossed arms, curling up on the ground ready to sleep. Her mind drifted, smoothly into a blissful stupor. Her breathing began to slow, a wistful smile spread across her lips, as the light in her eyes started to dim the last of She-Ra's essence was siphoned away. A black tendril of smoke slithered out of the fog and wrapped around her ankles, dragging her away, pulling her deeper into the swamp.

Catra crouched on a thick branch, watching the fog float through the swamp, like a low lying cloud. Tracking its movements, as it parted around corpses of trees, billowing and spreading around her like some supernatural predator. Adora's light had vanished but she didn't need to see. Taking a deep breath, Catra closed her eyes and settled her nerves. She needed to clear her mind and not allow the magic to feed upon any desires, regrets or insecurities. Shadow Weaver had punished her many times with this type of dark magic. She knew how it worked and what it's weakness was. She was more than capable of withstanding its effects for a short period of time. She stood up tall on the branch and dove forward into a front flip. Landing lightly upon a crumbling outcropping. The soft clay gave way at the slightest weight, she slid down the embankment as if riding a wave. Sniffing the air as the fog rolled in thick around her, charging towards its prey. She plunged a canine into the side of her lip, blood oozed from the wound, dripping from the corner of her mouth. But she needed to focus upon the stinging pain and nothing else. If the magic got a hold of her mind then she would be dead. She raised her face in the air and she sniffed. She could smell her, Adora's scent had always been so intoxicating to her. She could pick it out seamlessly from the rest of the musty, fetid smells of the swamp. It was soft and sweet....like sunlight...pure and warm.

“I'm coming Adora...just hang on.” Catra affirmed to herself.

As she rushed headlong down a dried out gulley. The loose stones and rotted leaves kicked up under her hands and feet as she lunged forward on all fours. The overgrowth of dead trees covered the ancient stream like a canopy of skeletal arms. Catra maintained a steady pace as the fog pressed down upon her seeking to smother her with it's oppressive whispers. Catra's ears twitched and her tail snapped, trying to ignore the insidious voices now calling to her. She barely noticed the shadow men converging upon her. Clamping her tooth down harder into her lip, relishing the sting as the pain washed away her thoughts. Shadow Weaver would punish her with this magic. These dark tendrils would wrap her up in this dark fog and it would feed upon her insecurities, her

self-loathing, her rage. When the punishment would end, hours later she would be drained both emotionally and physically. Spending days sleeping in Adora's bunk, while the little blonde would take care of her night and day until she got her strength back. In time as she got older she found out that she could slow the effects. With physical pain and by focusing her thoughts on positive things. She would pretend when Shadow Weaver released her that she was still drained. The perk would be getting the best of that old witch and having Adora all to herself while she pretended to recover. Catra's mind wandered to Adora, as the voices became stronger.

“Catra!” Adora's voice shouted out to her, her tone stern and unapologetic. Catra spun, finding She-Ra striding out of the fog towards her. She wore her old uniform from before, when the First Ones sword was still intact. The swirling, iridescent vortex of Hordak's portal spun behind her. She glowered down at her, her vibrant blue eyes were narrowed, cold...She glared down at her, like she was an enemy. There was no more forgiveness, no more understanding or excuses to be given for what she had done. This She-Ra....this Adora...in this moment. Truly hated her...the loathing in her eyes was unmistakable. That fierce, glower of judgement upon Adora's face. Had shattered what was left of Catra's heart. Knowing that there was nothing left between them. She had been consumed by her rage, her resentments. Her actions this time were unforgivable. She had finally destroyed the bonds she once cherished with Adora. Now the girl wanted nothing to do with her...ever…

“No....no,no,no,no....” Catra clutched her head and squeezed her eyes shut. Willing herself to clear her mind and not let the magic grasp onto any weakness.

That moment was too painful...that was when she believed Adora hated her, had finally given up on her. She stumbled and fell to her knees. But she never stopped moving, she was too stubborn and far too feisty to allow this magic to get the best of her. Adora needed her...she was going to die unless she got to her in time... Catra screamed....then screamed again but never gave up. She

kept moving, struggling to push down all the negative emotions that the magic was feeding on. As the voices began to whisper...gentle and soothing. The shadows behind the veil drifted closer,

“Kaira...” A voice sighed a long forgotten name. The sound of it brought pleasure, but also pain. Catra whined at the sound of it. It was so foreign but so familiar.

“Stop...fighting...now...you can rest...” The melodic voice coaxed.

Catra moaned, her crawling becoming more sluggish as more of her energy was being sapped from her body. She sighed and finally sat down, hunching her back and wrapping her arms around herself protectively. Tucking her legs under her butt, her tail curled around her waist. The small, wet stones of the gulley dug into her the flesh of her legs but they were not painful enough to pull her focus away from the intoxicating voices . Her ears slowly dropped downward as her head bowed in defeat. Catra slowly closed her eyes, allowing the exhaustion to claim her, welcoming sleep. Her head slumped forward as the life drained from her eyes, yet she remained sitting, her back stiff, holding herself tightly. Her body still unconsciously fighting against the dark magic seducing her towards unconsciousness. Memories flooded through her, a village stood upon the crest of a hill deep in some long forgotten grasslands. The buildings were short, rounded structures made of mud bricks and dried grass. With heavy wooden doors and simple windows of tinted glass. The outer walls covered with a dried clay. Murals very similar to Thaymor decorated the homes, but the images were of cat people. The village was built in rough circles, extending from a central courtyard. Larger, communal structures for guards lay on the outer circles with wooden walkways and tall watchtowers to defend against attack. A variety of other buildings lay within the middle circle, a commercial area for markets, blacksmiths and potters. The inner circles near the center held all the family homes. Squat rounded structures with thatch roofs, with smoke billowing from mud chimneys. In the very central courtyard a

brilliant orange stone gleamed in the sunlight. Hovering above the village atop an ornate pillar, carved from pure white stone.

“Kaira...” The voice was soft, almost melodic. Catra heard this name, called to her with such fondness, such love that her heart yearned to see the face it belonged to. She tried to sink deeper into this vision, her spirit falling towards the village. Desperate to find the source of that kind voice calling out to her.

“You must not be lost here... not yet...she needs you.” Another voice echoed out over the whispers. It was familiar...the lilt was strong and refined. That voice had pulled her from her nightmare? The vision wavered then vanished completely leaving her once again in the world of pure light. The woman with wings, who glowed the purest white knelt before her. Her hands cupped Catra's cheeks, her deep lavender eyes were warm, pleading for her to wake up. Catra sucked in a cold breath, as she felt two hands grasp her cheeks. The touch was gentle and full of reassurance. Memories of Adora blazed through her mind. Small cherished moments with her, growing up in the Fright Zone. Moments of friendship, compassion, understanding and kindness paraded through her, empowering her.

“I will always be your friend...” Adora's sweet little voice echoed out to her. So earnest and pure.

The final moments within the Heart of Etheria flashed in her thoughts. Adora lay in her arms...dieing. She felt utterly broken by the sight of it, her soul was shredded. The Heart howled above as Prime infected it. Over a thousand years of stored magic loomed like a raging storm above their heads. Lightening arced across the timeless void they were in, threatening to strike them down. She leaned over Adora's limp body, seeking desperately to protect her. As she held her close, refusing to allow her to give up.

“I love you...I always have...just this once...please.... stay!” Catra heard herself plead, finally having the courage to confess her love. She could feel the crushing despair of losing the only person in her life that truly mattered. How in that moment, she felt her

heart had been ripped out. She had endured so much pain and suffering just to get to this moment, just to have Adora torn from her forever. The torture of that outcome broke her like nothing else could. She could hear the maddening roar of the magic high above. Feel her own heart hammering in her chest, the shallow, rapid breaths leaving her as she cried out for her one true love. Dreading that at any moment she would be gone, leaving her alone forever. Yet comforted by the fact that when the Heart's full power struck them, she would finally be at rest. She would no longer be plagued by her regrets or haunted by her sins. No more what ifs, or what could have been. She would finally know peace... Then Adora's sweet smile, her loving gaze, washed away the fear and misery that had been destroying what was left of her.

“I love you too...” She whispered, clutching Catra's shoulders for support. Then the soft caress of Adora's lips against hers had followed. The unbelievable strength of her love, the need to always protect Adora. Bloomed inside of her, rushed through Catra’s whole body. Cleansing away the dark magic and silencing the whispers.

“Adora!” Catra screamed.

As dark tendrils of smoke slithered over her arms, legs and body, desperate to hold her down. She writhed and fought against the dark magic seeking to absorb her very life.

“Adora!” She screamed again, as fear began to choke her voice.

She snarled and twisted her body in a feral, wild manner. Her arms were pinned to her chest, hands crossed over each shoulder. Her rage was building and exploding threw her muscles. Fueled by a desperate fury. She dug her claws in deep, piercing the flesh of her shoulders and tore downwards to her chest. Ripping her red tunic in a criss-crossed pattern. The fabric shredded, revealing the tops of her breasts. Blood bloomed over the deep scratches on her chest, the thin layer of fur tuft through the torn fabric. The searing pain washed away the last of the dark magic's sedating effects. As the heat of unbridled rage exploded from her body, as

it was engulfed in brilliant flames. The tendrils wailed as they were set alight, vaporizing in the ethereal fire she was now emitting from every pore of her being. Catra's eyes snapped open, glowing with the fury of her magic. A thin silver Tiara of intricate twisting knots appeared upon her forehead. An orange stone glowed within the central knot, humming with an ancient magic. Catra leaped up to her feet and slashed at the fog, now recoiling before her. Flames shot from each clawed finger, howling towards the fog in a powerful, unstoppable vortex. The intense heat struck the fog obliterating it in an instant. As the dark magic dissipated on the wind, Catra charged down the gully at blinding speed. Her glowing claws flashed in the eerie twilight of the swamp, vaporizing the dark tendrils that sought to ensnare her. She was furiously cutting down the dark magic that got in her way, stopping only briefly to sniff the air to track Adora's scent. Her eyes glowed with an inner fire, her entire body was covered in brilliant flame. Leaping and rebounding over fallen trees, resembling a vengeful Ifrit more than a Magicat. Becoming a powerful fire demon, whose flame illuminated the coming darkness, as night fell over the swamp.

Catra was undeterred from her target. All of her senses were primed, her muscles coiling and uncoiling as she covered the distance in seconds. Her mind lay on a single focus... Adora. Sudden panic set in, when Adora's scent suddenly vanished. Catra never allowed herself to lose focus, she shifted her target to the smoky tendrils and followed them instead. Full night had fallen, leaving the bog in pitch darkness. Catra glanced up, finding even the stars could not penetrate the dead growth of trees and vines that twisted over her head. She was so deep into the bowels of the swamp, that finding solid ground was becoming harder. She kept to the trees as much as she could, as the ground below was soft, almost spongey. The dark fog had retreated to the very center of the swamp. What had once been the predator had now become the prey. Catra was hunting them, cooling the fiery glow of her body needing to fade into the darkness. She was now stalking the smoky tendrils from the trees, only her eyes were glowing with her inner magic. Her expression set in grim

determination she would allow them to lead her to Adora. But when she found the source of this malicious magic, she would give them no quarter.

An ancient black obelisk rose into the sky, deep purple designs of the First Ones, glowed upon the varied planes of its outer hull. Resembling more a three pointed star then a sharp pyramid. It wasn't identical to the ruin, she knew now was called The Crystal Castle. That had been designed to train She-Ra and held the gateway to the Heart...the First Ones weapon designed to destroy the whole universe. Catra figured that there are all kinds of First Ones ruins all over Etheria, why should they all look the same. Catra crouched upon a high branch, narrowing her eyes in disbelief.

“That looks like a First Ones ruin?” She spoke softly, scanning the shadows moving in the tall swamp weeds near the base.

The tendrils were coiling and twisting around the obelisk as if protecting it. A mechanical hiss echoed from the strange dark ruin, then a giant door flew up and a long metal ramp extended towards the ground. A small group of shrouded figures shuffled up the ramp, pushing a sleek, metal container with a glass top between them. It hovered off the ground with a soft hum, on a glowing cushion of air. Catra leaped to the ground and moved silently through the weeds towards the ruin needing to get a better look. She sensed Melog as they crawled up behind her, cloaking them both. Her eyes flew wide in terror, as she caught sight of blonde hair inside the container. She could barely see anything with the dark robed figures blocking her view. But she didn't need much to recognize Adora. She had every detail of her face and body memorized from a very young age.

“Ready for this?” She whispered grimly down at Melog.

Melog's unwavering loyalty hummed in her mind, as they brushed up against her. She would never go into battle alone. As the group of robed figures disappeared into the opening, Catra leaped up

onto the ramp, as it began to retract inside, dashing through the opening just as the metal doors hissed closed.

Mudolok

Catra pressed herself up against the wall of the corridor. Wanting to keep a discrete distance. Since the hallway was much more narrow then the previous ruin she had been in. The shape of the corridor was more retangular, rising up high over her head. Then sharply angled like the Crystal Castle's more vaulted, triangle style halls. Either way gaining a tactical advantage here would be just as difficult. There was no room to move around. She also had no idea what or who these robed figures were. The metal surface of the corridor still held the first ones writing, etched in glowing constellation style shapes. But instead of covering the whole wall, the writing ran down the center of the hall in a straight line. She glanced at the alien script bitterly, wishing she could read it. Navigating through these places would be so much easier if she understood the glyphs. Not relishing the prospect of getting lost again like last time, in the narrow, twisting corridor's. That might project any number of bad memories for her to relive.

Melog twisted around her legs, keeping them hidden as they moved silently after the group of robed figures. As they pushed the hovering silver container between them, going down slowly curving halls deeper into the ruin.

In time they moved into a large cargo hold, filled with more the same containers of various sizes and shapes. Lined up in long rows, from end to end of the cavernous room. Robed figures milling between the containers, some cataloging on data pads beside them, other's pushing containers into new smaller rows. Catra creeped up to a row of containers, just beyond the inner bay doors. Tentatively glancing into the glass top, to see inside the container. Taking a slow breath of shock, as she found a Salinean Sea Elf laying inside. The woman had long dark hair, pale blue scaled skin, with the webbed hands and feet of her species. Catra did not know if the woman was alive or dead, but she couldn't afford to be distracted by that right now. She kept slinking amid the rows, glancing into the container's as she

passed. Finding Etherian's from all races, Beasts from the Whispering Woods, the Crimson Wastes...

“What is going on? Who are these people?” She whispered harshly to Melog.

Melog growled low, a dark understanding falling into place. As their own people had gone through this over a thousand years ago.

(*These are Eternian's. They are harvesting Etheria.*)

Catra licked her lips and settled her courage. She had so many questions but now was not the time.

Catra gasped in shock, her stomach lurching with dread at what she saw at the center of the room. Figures were pushing containers up to a very familiar archway. Energy conduits were attached to the sides, large tubes connecting to the sides glowing with the same green light. Where the switch would have been, was a control panel very similar to what was in Darla's command deck.

A small army of robed figures milled around the portal. Cataloging rows of container’s, that were lined up in front of the archway. While others pushed those container's through the green glowing void of the portal.

“They're taking them...” Catra glanced around the room in a panic, suddenly overwhelmed by the severity of the situation. She had gotten distracted by investigating the cargo containers and had lost track of the group holding Adora. She needed to find that group, before they disappeared into the portal.

She could lose Adora forever if she didn't move quickly.

Melog clamped their teeth down onto her arm, sensing she was ready to bolt towards the portal without any common sense.

(*Patience*) They huffed.

Catra gave them a weak snarl, pulling her arm out of their mouth.

“I can't lose her...” Catra's hissed, her voice wavering with fear.

Melog nodded, taking the lead, knowing Catra would have trouble keeping a level head. They moved ahead, crawling on their belly towards the nearest row of containers, closer to the control panel.

Catra moved silently behind them, keeping track of the robed figures' movements and glancing into the container's as they went. Melog sniffed the air, their muzzle wrinkling in disdain at the heavy smell of Eternian's. Fighting down their own rage, wanting to rip the throats out of every one of these power hungry tyrants. That had weakened their planet by stealing it's magic. Then left it like a fresh carcass for Prime to devour.

“Modulok, We found a Master of the Universe.” An excited voice was shouting from near the portal, echoing through the cargo hold.

Catra's ears snapped forward, as Melog brushed up against her, wanting her to mount up. She nodded and crawled silently onto their back. They padded lightly down a row of container's with more urgency, heading straight for the portal.

An odd, insectoid looking creature stood before the portal. Its exoskeleton was a deep, dark red. With six, slender legs, jutting out of a long, segmented thorax. A muscular torso similar to a man grew out of it's insect-like waist, strips of dark leather armour covered it's chest. Crossing over it's waist and hanging like a loin cloth. Two slender arms grew from hunched, narrow shoulders. With human shaped hands, long boney fingers tapped furiously upon a thin data padd. Metal spiked gauntlets gleamed on his wrists in the bright, iridescent light of the hold. The alien creature was cataloging what was going through the portal. What was

most disturbing was the creature's two heads, each had wide, snakelike eyes with slits for pupils. A thin membrane flicked over the eyes when it blinked. Slender pointed ears, twitched on the sides of it's bald heads.

“Wow, I thought Horde Prime and his crazy eyes were creepy looking...” Catra started, her snide comment falling silent when the creature's high pitched, raspy voice echoed from the portal.

“Where is the Portable Rune Stone?” The creature scanned the container. “Without it, this specimen will be worthless. We will have no way to control her.”

The robed figure shrugged, unable to find the courage to speak up. “She didn't need one to transform...” it mumbled weakly.

“Impossible!” The insect creature screamed and back handed the figure. It's hood flew back as its head snapped to the side from the concussion of the blow. Revealing a monstrous face, it's skin was a sickly grey, blotchy and discolored. With a bald, domed head and no ears. What remained of its face was meshed with cybernetic tech. A black crystal was embedded into the creature's forehead, allowing it to store and use black magic. Just like Shadow Weaver had done with her shard of the Black Garnet that she had embedded into her mask. It's skin had scarred and grown around the components sloppily. One of its eyes were replaced with a telescopic lense, the other eye looked lifeless and grey. It had tubes filled with what looked like amniotic fluid like what the Horde Clones used as sustenance, were attached to the back of its neck. Entrapa would have been thrilled to examine these monstrous creatures, but Catra was disgusted. Glancing anxiously around the hold at the robed figures. They were slinking past, with a new found alarm, Catra swallowed hard. She had no chance at fighting so many...how was she going to rescue all these Etherians...how was she going to save Adora?

“Melog...” Catra whispered , leaning low over their slender neck to speak into their ear. She needed a plan...

Melog mewled softly, unsure as to what to do. There were too many of them...surrounded on all sides. If they gave away their position they would only get captured or worse killed. Melog was closing the distance to the portal, slowly, steadily, carefully. They had to stay hidden, stay silent until they reached the portal. Then....then they had no idea how they were going to get out of here with their master's mate!

“Show me!” Modulok shouted, pulling a cable from the side of his pad and jabbing it's sharp connection into the nodule at the base of the creature's neck.

Catra cringed and rubbed the back of her neck, instantly feeling that phantom pain from her time as Horde Primes hostage. The tech these alien's used was so similar to Primes...it was unsettling.

Modulok's screen lit up with footage from the Whispering Woods, as She-Ra dispatched one of their collared beasts. Then footage from the swamp as she succumbed to the dark tendrils. Moduloks snake-like eyes grew wide with excitement, as he glanced from his screen to the stasis pod's display, set on the side of the metal container. That showed Adora's vital signs and genetic sequence.

“You Husks have truly found a treasure on this backwater world. The Etherians, Master of Magic....The Etherian weapon...She-Ra. We implanted a synthetic heart on this planet over a thousand years ago...? I doubt this is the original vessel? But the planet disappeared….it had just shown back up on our star charts within the last year? But the genome of the First Ones are rare...if she is a new vessel, how did she come to this planet? Where did she come from? So many questions…” He mused. “This kind of planetary weapon has not been seen for over a thousand years.” He smiled with triumph, “This truly is a wondrous find. But curious, how does she transform without the Sword of Protection? Does the relic even still exist? I must study her. Take her back to my lab.” He commanded, ripping the cable out of the minion harshly. The monster grunted and nearly lost his balance.

Catra's heart sped up as panic set in.

“Continue harvesting. Lord Skeletor, will be pleased. ” Modulok tossed a hand towards the gathered minions in the cargo hold, turning towards the portal to depart. The energies inside swirled faster, the green now darkening into a deep purple.

“Now Melog...we can't wait!” Catra hissed, the muscles in her legs clenching against their sides, as she was preparing to leap.

“Alert, Eternia's central ground base. Head Scientist Modulok will be returning with precious cargo and will need a Force Guard complement to escort him back to the Capital City of Eternos.” The dark robed figure manning the controls for the portal, spoke into a hand communicator.

Catra knew they were running out of time. As another voice acknowledged the command from the control panel. Melog growled low, quickening their pace. Crouching down as they slowly stalked forward a few meters away from the control panel.

(*You take care of the control panel, we can't have them stealing any more Etherians. I will handle the prey in front of the portal*) They commanded, relief settling in over their nerves when they felt Catra's consent. They were going to clear the distance and leap upon the container holding Adora. Sometimes rushing forward without a plan and improvising was their only option. Melog waited, taking a deep breath as the scientist creature passed through the swirling vortex of the portal. Just as the robed minion moved behind Adora's prison. Preparing to push her container towards the gateway, it was then Melog allowed them to be seen. The cloak shimmered away, in a wavering flash of light.

Catra released a feral, blood curdling scream and leaped at the figure manning the controls. He spun in terror to find a wild woman engulfed in magic flames descending upon him. Her eyes glowed with a fury that froze him in the spot.

Melog leaped onto Adora's container, rocking the anti-grav servos off balance. It spun like a top, knocking the minion that was pushing it, back into the rows of containers below the dais.

Chaos ensued, with some robed minions standing stunned in place, while others ran, or rallied to cast spells towards them. The container's in front of the portal spun and collided with each other as the robed figures bumped them or merely pushed them out of the way in their mad scramble to flee or fight.

Catra slashed the controls, brilliant fire sliced into the metal, melting and fusing the components. The wires hissed and snapped, as the panel exploded. Catra used the smoke to conceal her position, as she leaped and bounded off the containers hovering near the portal, covering the distance to the gateway in seconds.

“We need to get out of here!” She screamed at Melog as she landed on Adora's container. The Krytis born had now doubled in size. Using their magical feline body to protect Adora's container, as dark magic bombarded them. Their mane snapping like brilliant red fire around their head, as they hissed and snarled at the small army attacking them.

Catra gasped in anguish, staring down into the glass window. Barely containing the tears that wished spring forth from her eyes. Finding Adora laying prone, her eyes closed, lips parted slightly in repose. The container resembled a coffin far too closely to her liking. She could not help the grim thought, that Adora looked like she was truly dead. The sight of it sent the most awful misery tearing through her heart. As fury and panic tore through her, all rational thoughts faded away.

She needed to get Adora out of there!

Catra roared and dug her claws into the sides of the glass window. Using her new found strength to pry open the container like it was nothing. Tossing the sheet of sharp glass towards the

black robed minions like a scythe. They screamed and parted, the magic bombardment stopping for a moment.

Giving Catra enough time to haul Adora's limp body, out of the container and drape her unconscious form over her shoulder. Then she leaped upon Melogs large back, who instantly went invisible, cloaking them in a shimmering cloud of magic. Catra eased her grip, allowing Adora's body to slide down in front of her. Her hand braced against her back, sliding up to her shoulder blades. Pushed her forward gently, her head slumping over Catra’s hunched shoulder. She held Adora to her chest tightly with one arm, hanging onto Melog's neck with the other arm. As they bounded through the confused Eternians, racing out of the cargo hold and charged down the corridors. As the first ones symbols began to strobe and flash a bright red.

[Warning, Warning....Eternia Portal disconnected...Crossroads of Worlds failure...Vortex containment compromised...Systems are overloading…] The same computer voice as the ruins Adora had found years ago, echoed throughout the obelisk.

“That's not a good thing...” Catra moaned, “I need you to go faster!” She demanded of Melog.

Melog whimpered, pushing their legs to cover more ground. As the warning echoed again, followed by the screams of Eternian's and the rush of footsteps thundering behind them. They were all seeking to evacuate, the massive crowds closing the distance behind them.

Catra turned her head back, to find the small army charging down the corridor, with a massive fireball roaring behind them.

“Melog!!!” Catra shouted. Melog veered right, running down another corridor to avoid the fireball. Galloping onto a balcony, that overlooked an open central courtyard in the middle of the obelisk. They raced up to the metal railing, finding they were on a balcony several levels above ground. More levels stretched above

to a circular skylight. They could make out a small scattering of stars and the faint light of the moons shining overhead.

Melog groaned and stretched their wings, pumping them just enough to get airborne, then shot up through the skylight. The glass shattered upon impact, Catra hung onto their neck. Bracing Adora against her chest with her other arm more tightly, hunching over her body, keeping her safe. Catra squeezed her eyes shut tight, at their sudden speed and assent. Was sending her stomach right into her toes.

“You gotta warn me next time...” She moaned weakly, trying to hold down her lunch. As Melog leveled out high above the dark peaks of the ruin, several massive explosions blew out of the sides of the various hulls. Sending giant pieces of metal panels and fragments of alien tech over the swamp. Data crystals glinted in the half light of the moons as their shards dusted the murky landscape below them.

Melog circled the now burning obelisk in dismay. Catra held Adora against her chest in relief. Burying her face into Adora's neck, seeking to avoid looking at the tragedy she had caused down below, as the blazing magic faded from her body.

“I'm sorry....I'm not so good at saving people...like you.” She wept, grieving all the innocent Etherian's and native animals that had just been caught up in that explosion. She felt horrible, this just added to the guilt that weighed upon her. But honestly, Adora had been her priority...she always would be.

Melog flew over the prairie, scanning the grassland for Swift Wind. Heading for a glowing magic seal in the distance, near a corpse of living trees. A large rock wall jutting out of the south perimeter of the tree line. It was the same campsite Catra had chosen before the swamp. Melog landed gently, padding towards the warmth of the fire glyph and Swift Wind. They were the same size as the horse, who was smiling at them with pride.

“Much easier when you're this size, huh.” Swift Wind, noted smugly.

Melog gave him a headbutt to the neck in response and settled down by the glyph. They were far too tired to communicate any more with the arrogant bird horse.

Swift Wind chuckled at Melog, taking their silent snark in stride. Then drew serious, prancing nervously near Catra as she dismounted.

“Is she alright?” Swift Wind asked, his crystal blue eyes pleading with Catra for reassurance.

“Yeah...she just needs to rest.” Catra responded in a clipped voice, still too emotionally raw to speak for long. Drawing Adora gently off their back and carrying her near the glyph. Catra laid her down on her side, unclasping her cloak and draping it tenderly over her like a blanket. She knelt low, placing a feather soft kiss to her cheek.

“You are not allowed to do that to me again. Princess.” She whispered against the shell of Adora's ear. “I love you...”

“Catra!” Glimmer's voice called out to her, in both relief and joy.

Catra turned to find Glimmer and Finn entering camp.

“You got her?” Glimmer inquired, dashing up to Adora. Kneeling down beside her and brushing a hand tenderly down her face. “I thought I'd lost her...” she whispered, holding back tears.

Catra couldn't help but note bitterly that Glimmer held no concern for her safe return. She had never cared about losing her. She sighed inwardly, as more negative thoughts took hold. It was plausible that Glimmer really did hate her and had been faking their friendship this whole time to appease Adora. Adora had desperately wanted everyone to get along and like each other. Things had been rather rocky at first, just after Catra’s rescue. Bow had been cordial but not trusting of Catra’s good intentions

and willingness to change, at first. While Glimmer was more warm towards her, but that was because she had a debt to repay. Adora had been an awkward, tragic mess around her for weeks. It had taken forever to get her to relax and be normal. In time they had all bonded, in their own ways and Adora didn't have to over compensate or smooth over anymore misunderstandings between all her best friends.

Catra understood that need for close friendships, craved it, even. But that's just not how things worked, at least not for her. So she had closed her heart off to ever having that kind of connection to others when she was child. She kept people at a distance, believing she could get through life alone. It had only made her feel more lonely, more broken inside. So when she joined the rebellion and started getting to know Glimmer and Bow, she understood what Adora saw in them. They were honest, caring people and she had started to open her heart to them. After what happened in the swamp. Glimmer's words felt like a harsh slap across her heart and she felt the need to pull away, shield herself from more rejection. So she began to close herself off again. Falling inward to that more secure place of uncaring nonchalance that she wore as armor.

"She's going to sleep for a while and when she wakes up, she is going to feel like crap." Catra answered, standing up and moving off. Needing some space, to sort out her raging emotions. She was irritated at Glimmer for being so fake, angry at herself for being so gullible. But she did not want to give away her hurt feelings just yet. Because if the Bright Moon Queen truly did hate her, she was completely justified to feel that way. She moved into the shadows under the outcropping of stone. Slowly, she leaned her back against the rough sandstone and slipped down to the ground. Catra hurt all over, but the cool stone felt good against her back. She sat silently brooding, reviewing somberly her new found powers and the forgotten voice, the strange village she could not remember. Watching Glimmer dig into her backpack by the fire glyph and hand Finn a packet of dried fruit and a chunk of bread.

Even back in the Horde she had felt uncomfortable around other people. When she was little in the nursery. She had been shy and timid, governed by her instincts. Which made her easily startled as a kitten, resulting in lots of hissing and claw injuries to their caregivers. Who did not understand how to care for a magicat. It resulted in her being branded as dangerous, unco-operative and confrontational. The rest of the kids kept their distance...except for Adora. Adora was the only person she wanted to be around anyway. So she grew up as an outsider, never truly fitting in with the rest of the cadets. Shadow Weaver never helped. Always putting her in her place, making sure she knew almost daily that she would amount to nothing, that she was a useless burden...that she didn't belong. The only reason she was allowed to stay was because Adora liked her. Otherwise Shadow Weaver promised she would have been disposed of as a baby.

Catra clenched her jaw, grinding her teeth in fury. That threat had been hung over her head like a noose as she grew up. Knowing exactly what being disposed of was in the Horde. She had seen it...happen….those memories were just one more trauma she had shoved down. Locked them up, tried to forget, in a mental box she would never open. Yet over time and having survived so many horrific things. The hinges had rusted and the lid was now cracked open slightly. Allowing those trauma’s to manifest as nightmares as she slept. Prime wasn’t the only demon that haunted her, she had a whole army of nasty memories waiting in the wings to torment her.

Catra clutched a hand full of stones and threw them angrily into the darkness. Shadow Weaver had been such a nasty woman. Cruel, calculating and bitter. She had been that woman's punching bag her whole life. Verbally or otherwise...

Catra groaned and thumped the back of her head against the stone, wishing to stop thinking about her. Those painful memories she wished Horde Prime had wiped away permanently, she might have been a much happier person for it.

“You look terrible.” Glimmer's voice intruded upon her brooding. Catra glanced up briefly, to find the young, pink haired woman standing in front of her. Glimmer crouched down next to her with a bottle and roll of gauze.

“I've been better.” Catra stated dryly, keeping her poker face in place.

Glimmer sighed and poured some clear liquid onto a folded piece of gauze.

“I don't have any healing magic like Adora but this should help.” She offered, with a weak smile, dabbing the moist cloth against the cut on Catra's temple.

Catra hissed and clenched her eyes shut.

“What the hell...” She growled, the side of her head felt like Glimmer had set it on fire!

“It's disinfectant...you look like you just took on an army of Horde Bots….and lost.” She moaned with empathy, wiping the blood away from Catra's cheek before moving down to tend to the deep gouges that criss-crossed her chest. Lightly pulling the shredded fabric of her tunic aside to dab lightly at the wounds.

Catra hissed in pain, as the salve burned against her skin beneath her thin layer of tan fur.

“You are totally enjoying this. Aren't ya, Sparkles.” She commented snidely, followed by a small bitter laugh.

Glimmer pulled away, gasping in horror.

“No!” She shouted, casting her eyes down in shame when Catra slowly looked at her. Her mismatched eyes confused, but guarded. Then Glimmer sighed heavily, brushing a hand, nervously threw her short pink hair.

“Look...Catra...I'm...” Glimmer stammered, hesitant to start this painful confession.

“Stop!” Catra, raised a warding hand. “I don't want to hear it. As far I'm concerned we're good. You have every right to feel the way you do, forever. If that is what you want.” She passed Glimmer a thin smile of sad understanding. “I deserve it...all of it.” She finished, her voice barely a whisper.

Glimmer dropped the bottle and gauze, then pressed both hands against her own face. Screaming softly in frustration.

“I hate this...I hate all of this...” She growled. “We just got done fighting for our lives....now we are fighting for our lives!”

Catra laughed lightly at her nonsensical tirade.

“Shouldn't be much of a problem for us, we got a lot of experience.” Catra smirked, watching Glimmer slide down the stone wall beside her with a bitter sweet smile.

“Want to tell me what happened back there?” She asked quietly, drawing her legs up to her chest and draping her arms over her knees.

“Not really, I figure I'd wait till Adora's awake then I'll tell you both. It’s a long, complicated story and I'm really tired right now.” Catra responded, scratching her claws into the earth at her sides. She really wished Glimmer would just leave, the burning ache of guilt and remorse, at the pain she had caused her, was growing heavy in her stomach. Along with a good dose of self loathing and insecurity about their friendship. She didn't know how long she could stay composed and fake this small talk. Before either lashing out in anger to push her away or start crying. So she just closed her eyes and focused on her breathing, wanting to maintain her composure.

She refused to show weakness...

Glimmer nodded and they sat in silent companionship for a long while. Catra never opened her eyes or thanked her for her help. Hiding behind that well fortified wall of apathy, not dealing with her emotions.

“Really, I don't hate you, at least not anymore.” Glimmer tossed back, done being ignored. She stood up and headed back to Finn by the glyph.

Catra took a deep breath, as the pressure of holding in her emotions lifted. She wondered if she could trust what Glimmer said? They had worked out a lot of their animosity towards one another back on Primes ship, just before she had teleported her to Adora. She felt they had come to a sort of truce while on Primes Ship, during their time on Darla it had turned into what she thought was an honest friendship...now she was so conflicted. Could she trust Glimmer to mean what she said? Had she forgiven her….didn’t hate her….wanted her around, accepted her, faults and all? It was incredibly difficult for her to understand how Glimmer could just let her grudges go. She had wallowed in her grudges for years, they had been the only thing to sustain her during the war….before Prime...

Catra kept a watchful eye on the prairie beyond the camp, from her position against the rock wall. The cool wind was blowing the tall grass in waves. The leaves of the corpse of trees nearby, rustled. The branches creaked as the night drew on. Glimmer had cuddled up against Adora's back, under her heavy cloak, wanting to stay close to the blonde, needing the comfort of physical contact. After surviving such a traumatic afternoon. Catra had refused to return to the fire glyph, glowering out over the dark fields instead. Wallowing in her guilt over how bitter sweet her rescue had turned out.

Knowing how upset she was, after an absolutely wretched day. Melog had fallen asleep and their low purr resounded through the campsite. Seeking to soothe Catra's turbulent emotions, in a gentle, unobtrusive way. Swift Wind had settled nearby in the tall grass, snorting fitfully in his sleep. While Finn had huddled by the glyph for most of the night, refusing to sleep, the same as Catra. Once again drawing in the dirt with a stick and singing softly to himself. At first his play had been annoying, but now after all the tragedy she had endured. Catra found watching the small innocent actions comforting. He had such a zeal for life, enjoying each moment for what it was and not yearning for anything more. Catra wished to be able to live like that, so oblivious and carefree. She smiled softly as Finn danced with his stick, swiping it around in the air as if he was drawing a magic glyph. He stopped when he noticed she was watching him and trotted over to her.

“I thought everyone was sleeping.” He settled himself down next to her, leaning against the stone wall and gazing up at the night sky wistfully.

Catra refused to let him know how much she appreciated his company. Keeping her expression bland, she followed his gaze up to the stars. She had been feeling really lonely and his presence was a balm against even more negative thoughts.

“The sky sure is amazing now...” He sighed, turning around and flopping down on his back. He smiled gently up at the starry night.

Catra glanced down at him briefly, flicking her gaze up to the sky again. She was having a hard time connecting with this kid. She didn't remember ever being so happy or care free. A big part of her resented Finn and his ability to let the bad stuff he experienced just slide off without any lasting damage. Thanks to her cruel upbringing and bad choices, she was the definition of damaged.

“You know if you look hard enough you can make pictures out of the stars.” He grinned, pointing his finger up at the sky.

Catra arched an eyebrow in curiosity, she shrugged and flopped down on her back beside him. Resting her hands on her stomach, she listened to him prattle on about the stars. Following his finger across the eternal skyline as he pointed out his own constellations. He showed her several of his heavenly discoveries, like the arrow, the big spoon and his favorite.

“That's the cake stars.” He grinned, pointing to a cluster of stars that formed a circle with a single set of four stars coming out of the top like a candle.

“I've had cake...” Catra mused sleepily. “I got to have some with Adora and her friends just after we defeated Horde Prime...Castaspella just 'poofed' it into existence...it was really cool. I'm starting to like magic.” She laughed at the warm memory of sitting around a fire glyph in the middle of the night, deep inside the Whispering Woods. The rebellion tents scattered around a large glade behind them. Eating cake right off a giant platter with the rest of the Princesses. As they laughed and bantered back and forth amongst themselves. Catra had sat quietly with them, enjoying the sweet companionship they shared. But not quite comfortable enough to be a part of their banter. But she was with Adora and as always it had been enough. She grinned happily, rolling her head to face Finn.

The little Thaymorian smiled sweetly at her, then poked a finger squarely into the center of her forehead. Catra's eyes went wide in surprise, she thought she was the only person who did this to get someone's full attention.

“You think too much, Cat Lady.” He stated flatly, then yawned. “You need to try and relax and enjoy the little things. Life’s too short for regrets, accept what you can't change and move forward with good intentions. At least that's what my moms always said."

He never even asked permission, just wiggled into her side for warmth. Snuggling in tight to her chest, with his little hands curled against her waist. Catra sighed rolling onto her side and wrapped an arm around the little kid.

“Maybe you're right, kid.” She yawned, slowly falling asleep.

Catra awoke with a shiver, her fur was cold and moist from the morning dew. With a groan she rolled onto her back, finding Finn was gone. With a sigh of resignation, she lifted herself up from the rough ground and trudged towards the now brightly glowing fire glyph to warm up. Glimmer sat next to Finn, digging into her pack for breakfast. She offered Catra a weak, apologetic smile as she passed. Catra ignored it, moving straight to Adora and knelt down. She pressed the back of her hand against Adora's forehead, feeling for a fever. She was very worried about the repercussions of yesterday. Adora had been She-Ra for far too long and the toxic effects of that dark magic would take an untold toll on her body, if it had already been weakened by her magic. Finding her temperature still cool, Catra nodded in approval. Adora's body seemed to be handling the effects of the parasitic magic just fine. She was sleeping soundly, curled up in a ball under her cloak, snoring lightly. She-Ra was a very potent magic and wielding her for too long put a lot of strain on Adora's body. She was going to be awfully sore when she woke up, though.

“Is she going to be ok?” Glimmer asked quietly.

“Yeah, between She-Ra and that dark magic spell, it packs quite a punch. She might not wake up anytime soon though.” Catra glanced up at the grey morning sky. Sniffing the air tentatively.

Rain was threatening again, it was holding off for the time being. But the sky was thickly overcast, the clouds hanging heavy with moisture.

“Explains why I feel like I just got hit by a Horde Tank.” Glimmer grumbled, pulling out a couple apples and heading over to Swift Wind.

Catra watched her go, her expression was pensive. Their relationship was strained now, awkward.

Finn was digging into another packet of dried fruit, casting each of them concerned looks. He never spoke up about the tension between them. Keeping his council to himself this time.

Melog padded softly to Catra's side, cocking their head quizzically as they sat in front of Adora.

(*How is your mate?)*

“She just needs to sleep.” Catra sighed heavily, as she brushed some stray strands of blonde hair off Adora’s forehead tenderly.

Melog rocked their head in the other direction.

(*How are you doing?)*

“I'm fine, too..” Catra responded pointedly. “ A bit sore, but nothing I can't handle.”

Melog huffed and nuzzled her cheek, knowing better. He could feel the emotional turmoil still churning inside her from the tragic outcome of last night. The confusion and hurt tearing at her heart in regards to Glimmer.

“I'm dealing...obviously. Back off.” Catra lightly pushed Melog's comforting muzzle away and stood up. She was getting irritated by all the concern, she just wanted some space.

Melog huffed again and nodded. They padded away, giving their whole body a shake as their iridescent mane fluttered briefly like a red flame. Purging all the negative emotions Catra was giving off from their aura.

“We need to find some decent shelter before that storm breaks.” Catra pointed up to the clouds as she approached Glimmer.

Swift Wind was happily chewing on an apple.

“There's an old farm house to the north near Thaymor?” Swift Wind offered, before snatching another apple from Glimmer's hand.

“Fine.” Catra nodded.

“But...” Glimmer began, staring sadly towards Finn.

“He will just have to deal. Adora's gonna be asleep for a few days and we need a safe place out of elements. ” Catra snarled back. “Life’s not always fair!” She shouted in frustration storming back towards the fire glyph.

Glimmer took a breath, Catra was right, she just wished that she could be a little more compassionate about how that little kid was gonna feel.

“We gotta go, kid.” Catra stomped over to the glyph and began kicking dirt on it to snuff it out.

Finn looked up, his cheeks stuffed with food and nodded. Trotting off towards Swift Wind. Catra swung Adora's cloak around her own shoulder's and pinned it in place. Then she carried Adora gently in her arms, propping her up against Melog's neck as she mounted behind. Glimmer rode on Swift Wind, with Finn who was sitting in front of her, pressed against the horse’s orange mane.

Melog stretched his wings, much more confident with them. Soon they were airborne, banking away into the grey dawn towards the abandoned farm.

Guarded Heart

Adora came awake, groggy and disoriented. Warm afternoon light was filtering through a tiny open window. The smell of prairie grass and the spicy aroma of food filled the air. She glanced around nervously, finding herself in a small room. Thick wooden rafter's stretched above on the roof, the walls made of tree trunks, the cracks filled with clay. She lay upon a hay mattress on a simple wooden bed. A small box window was across from her. She watched the old, faded white curtain snap and flutter in the breeze for a while before glancing to the door. It was open leading to the main room and she could hear the bright voices of Glimmer and Finn speaking softly.

Rolling her head to the side, she found a woven wicker chair set next to the bed. Catra was slouched on the worn grey cushion. Her arms wrapped around her middle, hunched over, her head hanging low, dozing fitfully. Her temple was bruised and long scratches were healing along the other side of her face. Her shoulders and the front of her tunic was shredded from her claws. Angry pink scratches were healing beneath the torn fabric.

Catra looked so beat up, the sight of her wounds broke Adora's heart. What had happened? She couldn't remember anything beyond falling unconscious. Adora shuddered in fear, not knowing, losing control, it terrified her more than anything else. She quickly shook off the rising trepidation, glancing with hope and pride at Catra. She would know what happened, all of her wounds were no doubt from saving her.

She could always count on Catra, she would always have her back.

As long as we stay together, nothing really bad can happen...

Adora clutched her head as she slowly sat up, every part of her was sore and ached with a bone deep pain. Her ponytail had loosened, stray hair from her long bangs fell over her forehead and over her eyes. She felt miserable and hungry. She glanced down and picked at her mud covered shirt. Alright she was dirty, sore and hungry.

Glancing around the room, she found a large wooden tub, with a heating glyph glowing just beneath. Soap and bath towels sitting on a tiny stool nearby. She would try and have a quick bath. She might not be able to clean up her clothes anytime soon. But she could wash off the long days of travel from her body.

She moved slowly, slipping her legs over the side of the bed. Grimacing and clenching her teeth at every stiff movement, her muscles protesting at being used. She found happily that she wasn't wearing her boots or socks. Her feet were bare and the cold wooden floor felt wonderful against the soles of her feet. She pushed herself up off the bed, too stubborn to give into the ache throbbing through her muscles. Shuffling her feet a few steps, forcing her body to move even just a little bit. Before a tingling, burning sensation exploded threw the muscles of her legs and she crumple to the floor with a yelp.

Catra jumped off the chair at the sudden exhalation.

“Adora!” She scrambled to her side, finding the blonde flat on her stomach.

“Why....is my body not working?” Adora moaned in humiliation, mumbling into the floorboards.

“Because you stayed transformed for too long and got poisoned by black magic, you dummy. ” Catra chastised with a lighthearted fit of laughter. The weight of the last few days lifted instantly, replaced by joy and relief to have Adora back.

She lightly rolled Adora over and poked her in the forehead with a clawed finger.

“What were you thinking?”

“Swift Wind heard someone calling for help, so we went to investigate.” Adora sighed, crossing her arms petulantly. As the claw tapped her between the eyes playfully.

“I'm going to kill that stupid horse.” Catra growled, as she crouched beside Adora.

“Please don't...” Adora pleaded, struggling to sit up.

“You always get into trouble without me.” Catra smirked.

“I wouldn't get into trouble if you would stop running off.” Adora retaliated with a playful look of irritation.

“Ok...ok...” Catra, offered her a hand and pulled her up to her feet. Then wrapped a protective arm around her shoulders and guided her back to the bed.

Adora sat down reluctantly on the bed, with her legs dangling off the side. Staring longingly at the bathtub. “I would love a bath...” She sighed.

Catra merely nodded, blushing lightly. As she carefully pulled, up Adora's long sleeve shirt. Adora raised her arms over her head, allowing Catra to pull the garment off. Catra turned with the fabric in her hands, discretely pressing Adora's shirt up to her nose and taking a deep sniff. She needed a little comfort, it had been a long few days of worry as she watched over Adora. Adora's scent always settled her anxieties. With a sigh she tossed it aside, on top of Adora’s balled up cloak. Turning back to the exhausted blonde with a reassuring smile.

“What happened to me?” Adora asked quietly, as Catra worked on slipping her pants down her legs.

“Lots....none of it good.” Catra responded cryptically. Bunching the heavy grey fabric of both pant legs down by Adora's ankles and giving a strong pull. Yanking the pants off with a small cry of

triumph. She tossed them aside and cleared her throat nervously. Finding her love, sitting before her in nothing but her underwear. A simple cotton white bra and tight black shorts. She couldn't help but stare longingly at her. Drawing her eyes up every inch of her strong athletic frame. Her toned stomach with its compact muscle, was such an alluring sight. Catra's heart was beating fast in her chest. Physically, Adora had changed so much in the last three years. To be able to wield She-Ra for longer periods of time. Adora had to put in long hours of weight training and stamina building exercises. Welding that heavy broad sword for two years. Her arms were now twice the size that they had been when she had left Catra years ago. The muscles of her shoulders and biceps rippled and flexed as she shifted nervously under Catra's steady, admiring gaze. She had filled out in all the right places, leaving her awkward, skinny adolescent body behind. Her skin was soft, pliable and silky smooth. Catra longed to run her fingers over every inch of her supple body. Hungered to caress the soft flesh of her large, perfectly formed breasts. Kiss away all the small scars that covered her body, knowing that most were marks she had made as they grew up. Some created in fits of rage, others not of her own choice. Her gaze fell upon the raised skin of the FailSafe scar that remained upon her chest, just above her breasts, upon her collar bone. The sight of it was bitter sweet. It was a mark that spoke of their first kiss and the blossoming love they now shared. It was also a scar, left over from Adroa’s willingness to sacrifice herself for Etheria.

Taking a deep calming breath, Catra knelt before Adora. Suddenly overwhelmed, her eyes lost their playful shine and became distant. She had almost died...Catra swallowed hard. She could have lost everything that truly mattered to her. She tentatively drew her claw over the scar, her finger trembling. She blinked a few times trying to calm herself, knowing that her eyes were filled with tears. Adora shivered at the feather light touch, Catra's claw tickling the tender flesh. Fighting to hold back tears of her own, over how profoundly sad Catra looked while tracing the scar. She never would have taken on the Fail Safe, if there had been any other viable options. But there weren't, she was the only person

that might survive the Heart. As always, she was the chosen one to bear the burden. Catra could never understand how she could give up everything, even her life for others. She had nearly lost her over that selfless choice. But Adora always put others first, yet now she was learning that her happiness mattered too.

“I will never lose you...again.” Catra promised in a breathy whisper, reluctant to pull her eyes up from the scar. But Adora cupped her cheeks in her hands and forced her to look up at her. Catra raised her head slowly as Adora guided her troubled gaze upward. Gently, pulling Catra from the floor, to kneel on the edge of the bed. Catra instinctively slipped her knee between Adora's legs. Gripping the blondes shoulder gently, as she hovered over her. Adora raised her face up to meet hers, as Catra bent down, pressing her lips softly against hers. Seeking to soothe the ache of those bad memories with a more tactile reminder that they were ok.

They had survived and were finally together, in all the ways they had both truly wanted.

The kiss lingered and grew with passion. Becoming hungry, a longing for more passing between them. Adora moaned with need, when Catra swept her tongue inside her mouth. Unable to resist the urge to taste her. Adora thrust her own tongue inside Catra's mouth, tangling and twisting as she deepened the kiss. Catra's breath was coming fast, as she adjusted her hold, raking her hands thru Adora's hair. Pulling out the elastic of her ponytail as she went, gripping the back of Adora's head. As Adora's blonde hair unfurled over Catra's wrists and down around her shoulders. Their tongues spared, thrusting and retreating as the passion built, becoming something wild and unrestrained. Adora struggled to keep up, as Catra possessively held her head in place. Her longer feline tongue thrusted deep then withdrawing. Catra pulled back for only a second, taking in Adora's hooded, blissful gaze. A lazy, proud smile pulling upon her kiss swollen lips. Then swiftly drew back in, suckling her bottom lip, making Adora moan with rising need. Then covered Adora's mouth with hers, smothering any further sounds.

Adora felt her return kisses were clumsy and sloppy compared to the finesse Catra possessed. With her tongue sweeping deep and then retreating. Varying the pressure and angle of her lips against hers, sucking and nipping. As her purr resounded through out the room. A yearning for more built between them. Adora moaned with desire, a needy ache building low in her belly. Caught up in the passion, she swept her tongue deep into Catra's mouth, when something sharp pierced her tongue.

Catra cried out in alarm, as Adora yelped.

Catra pulled back, retreating several steps away from the bed. Eyes wide in shock, clasping her hands over her mouth. Adora laughed in mortification, sticking her tongue out to check the damage. Finding a spot of blood forming on the tip of her tongue.

"I'm sorry..." Catra breathed, her eyes full of remorse. Adora had nicked herself on one of her sharp fangs. Adora shook her head and laughed, bowing her head, her cheeks flaring in humiliation.

"I am such a dork, I think I need to practice more." she stated, casting Catra a goofy lopsided grin. Her soft blue eyes shone with a simmering passion as she stared at Catra.

Catra's frown quickly turned to a smug, excited grin at the prospect of more kisses. They shared happy laughter for a moment before Catra sobered. The blush upon her cheeks burned even more as she returned to kneel beside Adora on the bed, her nimble fingers working upon the clasps of her bra.

"Catra..." Adora breathed, suddenly very aware of what she had asked of her girlfriend. They had grown up together, used the communal showers many times with their squad. They had seen each other naked tons of times. Being it to tend to wounds received from harsh training sessions, or corporal punishments, or just needing to clean up. But things were different now, their relationship had moved way beyond friendship. The intense

sensual feelings she harbored for Catra now were far more carnal in nature.

“Yeah...” Catra's hot breath, puffed against the back of her neck. Adora instantly arched her back and went rigid. Sucking in a cold, startled breath. Then the last clasp loosened and her bra fell away, falling softly to her lap. As the cold air brushed against her bare breasts. Adora moaned and bit the side of her lip, bashful and burning with desires she didn't know how to deal with. Her nerves were shot and her instinct to hide herself was suddenly very strong. She instantly shot an arm up to conceal her bare breasts as Catra shifted off the bed. Adora's face felt extremely hot, her nervous anxiety pleasantly set at ease. When she found Catra's face was just as flushed. Sharing with her the same awkward arousal, over what they were doing.

“Com'on Princess...I've seen you naked like a thousand times.” Catra laughed, trying to hide how turned on she was. With fake nonchalance towards the whole situation, kneeling down before Adora. Valiantly trying to stay on task and not allow her eyes to wander upward. Yet her hands were trembling as she tossed the bra aside, reaching for the band of Adora's underwear next.

“I know....but still...this time it's different.” Adora rolled her eyes. Her breath hitched, as she felt Catra's fingers slipping into the top of her underwear at her hips. Clamping her eyes shut tight, her heart hammering in her chest. Adora held her breath.

“Adora...” Catra chided. Her voice was soft, but she was breathing rapidly. “Let me take care of you.”

Adora nodded briskly, as she raised her butt off the mattress. Heard Catra take a sharp intake of breath at the exact moment she pulled down her underwear.

Catra leaned back, unable to resist taking in Adora's naked body for a moment. Her glorious form was on full display for the first time in years. She was so demure and sweet, with her head cast sideways, eyes closed tight and cheeks flushed a rosy pink. Catra

was holding her breath, an arousing heat had blossomed low in the very core of her body. Adora was seducing her, without even trying. She was just so gorgeous and pure. She liked how wild and out of control her arousal felt but it scared her as well. She yearned to be more intimate with Adora, but would take things slow. She would respect the pace, Adora set. When she was ready for more, she would initiate and Catra would comply. She cleared her throat, grasping her libido in a choke hold and forced it to submit to prudence, needing to stay on task. Catra wrapped an arm around Adora's waist and helped her stand. They moved slowly towards the tub. Adora leaned heavily on Catra as she guided her gently into the water.

Adora moaned blissfully as she slipped into the warm water. The heat soothed every ache, her whole body relaxing along with her nerves. She leaned casually against the tub, resting the back of her head against the rim. Her eyes closed, as she hummed with delight. Basking in the heat, listening to Catra busy herself gathering the soap and a cloth.

“Thank you...” Adora breathed, feeling every muscle loosen.
“I promised, right.” Catra responded, “That I would always take care of you.”

Adora felt Catra’s breath, it was hot and puffed softly against her cheek. Before her lips followed, pressing tenderly against the side of her face. Adora raised a wet hand from the water and caressed the side of her face lovingly. Holding Catra close, unwilling to let go of the tender moment passing between them.
“I remember...” Adora smiled, slowly opening her eyes to find Catra kneeling beside the tub. A cloth and soap in her hands. Her face was flushed and she offered Adora her sweetest most honest smile.

“I am so glad you're alright.” She spoke quietly, dipping the cloth and soap into the water.

“Why did you run off?” Adora inquired, her tone serious.

Catra sighed, her movements slow and steady as she brought the soap up from the water. Her hands trembled as she began to caress the soap along Adora's collar bone.

Adora held her breath at Catra's irreverent touch, their eyes met for only an instant. Before Catra refocused her gaze upon her work. Washing her collar bone, trailing the cloth over both her shoulders, caressing her neck and then washing down each arm.

“I needed to scout ahead, make sure seeing Thaymor wasn't going to hurt Finn, I've hurt that kid enough.” Catra answered softly, the guilt and remorse thick in how her voice trembled.

Adora smiled, “You do care.” her tone playful, wanting to give Catra a hard time and hopefully get her to ease up on herself. She had been acting rather aloof and apathetic towards Finn. Giving off the impression that she didn’t like him much. But Adora knew she had a big heart. Even if she kept it hidden most of the time.

“Obviously, I'm not some heartless monster.” Catra scoffed, the hurt and anger burning in her eyes. As she shot Adora a hard look.

“I never thought you were?” Adora was taken off guard by her choice of words, but they were incredibly telling. She watched Catra for a few moments needing to gauge her emotional state. She could fall into some really dark places. Adora had always protected her from that. She had seen it again and again over the years back in the Horde. Something would set Catra off, she would start to brood then spiral down into her anger, her destructive self loathing. When she had left the Horde, no one had been there to pull Catra out of that darkness and she had spun out of control for years. Adora felt immense guilt about not being there for her.

Never again.

Adora snatched Catra's hands from the water. Holding them tightly, she searched Catra's eyes for her true feelings. The ones

she was hiding, behind that self deprecating remark.

“Talk to me.” She demanded.

Catra groaned and squeezed her eyes shut, unwilling to face Adora's concern.

“I'm fine...” She growled. “It was just a joke.”

“No, it wasn't.” Adora let go of her hands and bowed her head in remorse. “I’m sorry if what I said, hurt you. I was just trying to give you a hard time.”

“It’s fine...I’m just a little worked up is all.” Catra shrugged, deflecting Adora’s concern by tweaking one of her nipples. Desperate to destract her from pursuing further explainations.

Adora cried out sharply, smacking her finger’s away and gapping slack jawed at Catra's boldness.

Catra was shocked by her own actions, eyes wide and brows so high they were nearly lost in her hairline.

“Talk to me, Catra.” Adora quickly gathered her wits. Crossing her arms over her bare chest feeling she needed to protect them from further assault and staring up at her sternly.

Catra groaned, none of the tactics she used in the past to avoid opening up about her feelings with Adora were working. She wasn’t ready...might never be able to come clean about what happened in the swamp without losing everything that mattered to her. Catra stared at the water, hesitant and scared. As the concern and worry in Adora’s eyes bored down into the back of her head.

“We got much more serious stuff happening, then my stupid issues.” Catra shouted, dropping the soap and cloth into the bathwater. Before storming out of the room.

Adora watched her go and her heart broke just a little. Before she had left the Horde, Catra would have just opened up to her, begrudgingly allowed her to comfort her, they would have worked it out. Now...She just balled up all that hate and anger and allowed it to fester inside her. Adora groaned and raked her hands down her face in frustration. Then sank under the water, blowing annoyed bubbles under the surface. Wondering if things between her and Catra would ever not be so damn complicated.

When Adora came out of the bedroom, dressed in her white compression shirt and grey pants. With her hair hanging damp and loose around her shoulders. She found Glimmer and Finn were sitting at a small round, wooden table waiting for her. She glanced around the main living space, finding no trace of Catra. It was a simple home.. With a large fireplace made of collected field stones, all different shapes and sizes. Set against the back wall, with an iron pot hanging from a hook. Two cloth chairs with wooden carved arm rests sat before the fireplace, the cushions were stuffed with hay. Straw stuck out of the pale grey cloth here and there. Two small windows were set into the log walls at the front of the room.

Glimmer smiled warmly at her, offering her to sit on a simple wooden chair at the table. She must have bathed during the time she had slept. Her pink hair glistened in the sunlight and her eyes sparkled with joy at seeing her.

A big bowl of stew sat before the empty chair and Adora moved briskly to sit.

“I am so hungry.” She stated, as they both laughed. Finn offered her a chunk of bread and cheese.

“How long did I sleep? She asked around huge mouthfuls.

“Two days.” Glimmer answered.

Adora's eyes flew wide in alarm, she hadn't been that worn out since the Heart.

“We're staying at Old Grimbles farm. “ Finn offered, “The old goat has some really neat stuff, in what's left of the barn.”

Adora gave him an approving smile, then resumed eating.

Glimmer watched Adora shovel food into her mouth for a few minutes before speaking again. She sat resting an elbow on the table and her chin in her hand. She gave Adora a knowing smile, watching her best friend eat with such gusto, was a welcoming sight. She had been very worried.

“How has Catra been?” Adora asked, slowing down and able to speak now that the stew was gone. She tore off a hunk of bread and popped it into her mouth.

“Catra.” Glimmer gave her a non committal shrug.

“That bad?” Adora sighed, having finished off the bread she was nibbling on the cheese.

“Whatever she encountered in that swamp, it really shaken her and I didn't help.” Glimmer pouted, crossing her arms over her chest.

Adora raised a questioning eyebrow.

“The magic made me see things...my mom...I kinda freaked out when Catra saved me and said a-lot of really not so nice things.” Glimmer took a deep breath that she released slowly, giving Adora a very pained expression.

Adora licked her bottom lip and then started to chew on the edges, anxiety clear in the shimmer in her eyes. After her mother was lost, Glimmer had been filled with so much anger. She had lashed out and Adora had been her primary target, then. Their friendship had almost ended. But Catra had been the catalyst that led to Angella's loss. The Queen had a sharp tongue, her choice of

words could be rather venomous. Adora could only imagine what terrible things Glimmer might have said to Catra.

“Did you apologize?” Adora inquired.

“I tried, she wouldn't listen.” Glimmer stated with irritation. Catra had been avoiding her for days, when she did manage to get her to talk. Her friendly attitude was polite, and totally fake. But after pressing her several more times to hear her out. Catra's demeanor changed to irritation, snapping at her to just leave her alone. It hurt how much damage she had done and how Catra would not even try to let her repair their friendship.

Adora flicked her eyes up to Glimmer for a moment then glanced down at her hands in her lap. Twisting her fingers and picking at her cuticles as she contemplated her next move. Concerning Catra and her less than stellar coping methods. There was more than just Glimmer's words of anger that was bothering her. Whatever it was, whatever happened, it had shaken Catra to her very core. She was angry with herself, more than usual? Her comment about being a monster spoke volumes as to what she was brooding upon. She was also scared....more scared then she had ever been. She only sought out solitude when she was overwhelmed by too many emotions. Since she had been hiding for the last few days. Catra was dealing with some serious problems.

“What happened to you there?” Glimmer asked.

“I don't remember, you got lost, I freaked out, then I woke up here.” Adora shrugged, refusing to tell Glimmer how the magic had seduced her with selfish images of a normal life. Of a happy future without worries or responsibilities. A future without She-Ra.

Finn had watched the painful exchange between them. His heart hurt for them, Catra was acting like a complete brat and neither of them deserved to be treated so badly. He jumped off the chair and chucked a thumb to the heavy oak door. Then dashed off without another word.

Catra had retreated to the highest point in the barn, the hayloft. The back of the platform was filled with loose hay. The air was stale and dust was floating in the filtered sunlight, streaming in through the gapes in the wooden slats above. Melog was curled up beside her, offering her support and comfort as best they could. As she sat on the edge of the wooden platform, one leg tucked under her butt with her other leg dangling over the side. She had been lost in the same grim thoughts. Concerning her failure to protect all those people at the obelisk. Her mind spinning over how angry and disappointed Adora would be if she found out. How she would finally give up on her, knowing that she truly was a monster just like Shadow Weaver had professed. The bitterness towards her bad luck and her self-loathing was a constant companion for her. She didn't need Shadow Weaver to verbally berate her anymore. The vicious, snide voice that lived inside her head did a fine job of beating her down. She knew she was a terrible person...just like Shadow Weaver. Her cruelty and all the people she had hurt in the past was proof enough.

Then her thoughts spun back to the strange magic that had taken over her when she saw that village filled with people just like her. She had lived for nearly twenty years and seen all manner of Etherian's, not one had looked like her. She had always felt like she was alone, an outsider, that no one could truly understand. Adora had been the closest she had to family but even then there were times when she was completely at a loss in regards to Catra. To see so many people who looked like her, it had given her hope. That perhaps somewhere, her people were still alive? That yearning to belong, to have a history, a culture that might explain why she was the way she was? It evoked a selfish want she had never felt before. Catra picked at the splinters, her claws had dug out of the wood in the floor. She didn't know how she was going to explain any of that to anyone, especially Adora. Then her mind drifted back into the darkness, if she knew how many people Catra had killed...she would hate her for sure. Catra growled in annoyance with herself. Raking her claws down her short hair, trying to find some semblance of control over her raging

emotions. That had been swinging like a pendulum from one bad thought to another, for days. The negativity was festering and roiling inside her heart like a cancer.

Melog yeowled beside her, their iridescent mane had turned a dark lavender, trembling with the turbulent emotions washing over them. Catra sighed and began to soothe Melog, by absently petting them down their back. She was grateful for their support and attempt to comfort her. But sometimes she was just a lost cause.

Finn's voice singing in a high pitched warble caught her attention. She glanced down, finding the child skipping through the alley between empty animal stalls with a large stick. His mess of blonde hair curled around his sharp horns, the tips glinting in the half light of the barn.

“Grumpy cat, Grumpy cat.”

“She is so very grumpy.”

“You gotta remember, she's got a temper.”

“Scowling and shouting, scaring and snapping, stomping her feet upon the ground.”

“Causing trouble with everyone, all around.”

Finn struck his stick against the wooden gates of the stalls, keeping a steady rhythm to his song. He knew she was here and he was calling her out on her behavior. In a childishly irritating, passive aggressive sort of way. Catra leaned over the hayloft, her ears twitching in fury, tail snapping as she tracked Finn with her eyes.

“Grumpy cat, Grumpy cat!” Finn shouted, swinging his stick at the thick wooden post at the end of the stall gate with all that he had. Catra narrowed her eyes, noticing with confusion that Finn was crying.

Unable to stay hidden at the sight of his tears, knowing that she ended up hurting him along with everyone else. She was urged to try and repair the damage she had caused. So she leaped from the loft, landing softly just behind him.

“Nice song, kid.” She smirked with irritation, bracing her hands on her hips.

“Why are you like this?” Finn spun to face her, scowling up at her.

Catra arched an eyebrow then merely shrugged.

“You’ve made everyone unhappy? Why?” He stated bluntly.

“Cause I'm a Grumpy cat, obviously.” She responded snidely.

Finn sniffled and rubbed the back of his hand under his nose. Glaring up at Catra, his blue eyes burning with frustrated anger.

“You barely spend any time with us. You have been so mean to Glimmer. You barely talk to me, now, and that hurts. Now Adora's gonna cry cause you're mad about something and hiding in the barn...” He raised his stick and poked her right in the chest.

Catra looked pained for a moment, glancing through the large open barn door to the old farmhouse.

“You're not really good at this, are you?” Finn took a deep breath refusing to give into his anger.

“Good at what?” Catra cast him a small glance, arms folded defensively over her chest. Her thoughts were preoccupied by guilt over lashing out at Adora. Glimmer...well she felt bad, but she hadn't come to terms yet with what happened between them.

“Friendship.” Finn stated bluntly, refusing to look at her this time. Drawing on the dirt with his stick again.

Catra sucked in a cold breath, craning her head up to the roof. Closing her eyes briefly as if seeking clarity, then licked the corner of a canine in resignation.
“No...I really suck at it, actually.” she admitted, when she finally looked down again. Finn was gone, but he had scratched a picture in the dirt of the barn. It was three very simple faces. One had short spiky hair, with stars in their eyes. That was no doubt Glimmer. The one on the far right had long hair, in a ponytail with a huge poof. The middle was definitely her, with short messy hair, pointed ears and wide mouth with fangs. All three of the faces had wide grins. It reminded her very much of the childhood drawing she had done with Adora back in the Horde.

Then Finn’s sweet voice called out from the dark recesses of the barn.

“Forgiveness is not always earned but it's always needed. “

Catra nodded with a thin smile of reluctant acceptance. That kid was far too wise and it was really getting irritating. “Easier said than done, kid.” she muttered, heading out of the barn towards the Farm House.

When Catra returned, she found Glimmer and Adora sitting in the fabric chairs before the fireplace, speaking softly.

“Are you ready to tell us what happened in the swamp?” Glimmer had no more patience having been waiting for days for an answer. She crossed her arms over her chest as Catra strode in front of the fireplace.

Catra merely nodded, keeping her back to them, she leaned a shoulder against the simple wooden mantle. Staring at the low

burning fire, needing time to focus on her words so she didn't confess to much, just enough to satisfy Glimmer. The fire crackled and snapped towards her in welcome. Frowning at the strange way the fire reacted to her presence, Catra quickly dismissed it needing to organize her thoughts. “After I left you at the shore, I tracked Adora for a long time. She-Ra shot a pillar of light into the air near the center of the bog, so I headed in that direction. I found her unconscious, surrounded by dark robed figures. They must have been the ones who cast the spell, I don’t know why or if She-Ra was their target? But I fought them off, they were tough and their magic was powerful. But I managed to get Adora out of there.” She turned from the fire, a flat expression on her face.

Glimmer arched an incredulous eyebrow. That story was neither long nor complicated. It contradicted everything Catra had told her back at the campsite a couple days ago.

Adora nodded, staring intently at Catra. That was the most straightforward story she had ever heard. It was believable, but Catra's body language spoke otherwise. Her steel blue eyes were searching Catra's face, acknowledging how her ears flicked nervously. How she glanced away as she spoke. She was being honest to a degree, but not telling them the whole story.

“Did you get a look at them?” Glimmer asked, hope shining in her eyes.

Catra shook her head, “They ran off pretty quickly, as soon as I got the upper hand.”

Adora narrowed her eyes, scrutinizing Catra's nervous shifting of her feet . “You're not telling us everything.”

“It's not like I remember it clearly, that spell makes you see things, it drains you. You can't fault me for not wanting to stick around and investigate!” Catra shouted back, crossing her arms in indignation.

Adora sighed, suddenly feeling very guilty for accusing her. She was trying to do better, be better. She needed to have more faith in her. “You're right, that spell was horrible. I'm sorry, Catra.” She apologized.

Catra nodded. “Don't worry about it, it's fine. But we should get to Dryl.”

“Right.” Adora sighed, standing up and heading to the back room to grab her cloak.

“I should notify the Bright Moon guard, “ Glimmer mused. “They could go investigate.”

“No!” Catra shouted.

When Glimmer turned to her with a perplexed frown.

Catra quickly cleared her throat and pushed on. “Those robed guys might be just preying on travelers, luring them into the swamp and stealing their stuff. I wouldn't put your men in danger. When we get to Dryl, I'll talk to Entrapta. Maybe she's got some bots that we could send instead.”

“That's a good idea.” Glimmer grinned, heading out of the front door to call Swift Wind.

The sun was setting by the time they climbed up the higher peaks of the Talon mountains. The narrow passes along the northern ridge were littered with the remains of a long held standoff. Between the Horde, who took over Dryl years prior and Horde Primes forces. Tanks and bots blocked portions of the pass and they had to navigate around them. Primes Sentinel robots and drones were smashed amid the wreckage of Horde war machines. There didn’t seem to be a definite victor? The horde soldier’s must have held off the siege for most the year. The long stretch of destruction spoke about how hardy and well trained they were. Catra couldn’t help but feel proud. She wondered if any of the

soldier's remained at Dryl. Or if they had left when Prime had been defeated and returned to the Fright Zone? She noted the blood splatters across the sides of the tanks and bots. The deep scars from cannon blasts along the road and scorch marks blackening great swaths of the mountainside. Thankfully, there had been enough of a break in the fighting that her soldier's had managed to retrieve their dead and bury them somewhere.

The grim sight of the war torn passages was sobering and very chilling for all of them.

Catra had unconsciously picked up her pace. Needing space as she dealt with the brutal consequences of the war and the role she played as their commander.

She had sent so many to their deaths…

She could feel Adora's concerned gaze penetrating into her back as they walked. The worried, nervous glances from Glimmer who understood her torment. That grim sense of responsibility at the cost of the war was a mantle they both shared. She too had sent far to many soldiers to their deaths and felt the very same kind of guilt and remorse.

"Catra…" Adora's soft voice invaded her brooding.

"I don't want to talk about it!" Catra snapped back, wrapping her arms around herself. Her muscles were coiled tight and her tail was lashing violently.

Adora let it go, slowly lowered her arm. She had been reaching out for her, hoping to draw her away from her bleak thoughts. She merely nodded, understanding the emotional turmoil Catra was in. Accepting that Catra was unwilling to risk talking and end up breaking down out here on the open road.

The Crypto Castle at Dryl was as sterile and creepy as ever. Looming ahead on the barren mountain trail. Its many windows

glowing an eerie purple in the pale dusk of evening. The central spire that acted like a distress beacon, thrusting skyward into the heavy clouds, a ball of energy pulsing inside it's spiral rotunda. Dark figures moved along the lone parapet that connected the tower to the mountain passes high above.

Finn once again never dismounted Swift Wind, keeping a watchful eye on everything around them. As they walked through the main gates and into the outer courtyard that housed the small village of Dryl. The houses were simple, built in quaint block shapes of stone and mortar, quarried from the upper passes. The villagers were hardy and resilient people, shorter and more compact then other Etherians. Spending their days mining the mountains for tech, ore and crystals. They were metalsmiths, and makers of all sorts of high tech equipment. The villagers were a reserved, stoic people who kept to themselves. When they entered Dryl, the villagers they saw didn't even acknowledge their presence. Evening was falling and they were eager to get indoors for the night. The Scorper's prowled the passes after dark, so everyone huddled inside the Castle walls for protection.

Adora took note of how wary the villagers seemed, it wasn't that different since the last time she was here and they were hiding from Entrapta's murder bots. Being alert and on guard seemed to be the norm for Entrapta's subjects. She also caught sight of several clones, milling around the buildings. Some still wore the white robes of Prime's acolytes while others were dressed in tunic and pants of regular Etherian's. Adora wondered if these clones had followed Entrapta and Hordak from Primes Spire after the final battle? Oddly, not a single Horde Soldier remained at Dryl.

Adora took the lead, as they passed under an stone archway leaving the outer courtyard and entering into a massive enclosure just before the Castle Gates. Catra and Melog were guarding the rear, with Glimmer walking beside Swift Wind, patting the horse on his shoulder reassuringly.

“This place is really weird but it's not evil.” Glimmer advised, giving Finn a warm smile.

“I know, but it still looks evil.” Finn muttered, hanging his head refusing to look around at the creepy castle that now rose up before them. Carved from black stone and cobbled together with all kinds of metal sheeting and blinking lights, panels and wires. The Crypto Castle was Frankenstein's nightmare of various materials, both high tech and medieval. With narrow spires and twisting parapets, that rose high above the rocky crags of the mountains. The inner walls are a confusing labyrinth of corridors filled with an eclectic assortment of paintings and odd relics that Entrapta found interesting.

“My Sister's!” Wrong Hordak shouted, dashing happily up to them from the far side of the courtyard. He no longer wore his white robes, but a simple black sleeveless tunic, and grey pants. Looking more like an average Etherian than a clone.

They all turned and found Wrong Hordak approaching them with a huge, welcoming smile. Arms outstretched in greeting. The massive angled bulk of Darla sat in the center of the courtyard, with many more clones boarding and disembarking. After the final battle, Entrapta, Hordak and Wrong Hordak had not stuck around for the celebrations. The clones that they had been fighting at Primes Spire must have left along with them. Now, it seems. Entrapta had taken in several hundred more clones in the weeks that followed, from all over Etheria.

“What's going on?” Adora questioned.

Catra couldn't help but rub the back of her neck nervously, every time she saw a large mass of clones. The ghost pain of the chip always seemed to throb when the clones were nearby. She didn't like being around them, they made her anxious and unsettled.

Emily stomped towards them, just behind Wrong Hordak, her central core glowing a bright purple.

“Welcome to Dryl.” Entrapta's voice greeted them as Emily came to a sudden halt. Shivering and cowering at the sight of Catra. Catra noticed and kept her distance, giving Emily the space she

needed to feel secure. She had taken out her rage on the poor bot, slashing her across her face plate. Emily still sported that damage, seeing it made Catra feel terrible. She had never really treated the bot with any respect or kindness. It had taken her a long time to come to terms with the fact that Emily was not just a bot, Entrapta had given her an A.I. She was alive! With emotions as real as anyone else's. Catra regretted how she treated Entrapa's pet, the physical and emotional abuse she had inflicted upon her was a dark reflection of her own twisted upbringing. One she was struggling to overcome every day.

Melog butted their head against her hip, distracting her from her troubled thoughts, wanting some attention. She smiled down at him, knowing what they were doing and gave their ears a fond scratch.

A hologram figure of Entrapa shimmered out of Emily's central core, hovering over the ground in front of Adora.

“Entrapa, how are you?” Adora inquired, trying to be polite. But her voice was strained and her words rushed.

“I'm not here right now, but if you leave a message with Emily. I will get back to you as soon as I can.” Her hologram responded cheerfully.

Adora's mouth dropped open in surprise, as she cast Glimmer a confused look. Catra laughed bitterly, pinching the bridge of her nose in annoyance.

“This is just perfect. We are in the middle of a new crisis and our resident tech genius is M.I.A.” Catra groused, flapping her arms at her side in irritation before stomping off. She retreated a few feet away, to lean against a nearby wall and glare down at the ground, as if it was to blame. Melog huffed and sat down beside her. Mirroring a fraction of her frustrations, with the dull crimson shade of their body.

Glimmer cast her a troubled glance, Catra's anger had a hair pin trigger lately and she was getting nervous. The last thing Adora or her needed to deal with was the old destructive Catra.

“Wrong Hordak, We really need to talk to Entrapa. Where is she?” Glimmer asked.

“Oh, she has been travelling for weeks. Sometimes she would be on Etheria, overseeing the dismantling of Primes's magic syphon. Or she could be at any one of Primes spires, checking on the data downloads to Dryl’s computer system. Sometimes she would be up in the Sky Tree, or over on one of the derelict Armada ships. She has been working with Hordak and my brothers to dismantle and scavenge parts from all over....more and more of my brethren are gathering into our flock each day. ” He stated proudly. “It was so kind of Hordak to take us all under his wing. He has given us all purpose. We are currently transporting all the viable equipment here to Dryl or up to the Sky Tree, so they can use them for future experiments.”

Glimmer past Adora and Catra a worried glance. Unsure if she liked the idea of all the clones now obeying Hordak?

“Relax, Sparkles. Entrapta will keep him in line.” Catra assured her. “Back in the Fright Zone she had the megalomaniac wrapped around her finger.”

“Take us to, Entrapta.” Adora commanded, striding off with Wrong Hordak and Emily towards Darla.

“We are currently heading back to the transmission Spire on the Border of the Fright Zone, from there we can get in contact with Entrapta and find out where she is.” Wrong Hordak offered with a smile and a nod.

Finn ran down the narrow corridors within Darla, spinning and gazing all around in amazement.

“Wow...” He breathed.

The huge grin he had plastered on his face was adorable. Glimmer couldn't help but smile and laugh, finding his joy was contagious. She could feel her spirit become lighter just by being around him.

Adora was busy chasing him around, seeking to answer his never ending questions and deter him from touching every control panel they came across. Worried that the young man was going to accidentally break something or shoot cargo or perhaps a few clones out an airlock while they were in flight.

As they followed Wrong Hordak to the Command deck. Catra took note of the Clones wandering the ship. Some wore plain clothes while others still wore their robes. Personalized just a little by omitting part of the garment. Be it the cape or wearing different boots or gloves, adding utility belts to aid in their tasks. Each one displaying various stages of autonomy.

The Clones moved around the ship in clusters of two or three, whispering to themselves. Still attempting to recreate the hivemind. By mirroring each other's mannerisms, echoing each other's words during conversations, and needing to move about the ship in small groups. They might be free, but they were still a long way from becoming individuals. The clones paid them little notice, offering Adora small nods of affirmation as they passed. They completely ignored everyone else, yet a few would linger and stare at Catra with guarded eyes. They were no longer connected to the hive mind, but they still recognized her.

Catra could feel them staring, it made her uneasy. She wrapped her arms around her middle to calm the trembling of her body. Melog was trailing behind her, they cocked their head as anxiety washed over them. Turning to regard the clones with narrowed, hateful eyes, they remembered Horde Prime and his clones. They felt mildly threatened by them, having fought so hard to free Krytis from their occupation. It was difficult for them to let go of the anger, even if these clones might not be the ones responsible for their planet's demise.

Catra was having a hard time breathing and she was starting to feel rather nauseous. The trauma of being controlled by Prime still haunted her and these clones were triggering a panic attack.

“How long till we get to the Spire!” Catra called out, her voice was high pitched and nervous. As Melog brushed against her hips. Feeling the torrent of fear and anxiety churning inside of her.

“Not long, Darla is very fast for an ancient rust bucket.” Wrong Hordak, turned to face her with a wink and a smile.

Catra paid him a small fake smile, then chucked a thumb behind her. “Well, if you don't mind. It's been a...a day. I'm going to go lay down in my old quarters till we get there.”

“Catra!” Adora called to her from further up the corridor, her face stricken. She was holding Finn's hand, who had been chatting to her excitedly. Catra had let her in a little about the bad stuff she endured on Primes ship for all those months. But she had never mentioned anything about what happened to her after she saved Glimmer. She had come to some conclusions herself about what Catra's night terrors might be about. She had been worried about her state of mind, surrounded by the Horde Clones. Now she regretted not making her a priority, getting distracted by Finn's exuberant behavior. But she had no chance to reassure her, as Catra was already gone.

Glimmer sighed and reached for Adora's free hand, offering her a small apologetic smile. Adora gave her hand a squeeze. “She's still dealing with a lot and the Clones kinda freak her out. Give her time, she won't stay mad at you forever.” Adora advised, with a warm smile.

Glimmer nodded, she felt terrible for how she had treated Catra. Even worse, knowing Catra had been chipped because of her and was suffering because of it.

Catra retreated into the tiny compartment deep in the bowels of the ship, with Melog in tow. Her old quarters were near the main engines. It was the room Bow had given her just after Adora had saved her from Prime. This was her safe, dark place. Here no one could hurt her, she could relax and take down her guard. As the door hissed closed behind her, sealing her in. She darted for her cot and wrapped the blanket around herself tight. Pulling the scratchy cotton up over her head so only her face could be seen. Hiding away in every way, comforted by the small space and warmth the blanket provided. Showing weakness of any kind in the Horde was not tolerated. She had learned at a young age to swallow her fear or any other emotion that might make her weak. Otherwise she would face ridicule from the other cadets or punishment from Shadow Weaver. If she got physically hurt she would hold her pain in check and just pretend that nothing was bothering her. Their squad Sargent would come down on her harder, for putting her squad at risk by not keeping up with the training. So whenever she got badly hurt or felt scared or vulnerable she would run and hide. It was a tactic of protection she might never overcome.

Melog settled down in the corner of the room, watching her quietly. Monitoring the intensity of her anxiety and casting reassuring words of comfort through their link. It soothed her panic to a degree, but the guilt and shame that was eating at her remained to torment her.

In time Catra found her old communication pad, from their time flying home. Laying forgotten in the corner of her room. Bored and needing some kind of distraction. She began to play around with the settings, huddled securely in her blanket when a sharp buzz issued from the pad as a communication came through. Catra cried out in alarm, her body jerking in fright nearly dropping the pad on the floor. The scrambled screen snapped into a brilliant view of the eternal expanse of the universe.

“Catra, Hi! How are you?” Entrapta's cheerful voice filters out of the screen.”Your communication pads activation signal came up on my screen, so I figured I could call and touch base.”

“Where are you?” Catra inquired, with a confused frown.

“I'm walking outside of Primes ship....” Entrapta answered, as a huge branch came into view. She had to duck to get around it and Catra could see the metal of the hull overgrown with lush green leaves.

“The clones call it the Sky Tree.” Entrapta laughed.

“Ok...” Catra, nodded. “Why are you outside of the ship?” She started, as the view from Entrapa's space suit panned behind. She could see her long lavender hair floating against the backdrop of stars. But nothing else. Catra's eyes flew wide in sudden terror.

“Where's your tether!” She shouted into the screen, her heart leaping into her throat as every nerve in her body began to hum with sudden shock. Frightening thoughts of Entrapta floating away into the crushing void of space running wild in her mind.

“Owwww....” Entrapta moaned, as Catra's voice blasted her eardrums. “Wait a sec...Let me change the view.”

The screen snapped to a sudden picture of Entrapta's face, behind the glass visor of her helmet. Her magenta eyes and quirky smile filled the screen. “I don't need it anymore.” She laughed. “I've got magic now!” she exclaimed excitedly.

“Wait...what...” Catra was completely confused now.

“I seem to now have the power of magnetism, so I can walk freely around the outside of the ship without floating away.” She answered excitedly. “I will have to run more tests, but I think my magic can be much more versatile, then just sticking to metal.”

Catra couldn’t help but laugh, “How?”

“Well, as far as I can tell. When She-Ra returned the magic of Etheria. It fell like snow for days...the planet reabsorbed the magic and so did we...the Etherian's.” She mused.

Catra nodded, “Ok, then that explains how this happened to me, then?” She had been practicing in private for the last few days. Wanting to keep it a secret for now. She needed to process it all first, she still had a hard time with sharing...

She had Shadow Weaver to thank for that little hang up. The vile woman always had something negative to say whenever she managed to be proud of anything.

Closing her eyes she thought of Adora and the soothing heat she felt when she was near. She focused deep inside of herself for that burning core of power. Summoning it up to the surface of her consciousness. It felt like fishing, she had to reach and snatch it out of her very soul.

“Wow!” Entrapta's voice floated to her in awe.

Catra opened her now glowing eyes, pulling the communication pad away as she stood up from the cot to give Entrapta a full view.

“Your a princess...now?” Entrapta laughed enthusiastically. Pointing to her tiara.

“But you do realize that you're also on fire...” She observed, her expression turning suddenly serious.

“I know...it's crazy, right.” Catra grinned broadly, glancing down at herself in wonder.

“Like...all of you...is on fire!” Entrapta laughed with wild abandon and Catra joined in for a while.

“I can’t wait to study you!” Entrapta declared.

“Entrapta...focus!” Catra snapped, sensing the hyperactive geek princess was going to go off on some wild tangent.

Entrapta sobered up instantly, getting herself back on topic.

“Well, to answer your previous question. I am currently mapping the Sky Tree. Adora's ‘natural renovation’ to Primes Ship. “ Entrapta’s tone was slightly sour, over how the living tree had been an inconvenience to her. “Pretty much rearranged the whole structure. There are no vents and I can not get around this place very efficiently. Sooooo, I have been mapping both the inside and outside...cause I am getting really, really tired of getting lost.” She spat out her explanation in one breath, smiling cheerfully.

Catra nodded, then took a deep breath. “I need your help.” she blurted out quickly, before overthinking her decision and backing out. She needed to trust someone with her secret. She needed Entrapta's help, she was the only one who had the smarts and ingenuity to check on the ruin.

Entrapta calmed down and gave her her full attention.

“I ran into some strange people in the lowland marsh on the Plains of Thaymor. They were capturing Etherian's and nearly kidnapped Adora. There's an old first one's ruin in the center of the swamp and they had managed to get a portal working from their end.” Catra began.

“Where was the portal linked to?” Entrapta interrupted, her eyes wide with excitement.

“Eternia.” Catra replied.

Entrapta nodded, mentally filing away the data.

“I managed to stop them, but I destroyed the portal and I think I blew up most of the ruin.” Catra suddenly felt very scared and overwhelmed with regret, her transformation faded instantly. She instinctively crawled back under the blanket and pulled it up over her head.

Her voice was trembling when she admitted her latest sin. “The Etherian's were all encased in these transport pods and the Eternian's were pushing them through the portal. I don't know if any of those container's survived or if they are still alive inside... I

need you to go check it out and let me know.” She was crying softly at this point.

“Ok, I'll head over there right away.” Entrapta answered, her voice soft and full of compassion. Seeing Catra cry made her nervous, she didn't really know how to comfort other people.

“Thank you..” Catra groaned, angrily wiping away the tears with the palm of her hand. Silently fuming at how soft she had become.

“Adora's going to contact you when we land at the Spire near the Fright Zone. A lot more is happening down here on Etheria, she's hoping you have the answers. Don't say anything about this to her...about me being a princess or what I did in the Swamp. I will let her know soon, but I need this to be a secret mission for just the Super pal trio for now...ok.” Catra hated the corny name, Scorpia had given them. But right now she needed Entrapta to stay quiet, so using that old name to invoke a sense of loyalty to just her, it was a ploy she needed to use.

“Catra...” Entrapta's expression was nervous and very concerned. Her eyes kept darting away from the pad, seeking to avoid if only for a moment, the raw desperation on Catra's face.

“Promise me, you won't say anything...I'll tell them...but not until I have more information.” Catra appeased her with a little white lie. Her telling Adora what happened completely hinged on the outcome of Entrapta’s expedition.

“Ok...I promise.” Entrapta sighed heavily, she did not like holding back data. Staying quiet about something so very important like new invaders...that was lying. It could put a-lot of people she cared about at risk. But she cared about Catra too...and she could tell that what happened in the swamp had made her very distressed. She had promised to tell the rest...so she would have to trust her.

By the time Entrapta made her way back into an airlock, she was receiving a transmission from Darla. She tapped the side of her helmet to activate the channel, as she moved through the second set of doors. When the metal door hissed closed behind her, a small screen in the corner of her visor snapped to life.

Adora's smiling face filled the screen, then Glimmer slid into view with a giggle. Entrapta smiled warmly but her thoughts were racing.

"Entrapta, Hi." Adora greeted her, but her voice sounded strained.

Entrapta had been rather oblivious to the emotional and social cues of others. Hence all her social experiments, as she attempted to understand other people. She had to really focus on the person to pick up on the more subtle emotions. Right now she was distracted by Catra's secret mission. So she never really noticed that Adora and Glimmer were anxious. Her mind was already racing forward, eager to help Catra. Excited about the new ruin and the tech it might hold. Concerned about the Etherian's and making a mental list of what tools she was going to need to open the containers.

"We have to skip the pleasantries, I have an urgent experiment to run and not a lot of time." She spoke quickly. Pulling off her boots and unzipping her space suit. She tossed the suit to the floor and kept walking, stepping over thick tree roots that had pushed through the outer walls and twisted down the wide, vaulted corridor. A humanoid robot rolled up behind her and picked up her boots. Draping the space suit over its corrugated arm as it rolled after Entrapta down the dimly lit corridor. Zipping back and forth between the roots and overhanging branches, as nimble and agile as only a little robot could be.

"I know exactly what you are going to ask. I've been expecting it...since the Fail Safe. I just thought I'd have more time. I've been pretty preoccupied with my current endeavors here and I had been hoping the Rune Stones magic reserves would have lasted a bit longer. I guess not." She pulled off her helmet, tossing

it over her shoulder. The little robot made a twittering sound, his bucket head craning back as its one green eye tracked the helmet. Catching it with one hand, then gave a happy beep and spun in a circle on it's solitary wheel.

Entrapta unclipped a communication pad from her utility belt that now hung from the waist of her overalls. Patching in the transmission from her helmet. A concerned Adora and Glimmer reappeared on her screen.

“Why didn't you tell us!” Glimmer exclaimed with irritation.

“As I said, I thought I would have more time. I was hoping to finish my work up here before taking on any further tasks.” Entrapta shrugged, scratching her nose nervously. She did not like confrontations or being yelled at. She found people so very hard to understand and stressful to be around sometimes.

“What happened to the Rune Stones.” Adora interrupted.

“Well, they are parts of the Heart Weapon. When She-Ra released the Fail Safe code, she deactivated all the First Ones tech connected to the planetary weapon. I don't know yet, but perhaps the Fail Safe code deactivates all the First Ones tech on the planet? I will need to access the Fail Safe's data to find out.” Entrapta explained, her boots clipping briskly down the faintly lit hall. She had to duck, when a large overgrown branch hung in her way. She kept her ponytails tucked tight to her back, having gotten her hair caught in the thin branches numerous times over the last few weeks. It was painful and annoyingly time consuming. So she had learned to keep her hair under control when traversing the inside of the ship.

Glimmer merely blinked at Entrapta, with a stricken, confused expression. “Does that mean...my princess powers are gone for good?”

“The Moonstone was merely a storage device for your type of magic, to power the weapon and enslave you and your magic to

the Heart when it was activated.” Entrapta answered. “Your elemental abilities have always been inside you and not connected to anything else.”

Entrapta walked into Primes dimly lit central chamber, crossing the long bridge towards the command deck. There were fewer branches invading the inner ring of the ship, but she could still see the thin shadows of growth, hovering in the upper reaches of the vast chamber. Several dozen clones moved just beyond her sight along the balconies that surrounded the central command dais. Trimming away branches to clear the equipment so they could get the ship up and running again.

“Adora can explain,” She stated, not noticing how Adora paled and glanced at Glimmer nervously. “ I'll talk to you guys in a few days at Arxia..uhm...Mystacor. “

“Wait...there's more going on!” Glimmer shouted, but Entrapta cut her off. Striding up the shadowed ramp to the dais “I should have more information for you after I hack into Arxia's database.” Entrapta closed the transmission promptly, as she crossed into the faint glow of the giant shattered command screen.

Hordak stood before the smashed remains of Primes throne, staring at the data pad in his hand that he had plugged into the command terminal beside the screen. He had discarded his robes, for a sturdy set of armor created by Entrapta. It was similar in design to the one she had made before, less bulky but more durable. She had used Primes tech to create it, as it was the most advanced. Using softer, more somber tones of indigo and grey. The collar guard still had the purple data crystal she used to power the previous suit. This new suit allowed Hordak to survive any hostile environment. A token of affection from Entrapta that he cherished.

“I have to go down to the surface for a while, I could really use your help.” Entrapta approached Hordak with a tentative air. Twisting her hands in front of her, she rocked on her feet nervously

“I'm busy here, I can't leave right now.” He rumbled back, tapping on the screen, avoiding her completely. He still felt very awkward around her. He cared for her deeply but just didn't know how to express it. She didn't seem to mind how aloof and serious he was, accepting him and all his imperfections.

“Hordak, you can't just hole up here in the Sky Tree and not be a part of the world?” Entrapta moved into his line of sight, placing a hand gently on his bicep.

Hordak had intentionally imprisoned himself here on the Sky Tree and had no intentions of ever setting foot on Etheria again. “I want to make amends for my mistakes, I owe She-Ra my life....my freedom. But for right now I only have the courage to help Etheria from a far.” He stated softly, his true intentions of imprisoning himself here on Primes ship for his crimes remaining unspoken. “I will continue to dismantle Primes Legacy and use it to protect Etheria. In time I will be able to help these people defend themselves properly. The universe is not a benevolent place, far from it. We need to be ready.” He finished, refusing to look up from his pad.

Entrapta sighed and nodded. As soon as Hordak got up to Primes ship, he was driven by a single focus. He rarely slept, and barely ate. He worked all the time with his brethren. The only conversations he would participate in with Entrapta were entirely related to their own projects. She knew he was keeping her in the dark as to what he was working on with his brothers. She was curious but figured when he had gotten that project to a point of completion that he was proud of, then he would show her. She could understand that, everyone had passion projects and Hordak still had issues with sharing and accepting failure.

He had no interest in going back down to the planet. Entrapta was worried about him, he was falling into the same reclusive patterns as before in the Fright Zone. But instead of hiding in his sanctum, he was hiding in space. She understood it, better than most. She had hidden away in her castle for her whole life, scared of getting to know people because she didn't understand them. Making

friends was very hard. After both the princesses and Catra had abandoned and betrayed her. She had felt it wasn't worth the struggle.

Until Adora and Bow had come and saved her. Then she had pushed herself out of her comfort zone, again. Sought friendship and understanding from others, sought forgiveness. Being a good friend was difficult and painful at times but so, so fulfilling...being a part of the world....was wonderful. She wanted that for Hordak. But she could be patient, in time he may want more too.

Forgotten Daughter

From the moment she had entered the sprawling grasslands, Catra felt a sense of timelessness, this was the land of her people. A belonging so intimate it was almost premortal, washed over her, leaving her trembling with the exhilaration of it. She walked softly through the tall golden grass, scanning the flat horizon that was unmarred except for a lone standing rock. The massive stone was jutting upward towards the sky, like a proud sentinel guarding the savannah, far in the distance. The day was ending, with Etheria's sun sinking slowly behind the shadow of that stone monolith. It's dying light bathing the horizon in brilliant colors of crimson and orange. Her amazement of this forgotten realm, lost to the unrelenting tides of time. Grew as she followed the ethereal presence that occupied most of her dreams, lately. A woman of pure light, capable of holding the nightmares as bay. Who had been offering her solace, comfort and acceptance. She shone just to the right, her wings at rest as she walked quietly beside her. A silent companion to her reawakening.

"Where have you brought me?" Catra asked quietly.

"Home." The glowing woman stated, her refined voice soft and serene.

Catra's ears flicked as she heard the faintest sounds of movement just to the left, deep in the field of gold. The smell of prey assaulted her nose, her senses priming in an instant. Driven by instincts, she crouched low hiding in the grass, Her butt held high for only a moment, tail lashing with excitement as she lowered her haunches preparing to spring forward. Her muscles coiled and flexed as the enticing smell drew near. Her mismatched eyes focused and unblinking, as her pupils expanded with excitement. She scanned the fluttering curtain of grass in front of her, searching for any subtle signs of where her prey may be. Her lips vibrated, against her fangs, short, sharp trills issued from her throat. Her heart pounding in her chest, with the thrill of the hunt. Searching the tall grass for the owner of the rustling sound.

The immortal presence faded. Bestowing upon Catra a gentle, sanguine smile, that she would find what she had lost. Her voice echoed in the coming twilight, as she departed. "It is time for you to begin your journey. To find your true self. To forgive your past self and allow your current incarnation to heal."

Catra's invisible prey stopped for a moment as if sensing her, then moved away with incredible speed. Catra barred her fangs and rushed through the grass on all fours. Tracking the creature's movements as it sought to escape. Her heart was thundering in her ears, to a crescendo, that her arms and legs kept pace to. As she sprinted across the grassland, on all fours. Her lungs were soon burning, body humming with exhilaration, eyes dilating even more, to draw in more light. So she could continue her hunt into the coming night.

She had never felt more alive!

Night was falling, the light fading into the somber greys of twilight. She caught sight of two others joining her hunt. They were cat hybrids just like her. One looked male, his body was more bulky and stouter. With dark chestnut fur and a long black mane, plaited into a top knot upon his head with a leather string. Two grey tufts hung low behind his ears, bound in two intervals, with thick black leather bands. He had piercing golden eyes and strong, square features. He ran on all fours just like her, flanking Catra to the right. Wearing a pair of maroon dyed hide pants that only reached his knees and a simple, sleeveless, black leather vest, with orange crystal beads woven into the threads. His powerful arms were bare except for woven leather bracers on his wrists. He had similar stripes as Catra, upon his arms that were as dark as his hair. On her left was a more lean, lithe cat with warm tan fur similar to hers. Her hair was a dark auburn, full and wild, snapping like a cape down her back. She had two tufts as well, but they were golden blonde. Orange crystal beaded leather ties were woven in the braided tufts. A leather head band with similar crystal beads was tied around her forehead. Her facial features were elegant but sharply angled, with a smattering of freckles upon her cheeks. Her eyes were wide and deep blue, like the sky

on a clear day. Wearing a deep orange dyed hide halter top, that left her slightly rounded belly bare. With a short matching hide skirt, that barely reached her thighs. That parted up the sides of both legs allowing her full movement. An ornate symbol was embroidered with white thread along the back of the skirt.

Catra was instantly transfixed on the two cats, her heart swelled with a feeling of familiarity. Their smell sparked a longing deep inside her heart. Curious she slowed enough to follow them as they hunted towards the massive stone outcropping that dominated the center of the savannah. They took to the narrow trails up the nearly sheer rock, using their claws to climb or to leap and bound on narrow ledges, as they climbed up to the top. Catra kept up with them, grinning with joy at being with them. Her wonder grew beyond all bounds when they reached the peak. The place was magical, she could see forever. With a crystalline lake stretching just beyond the stone. A huge waterfall crashing down from the far side of the stone, down into the lake. An ancient forest sprang along the edges of the hidden grotto, as lush and mysterious as the Whispering Woods. Catra stood in the cool breeze while a thousand alien scents assaulted her nose. Her ears swivelled to listen to all the nocturnal creatures coming alive all around her. While eternity stretched above her, in an endless blanket of starlight. The moons and all their satellites were rising in the distance casting their somber light over the land.

She watched with fascination as the two cats who had joined her on this hunt, flanked a large boulder just ahead. Pouncing on something hidden behind.

Bright laughter erupted from behind the rock, along with a cloud of sparkles. "You found me!"

"Loo-Kee, stop hiding and come out." The female cat scolded. Standing up from behind the rock and leaning casually against it. Her voice was gentle and melodic, just like the woman calling out to her from her vision back at the swamp.

“Here I am, Aoi” The creature called in a bright childlike voice. As a sparkle of magic flashed at the woman's bare feet.

Catra moved closer, her steps slow, tentative as if worried if she moved too quickly the woman would disappear or perhaps run away. But the young catwoman never noticed her approach. Catra glanced down at herself, stunned to find she was translucent, cloaked in magic just like Melog.

“We almost killed you.” The male feline stood up behind the stone, his voice low, almost gruff. Holding a small pixie by the scruff of its furry neck. Loo-Kee was a tiny creature, with large pointed ears and a large bulbous nose. He was covered in light tan fur, rounded cheek rosy from the earlier chase. His gentle brown, almond shaped eyes shone with mirth. As he crossed his arms stubbornly over his chest. He had wild deep blue hair and a fluffy striped tail. Wearing only a pair of red cloth overalls, torn at the knees with an overflowing leather satchel strapped to his back.

“Stop sneaking into the savannah. It's not safe.” Aoi scolded.

“Saladin, you are no fun.” Loo-Kee grumped, frowning up at the dark haired male cat holding him.

“And you, my friend. Are a troublemaker.” Saladin grunted, dropping the pixie back to the ground. Loo-Kee landed harshly on his butt. With a moan of discontent, he hopped back onto his tiny feet and stuck his tongue out at both of them. Before shimmering invisible just like Melog. The only sign of him was the sound of his feet scampering down the stone and eventually into the lush grotto on the other side.

Saladin shook his head and moved with a strong gate towards the female cat. Leaning next to her against the boulder and folding his powerful arms across his broad chest.

“He is a sly, little thief.” Aoi laughed, ruefully. Turning towards Saladin, leaning upward on her toes, she rubbed her cheek lovingly against the males neck, scent marking him.

“His bag was near bursting with the stolen food from our pantry.” Saladin smiled ruefully, before casting the female a loving glance. He placed his hand lightly against her stomach, waiting patiently for something to happen. A low purr of satisfaction resounding from deep inside his chest.

Aoi laughed softly. “Sal, it is still weeks away before you will feel her kick.”

Saladin merely shrugged, “Perhaps I just want to touch my wife.”

“Or you are as impatient to see your child as you were to marry me.” Aoi grinned knowingly, placing her own hands over his to keep them there.

“Our world is changing, Aoi. I can't help but be worried about the future.” Saladin rested his cheek against the top of his wife’s head. Her ears flicked as his hot breath brushed against them.

“Change is an important part of growing, I must believe that our people will only become stronger for it.” Aoi reasoned, as she raised her face to the night sky, as a thousand stars fell from the heavens. Catra was mesmerized by the sight, squinting her eyes finding out that they were not stars. Making out the burst of engines as small star craft were landing in the distance. But her awe was soon tempered by what Saladin said next.

“More Eternian's... here to settle. Soon our planet will be overrun with them.”

“They are promising us protection. The Galactic Horde only grows stronger each day.” The female stated, resting her head wearily against Saladin's shoulder.

“Their protection sounds more like slavery to me.” Saladin growled.

“The heart is the only weapon we have against Horde Prime. So many planets have fallen already.” Aoi responded, her gaze falling down into introspection.

It was the soft brush against her arm that jerked her awake. Catra screamed and bolted backwards, her tail fur bristling in fright. It was instinct that caused her to slash at the sudden intruder to her dreams. Her wrist was clutched tight in a strong grasp, mid swing. As she came to her senses, she found stern but concerned steel blue eyes staring back at her.

"Sorry..." Catra cringed, twisting her wrist and pulling her hand free from Adora.

"Alright, I can understand you being a bit freaked out about the clones. But come on Catra...you are so upset and scared you nearly slashed me? What happened?" Adora huffed, rocking back on her heels and wrapping her arms around her knees. Seeking to shield herself in case Catra lashed out again, she could be very volatile when confronted in a vulnerable state. Her instincts seemed to dominate her rational mind when feeling cornered. Adora sat patiently, her blue eyes pleading with Catra to open up to her. Nothing set alarm bells off more than finding Catra wrapped in a blanket, with her head covered, curled up tight, in a ball. The sight brought back so many bad memories of when Catra would return after being punished by Shadow Weaver. She would just crawl up into her bunk and wrap herself up tight in her blanket and hide from the world. She had been like this for days after her rescue from Horde Prime. Which only illustrated the severity of the trauma she had endured at that monster's hands.

Catra took a deep breath, huddled in the blanket looking sad and guilty at her. A low, angry growl vibrating out of her blanket cocoon. Adora knelt before the cot for a long time, studying Catra's body language. She was more confident in interpreting an angry, scared Catra. Then the soft, affectionate side of her, she had shown her recently. Adora waited till her tail stopped thumping against the mattress, before she slowly leaned forward, to brush her finger tips tenderly down Catras cheek.

“I'm really worried about you.” Adora sighed heavily, her eyes shimmering with tears. Moving to sit on the edge of the cot to be closer to her. Catra needed her space when she was upset, Adora knew this. She hated looking weak or vulnerable. Her emotions would be raw and volatile. So she never pushed too hard, but always remained within reach. Waiting for Catra to take the lead, to let her know when she was ready to receive comfort or affection.

Catra scrubbed a hand down her face, Adora's compassion or sympathy she couldn't tell, was grating on her nerves. “I know, I'm a mess right now but I gotta work it out a bit on my own first, before I get you involved.” She grumbled, rolling away from the hurt in Adora's eyes.

“I'm here if you need me, I'm always here...” Adora's voice was small, as she dropped her gaze to the floor, getting slowly to her feet. The hard lump of rejection sat heavy in her gut as she moved a few feet towards the door. Stopping for a moment hoping that Catra would ask her to stay. She glanced at Melog, needing to assess Catra's emotional state. Finding the alien Cat had not changed their normal colors since entering the room. They were curled up in the corner, with a somber, vigilant expression. When Catra remained closed off, staring at the wall, wrapped tight in her blanket shelter. Adora heaved a deep sigh of resignation and left.

When the hiss of the door closing greeted her ears, Catra flopped on her back and groaned with regret. She was falling back into her old habits. She was pushing Adora away, hurting her, the guilt and remorse was eating away at her resolve. She knew she was spiraling back into that dark place of negative thinking. She had promised Adora that she wouldn't pull away again...She needed to fix this. She couldn't tell Adora about the Eternian's but she could show her her new powers. It was a start towards full disclosure, she just needed to tread carefully. She didn't want to mess this up and lose her again. Catra closed her eyes and called up the flames, her body ignited and with a cry of triumph she bolted out of the room.

Melog perked up, raising their head with a slight smile of pride. As Catra dashed out of the room.

“Wait....Stay!” Catra called, the high pitch and volume betraying her sudden panic.

Adora turned in shock at Catras sudden cry. Her mouth hanging low, eyes round with surprise, to find Catra standing in the corridor completely on fire. Panting and out of breath, sporting a thin, elegant tiara.

“This is what I'm dealing with right now!” Catra sighed, “Still on the fence if I'm happy about it, yet.”

“Wow...” Adora mouthed in awe, moving slowly back down the hall.

The steady hum of the engines filled Catra's quarters, the soft glow of the diamond shaped tiles that lined the back wall cast them in a somber halflight. Discarding their clothes into a pile in the corner, preparing for bed. Wearing only their underwear they cuddled under the blanket on the bed. Adora in the simple bra and shorts style underwear that hugged her muscular thighs. Catra in her black breast wrap and bikini style panties. Adora was leaning her back against the far wall with Catra curled up between her legs and held tight in her arms. They had been speaking in hushed tones for the last hour, discussing Catra's new powers and her strange dreams. Catra had kept the conversation light, never allowing Adora to delve too deeply into anything more about what happened in the swamp. Adora was more focused on making Catra happy, seeking to alleviate the stress and anxiety that had been plaguing her for the last few days. She lightly brushed Catra's bangs behind her ears, lightly giving the backs of each ear a soothing scratch and caress. As Catra snuggled into her full breasts purring contentedly, her face tucked under Adora's chin nuzzling her lovingly.

“We docked at the Spire, we'll be spending the night in Darla, are you ok with that.” Adora asked softly. Catra shrugged, Adora’s soft touch was lulling her into a boneless, languid state. As she slumped contentedly against Adora's front, her head resting against Adora's shoulder. Her face tucked under Adora's chin, breathing softly against the blondes neck.

“You know the clones freak me out, but I can deal.” Catra admitted, pulling away. She rubbed the back of her neck absently, her mind lost to unsettling thoughts. As her fingers brushed over the star shaped scar...a memento from Horde Prime.

“I get that.” Adora sighed. “You don't need to worry, Primes is gone and She-Ra made sure he is not coming back.”

“One less, big bad to worry about.” Catra grumbled softly to herself.

“What did you say?” Adora stopped combing her fingers through Catra's short hair. Inclining her face to listen more closely.

“It's nothing, don't worry about it.” Catra craned her head up, offering her a reassuring smile. “Where's Finn?” She quickly changed the subject.

“He's with Swift Wind, they kinda bonded over singing. I think he's going to sleep with him tonight.”

Adora grinned, “Last I saw, those two, they were in the cargo hold playing with the echos.”

“Have you heard any of his songs?” Catra asked nervously.

“He was working on one, I think.” Adora mused.

“Please tell me it's not Grumpy Cat.” Catra grumbled.

“Seriously?” Adora began to laugh and snort, the purity of joy in the sound was infectious. Making Catra start to laugh loudly as

well.

“Did you get to talk to Entrapta?” Catra asked, when they had quieted down.

Adora nodded, brushing away happy tears with her finger tips. “Yeah, what she said makes total sense. But moving forward is going to be difficult.”

Catra pulled away again and raised an inquiring eyebrow. Adora adjusted herself, pulling her legs together as Catra settled beside her on her knees. Adora sighed and explained that the Princesses, Rune Stones were artificial. That since they were part of the Planetary weapon the Fail Safe's code had deactivated every one of them.

“I remember Entrapta saying something like that, after I stole that data crystal from your First Ones ruin. That all the Runestones were interconnected with the planet and she could use them to Hack into the First Ones network.” Catra nodded, her eyes falling distant on yet another bad memory she wished to forget.

“That was when you guys disrupted the balance of the Rune Stones and froze the Whispering Woods.” Adora sighed, rubbing Catras back tenderly. As the magicat bowed her head in regret, balling her hands into fists in her lap.

“Thinking back on it, what we did was so dangerous....we could have destroyed Etheria. I was so angry at you back then.” She moaned, squeezing her eyes shut. “ So hell bent on proving to everyone that I wasn't worthless....I just didn't care...about anyone or anything...but my own selfish desires...” Catra took a shuddering breath, as a few tears crept out of the corner of her eyes. “I was such a monster...I'm so sorry...”

Adora reached up and placed a comforting hand against her cheek. She was spiraling down into her guilt and she needed to pull her out before it got any worse.

“Enough, We promised to leave that stuff behind us. I love you, I've forgiven you. You need to let it go.” She admonishing her gently.

“I can't!” Catra cried brokenly, snapping her eyes open and focusing on the small linear scars that decorated Adora's face. She took several shaky breaths, as she stared at them horrified at what she had done. Adora was so beautiful, inside and out. How could she have marred her skin so much?

“I'm sorry....” Catra whispered, leaning close to Adora's face. Pressing a tender kiss upon the first scar she had ever made. The nearly invisible marks just above her nose, then she brushed her lips downward to her left cheek. Pressing a loving kiss upon the scratches she had made during their fight at the Salineas Sea gate. Tears were flowing down her cheeks as she kissed the deeper scars she made lower upon either side of Adora's jaw when they fought at Bright Moon. Adora's hand had skimmed downward from Catra's face when she leaned in. Grasping the crook of Catra's neck as she peppered kisses upon Adora's face.

“Catra...” Adora breathed, the tenderness of Catra's lips and soft sounds of her remorse was breaking Adora's heart. She needed Catra to calm down before she was in tears herself. “Catra, please stop...” Adora pleaded, pulling Catra away gently, by pushing her palms against Catra's bare shoulders.

Catra sat back on her knees, taking deep breaths as she tried valiantly to gather her composure. This breakdown had been building for weeks, ever since their time at the inn in Erelandia. Ever since she had seen the long scars down her back, that criss crossed pattern over one shoulder blade. Catching sight of the scar she wore on her thigh, that she had given during their battle on Primes ship. While she was pulling off her underwear at the farm house. Her regrets just kept piling up, chipping away at her peace of mind until she was reduced to tears once again.

“I just want them to go away....I hurt you so much...” Catra blubbered, roughly brushing away tears with the heel of her

hands.

“Unfortunately, She-Ra's healing magic doesn't work like that....if the wound is going to leave a mark. Then even after the wound has been healed the scars remain.” Adora sighed heavily, reaching up and enfolding Catra into her arms. Pulling her down tight across her chest and kissing her temple softly.

“I like them.” Adora admitted with a warm smile. “I think they make me look tough.”

“You're an idiot!” Catra groused, slipping one arm around Adora's lower back and the other grasping her shoulder. Draping a leg across Adora's lap, as she leaned against Adora's side. Snuggling her face into the crook of Adora's neck, a low comforting purr vibrating from her body.

Adora sighed, she had heard all manner of purrs from Catra over the years. She understood the difference between them, the louder more vibrant rumble when she was happy or merely content. To the soft melancholy vibration she was doing now. She would use this subtle, more quiet purr to soothe herself when she was very upset or in a great deal of physical or emotional pain.

“It's ok....we are ok...I love you.” Adora kept repeating, holding her close and rubbing her arm, or petting down her back lightly with her finger tips. Giving her all the time she needed to calm down. She was shivering, so Adora pulled the blanket up to cover them both. Wrapping her up in her strong arms over the blanket and snuggling her close. It took a while, but soon a comfortable silence remained. In time Catra began to shift onto Adora's lap more fully. Ready to keep talking.

“So what's the plan?” Catra rose up and straddled Adora's waist, the blanket pooling around her hips. She was over her little break down and refused to wallow. Trusting that Adora meant what she said, that they were ok. Catra had made a promise to her, that she would do better, be better. From that point on, she had been trying to be good to everyone around her.

Adora moaned nervously at Catra's bold, perhaps unconscious allure. Not knowing what to do with her hands. Wanting to put them on Catras bare thighs but way too timid to do it, she coughed and crossed her arms behind her head. Offering Catra a relaxed pose and easy going smile, valiantly trying to cover up how turned on she was. Catra was oblivious to Adora's sudden arousal and nervous energy. Closing her eyes slowly, Catra stretched her arms over her head and arched her back. Desperate to get the kinks out of her back and shoulders. Adora watched in both breathless awe and arousing alarm. Her face blushing profusely, as a throbbing desire ached between her legs. Her pulse quickened at her girlfriend's sexy, lazy movements on her lap. Catra's stretching inadvertently made her sex rub softly against Adora's. It took the blonde everything she had not to moan at the sudden, very delightful friction. Catra was in mid stretch when the hiss of the door opening interrupted them. Followed by a sharp, startled and mortified noise from Glimmer.

“Sorry....you guys are in the middle of something...I....I...I'll come back later.” She stammered.

Adora flushed even more, at their lack of undress and with Catra’s very illicit position, straddling her lap. Catra chuckled, unable to resist tormenting Glimmer a bit when she realized for herself how compromised they looked.

“You could always join us?” Catra crooned sassily, casting Glimmer. Her sultry bedroom eyes and a sly smile over her bare shoulder. Laughing uproariously when Glimmer went several more shades of red, turning to look at the door frame as if it was the most interesting object she had ever seen.

“Glimmer...” Adora was mortified, rocking her hips to get Catra off so she could salvage the situation.

“Relax, Sparkles nothing is happening...yet.” Catra giggled, crawling off Adora to stand beside the cot. Having some alone time with Adora, reconnecting and snuggling had settled her

anxieties and brightened her mood. She was once again happy and playful.

“I never meant to intrude. “ Glimmer kept trying to apologize, refusing to look at either woman. She kept staring at the door frame, picking shyly at the hem of her tunic. Desperately wanting her face to cool down. Flustered and unsure how to proceed, she remained in the doorway. Suddenly feeling like the awkward third wheel.

“Get in here.” Adora sighed, darting across the room and pulling Glimmer inside by both hands. Making the decision for her.

Glimmer giggled with relief and stumbled inside. The faint light from the hall disappeared when the door hissed closed leaving them in the near darkness of the room.

Catra figured she could turn on the light or just show off. With a smug grin, she ignited the palms of her hands. Her tiara glowed to life on her forehead, the orange crystal gleaming in the half light of her flames.

“Wow...” Glimmer breathed, staring at Catra in awe.

“I figure this is Etheria's gift for my full on panic attack back in the Swamp.” Catra stated sarcastically, rolling her eyes before she chuckled dryly.

“This sucks...” Glimmer growled, “I lose my princess abilities and Catra gains hers!”

“It was hard on me at first too, Glimmer.” Adora advised gently, moving to the cot and pulling the mattress off and tossing it on the floor.

“Breaking the sword was like destroying my touch stone. I no longer had an easy way to activate She-Ra.” She knew exactly why Glimmer had sought them out. Being best friends with someone for years had it's perks. She was lonely and missing

Bow, they had been inseparable since her rescue. So she had sought out the next best thing for companionship.

"I had to figure out how to summon that magic from inside myself. She-Ra came back, stronger than ever. At least for a while…." She finished bitterly under her breath. It had taken Catra's intervention at the Heart and her confession of love. To reignite her link to She-Ra. Catra became her touch stone then. Adora raised her eyes from the floor, her melancholy lifting as her gaze fell upon Catra. Her eyes warmed with love, as she smiled softly in silent gratitude towards the magicat. That it had the hybrid blushing. Before Adora returned her focus back on Glimmer.

"You are the daughter of an Immortal being and a very powerful sorcerer. You will have no problems finding the Magic of Bright Moon inside yourself and it will come back stronger than before." Adora grinned proudly down at Glimmer.

Glimmer beamed, "Thanks, Adora."

Catra passed Adora a confused look, as Glimmer settled on the mattress with her. Taking off her cape and pulling off her boots, setting them aside as she got comfortable. They had had enough sleep overs in Adora's room back at Bright Moon. That her pulling her mattress off her cot and throwing it on the floor for the three of them to share had become tradition.

Melog growled low, his mane sparking slightly as they picked up on Catra's agitation. They had been curled up in the corner of the room and just now made themselves known.

"We're having a sleepover, Catra." Adora beaconed her over with a raised hand, curling her finger invitingly. Catra licked her bottom lip nervously, her good mood souring with anxiety. She had never slept with anyone but Adora. The small fires in her palms snuffed out instantly, leaving them back in the darkness.

“We had a ton of these back at Bright Moon.” Glimmer offered, adjusting herself to stretch out sideways on the mattress so there would be enough room for three. Glimmer left out the various reasons behind those sleepover's not wanting to hurt Catra. At the beginning they had camped out in Adora's room mostly because she had trouble sleeping by herself. She had stated it was because she was used to sleeping with others in the barracks. They accepted that, but as they came to understand how much Catra meant to her and their ritual of sleeping together in the Horde. They knew that it was more likely she was missing Catra at night. As the years came on, other reasons came up for the need for sleepovers. Sometimes it was to alleviate the stress of the war, by having a bit of fun and comfort, or nightmares would draw Glimmer or Adora to each other's rooms. Sleepovers had become a cherished ritual. Adora lay in the middle of the mattress, patting the open area on her other side.

“Com'on Catra, it'll be fun.” Adora coaxed.

Catra groaned and rolled her eyes, unable to protest. She crawled over, laying down beside Adora. She was quick to seek reassurance, clasping her hand with Adora's. Weaving her fingers with hers. Adora took note of how nervous she was and brought her hand up and kissed her knuckles tenderly. They lay in awkward silence for a long time. Glimmer picked up on Catras silent disapproval of her staying. Shyly, keeping her back to them both, picking at the mattress. Trying to come up with excuses to leave. She had really messed up back at the swamp. She knew how insecure Catra felt about her new friendships with her and Bow. How difficult it was for her to trust others, to accept that she might have actually earned her place among them. With all the good she has done, the selfless choices she's made and the sacrifice she made for Glimmer, that had cost her so much.

“So when do we raid the kitchen for cake?” Catra asked a few tense minutes later. Finn’s words back at the farm house inspiring her to open her heart and try again.

Glimmer smiled, it was an olive branch. She rolled to face Adora and Catra, propping the side of her head up with a bent arm. “On Darla, it would more likely be dehydrated protein slaw.” She quipped dryly.

They all shared a good laugh.

“Yummm.” Catra hummed sarcastically, laying on her back staring up at the roof.

“Anything's better than ration bars.” Adora stated. Catra nodded and snuggled up to Adora's side, resting her head on Adora's chest. Staring at Glimmer with reserved affection, not knowing how to proceed from here.

Glimmer gave her a warm smile. “If it wasn't for this Horde Scum, coming to my rescue...yet again. I wouldn't be here. To enjoy eating anything.”

Catra was silent, staring at Glimmer with uncertainty in her eyes. Glimmer had just thanked her for saving her life and she had no idea what to do or say. Glimmer moved and rested her chin on the other side of Adora's chest. Staring intently at Catra for a moment.

“I..do..not..hate...you.” She enunciated slowly, articulating every word so she would be understood. Then darted her hand towards, Catra’s nose and booped her with a finger. “I admire you, actually. You are one of the strongest, bravest people I know. I'm your friend Catra...no matter what.”

Adora glanced down at her girlfriend as she silently absorbed Glimmer’s compliment and reassurance. Glimmer choice of words had resonated with Catra, filling her with hope. Then Adora turned to her best friend, who was smiling softly at the magicat. Adora’s lopsided grin, turning to surprise as she watched Catra blink slowly at Glimmer. Adora understood at that moment, Catra had finally given Glimmer her complete trust.

“I'd like to make a quick stop in the Fright Zone. “ Catra stated, as Adora settled her arm around her, holding her close.

“I figured you never wanted to go back there.” Adora stated softly, her chest aching with anxiety.

“Well, Scorpia needs a heads up and I'd like to pick up some things from my Force Captain Quarters.” Catra yawned, nuzzling her face into Adora's neck as she got more comfortable. Her hot breath made Adora shiver.

“Ok...” Adora agreed, her voice exploding out rather high pitched. As her whole body hummed with sudden arousal. Catra had no idea how naturally sensual and alluring she could be. Adora cast her a sideways glance, finding her smiling contentedly, now wondering if the sly cat knew exactly what she was doing.

“But, I want to go with them.” Finn whined, from his position on Swift Winds back.

“Not this time.” Glimmer knelt beside the horse, checking her pack one last time. Tucking her own communication pad inside, before mounting behind him.

Swift Wind watched Adora and Catra striding into the distance towards the foothills that would lead them down into the heart of the Fright Zone. They both had packs, filled with equipment and provisions. Melog flew overhead, keeping a close eye on the landscape ahead. There was, far too many dangers lurking in the wilds of Etheria.

“Be safe.” Swift Wind whispered, pushing his affirming emotions through their link. Adora responded with a bright, confident feeling. Urging Swift Wind to stop worrying, she would be fine.

“But Adora said I could stay with her for as long as I wanted.” Finn stated in a whine.

“She's going to meet us at Mystacor in a few days. Nothing is going to hurt you there.” Glimmer responded as she climbed up behind Finn. Holding the deer hybrid close as Swift Wind took flight.

“Famous, last words.” Finn groused, folding his arms stubbornly across his chest.

Catra and Adora stood in silence for a long time, lost in their own grim thoughts. Standing upon the crest of a sprawling hill, the wind howling up from the flat lowlands below. Staring out over the once barren plain that bordered the edge of the Fright Zone. The wide open land stretched as far as one could see, a year ago it had been a desolate place. Now it was lush and full of wildflowers. Far in the distance was the broken, rocky crags of the Fright Zones main base. It might have been a mountain at some point but Hordaks' ship when it crashed had hollowed it out. Now the crumbling mantle that remained, folded around the expansive, highly technological fortress nestled in the middle. Forming a natural barrier, protecting it from attack on three sides. Forcing anyone crazy enough to attack the Fright Zone to have only one avenue to assault. Which was highly fortified and nearly impenetrable. Melog hovered a few miles off, keeping a close eye on the sprawling grasslands. They were headed back to the fortress on foot, needing time to digest the pain and trauma being here resurrected in both of them. This trip was going to be more than just retrieving Catra's belongings. They wanted to put a seal on all the shadows Hordak and Shadow Weaver had created inside of them. They had promised each other back in the Inn at Erelandia, that they were going to face all the pain of their past head on and move on from it. This was a new beginning for them...to move resolutely and without doubts towards their future together.

“Let’s find Scorpia, first.” Adora offered, slipping her hand into Catra's. Catra merely nodded, the shadows of the past haunting her eyes, as she focused on the distant fortress.

By mid-day, the sun was beating down upon them as they crossed the flat plains. Very few words had been spoken between them. Coming here was still very hard, the emotional toll was draining. Shadow Weaver's constant tactics to manipulate and control them had been traumatic as they grew up. The emotional and physical abuse of being raised in the Horde had broken them both. The constant fear of Hordak's punishments, instilled in them as children. As they were forced to attend tribunals, watching his judgements upon soldiers who had failed him. Seeing the terror of those banished to Beast island, the suffering of those who earned correction. It had instilled a constant state of stress upon their developing minds, that made them view the world in absolutes. The strict routines of years of military training. Putting a brutal toll on their bodies. The daily pressure and anxiety of being groomed to be soldier's. Had left invisible scars that were still very raw.

Adora squinted into the sun, catching sight of a dust cloud kicking up on the horizon. The cloud billowed up over the tall grass, rolling towards them.

Catras' ears perked up at the low hum of the engines, as Melog landed and brushed up against them. They all shimmered out of sight, as Melog cloaked both of them. Just as the roar of Horde transports rumbled in the distance, closing in rapidly. A caravan of Horde cargo haulers charged past them a few minutes later. The massive bulk of the machines had made them indispensable for the military supply chain during the war. But they were not fast, or very maneuverable, making them easy targets for the rebels. As they fought over outposts on the borders of various kingdoms during the war. Adora and Catra watched them charge past, wondering what was going on.

It was closing in on dusk when they approached the border outpost, which had once been the first line of defense for the Horde. The burnt remains of the watchtower stood like a dark, metal sentinel at the fringe of the Fright Zone. The heavy military fortifications that once protected it, were twisted and blackened. Scattered fragments of metal sheeting and broken equipment blanketed the fields. They could see the remnants of Primes

drones and sentinel bots. Even the Fright Zone had not been spared, during the first few weeks of Primes occupation. The tyrant had rained down his fury, taking over the planet in a matter of weeks. The rusted remains of chain link fences, sagged around the perimeter. While the remains of Horde war machines lay abandoned inside the compound. The entire compound was overgrown with wild flowers and hardy prairie grass.

“Want to take a skiff?” Catra offered, pointing to the mostly intact flying machine, propped up against the back of a squat metal equipment shed.

“Otherwise we'll be spending the night outside.” Adora shrugged, “The main fortress is still pretty far away.”

Catra nodded and jogged for the skiff. They pushed it off the wall, the rusty metal hover boat groaned in protest then crashed to the ground like a dead weight. They both tossed their packs on board.

Adora checked the back engines for damage. “I doubt we'll find the keys.”

“Don't need them. " Catra replied as she climbed up to the flat platform, checking the steering rudder. To make sure it hadn't seized in place. When it moved with little protest, she squatted down at the back of the small craft just above the engine compartment and pried up a flat panel with her claws. In seconds she had pulled out the wires for the engine and started taping the ends gingerly together.

“When did you learn to hot wire one of these things?” Adora noted with a curious smile, moving to the rudder as Melog curled up on the curved bow.

“Just one of the many new tricks I learned while you were away.” Catra responded, focusing on her work. Not wanting to delve too deeply into memories of when Adora had left her. They both still had a lot to work through in regards to the war and the

repercussions of the choices that they made. They were taking that pain one wound at a time. Being in the Fright Zone was going to bring up a-lot of bad memories. Adora nodded, her smile fading, as the skiff roared to life. She steered it clear of the rubble, setting a course for the looming shadows that was the main fortress on the horizon.

Adora slowed the skiff down, as they flew through the blown out remains of the heavy entry gates. Entering the outer quadrant of the eastside sector of the Fright Zone, the same weak point they had used to infiltrate the base months prior. When they had attempted to free Spinerella and Scorpia from Primes control. The looming Guard tower and battlements that flanked the gates were filled with flowering vines. There were no guards posted on the towers to detain them. So they soared into a vast outer compound without protest. That was now filled with Horde tents. Ex-soldiers were moving around the massive encampment, sorting out supplies and setting up for a long stay. The grass that had once carpeted the ground inside the open space had been stomped dead by the massive crowd of Horde Soldier's. Now it was just churned up dirt and mud from constant movement of feet and heavy equipment.

“What is going on?” Adora mouthed to Catra. Who was now on full alert, crouched on the bow next to Melog. Her eyes took in the hundreds upon hundreds of troops, now clogging the streets of the ruined fortress. As Adora guided the skiff slowly, into the interior of the Eastern Fright Zone. Passing through narrow alleys, with huge storage buildings on either side, the walls in full bloom with fresh flowers. The massive hanger doors open, with troops unloading cargo haulers of food and supplies. Moving deeper, past the foundry and forge, both of them glancing up to their cherished platform high above. Passing each other fond smiles as they found the railings were covered in blooming flowers as well. It was a very poignant sight, illustrating to both of them, how their new relationship was flourishing.

They found troops clearing the debris and tossing it into cargo haulers from one end of the Fright Zone to the other. While other soldiers were busy with repair kits, trying to resurrect what they could of machinery and vehicles abandoned in the alleyways when Horde Prime had taken over. Adora took the skiff down a series of narrow streets, heading towards the training sector. Where their old squad barracks along with countless others were located. Coming across another smaller encampment of tents, in the open area just before the chain link fence of their squad's old training yard. Catra leaped off the skiff before Adora had it to a full stop. Her keen eyesight catching the awkward, stumbling figure of Kyle. He was dressed in his training shirt and black pants, a cargo vest zipped up on his lean torso. He had a huge stack of ration crates in his arms and had just entered a Force Captains tent on the far side of the yard.

“Catra!” Adora shouted, jumping off the skiff with Melog and rushing to keep up.

They ran into the tent, finding Catra in a less than cordial stand off with Lonnie. The two women stood glaring at each other on either side of a long table. Lonnie wore the breastplate of a Horde commander, the sharp winged, symbol of the Horde, that once adorned the chest armor. Was dented and scratched from battle. With her black training pants and heavy army boots she looked like a battle hardened Force Captian. Her tightly braided hair was pulled back into her signature ponytail. Her hazel eyes glared with a cold fury at Catra. In the last three year she had become a hardened soldier who had seen far too much. Kyle had only made it a couple steps inside before tripping and spilling the crates upon the dirt. He was more pale, with heavy discolored bags under his eyes. Whining and fussing with the scattered ration bars, trying to put them back in order inside the single intact wooden crate that survived.

“What are you doing here?” Lonnie complained, “I had hoped to never see your face again. Force Captain, Catra.” She sneered, her hand slowly inching towards a stun baton that sat on the far edge of the table. She was a battle scarred soldier now and she had

absolutely no trust that Catra wasn't going to attack. Near the end of the war, Catra had become an obsessed, cruel taskmaster. That had nearly gotten her, Kyle and Rogelio killed in the field. After Scorpia left, Catra became even more unstable. Lonnie didn't know how to handle her, she was suspicious of everyone, worried people were laughing at her. She was volatile and emotionally unhinged. If it wasn't for Kyle's intervention, Catra might have gutted her in the locker room. That had been the last straw, They left right after that brutal confrontation, finding themselves in the Crimson Waste. Fighting once again for freedom, against Primes forces and then against their own people who were chipped. With the war over they had returned to the only home they had ever known. Finding Scorpia, who gave them a new purpose and a dream of creating a kingdom to call their own.

"Relax, I'm not here to cause trouble." Catra raised her hands, keeping a close eye on Lonnie's hands.

"Let me help you." Adora offered, gently. Rushing to Kyle's side and helping the nervously stuttering young man with the clean up.

"We're looking for Scorpia." Catra asked, taking in the huge cork board behind Lonnie full of charts and schematics of the fortress. The table was scattered with files and documentation, Lonnie had been cataloging.

"She's up at Horror Hall, been there most of the week." Lonnie answered, chucking a thumb vaguely towards the barren hilltop out past the fortress that it sat on.

"What are you guys doing, back here? I thought the ex-horde would have scattered all over Etheria? You're all free now." Adora stated, tossing the last ration bar, on a loose pile beside the full crate.

Lonnie snorted and crossed her arms over her chest. "We had defected to the Crimson Waste during the end of the war. Catra had become absolutely insufferable!" She narrowed her eyes at

Catra, silently instigating a fight. When Catra refused to move, glaring back just as heatedly. " We joined the rebellion for a time but ended up back here." Lonnie shrugged, before continuing. " Not all of us, Horde. Got a free pass after the war." She glared pointedly at Catra, her eyes flicking warily to Melog who was glowing a deep crimson near the tent's entrance. Lonnie was nervous of the new creature, Catra had obtained. Debating quickly if she could take on the strange cat in a fight, if it decided to attack.

Catra grit her teeth, her ears flattening and tail snapping in anger. Lonnie's words cut deep, but they were the truth. She had been given a second chance because of her association to the Princess Alliance and the final battle at the Heart. She hadn't had to endure the hatred and fear the rest of the ex-horde had too. She could understand Lonnie's resentments. She had been the worst of them and she had gotten off the easiest.

Lonnie turned her somber gaze upon Adora. "Etheria hates us, Adora. We've been shunned and persecuted everywhere we go. No one wants us in their kingdoms. So Scorpia welcomed us into her kingdom. The Horde are now coming back to the Fright Zone. We are going to tear this place down and then rebuild the Scorpion Empire in Scorpia's image. Here we can finally make a home."

"That can't be true..." Adora stood, appalled. "You fought Horde Prime with the rest of us. You deserve to be treated fairly."

"Grizzlor's out on the Plains of Thaymor with several squads, looking for a place to settle." Catra offered, casting Adora a side glance. Finding the blonde staring at her in confusion.
"When did you?" Adora began.

"I drove him and his horde army out of Thaymor Village." With a sigh, Catra turned to confront the hurt in Adora's eyes.

"You have not been telling me everything." Adora's voice was low, anger simmering in her blue eyes.

“It just never came up.” Catra shrugged in her defense, “We have had a-lot of other stuff going on, it's not important.”

“I'll send a squad out to track him down, then.” Lonnie, stated. “Kyle, go get Rogelio and take a transport out to Thaymor. Let’s get our people back here before they cause any trouble.“

“Right!” Kyle gave her a sloppy salute and darted out of the tent. He stopped just before the tent flaps and turned back to Adora.

“It's good to see you again, Adora.” He gave her a small smile and then disappeared.

Catra sighed and hung her head for a moment. “For what it’s worth, Lonnie. I'm really sorry, for how I treated you and the guys. I was really messed up at the time, I'm working hard at being a better person now.”

“After what happened in the locker room. Kyle's scared of you, it's not that he's still carrying a grudge.” Lonnie advised. “We've all done a lot of things we regret, Catra. All we can do now is move forward and make better choices.” At that she was done talking and returned her attention to the paperwork in front of her.

Catra merely nodded, understanding that Lonnie wasn't ready to give her a second chance. She had so much to repair.

But she had the time....right?

Horror Hall was a dreary place normally, at twilight it was a lonely, sprawling monolith. With long empty halls of stone, cut into the remains of the granite foothills just beyond the Fortress. The only touch stone Scorpia had to the history of her people. This would be the foundation for her kingdom, her castle would be built from these ruins. She sat on a grand dais, in a simple, crumbling throne, carved from pale granite deep in the central chamber of the Great Hall. The flag stone floor was littered with rubble, crack and broken from war and time. The central chamber was a giant

round room, with pillars of blue black granite stretching up to a massive domed ceiling. A abstract mural of the royal family lay behind the throne, the six figures of her two mother's, her grandfather in the center. Then her grandmother and her aunt took up the entire wall behind the throne. A huge mural, cracked and peeling dominated the dome above. It was painted an exquisite blue as if to mimic the sky, crude designs were etched into the ceiling. The scorpion people were. not known for their artistry, but for their abilities as powerful warriors...at least that's what Scorpia thought. She honestly knew nothing about her heritage. Hordak had taken her in as a child, after her kingdom had fallen. Her people scattered or extinct? She didn't know, she had never seen another Scorpion hybrid.

Glancing up briefly from the data pad in her pincher, to a row of ancient portraits in dark alcoves that lined the Great Hall. The paintings of the long dead monarchy were cast in the flickering light of torches, set in iron scones down the vast corridor. Those paintings were of her ancestors but she did not remember them. Her grandfather had alllied their kingdom with Hordak, when she was little more than a baby. She wondered why her grandfather never fought against the Horde like all the other kingdoms? Was their kingdom's relations with the other kingdoms of Etheria so bad, at the time. Joining Hordak, an invader from beyond the stars, was a good idea? Or had Hordak completely overpowered her kingdoms defenses? Leaving her grandfather with no choice but to join the Horde or die? Either way, her grandfather had been loyal to Hordak for years? At least until Hordak demanded their families Rune Stone. She had been a young child then, already in cadet training for a few seasons. Moving into the barracks. Leaving her mother's quarters for good, it had been a scary transition. She was happy to have been able to bring a few things. Like a picture of her mothers and her stuffed scorpion, Pinchy. She had been in the Black Garnet Chamber up in Horror Hall with her mother's and Grandmother. She couldn't remember why, only that it was one of the cherished times she got to share with them between endless weeks of training. It had been a really awful day. Hordak had showed up at Horror Hall with a contingent of soldiers

and demanded the Black Garnet, wanting to study its magic. Her grandfather had refused. Which led to a fire fight in the in Black Garnet Chamber here in Horror Hall. Her mothers and grandmother had been caught up in the crossfire. She guessed that after her parents and his own wife had been slaughtered by the Horde as punishment for his refusal. Her Grandfather had lost his mind and soon his own life. She was grateful that Hordak had granted her mercy and allowed her to continue to train. He could have easily killed her and been done with it. She had dedicated her life to the Horde. Her loyalty had been unparalleled...until she had met Catra. Through her mentorship and witnessing all the cruelty and unjust punishments she had endured at the hands of their superiors... at the hands of Hordak. She had finally come to question why she willingly obeyed those who were in charge. Watching Catra strive so hard to achieve her own goals, forge her own destiny no matter the odds. It inspired her to stop just existing each day, doing her duties...it made her want more for the first time.

When Catra began to spiral downward after the Crimson Waste, Scorpia realized she couldn’t help her, couldn't save her, it was hurting her too much to keep trying. She needed to save Entrapta, needed to change her focus and move one. She was emboldened to forge her own destiny.

Her gaze fell sadly on a dark room, that lay down a side hall just behind the throne. She had moved her Rune Stone out of Shadow Weaver's sanctum, returning it to its rightful place in the Garnet Chamber up in Horror Hall. It hadn't worked for her since. She figured she must have broken it, since she broke just about everything she touched. Until Entrapta's transmission this morning, she had explained what happened to her Rune Stone. Then relayed to her the Super Secret mission Catra had given them. Expressing that she was going to need several dozen cargo transports to help with the excavation of the First Ones Ruin. She had sent them out immediately, eager to help her Wild Cat anyway she could.

“It's for the best.” Scorpia muttered, returning her attention to the data pad. She wanted nothing more to do with the First Ones and their meddling tech. She was more than happy to learn how to access her magic naturally. Learning to focus on the power that lived inside her sounded exciting. She was going to Mystacor with Entrapta in a few days to meet up with the rest of the Princess Alliance.

“Scorpia?” Catra's voice, called from the darkness of the hall.

“Catra...” Scorpia, set the pad down, jumping to her feet to greet her long time friend.

When Adora and Catra walked into the firelight. Scorpia's dashed for them, a huge, eager smile spreading across her once somber face.
“Oh...I've missed you guys.” She exclaimed, “Come here!”

Catra yelped and Adora laughed merrily as Scorpia swept them up into a mighty hug. Melog mewled in surprise, jumping back a few steps.

“Oh, Wow. Melog has wings?” Scorpia observed in shock.

“It's a long story.” Adora groaned, Scorpia's hold was so tight, she could barely breathe.

“How have you been...things have been just crazy around here, let me tell you.” Scorpia stated, setting them down.

“Lonnie filled us in.” Catra groaned, rolling her neck wondering lamely if Scorpia had just dislocated her spine. Melog padded up to her, raising their head up inquiring softly if she was ok. Catra smiled and nodded down at her companion, giving them a gentle pat on the head.

“Oh, well...yeah. That's, that's just terrible how the Horde is being treated in other Kingdoms. I will be bringing that up at our next Princess meeting for sure.” Scorpia nodded.

“I'm sorry about your Rune Stone.” Adora tapped her chest sadly to accent the Fail Safe scar hidden beneath her shirt.

“Not to worry, Entrapta filled me in about everything.” Scorpia started with a smile, giving Catra a knowing wink. Which made Adora frown in confusion.

Catra cried out in sudden alarm, realizing that Entrapta had let Scorpia in on the plan and the woman was terrible at keeping secrets! She made a cutting gesture across her neck, glaring up at her in fright. Scorpia clasped her pinchers to her lips, her face flushing instantly.

“What is going on?” Adora questioned with irritation, placing her hands on her hips. “Did Scorpia just wink at you?”

“Nothing..nothing...” Scorpia jumped in, “I just got some dirt in my eye. It wasn't a wink...definitely not a wink.” She moaned, turning on her heel and pretending to wipe her eyes with the tip of a pincher.

Adora gave Catra an incredulous look. Catra shrugged and offered her a weak smile.

“Did you have any trouble with your Guardian?” Adora inquired.

“Naw, Mr. Pointy has been dead for years.” Scorpia responded, “His bones lay in the Garnet Chamber, along with my Rune Stone.” She states nonchalantly, chucking her pincher at the dark room behind her throne.

“What happened?” Catra asked, needing to keep the conversation off Scorpia's screw up.

“Hordak killed the Rune Stone Guardian, when he took the Black Garnet back to the Fortress for Shadow Weaver.” Scorpia answered. Her voice should be sad or perhaps angry at what happened. But instead she was resigned to it all. It was in the past she would not dwell on the bad stuff that lived there.

“Sorry, I asked.” Catra grumbled, feeling terrible about having Scorpia dredge up such morbid memories.

“Naw, don't worry about it.” Scorpia waved a dismissive claw, sitting back down on her crumbling throne and picking up her data padd. “I always look ahead, ya know. This is a fresh start for my kingdom and I am going to do things right.” She offered them a warm, positive smile.

“I came to get some things from my old quarters. Want to walk back with us?” Catra offered, they had nothing new to tell Scorpia thanks to Entrapa so that cut the visit short.

“Naw, I got a lot of work to finish up here first.” She responded, “Gotta get it all done before we head to Mystacor.”

“Ok, then.” Adora, sighed heading down the hall, peeking into every alcove to look at the old, faded paintings. She barely remembered these ruins, but she knew Catra and her had explored them once before as small children. They had gotten caught too, not allowed to leave the fortress grounds. She had gotten a good tongue lashing from Shadow Weaver. Catra had gotten far worse both verbally and physically. Shadow Weaver had been so unfair.

Melog cast Catra a concerned glance, as they sensed the intense feelings of melancholy and grim understanding, radiating off of her. Then feeling she might need a moment alone with Scorpia, they padded off after Adora.

Catra stood on the dais for a moment. “If you need any help.. with anything. Or you just want to talk. I'm here for you.” She placed a comforting hand on the rough exoskeleton of Scorpia's shoulder. Sensing how forlorn Scorpia was about her Rune Stone. Catra understood better than most what she was going through. Scorpia had just recently been able to bond with the Black Garnet. Losing that power again, the feeling of abandonment, of being unworthy. It ate at your heart like a tumor.

“Naw, I'm good. But thanks.” Scorpia responded, they fell into a companionable silence for a moment while Scorpia mulled over her next few words. “I never meant to hurt you, when I left. It was the hardest thing I have ever done. But I never betrayed our friendship either. I will always have your back, Wild Cat.” Scorpia promised, her dark blue eyes were earnest. “Remember that.”

Catra swallowed hard, overwhelmed by her loyalty.

“Thank you...” She whispered, having a hard time holding back tears. After all the horrible things she had done, how cruel she had been, the mean things she had said to her. She really did not deserve her forgiveness or her friendship.

Catra took a deep breath, trying to settle her emotions, wanting to remain reserved and stoic. But she just couldn't do it. Scorpia had become so very important to her and she had come to trust her completely. She would never hurt her, ever again. So she flung herself forward and wrapped her arms around Scorpia's neck. The scorpion was shocked at first by Catra's sudden show of affection, but rolled with it.

“Oh...wow.” Scorpia breathed, wrapping an arm around Catra and held her tight for a moment. She leaned her head on top of Catra's humming with contentment. This was the close friendship she had always dreamed of having with Catra.

“Thank you for everything....for never giving up on me.” Catra whispered, her voice breaking. “I'll make you proud...one day.” She pulled away, blushing profusely with embarrassment. She was not used to being affectionate with anyone but Adora. Overwhelmed by what she had done, she darted off to catch up to Adora.

“I am already proud of you.” Scorpia smiled, watching her best friend rush away into the darkness of the hall.

Catra pressed her palm to the lock pad, opening the door to her old force captain quarters. Melog mewed and sniffed cautiously, as they entered. Sensing the lonely rage and brooding sadness that still haunted this place. Adora proceeded inside, her expression was somber, almost pensive. Catra watched Adora glance hesitantly around the spartan room, as she moved slowly towards the bed. Tossing her pack against the far wall near the side cabinet. Quickly unclasping her cloak and tossing it on top.

"This was supposed to be my room." Adora sighed, folding her hands nervously behind her back.

Her eyes searched the barren walls that were marred with scratches. The horde banner that dominated the back wall above the headboard of the bed was shredded. Catra cut her eyes to the banner and sighed. It was hanging in tattered ruins on the wall, the victim of her grief and rage. After she found Scorpia's final note in her quarters months ago. The years of damage had accumulated in the room. A clear marker for how angry and hurt Catra had been at the time. There were plenty of other places in the Fright Zone that Catra had retreated to while growing up. To scratch up or just to hide. Dealing in private with whatever was tormenting her, until Adora had found her and she sought solace in her comforting arms. Adora had always retreated to their barracks gym to take out her frustrations on the punching bag, or run laps out in the training yard till she couldn't breathe or think, or even stand. Catra though, she needed to feel her claws ripping through things to release that unbearable tension. With Adora no longer around to help her calm down she had completely destroyed many places including her room. The room had a slight musty smell from not being aired out for months. Catra's nose scrunched up at the heavy smell.

"You gave up a-lot of things back then, for them." Catra leaned against the doorframe for a moment, crossing her arms over her chest and giving Adora a bitter sweet smile. She had been so jealous of Glimmer and Bow at the beginning. So hurt that Adora would leave her, that she wasn't enough. That was when her heart had begun to crack, then in her anger and pride she had

pulled away. As the war raged on her heart continued to break until it shattered completely and she gave up on everything including herself.

“Catra...please don’t go there.” Adora turned to regard her with a remorseful frown. Her words might be flippant, but they held so much hurt deep down.

“I get it.. now. You never left me for them. You left for the greater good and all that. ” Catra chuckled dryly, moving into the room. She hated seeing Adora so torn up inside and needed to lighten the mood. The door hissed closed behind her, as she tossed her pack against the small metal cabinet by her bed. Melog curled up in the corner, shivering. Their mane rippled with a deep lavender aura. Glowing eyes watching Adora intently as all of Catra's roiling emotions washed over them.

“I never wanted to leave you.” Adora muttered softly.

“I know....” Catra sighed. “You asked me to come with you a dozen times, Adora.”

“I should have tried harder.” Adora growled, curling her fingers into tight fists.

“Shoulda, woulda, coulda...” Catra rolled her eyes, mockingly. “ I made my choice! Let it go, Adora. We both messed up. Kay.”

Adora sighed and slumped her shoulder's, following Catra towards the bed. Catra opened the top drawer in the cabinet she used as a bed side table. Pulling out another maroon, commander's tunic, like the one she wore last year. Cutting out the Horde symbol at the back with a claw and then setting it on top. Than retrieved her leather jacket from the Crimson Waste, from a small locker on other side of the room. Placing it on top of the tunic. Then pulled out her fingerless, leather gloves from prom, from the drawer setting them on the pile. With a weary sigh she closed the drawer and began to undress. It had been a long day and she really wanted to get some sleep.

Adora swallowed hard, as Catra pulled off her ripped tunic and tossed it on the floor. After their last playful bout of affection on Darla. The sight of her pert breasts, hidden just behind her black wrap was highly arousing. Adora found herself staring, her desire completely obvious. Her blue eyes were intense, unable to blink. Adora cleared her throat and closed her eyes as her cheeks heated. Regaining her composure and calming her heartbeat she slowly opened her eyes.

Finding Catra smiling coyly up at her. “Hey, Adora.” She crooned sweetly.

Adora suddenly felt a surge of joy and reassurance, Catra's open and honest smile always gave her. Her cheeks flaring right back up again at the playful, seductive tone in Catra's voice. As it got her worked up all over again. She smiled back with a groofy, lovestruck smile, rubbing the back of her neck and nervously rocking on her feet.

“I dreamed for years to see that kind of reaction from you, towards me.” Catra giggled, flopping back on her bed. “I also dreamed of having you all to myself, here, in this room.” Catra's sexual innuendo's did not go unnoticed. So many lewd thoughts ran rampant through Adora's mind, leaving her blinking and swallowing repeatedly. Catra curled up on the edge of the bed, laughing uproariously as Adora unraveled into a blubbering mess. Unable to speak or even form a sentence at the thought of having sex with her.

“Breathe, Adora!” Catra coaxed, after she regained her composure. Adora opened her eyes, to find her girlfriend now standing before the bed. Catra gave her shoulders a quick shake, staring up at it her with a mixture of fear and excitement.

She wasn’t ready for that next step either...

Adora started to laugh, stepping out of Catra’s affirming hands on her shoulders. Nervously taking in the room once more. The overhead light flickered and buzzed, the lack of personal items

gave the room a cell like atmosphere. The space held such a profound sense of loneliness, of despair and fear. The realization dampened her mood quickly.

They had always promised to be together. That nothing really bad could happen...as long as they had one another. She had betrayed that promise, abandoning Catra. Because she had a greater destiny to pursue and Catra...well, she pulled away to forge her own destiny...she thought. The Fright Zone was a hard place to grow up in. You were always training, always fighting against one another for approval. It was survival of the fittest from day one. You couldn't show weakness of any kind, otherwise you would be seen as a failure in front of your fellow cadets or your commanding officer. Catra could always count on Adora for support, comfort and loyalty. She had given her so many small touches over the years. Lingering looks and flirty remarks...that Adora had been completely oblivious too. Or perhaps ignored, cause she was never willing to lose sight of her own goals. Or believe there was anything more between them than friendship. Always striving to achieve more and never content with what she had. She had known how much Catra needed her, back at Thaymor. But she had left anyway.

The Horde's brutal, callus way of life wasn't so scary as long as they were together. Then suddenly she wasn't there for her ...and her life spiraled out of control. She had been selfish and short sighted and Catra had paid the price for it.

“Wow...” Adora breathed, realizing how oblivious she had been. Catra had been in love with her way back during their time in the Horde. She felt that perhaps she might have been in love with her too. But she was not capable of understanding those kinds of feelings back then. She had been rather repressed emotionally, thanks to Shadow Weaver. She would have also been too scared of the repercussions anyway to act on them. She had been so driven, so single minded in her goals. She honestly never paid much attention to Catra's feelings, just took for granted that she would always be there. Her trusty best friend....her side kick that always had her back. That crushing understanding of how terrible

she had treated Catra for so many years, struck her cold. The guilt washed over her and drowned her instantly. Deflating onto the bed, she suddenly felt light headed and dizzy. “I'm sorry for leaving you. I'm so sorry for not protecting you. For not paying enough attention to you, to see how you truly felt. For taking your loyalty, your feelings for granted for all those years. I was a horrible friend.” She couldn't even verbalize all the trauma and abuse Catra had gone through growing up, because she was so close to Adora. All the hurt she had caused her, by focusing on her own selfish desires instead paying more attention to her. Or the pain and suffering Catra had endured on her own, trying to survive without her, here in the Horde.

“Please, don't apologize.” Catra sat beside her, snaking her arm in between Adora's legs. Capturing a hand with hers. “We were just kids and I should have never expected you to stand up to Shadow Weaver. You were as frightened of her as I was. You're a sweet, caring and driven person, Adora. That's why I love you. But rather obtuse when it comes to feelings, your own and anyone else's. It was not like the Horde was all that touchy, feely. I think we're both rather clumsy when it comes to feelings, but we'll figure this all out together.” She leaned in, placing a soft, if terse kiss on Adora's cheek. “I always hid my feelings for you. About everything, I really cared about back then. I never expressed what I really wanted, instead I just wallowed in my bitterness and resentment instead. Ultimately, I made the choice to stay, you tried to get me to leave many times.” Catra took a deep breath, as Adora wiped her watery eyes with the back of her other hand.

“I wasn't here to protect you...” Adora moaned, her lips trembling with profound sorrow. She left unsaid, that she had not been there to protect her from her own self destructive tendencies. That perhaps if she had gone back to the Horde, she might have been able to convince her to leave eventually. Provided enough clarity to do what was right and trust that she could take care of her, out in the real world. Catra had always needed to feel safe and in control, she needed to contemplate all the angles before making a decision. She was not reckless or brash, like Adora.

“I can take care of myself, dummy!” Catra growled playfully, not catching onto the unsaid meaning behind her words.

“I know...” Adora whimpered, rubbing her other eye with the heel of her hand. But the tears continued to fall.

“Honestly, I couldn't leave the Horde. When you first asked me, at Thaymor. I was scared. This is all I knew and I wasn't ready to give it up, not for two complete strangers...and a magic sword. " Catra stated, with a bitter laugh. Adora nodded, refusing to lift her gaze from the floor.

Now that Catra had started to bear her heart, it all flowed out of her like a broken dam.

“I...I hated your sword. I hated the giant, magical warrior it turned you into. She didn't look like you, not really and she definitely did not smell like you. She-Ra honestly really scared me, back then.” Catra sighed, giving Adora's hand a reassuring squeeze. “I blamed the sword for taking you away from me, but I never had the heart to destroy it. I knew it meant a lot to you.”

“Well...that might have sped things along.” Adora paid her a small smirk. “My destiny and all that.”

“You would have hated me for it.” Catra confessed. “You are a stubborn brat and you like to make your own decisions...and mistakes.” She chided with a shoulder shove, adjusting her fingers as she re-carded them in Adora's hand. The blonde's hand had grown damp with stress and anxiety, but Catra refused to let go. She would always be there for Adora, to help guide her out of her troubled thoughts. To give her comfort, soothe her worries and love her no matter what. Just like Adora did for her...

Adora nodded, she couldn’t refute that, bumping Catra back with own shoulder.

“Sounds familiar.” Adora smirked, staring pointedly at Catra with watery eyes. Catra chuckled bitterly and nodded.

“At first I just wanted to prove myself that I wasn't worthless, that I was more than just second best...your sidekick. That I didn't need you at my side to become powerful. That I could protect myself for once!” Catra snarled. “But I got all caught up in the power struggle here. I lived in fear at first, as Shadow Weaver and eventually Hordak threatened my life at every failure. Eventually, I needed to out-do Shadow Weaver to keep my place with Hordak. Which meant doing some very bad things that I regret. Soon I was lying, manipulating and lashing out at everyone. Consumed by guilt by the terrible things I had done. My anger and resentments were the only armor I had to keep going. Every day was a struggle, as I was desperate to rise up in the Horde, to prove to everyone that I was strong. I wanted to win for once!” Catra shouted vehemently, ducking her head swiftly in shame.

“Catra...” Adora was staring at her, tears of regret glistening in her eyes.

Catra looked uneasy, shifting her weight on her feet, making the bed creek up and down. Giving Adora's hand a good squeeze before letting go, as she rose off the bed and began to pace.

“It hurt...a-lot... when you left. It felt like you had ripped my heart out at Thaymor when you rejected me….abandoned me... I was angry and grieving our friendship. The future we had always talked about was gone! I had a really hard time letting that go....I don't do change...well...” She offered Adora a bitter smile. “ But after our time inside that First Ones ruin, I gave up on convincing you to come home. I thought I was better off without you holding me back, that perhaps Shadow Weaver would see that I was a loyal daughter…. See that I was better than you, perhaps she would finally love me in the same way she had loved you...” She was quiet for a long time, unable to meet Adora’s sad eyes. She had tried to kill her...cutting that spider web...she had wanted her gone! Catra stared down at her feet in shame. Heaved a broken gasp of air, valiantly trying to push down the sobs that were wanting to break free. She was seeking to apologize for yet another horrible mistake, made in a fit of selfish rage.

Adora took a shaky breath, casting her eyes down, overwhelmed by her own grief and pain. Catra had been so detached from her cruelty then. Her betrayal...the fact that in Adora’s mind, she had abandoned her and left her for dead. Her harsh words, that placed the blame of Catra’s abuse, her stolen laurels upon Adora's shoulders. The cold disdain in her eyes...that showed her that she no longer mattered, that to Catra she was already dead. Her malicious actions of cutting the webbing...with every intention of ending Adora's life. It had crushed Adora's spirit, having to let go...commit to that fall and whatever outcome awaited her at the bottom. The grief of losing Catra had been unbearable for a very long time. Bow, Glimmer and Swifty had gotten her threw it, healing the cracks Catra had made in her heart. But over the course of the next few years, their battles, the harsh words they shouted at each other, would leave her completely shattered inside.

“My pride would never let me leave the Horde after that. I gave into my anger cause it was easier than admitting I was wrong. I should have left with you at Thaymor. I silently regretted that every day. But blaming you for all my mistakes, all my sins, hurt a lot less than admitting them to myself. But they were all my choices. I have to live with that. I was a stubborn, hot-headed fool, Adora. I am paying the price for it everyday. But I promised, I would do better...be better.” Catra clasped her hands behind her back as she paced, refusing to look at Adora lest she lose her courage. Then Catra moved swiftly, kneeling before her. Seizing Adora's face with her hands and kissing her. Catra's lips were warm, insistent and pleading.

Adora's eyes flew wide in shock, freezing in her grasp. Catra released her unwillingly, her eyes searching for understanding, for forgiveness.

Adora stared down at her in amazement, then dropped her gaze as she noticed the desperation on her face. Unsure as to how to respond.

“Something really bad happened back in the swamp...I didn't mean for it to happen. I couldn't tell you...I was scared...that you might hate me. I'm not a good person, Adora! I don't deserve your love or Glimmer's friendship.. or any of the forgiveness that's been given to me...” Catra's voice was so soft, Adora could barely hear it, but she did and her words broke her heart.

Then Catra's communication pad went off in her pack. She scrambled for her bag, yanking the pad out and passing Adora a frightened look.

“Catra, you gotta stop keeping things from me.” Adora stated with some annoyance. “I've known something was up for days. So sit down and show me who's on the pad.”

Catra took a deep breath, activating the call and sitting down beside Adora on the bed.

Entrapta's face appeared, smudged black with ash and dust. She looked tired but excited, as she confronted both Catra and Adora.

“Good, you've told her then?” Her shrill voice inquired.

“I was starting too, before you interrupted.” Catra responded in frustration.

“Oh...well. I could call back if you need more time.” Entrapta offered, about to cut the transmission.

“No!” Adora shouted. “Just tell me what's going on.”

“Ok,” Entrapta flipped her pad to show Adora the blackened devastation of an old first one's ruin. The melted remains of portal arches and hundreds of burnt and dented containers and charred, unrecognizable bodies.

“The bad news is. The portal is toast. I couldn't even salvage it for parts.” Entrapta grumbled in disappointment.

Adora passed Catra an alarmed look. Catra merely cringed, shrinking slightly away from Adora.

“Equally bad news, most of the Eternian's are dead...some have escaped. But most of them are dead.” Entrapta's voice grew somber. “The good news is the containers survived. The Etherians inside are still alive...in some kind of stasis.” Entrapta's voice was breathless with awe and building excitement. “Scorpia sent a convoy of cargo transports and I am going to load them up and take them to the Fright Zone to study.” She finished with a huge excited grin.

Adora's alarmed look turned into horror then to irritation. “You told Entrapta and Scorpia and not me!” She shouted, her anger burning deep inside her chest.

Catra paid her a wilting grimace.

“I'm sure I can figure out how to release them.” Entrapta mused.. “Eventually.”

Adora huffed out a tired breath, pinching the bridge of her nose in aggravation.

“So, anyway. I'll see you in a few days. Scorpia says you're in the Fright Zone.” Entrapta finished cutting the channel.

As soon as the transmission ended, Adora screamed with rage and lunged for Catra. Catra cried out in fright and dropped the pad to the floor.

As Adora pinned the smaller feline woman to the bed, straddling her hips and holding both arms up over her head by the wrists. Heaving for breath and absolutely furious. Adora glared down at her girlfriend, her eyes cold and unyielding. “Tell me everything!”

Catra was heaving for air, her heart hammering in her chest with fear. Adora had never been so angry, so desperate for her to comply.

Catra bit down on her lower lip to stop it from trembling and shut her eyes tight.

“Please, don't leave me...I'm not a monster.” She pleaded softly, tears falling down her cheeks.

Shattered Self

Adora pulled back, loosening her grip on Catra's hands. Scared and appalled that she would think that. It tore her up inside, knowing that Catra saw herself as a monster. That she would ever leave her?

“Catra...what?” Adora gasped. The look of hopelessness and fear on Catra's face, broke her heart in an instant.

“I was scared... that I don’t deserve forgiveness. I just couldn’t tell you… and risk that you might realize that I’m a truly terrible person. That I’m not worth loving. I don't know what I'd do if you hated me.” Catra wailed, struggling in Adora's grip, twisting miserably under her. “They had captured you and put you in one of those container's. They said they were from Eternia? By the time I had caught up, they were pushing you into the portal. I had to save you...you were the only one I was thinking about. I had to stop them, I couldn't let them take you. I ripped open the container they had you in and got your out. I somehow destroyed the portal...but I never thought it would set off such a powerful explosion. I thought I had killed all those people.” Catra confessed between broken, heart rending sobs.

“It was an accident! What happened was out of your control, you couldn't stop it. So beating yourself up over it is pointless.” Adora shouted back, then switched tactics, she needed to get her attention. Shaking Catra by the shoulder's, needing her to come to her senses. “How could you think I would ever hate you! Ever leave you...again!” She declared, when Catra snapped her eyes open. Heaving for air and choking back even more sobs.

Adora gave her a gentle smile, to help ease the desperation she could see on Catra's face.

“I love you...I will always love you.” She professed, cupping Catra's cheeks tenderly.

“I'm no hero....I never once thought about those other people...just you.” Catra confided quietly, laying still beneath her. Her arms still above her head, finger's curled up tight to her palms, her claws poking into the tender flesh there but not breaking the skin.

“If the tables were turned...and it was you being taken away like that. I would have put you first too.” Adora admitted softly, blinking back regretful tears of her own. Her thoughts falling back to that desperate moment before the gateway to the Heart. Unable to leave Catra behind, or bear to hear her anguished cries. As she fought the Guardian all on her own. She had turned back, putting Catra first over the well being of all of Etheria..over the universe. Forcing Shadow Weaver to make that fateful choice.

Catra had been living with that same guilt for days, letting it fester and eat away at her. She needed to do better, to regain Catra's trust that she wasn't going to betray her or abandon her so easily.

Catra sucked in a cold breath, blinking up at her. Her expression was bewildered, her eyes filled with uncertainty. That she had heard Adora correctly. She believed Adora was the selfless hero, who always put others ahead of herself. To know that she put her above all the others, it mattered....it mattered so much. To know that she was loved in spite of her faults, in spite of her terrible past.

“I love you.” Catra leaned up, cupping Adora's face in her hands and crashing her lips against hers. The kiss this time was rough, hard and demanding.

Adora moaned, the warmth and sweetness of Catra's mouth was intoxicating. She was trembling and struggling to remain straddling her. As Catra pulled her down on top of her. She was responding to Catra's love with a longing of her own. Sweeping her tongue inside her mouth, deepening the kiss.

Catra moaned and arched, their bodies pressed together tightly for a moment. Adora could feel every inch of her supple body against hers. The tight muscles of her stomach as they clenched, the soft mounds of her breasts squashed up against hers. The hard pebbles of her nipples now brushing against her breasts. The feel of their bodies, sliding against each other like two puzzle pieces. Was so sudden and overwhelming. Adora breathed a husky moan, as desire bloomed in the very core of her. Making the muscles in the lower half of her abdomen spasm. She cried out with pleasure, unsure what had just happened. But the blissful feeling that followed eased her fears.

Catra's tail curled seductively up and around her thigh. The tickle of the soft fur against her inner leg was pleasantly distracting. When Catra’s tail tip began flicking happily, against her crotch. Adora was left panting and gasping for air. As another shock wave of pleasure rippled through her core.

Distracted and overwhelmed by the rising pleasure, Catra regained the upper hand. She rolled Adora down on the mattress, taking control of the seduction.

She pulled away, grinning joyfully down at her. Her beaming smile, for the first time in years, was unguarded and honest. She was truly happy and at ease enough in Adora’s company to show her.

Adora gently caressed her cheek, tracing the trail of a tear. Catra's eyes closed at her touch, her head tilted into her caress as Adora cupped her cheek.

Adora never stopped, she had never been so bold. Her fingers traced down the contours of Catra's neck, to her collar bone and then the hollow of her breasts. Before she pressed her palm against her chest just above her heart and felt it pounding.

Catra drew in a sharp breath, now trembling herself as she straddled Adora. Slowly she opened her eyes and looked down at her. How far was this going to go? How far did Adora want this to go? They remained motionless, barely breathing, hearts racing.

“It feels like you have a heart to me?” Adora finally stated. She watched Catra take a deep breath, trembling, her expression vulnerable. “Monster's don't have hearts, Catra, and yours...yours is brave, strong, selfless and good.” Adora advised gently. “You've already shown me, Glimmer and Bow all those qualities...you need to trust that the others will see it too.”

“But it's fragile...” Was Catra's soft reply. “I can't survive it being broken again.”

“Ok, then. I can be the Protector of your heart and you can protect mine.” Adora offered. “We will keep them safe, this time. ” She cupped Catra's face, smiling warmly up at her. Her soft blue eyes are earnest and hopeful. Searching hers for assurance, that she wanted this too.

Catra stared down at her, awestruck and lost in the swell of emotions flowing between them.

“You promise.” Catra breathed, it was the heartfelt entreaty of the vulnerable girl. The one that had only known cruelty and heartbreak. The one that still had not given up hope for a better tomorrow.

“I promise!” Adora answered, grinning and crying softly as she stared tenderly up at her one true love. The only person in all of Etheria who loved her for who she truly was and asked no more of her than what she was willing to give.

Catra's head was spinning. Amazed by the depth of love she saw reflected back at her, in Adora's eyes.

Fresh tears stung her eyes, as Adora pulled her down on top of her heaving chest. Catra was gasping and sobbing and unable to catch her breath. As she was cradled once more in Adora's arms, wrapped up tight. With her face pressed against Adoras neck, as they both cried. Their tears mingled, as they held tight onto one another, as if their lives depended on it.

Two girls, broken in their own ways.

Trying to heal one another.

Season's had passed since her last visit to these ancient grasslands. Catra stood upon the crest of the mighty stone monolith. She wondered if it had a name, most giant stones did? The Mountains of Etheria each had a name, like Talon Mountain in Dryl and Skydancer Mountain in Bright Moon. The significance of those names, she still didn't know but they were landmarks traveler's used to help guide them. Catra's musings returned to the landscape that surrounded her. The trees below in the hidden grotto had begun to turn. The leaves tinged crimson and gold. The view was tarnished now by a huge black obelisk jutting out of the center of the lake. Reaching out of sight into the clouds high above.

Aoi and Saladin sat on the lone boulder Loo-Kee had hidden behind. Each now dressed in heavier clothes to hold off the chill in the air. Saladin now wore tan leather pants that reached down to his ankles and a dark sleeveless tunic, with a heavy wool long sleeve shirt beneath. With the same crystal beads sewn into the seams of the vest. Aoi was wrapped in a heavy hide dress with a large hood trimmed with white fur and long flowing sleeves. Her dress had similar accents as Saladin of fine crystal bead work. That formed small interlocking knots. In her arms she held a tiny bundle, wrapped tight in a grey woolen and hide blanket, dyed a very soft blue. It mewled and cooed, small hands reaching from the heavy wool folds.

Catra was curious and approached cautiously. Her breath caught as she took in the baby, with heterochromatic eyes of blue and gold and thick dark brown hair. That grew in a wild halo over the top of her head, dark ears far too large for her tiny face. Were tucked back securely under the folds of the blanket.

"Kaira, is a fine name. It will suit her well." Saladin smiled down with pride, tickling a claw under the baby's chin. The baby's large

dark ears twitched free of the fabric restraints as she smiled back, a faint purr rumbling in her throat at the affection.

“When Senator Keldor of Eternia pays a visit to our village again. It is said that She-Ra will be accompanying him.” Aoi stated, her expression soured at the senator's name. She didn't trust him, he hid his true intentions behind a warm smile and far too many promises that he could not keep.

Saladin rolled his eyes. “He was just there last month, a hunting party brought him, with two other's of his kind, before the Pride Elders and Ouroboros. They proposed to construct a Rune Stone in the middle of the village, to harvest our magic so that we could become stronger. Spouting how proud we should be. To have been chosen to become part of the Heart of Etheria project.” Saladin explained, casting the Eternian obelisk an accusing glare.

“Power does not come without a price.” Aoi stated, with resignation.

“Haven't they taken enough?” She complained a few minutes later, as Saladin gazed down at her and the baby. His golden eyes shadowed with worry over their future here in the Savanah.

“They have harvested every part of our world, mined our star seeds and now they want to possess our magic as well.” She held the baby closer to her breast, unable to shake the fear Keldor invoked in her. His manner was far too polite, too polished. The council of elders had welcomed him and his cohorts with open arms. If he brought the She-Ra. The most honored warrior of their planet to vouch for his good intentions, then the elder's would surely give him whatever he wanted without a second thought. Many of the other kingdoms had already agreed to his plan, she felt it was only a matter of time before they were forced to give in as well.

Catra was jolted awake, by a sudden strike to her gut from Adora's knee. She groaned and rolled away from the assaulting limb. Falling out of bed with a soft grunt as she hit the cold floor.

“Well, I guess I deserved that...after what I put you threw.” Catra rubbed her bare stomach ruefully as she stood up. Finding Adora still fully clothed, hair loose and wild over their shared pillow. They must have fallen asleep, wrapped up in each other's arms.

Now Adora was thrashing in her sleep, seeking to subdue someone in her dreams. Her old cadet blanket, that Catra had stolen from the barracks when she had been reassigned to her Force Captain quarters, was now balled up at her bare feet. She had used it to comfort herself for all those long years they had been separated. Adora was moaning, her cheeks were flushed and she was rolling from side to side, her arms twitching, fingers flexing as if grappling or thrusting with her sword.

“Adora?” Catra called, moving around the bed. She was about to reach out to her and give her shoulder's a shake. When Adora was engulfed in light, transforming into She-Ra with a painful scream. Her eyes flew open, glowing a brilliant blue, her magic surged and engulfed her pupils. Turning her eyes into two glowing white orbs of pure power. The Horde cot was not built to handle the solid weight of a sudden eight foot warrior woman and promptly broke. The weak legs snapped and it went crashing to the floor in a heap.

She-Ra's light faded as swiftly as it had appeared leaving a very confused and dazed Adora behind.

“What...just happened?” She moaned, clutching her head that was starting to pound. She couldn't remember her dream at all. But it had been intense, leaving her emotionally spent, with a strange, yet pleasant feeling swirling in her gut.

“You transformed into She-Ra in your sleep and broke the bed.” Catra answered, her eyes full of concern and wide with awe.

Standing a few feet from the bed, curling and uncurling her fingers nervously.

“That's not a good thing...” Adora moaned, rolling over to sit up and get her feet on the ground. Reaching for Catra as she suddenly felt very disoriented and dizzy. Her body felt hot like it was on fire and her skin was humming with residual magical energy. She had never lost control of She-Ra before? It filled her with dread.

“I wouldn’t think so.” Catra responded with a rueful smirk, as she took her hands and helped her up.

“Sorry about the bed.” Adora apologized, glancing down at the wreck with remorse.

“I was about done with that bed anyway. Good riddance.” Catra smiled softly, keeping a hold of her hands as she pressed her forehead against Adora's. “You need to relax, you got so worked up in your sleep you summoned She-Ra!”

“Well, we are headed to Mystacor. I will have plenty of time to rest, relaxing is not my strong suit." Adora chuckled, dryly, as she pulled away.

"We are going to work on that, princess." Catra drew her back in and gave her a slow, tender kiss. Before turning towards the metal storage cabinet set beside the bed.

"I can show you the cloud beach and the steam grotto. You would not believe the feast Castaspella gave us the last time I went with Glimmer and Bow.” Adora welcomed the happier topic. As Catra quickly changed into a white, horde issue sleeveless tank top she would have worn for working out and training. Then slipped on an old, worn leather jacket.

“Nice jacket.” Adora commented smiling with approval at the serpent design on the back. She had noticed it before years ago, when Catra had captured her on Mara's ship. But was a little

preoccupied with trying to convince her not to open a portal then comment on her keen fashion sense.

“Yeah, I got it off a guy in the Crimson Waste a few years back.” Catra pulled on her fingerless leather gloves, casting Adora a proud grin over her shoulder. Her smile faltered as the memory soured. Clearing her throat nervously, she ran her hands through her short hair. Her eyes darkened with bad memories as she briskly, headed for the door. She had left Tongue Lashor in a sand pit for dead. She didn’t know if his gang had pulled him free or let the Waste claim him? At the time she didn’t care much about anything or anyone, out to prove herself as some bad ass that no one in the Waste would ever dare to mess with. Reaching out to save the lizard kin she had just defeated would have been seen as weakness. So now because of her callous, disregard for his life. She was left to wonder about his fate, filled with remorse and regret. Her spiral downward only intensified after that. She ended up kidnapping Adora and within a few days, betrayed Entrapta and selfishly put the whole of their reality at risk. Her arrogance and recklessness claiming another life...Queen Angella. Melog followed her out, their head hung low, mane flowing close to their neck. A somber manifestation of the grim melancholy now affecting Catra.

“I remember...” Adora nodded, her voice pensive as she watched Catra leave. They had still been on opposite sides of the war. Catra had captured her and taken her to Hordak. It was only a few hours later Catra would pull the lever and nearly destroy everything. Licking her lips nervously, she pulled her loose hair up into its ponytail. It was the first thing she did every morning. A simple hairstyle, she had for years. At first it was just functional, so her long bangs didn't impede her sight. She always tried to be prepared for anything before leaving the barracks. Not knowing what kind of training they would be engaged in. Now as she got older, it was a way to maintain control. To put her thoughts and herself in order before starting the day. She threw on her cloak and headed out of the door. Catra was not waiting for her outside, but Melog was.

Adora knelt down and caressed the cat tenderly down their neck. Melog mewled and gave her an apologetic head butt. Showing her Catra's true emotions when she was unable to.

“I know, I regret a lot of what happened between us.” Adora sighed, understanding that they were an extension of Catra herself. Thankful that Melog could reach out to her, when Catra was to upset, or to lost in her own head. Then walked slowly after Melog. As they led her down the shadowed halls of the abandoned fortress towards their old cadet barracks.

She found Catra sitting on the shredded remains of her bunk, tracing the damaged outlines of the drawings they had made as children. Her face was downcast in shame, eyes moist with unshed tears. Adora sat down heavily beside her, glancing sadly at the scratches. Catra had no doubt made across the drawing of her face. It was too painful, Adora could feel the rage and hurt in this space. It made her shiver and avert her eyes to her boots in regret.

“I'm sorry.” They both stated in unison, then giggled.

“Did you hate me?” Adora asked quietly.

“I thought I did at first. I felt betrayed, rejected and abandoned. I was really mad and hurt that you left me. That I wasn't enough to make you stay. But honestly, no. Even after all the fighting we did, I never hated you. ” Catra responded, “That's just not in me.” she passed Adora a weak smile, silently finishing the sentence in her mind. (Hating myself...well that was always easy.)

Melog folded their ears back, narrowing their eyes in disgust, as they shook themselves violently. Wanting to purge the self loathing now flooding through them, as they settled on the cold floor near the bunk.

“I was frustrated with you for a long time. I couldn't understand why you stayed. You knew the Horde was bad.. that Shadow

Weaver and Hordak would punish you for failure, torture you...hurt you….use you to achieve their own ambitions. I couldn't grasp why, I was not enough for you to leave.” Adora took a deep breath before confessing. “It really hurt, every time we fought. I cried after, every time...and screamed and punched a lot of things.” Her gaze had fallen to her lap, where she played nervously with her finger's. The once warm blue of her eyes had deepened into a dull grey as she brooded, moist with unshed tears.

Catra moaned with regret, unable to handle her own anguish reflected back in Adora's eyes. Knowing that they had hurt each other in the same ways over and over again. She swiftly reached out and pulled Adora into her arms. Resting her chin atop of Adora's head as tears threatened. Adora curled up against her, silent tears falling, as she held onto Catra's waist.

“I cried too,” Catra admitted bitterly. “I also screamed and destroyed a lot of stuff.” She smirked and nodded towards the clawed drawings, patting the shredded mattress with her hand.

Adora laughed softly and nodded. “Yep, that's us. Working out our feelings... through violence...”

Catra shrugged. “Whatever works, I guess.”

Catra took a deep breath, cupping Adora's chin and guiding her face upward. She leaned down and pressed her lips tenderly upon hers.

“This works too, right?” She offered, with a coy smile against Adora's lips.

“This works the best.” Adora answered, shifting her body to press Catra down upon the mattress. Deepening the kiss as they went down, cupping her chin to keep her steady as she did not want to hurt her tongue on Catra's fangs again. That had been awkward and humiliating.

Catra's breath came in short bursts as the kiss turned more passionate, her fingers curled into the fabric of Adora’s shirt, just below the collar, to keep her close. Adora's leaned on her elbow, braced on the mattress to keep herself steady. Her fingertips holding Catra's chin, not allowing her to move freely as she controlled the kiss. Her lips opened and glided, pressing aggressively against Catra's mouth. Her tongue thrusting and sweeping deep inside. Catra attempted to keep up to Adora's desire, kissing her back just as fiercely. As a yearning heat built between them. Catra made a small pleading noise as Adora released her chin. The blondes free hand wandering, finger tips caressing down Catra's side. Gliding down her thigh and pulled up her leg. Hooking Catra's ankle just above her lower back. Adora pressed herself more intimately against Catra's core, a soft, needy sound humming from her lips. The added friction of their lower bodies makes Catra moan with pleasure. As their kiss intensified, growing more hungry, more demanding. Catra's hands slipped from Adora's shoulders, clutching desperately at her back, pressing Adora’s weight firmly against her own body. Rocking her pelvis, as Adora’s hand crept up her thigh towards her butt.

“Seriously!” Lonnie's voice broke the spell, like a bucket of ice cold water.

Adora screamed and pushed up off of Catra in an instant. Slamming the back of her head against the underside of the top bunk with a resounding clang. She groaned and scrambled out of the bunk, rubbing the back of her head where it throbbed.

Catra huffed, leaning back on her elbows and craned her head backward, seeking to hide the burning flush of her face. Behind the curved metal sheeting that held up the top bunk. Her whole body was tingling and her lower half was throbbing with unsated arousal.

“Perfect timing, Lonnie. Like always.” Catra growled.

Lonnie folded her arms over her chest, smiling smugly at them.

“I knew something was up, between you two.”

Adora's jaw dropped in disbelief. “How...” She breathed.

“You guys were always whispering and giggling after lights out?” Lonnie shrugged. “Catra slept in your bunk, like...almost every night.”

“I thought you were asleep when I crawled into bed with Adora. ” Catra huffed, shuffling out of the bunk.

“I'm not blind or deaf! I slept in the bunk right next to Adora's. For like ten years! You were not that stealthy or quiet. .” Lonnie laughed.

“Why didn't you say something?” Adora cried in humiliation.

“Why?” Lonnie raised an eyebrow in confusion.

“Because you could have improved your standing with the Staff Sergeant.?” Catra stated, “Fraternization of any kind was prohibited. You could have gotten a reward? Better rations?”

“I would have never ratted you guys out. We were a squad?” Lonnie reminded her, “You guys were the closest thing to a family I had ever known.”

That hit both of them hard. Adora sucked in a sudden breath, biting down on her lower lip to stop it from trembling. Guilty tears welled up in her eyes as she stared down at Lonnie, who stood an arms length away.

Lonnie's demeanor was cold, aloof as she glanced between them. Her hazel eyes were dark, shadowed by uncertainty, as to how they would respond.

“Aw...Man.” Catra moaned. “ Thanks, Lonnie. Now I feel even worse about how I treated you.” She snarled as she stood up.

“You should.” Lonnie smirked. “You were both real dumb faces!”

Catra's eyes turned hopeful as she gazed at Lonnie. “Does that mean you forgive me?”

“No.” Lonnie spat back, “But it means. I'm giving both of you a second chance. So don't screw it up.”

She finished pointedly, turning on her heel and striding out of their old sleeping quarters.

“Scorpia wants you guys over at the Supply yard. Entrapta's back with a whole convoy of container's.” Lonnie called from down the hall.

Catra shot Adora a surprised, eager look before bolting out of sight down the hall.

“Catra...wait up!” Adora called, jogging after her with Melog.

The ex-horde had cleared out a large cargo hanger on the far north side of the fortress, where the main armory was located. This was where the Horde had stored their vast arsenal of tanks, charge cannons and bots. It was now filled with rows upon rows of container's of all shapes and sizes. They were blackened, dented and the glass on top was fogged over from the intense heat. So the animals and people inside were hard to make out. The fluorescent, overhead lighting, hanging from the thick iron girders high above. Flickered and buzzed giving the cavernous hanger bay a morgue-like atmosphere.

A steady stream of Ex-Horde Soldier's were filing into the hangar, pushing flatbeds of supplies. Bringing in large pieces of medical equipment and army cots. While a group of young soldier's barely out of the cadet barracks were milling around the open doors, looking lost and uncertain as to what they needed to be doing or where they were supposed to go. Dressed in white training shirts and black pants, shock batons strapped to their hips. They each had a cart stacked full of boxed medical supplies. Lonnie was

quick to take charge leaving Catra and Adora standing at the massive open doors.

Shame filled Catra as she took in the sight of the young soldier's. They looked haggard and worn. A young man had an ugly scar going down the right side of his face, from temple to chin. Their eyes were haunted, expressions cool, tempered by war. They had been far too young and had seen way too much. It had all been her fault. She had pushed the full might of the Horde against the rebellion at the end, so even the senior cadets who had yet to graduate to active duty, had been sent into the field.

Not caring about the soldier's or the innocent people she hurt. Focused only on winning, intoxicated by the power she wielded as Hordak's second in command. Now she regretted her hubris, the consequences of her callous actions came at a great price. One she would spend the rest of her life repaying.

“Force Captain...we don't know where to go?” The young man with the ugly scar asked, naturally taking charge of the small group.

Lonnie took a quick look around, catching sight of Kyle directing troops nearby.

“Kyle!” She shouted, waving the young blonde man over.

Kyle nodded and jogged over.

“These guys are lost, can you take them to where we are setting up the triage?” Lonnie asked.

“Triage...” Kyle asked, his voice distant and confused. Turning to look around the massive hangar in a panic.

“Really, Kyle?' Lonnie moaned, shaking her head.

“I got this...” Kyle gave her a weak smile and waved the young cadets to follow him. “Don't worry, I got this!” He turned around with fake confidence and gave Lonnie two thumbs up. Jogging

backwards, he promptly ran into a container. It hummed and rocked as he hit it, Kyle shouted and spun around bracing the container with both hands so it didn't float away.

Lonnie groaned in dismay as she watched Kyle lead the group down one row then another, looking around anxiously, as if the answers he sought were hovering just out of sight.

“Dammit, Kyle.” Lonnie groused, tossing Catra and Adora a curt wave before rushing off into the hanger.

“Oh, good you're here.” Scorpia jogged over to them, as they entered through the massive bay doors. Her boots striking the cement in a staccato of crisp beats.

“How are they?” Catra moved briskly to meet her, her face drawn with worry.

“I have no idea.” Scorpia shrugged, “Entrapta's this way.” She waved a pincher for them to follow.

Catra remained rooted to the spot, her eagerness from before forgotten. Now that she was confronted by how dire things could have been. Her eyes were darting around the field of container's, her face stricken with rising dread. Adora reached out and grasped Catra's hand, sensing her trepidation and need for support. She offered Catra a reassuring smile, when she nodded in acknowledgement, Adora led her further into the hanger.

They found Entrapta sitting on a cushion of her own hair, a data pad in her lap. She had it plugged into a small control panel. That jutted out of a small box on the side of a container. Tapping lightly on the screen of her pad, surveying the various diagnostics scrolling past.

“Hi.” She waved distractedly. “This is all very interesting...”

“Really?” Catra moved swiftly to stand behind Entrapta to look at the screen. As if she had the technical skills and knowledge to understand any of it.

Adora turned to the container, unsure what to do with her hands, she folded them behind her back.

“It looks like whoever's inside...is sleeping. The environment suited perfectly to keeping the specimen inside the pod in stasis until the container is opened. The material of the pods is very sturdy and air tight, it could survive the crushing void of space if it had too.” Entrapta was in awe of the tech.

“I just wish I could open it.” Entrapta growled in frustration. “I've tried hacking into it's code... but it has a security system...”

“I just ripped off the glass?” Catra stated carelessly.

Entrapta gasped and turned to confront Catra with a look of pure horror.

“No wonder you blew up the place!” She shouted.

Catra was suddenly very frightened, her ears folded back. As she took a couple steps backward, her tail wrapping around her hips in a timid manner.

Entrapta typed furiously on a keyboard in the corner of the screen with slender tendrils of her hair. Bringing up an animation of what happened in the obelisk.

“When you tore off the glass, you compromised the artificial atmosphere inside the container. It imploded, since the container was right in front of the portal. It created a devastating chain reaction. The implosion caused the portal's vortex of energies to overload. Since the portal lost all internal integrity to the massive energies stored inside. Those energies exploded outward on both sides of the portal! You could have vaporized the whole planet! Thankfully the incredibly massive and sturdy structure of the ruin kept the explosion localized inside...” Entrapta's mind was racing through the variables, growing more and more panicked.

“You might have vaporized Eternia or at least a city!” Entrapa mused quietly in horror, tapping a tendril of hair against her chin.

Then, she sprung on Catra absolutely furious. “YOU ARE NOT ALLOWED NEAR ANYMORE PORTALS!”

Catra cringed and backed up a step or twenty. Entrapta’s very sudden, very loud and very terrified outburst. Violently hurting Catra’s ears and sending her heart racing with fear. Catra’s face had gone pale and she was trembling, twisting her hands against her stomach. Averting her gaze to the floor, looking very much like a shamed, chastised child. Melog came to her defense first. Growling and crouching low in front of Catra. Warning Entrapta to stay away by baring their fangs.

“Ok, Calm down.” Scorpia interceded quickly, placing her pinchers on Entrapta's shoulders. Their resident Geek Princess was quaking silently in fear as she glared furiously at Catra.

Adora had charged in front of Catra ready to defend her if necessary. Entrapta's theories were really scaring her but she kept her expression calm. Now was not the time to lose her cool.

“Entrapta...you need to stay focused. We have to get these people out and back to their families.” Adora offered, raising her hands up in a warding fashion.

“I'm sorry...I never realized...I...” Catra tried to apologize, the weight of her guilt now magnified. She never meant to cause such incredible amounts of destruction. She might have wiped out an entire world! Catra was suddenly having a hard time breathing, it was like her lungs refused to take in air. Her chest was so tight and heavy.

“Portals are dangerous...” Entrapta muttered, her eyes were terrified and filled with tears.

“I thought you learned your lesson...the last time.” She finished her voice thick with disappointment.

Catra struggled to take in several deep breaths, blinking away tears of her own. Entrapta had forgiven her so easily back on the ship. But she could see the trauma she had caused her by pulling

that switch, attacking her and sending her to beast island....to die. She had hid it well over the last few months. But this portal situation, it triggered all that pent up anxiety and anger she held inside. No longer able to contain the intensity of her emotions, she had exploded on the person to blame.

Now that all those emotions were out, Entrapta felt lighter. But she couldn't deal with talking to Catra any longer so she nodded, slapping her helmet down. Needing to narrow her focus and calm down. Strong emotions made her uncomfortable she didn't like expressing them, let alone feeling them. Then returned her attention to the container all business yet again. Hiding where she felt comfortable, where she felt safe. Wanting only to immerse herself in the alien tech and figure out how it worked.

“Ok, let’s crack this baby open...safely.” Entrapta stated, tossing the pad down on the concrete and pulling a blow torch out of her hair.

Scorpia backed up several paces to stand next to Catra and Adora.

“She's is brilliant....scary....but brilliant.” Adora muttered, Scorpia nodded. The angles of their faces glowing from the blinding flare of Entrapta's blow torch.

Catra took another shaky breath and crouched beside Melog, burying her face in their fur. Her heart was pounding so hard her chest ached, her face flushed from the sudden stress was now cooling. Making her shiver and her fur at the back of her neck stand on end. She needed to calm down and collect herself. Whatever happened to Eternia she couldn't do anything about it right now, that was for future Catra to deal with. She felt Adora's hand squeeze her shoulder offering her support and trying to soothe her. Melog began a low, calming purr. Listening intently as Catra's breathing began to even out and she slowly began to relax.

They watched for over an hour while Entrapta obsessed over the container, trying every tool she had stuffed in her hair to open the control panel.

“Let me in....let me in...” Entrapta pleaded while she worked.

“Eternia was a password in Mara's ship and in the Crystal Castle.” Adora mused. “I never thought it was a planet.”

“Melog told me when we were in the Ruin, that these Eternian's are First Ones.” Catra offered, petting Melog in short, calming strokes down their back.

“I wonder if that was where Light Hope had kidnapped me from.” Adora turned to Catra, her eyes bright with curious wonder.

“I don't know...” Catra breathed, a cold lump of anxiety growing in her stomach. She cut her eyes to Adora. Finding her tapping her chin with a fingertip, mulling over the idea of Eternia and what it could mean.

“Perhaps these Eternian's will know about me....or my family...or where I might have come from?” She muttered.

“Adora....” Catra sighed, not wanting to dampen her hopes at finding her own family. But needing to temper her enthusiasm in case things were not going to work out in her favor. She turned and grasped Adora's hands, holding them up against her chest. Drawing the blonde away from her growing fantasies about these Eternian's.

“They are not good people, they were harvesting our planet, stealing our people for who knows why.” Catra sighed, desperate for Adora to understand. “Melog told me they are dangerous....First Ones are conquerors....like Horde Prime.”

“I'm a First One...” Adora's smile faded, her voice sullen. Not wanting to show Catra how the truth in her words hurt. She gently shook off Catra's hands and slowly walked back up to the container. Genuinely intrigued by what Entrapta was doing.

Catra watched her go, resigned that she may need a little space.

“Can I help?” Adora offered, placing her hand on top of the little control panel. As she leaned down to talk to Entrapta who was now laying on the ground underneath, striking the metal box with a hammer.

A hum ignited deep inside the mechanisms of the container. The clear top of the panel glowed to life and a light rolled down Adora's palm. The glass on top gave a hiss, releasing the air and then the glass vanished. Adora yelped and pulled her hand away, staring in shock at her palm print, still glowing on the panel's surface.

“What did you do?” Entrapta popped up from the ground, scrutinizing the panel and then Adora and then the panel.

“I should have known, DNA scanner.” She laughed maniacally, striking her forehead with the palm of her hand.

“Your a First One...these Eternian's must be First Ones!” she nodded, snatching up her pad from the floor and reviewing the data, in the now unlocked container.

“Great, now you just have to open all the rest.” Entrapta smiled broadly up at Adora, inclining the huge hanger full of containers with a heavy mass of hair.

Adora took a long breath, “That's going to take a while.” She surveyed hundreds of container's with wide eyes. The daunting task that lay before her was more than a little intimidating.

“You are like a living, breathing, off switch, now?” Catra smiled and shook her head ruefully.

Adora smiled wanly, brushing her hand down her pant legs suddenly feeling very bashful. As much as it pleased her to be able to help. She was getting tired of being the chosen one. Everything always seemed to fall on her shoulders. The constant pressure of success, of always having to make the right choices

and at the right times...or the universe is doomed....was really starting to wear her out.

“There's a little container just like this one, up in Horror Hall.” Scorpia nodded. “It's really old and rusted out, but I swear it's just like these.”

“Why didn't you tell us earlier?” Catra scolded, hands on her hips.

“I forgot...” Scorpia smiled faintly.

“You never change.” Catra groused good naturedly. “Com'on, let's deactivate that one first. We don't need someone vaporizing Horror Hall by fooling around with it.”

“Good, idea...yeah. That really would be bad.” Scorpia shuddered, clicking her pinchers together nervously.

Catra grabbed Adora's hand and pulled her away..

“We'll be back.” She called, as all three dashed off. Leaving Entrapta, to deal with a very confused, very groggy Erelandian now climbing out of the container. His mushroom cap had shriveled up on his head, but as soon as it was back in Etherian air. It sprang back into its usual form with a sharp pop.

It was late evening when they mounted the hill of wild flowers that led towards Horror Hall. The low hum of engines and indecipherable echo of hundreds of troops faded away as they moved away from the Fortress. A dry wind howled down from the dreary stone ruin high above. The clouds overhead were thin, illuminated by the last of the sun's rays. Adora had been lost in her thoughts, trailing behind. While Catra charged ahead, eager to be away from Entrapta. Focused on doing something good.

When Horror Hall was in sight, Catra huffed and cast Adora a frustrated glance. She was far behind them, her face downcast trudging up the hill slowly. Catra was eager to get under shelter

before full dark. Things in Etheria were just getting too crazy. To think they wouldn't be attacked by rabid, beast island creatures so out in the open. So she dashed back down the hill, clasping Adora's hand in hers and pulled her along at a faster pace. Adora yelped in surprise, but Catra tossed her an encouraging smile.

“Somethings bothering you?” Catra asked softly, turning her attention forward. Finding Scorpia's shadowy silhouette standing at the top of the hill waiting for them.

“When this is all over. I want to disappear for a little while...just the two of us.” Adora stated quietly, she was still struggling with verbalizing her desires without feeling guilty about them.

“You got it!” Catra gave her hand a squeeze, grinning. Feeling how much she mattered, how much Adora needed her, loved her above all others in that request.

The walls of Horror Hall's labyrinth corridor's were crumbling from age and countless wars. The massive cracks were sometimes large enough to slip back outside. Filtering the dying light of evening into the interior. The flagstone floors were uneven, parts cracked and crumbled to dust. As they moved further into the ruin, the detritus and mounds of stone had become obstacles they had to navigate around, or even take alternate routes. Eventually weaving back through other passages to return to the main corridor they wanted to travel on. By the time Scorpia led them into the deepest chambers of Horror Hall night had fallen. The corridors had turned to roughed out tunnels, the rooms now caves and natural alcoves. The rock walls were more narrow, the torches few and far between. Leaving them in darkness for long periods of time. The air smelled like moist earth and mold. Catra wrinkled up her nose and Melog sneezed.

“Yeah...Sorry, about the smell. I know...it kinda smells like old, dirty, wet socks this far down.” Scorpia apologized.

As the darkness swallowed them again, Catra took a moment to adjust to the gloom before heading deeper down the passage. Adora had been quiet ever since they left the hanger, holding Catra's hand and following obediently.

“Seriously, Adora. What are you thinking about?” Catra asked, softly.

“Nothing much,” Adora responded absently.

“Well, that's normal, dummy.” Catra jokes. “But really, something is really bothering you.”

Adora sighed, “I was just thinking about,.. my Destiny.” She conceded reluctantly, grimacing in disgust. Saying it like that made her sound so pompous, like she was somehow better than everyone else.

Her statement drew Catra back to her own Destiny...her own elemental magical powers. Catra suddenly stopped in the pitch blackness, Adora stumbled right into her backside.

“Catra?” She questioned, nervously as Catra released her hand.

Catra turned, her eyes glowing with magic, then with a flare of wind and heat. A small fire bloomed in her palms. Illuminating the bare stone walls in flickering light. Within seconds the fire had crept up her arms and ignited her whole body.

“I'm an idiot...” Catra muttered, “We've been wandering around in the dark for like an hour.”

“YOUR ON FIRE!” Scorpia exclaimed in terror, thundering up before Catra.

“It's ok, Scorpia. She does that now.” Adora leaned into view, around Catra’s flaming shoulder with a proud grin.

“She sets herself on fire?” Scorpia responded, her voice high pitched in barely contained panic.

Catra turned to face Scorpia, pointing with veiled irritation at her elegant tiara that now adorned her forehead.

“Oh...your a princess now!” Scorpia chuckled. “Well, that's great. Welcome to the team!”

Catra groaned and closed her eyes in defeat. Scorpia could be so ingratiatingly chipper and upbeat about things.

With the stronger light, emanating from Catra a narrow opening appeared on their right.

“There it is..ha,ha,ha.” Scorpia laughed with embarrassment. “Nearly went past it.”

Catra took a deep breath, calming her growing irritation with Scoripia. “Ok, let's get this over with.” She sighed, striding into the cavern.

Adora trudged in after her, casting the crumbling chamber nervous looks. She recognized this place, a vague recollection began to surface in her mind. It rose up inside her memory like a forgotten dream, she had been in here long, long ago.

Catra's flickering light shone upon torn, rotting banner's that were littering on the floor. A faded goat skull sigil with curved horns adorned the banner's. Barely recognizable in their current state of decay. Broken, ancient weapons were scattered over the floor. The blades held the etchings of the First Ones, very similar to the Sword of Protection. What looked like small hand held cannons had rusted away into the floor. Several skeletons, nearly turned to dust with age, lay just in front of the entrance. While two dry, brittle skeletons, one wearing a dark cloth vest and hide pants, the other in a long hide and cloth dress were curled up nearby. The smaller skeleton had a thin hide head band adorning its skull, with the same orange crystal beads knotted along its length. They had died holding hands...

Catra sucked in a startled breath at the sight of the bones, her whole body shivering with trepidation. She recognized those

clothes and beaded, hide head band from her dreams. Her heart clenched at the sight of the hands, finger's woven together in death. It took her a moment, but she tore her eyes away from them. Her breath came in short bursts as far too many emotions began to overwhelm her. Anger, fear, loathing, unbearable grief...

Her fire was smoldering, her sorrow dowsing the intensity of her flames. She needed answers...so she forced herself to move deeper into the darkened chamber to investigate. Then her meager light caught the gleaming edge of something metallic. In the far corner of the room lay a tiny golden container. It was covered in a heavy layer of dust, slightly rusted around the curved edges. But she could still see that the front and sides were etched in First One's glyphs. The container was very old, the design more bulky than the ones back in the hanger. The glass top was more of a bubble than a sleek curve. The bubble-like lid was open, hanging off the side of the container stained with dusty green mold, from years of moisture.

Suddenly Catra's heart was pounding in her ears with every step she took towards the ancient stasis pod. She was trembling by the time she reached it, with her ears flat and tail swishing sharply in fear. Melog's body had turned black, their mane a flickering blood red, they growled and slunk after Catra, their belly brushing against the floor. Mirroring the storm of emotions, currently raging inside Catra. Catra took a deep breath and glanced inside, tears welling in her eyes as she saw the woolen and hide blanket that the baby had been wrapped up in, in her dream. The intricate symbol embroidered with orange crystal beads, on the blue dyed hide, shimmered in her meager firelight.

“No...” Catra whispered in horror, as her vision swam with tears. The grim realization of her fate, was brutal and it struck her like a devastating blow. Adora approached her quietly. Putting a comforting hand on her shoulder.

“Catra?” Adora questioned, glancing nervously down at the container. Wondering why she recognized it, her frown deepened as she searched her memory. It had been so long ago...

“I found you...here.” Adora finally muttered, her gaze snapping up to Catra in shock. “This was the box you were in, here in the Fright Zone.”

Catra hissed, snatching up the blanket with one hand and darting out of Adora's grasp. Scorpia had been watching cautiously from the entrance. She had witnessed Catra at her most broken and was quick to see the signs of a coming storm. She had looked like this once before, back in the Crimson Waste, when she found out Shadow Weaver had abandoned her for Adora. When it was thrown in her face yet again, how little she mattered to that cruel woman.

Catra's eyes were glazed, lost to her pain. Tears were threatening as she stalked over to the two skeletons. Scorpia, swallowed hard. Her Wild Cat was coiled tight, as she crouched before the ancient bones. Her muscles flexing, jaw clenched, eyes burning with overwhelming grief, with hate and a burning fury.

She reached out with a trembling hand to touch the forehead of the smaller skeleton. “Mother...” She breathed, her voice breaking with the weight of her sorrow. Her claw was shaking so badly and the bone was so brittle that she unintentionally scratched a groove into it.

“Adora...leave her for a moment.” Scorpia advised, as she caught sight of Adora moving briskly to Catra's side. Melog had slunk behind Catra back to the bones, their head swiveling for threats, eyes burning bright with rage. Their body had turned a deep blood red, almost black. Their mane snapping like an inferno around their now sharply angled face.

Adora nodded mutely, her eyes wide with fear, suddenly very unsure what was happening. She had never seen Melog look so threatening. Watching in sorrow as Catra glared down at the bones, tears falling down her cheeks. Dripping off her chin, as she clutched the blanket to her chest. She arched her back and raised her face towards the ceiling releasing a tortured sound from low in her throat. One Adora had never heard before. It ripped from

her throat like a keening wail, followed by a long mournful howl. It was so full of rage and grief it shook the very chamber itself. The fire that once flickered low around her body, now roared into an inferno. The heat was so intense the banners near her burned away into ash. But the clothes upon the two skeletons before her remained unscathed, they were not the targets of her flames.

“Catra...” Adora took another hesitant step forward, wanting to console her, to pull her into her arms. Needing to try and heal the pain shattering her apart.

But Scorpia intervened. Charging for Catra, tears streaming down her face. She understood what needed to be done, how to draw Catra back from the precipice of unyielding grief she was now standing on. Catra hissed, dropping the blanket to the ground. Her ears pressed back tight against her head, her tail bristled in fury as she turned to meet Scorpia's charge. Melog took up the mournful howl from their position just behind Catra. Their cat-like body morphing into a giant roaring vortex of pure blue flame, that surged and surrounded the two sudden combatants.

“Melog...” Adora gasped, stopping abruptly in mid dash. It was the most dangerous and frightening thing Adora had ever seen. She stepped back against the now damp, stone wall. As the heat was starting to melt the rock! Shielding her eyes with her arms, as the light was blinding, the heat so intense it felt like her skin was burning.

“Scorpia!” Adora screamed in fright. She couldn't see anything through the haze of fire light, and could only hear the sharp sounds of battle. Catra's snarls and the clipped ring of her claws striking Scorpia's exoskeleton. Scorpia's low grunts as she took the blows.

As quickly as the light filled the room it faded away, leaving Melog curled up on the floor completely exhausted. Scorpia sat on the floor, her clothes were shredded, chunks of exoskeleton were missing from her shoulders and pinchers. Her face was marred by dust but not a scratch. She had fended off Catra's brutal attacks

and protected the most vulnerable parts of herself at the same time. She truly was a formidable warrior.

Catra lay curled up in a tight ball in her lap, a low purr that sounded more like a growl issuing from her throat. Staring at the skeletons with a lost and forlorn expression. Her eyes were shimmering with unshed tears and shadowed with exhaustion. Her tail was curled tight around her body, in a protective fashion. Ears twitching, the claws of her hands flexing with the last remnant of her fury, digging into the thigh of Scorpia's black pants and then releasing the heavy fabric in a steady, kneading motion.

Scorpia was breathing hard, but she leaned down, placing a tender pincher on Catra's head.

“It's ok, Wild Cat, I got you.” She whispered brokenly, her cheeks flushed as much from their fight, as her own hidden feelings. “I love you....I always will.”

Catra purred and growled, her eyes fluttering closed to exhausted to stay awake.

Scorpia looked up from comforting Catra. Finding a gentle glow emanating from the far corner of the room. She-Ra stood tall, her sword aloft and a very confused expression on her face.

“She'll be ok, Adora.” Scorpia beaconed her over to sit with her.

“Why did you stop me?” Adora demanded, as the light from She-Ra faded. She stomped over to Scorpia and promptly sat down. Folding her arms over her chest, she glared up at the Scorpion silently commanding her for answers.

“That was the Death Cry.” Scorpia sighed, scratching the back of her head awkwardly.

Adora cocked her head, needing more of an answer than that.

“I've seen it before...with my grandfather...when Hordak was taking me away...After he killed my parents and my grandmother. My grandfather lost his mind and attacked Hordak and his soldier's. I don't know if he is still alive or if any of my people are still alive...haven't seen another scorpion since I was very small. Anyway...” Scorpia was rambling, she knew it. But she was nervous and explaining this was hard.

Adora looked at her with compassion and a degree of understanding. They were both orphans, raised by the Horde. “I'm sorry...” She offered, folding her hands in her lap and bowing her head with sorrow.

“Naw, it's ok. It's in the past.” Scorpia waved off her concern with a weak smile.

“Scorpia...” Adora wanted to console her. But when Scorpia took a deep breath and pushed forward with her explanations. She held her tongue and listened instead.

“When an animal hybrid...like me...like Catra...is overcome with grief and rage all rational thinking just goes, bye, bye.” Scorpia gave Adora a weak wave with a pincher. “They fly into a fury, so intense, so all consuming that they need to release it. There was no way to stop the violence that was to come.” Scorpia began.

“You could have knocked her out with your venom?” Adora offered pedantically.

Scorpia heaved a great sigh of patience and offered Adora a thin smile. “I would never do that...cheat Catra out of mourning her parents, she had to release that grief or it would have consumed her.” Scorpia sounded appalled by the very notion of Adora's idea.

“How did you know?” Adora breathed.

“I heard her, call the smaller skeleton...Mother.” Scorpia answered, softly.

Adora sucked in a cold breath of surprise. As she quickly glanced over at the two skeletons, her expression grim and full of anguish.

“Oh...Catra…” She moaned, reaching out and petting a hand down her thick, dark hair. Giving the back of her ears a soothing rub. Catra merely snarled threateningly, flicking her ears at Adora’s attempt to soothe her.

“I guess...I don't understand.” Adora mumbled, feeling rather foolish as she drew her hand back into her lap.

“I knew I could take it and I needed you to stay safe.” Scorpia's voice was pensive and somber.

“You are way more important than me.” She finished, speaking under her breath so Adora would not hear. Knowing Adora would not approve of that statement even if it was true.

“I would have been fine...She-Ra?” Adora stated in frustration.

“She would have ripped out your throat before you could have summoned her.” Scorpia's voice was cool and completely serious. “Wild Cat has never gone all out, fighting you. She has never tried to really kill you.” She sighed and scratched the back of her neck nervously.

It gave Adora pause, she had thought Catra had gone all out fighting her several times during the war? At least while she was transformed into She-Ra...she had only fought her as Adora once. But she had been forced to by Prime. She stared down at Catra, now sleeping soundly on Scorpia's lap with trepidation.

“How lethal do you think she truly is?” Adora asked, her voice quiet. As she came to terms with how little she might know about Catra's species.

Scorpia raised an eyebrow. “Shadow Weaver never talked to you about people like us?”

“What do you mean?” Adora asked.

“Etheria is full of all kinds of creatures. Lizards, frogs, wolves...but then there are the animal hybrids like me and Catra. We are far stronger and faster than any human, which makes us good soldiers. There are two types. Predators like me and Catra and Prey, like the Thaymorian's or some of the Selinean's. I mean Octavia is a predator type...but... I mean they covered all of this in Force Captain Orientation.” Scorpia shrugged with a joking smile.

“I was never a Force Captain.” Adora advised, with a dissatisfied frown.

“Yes, you were. It was on file, Shadow Weaver gave you the badge and everything.” Scorpia reminded her with a soft chuckle.

“Yeah, I had the badge for like an hour before defecting to the rebellion.” Adora shouted, then took a deep calming breath. “Can we please get back on topic.”

“Oh, yes, yes, of course.” Scorpia laughed, nervously.

“Well, anyway. The prey type has more instincts to flee when under extreme duress. While us, predator types...well, we can get rather violent.” Scorpia's eyes went wide in fear.

“Very, very, very violent...” She finished in a hushed voice.

“So it's better if we deal with our own kind when things like this happen.” Scorpia finished with a cheerful smile.

Adora glared at her, crossing her arms. “I could have handled her.” She stated stubbornly.

“And if you couldn't, if she got a real good strike in and hurt you real bad.?” Scorpia responded soberly.

“I could have just healed myself before she woke up. She-Ra, remember.” Adora shrugged, she could play this what if game all

night.

“She would still remember hurting you...remember that she was not, play fighting like all the times before. That this time, she had been so blinded by her rage and pain that she had tried to kill you instead.” Scorpia stated, her eyes were stern, unyielding. “You can't heal those sorta wounds, Adora. She would have never forgiven herself and she has endured enough emotional damage.”

Adora clamped her mouth shut, she couldn't argue with that. Now her heart was burning with shame for how proud and entitled she had acted. As if she was the only person qualified to save Catra, to help heal her wounded soul.

They sat in silence for a very long time, listening to the soft breaths of Catra and Melog while they slept. Lost to their own grim thoughts, Adora found herself wallowing in all the crazy that had happened so far. Wondering as she glanced up at Scorpia. Who was petting a large pincher down Catra's short hair, staring down at her so fondly. What she was thinking about.

“You love her.” Adora stated with a heavy sigh, giving Scorpia an empathic look.

“What...naw....no...I mean...” Scorpia blushed and blundered for words. “maybe” she finally blurted out. “At one time...but...that’s all in the past.”

“It's ok...” Adora consoled. “ She can be quite the charmer when she wants to be.” She smirked at Scorpia.

Scorpia laughed and nodded. Remembering her sweet, honest smile and how she had held her pincher after the party in the Crimson Waste. How in that moment of pure happiness that she had shared with her, Wild Cat. She thought that her feelings might be more than friendship...that they had turned into love. Perhaps if they had stayed in the Waste, then they might have had a

chance to become something more, to find happiness with one another.

“You don't have to worry, I would never intrude or try to win her over.” Scorpia proclaimed, trying to sound confident that she was even capable of such a feat. But in truth she understood that she never stood a chance with Catra. That her heart had always and would always belong to Adora.

“You seem to understand her on a level I could never reach.” Adora sighed and laid down on her side, drawing sadly in the dirt with a finger. She was so tired now all she wanted was to fall asleep, but her mind was spinning and her body hummed with adrenaline.

“I could never have the bond you share.” Scorpia responded. “Catra loves you! Adora. You have been her whole world since....since you rescued her from that container. I guess.” Scorpia smiled sadly at the ancient metal coffin that Catra had been sealed in for an untold amount of years. She had heard everything Adora had confessed to Catra about being in this room before. She had pretty good hearing for a Scorpion.

“Who were all these other people?” Adora whispered in fear, glancing over to the container in wonder. “Why was Catra in that stasis container? How long was she in there?”

“When did you find Catra here?” Scorpia asked, her frown deepening.

“When I was very young. I ran away from the nursery and I hid in these ruins. But I wasn't alone for long. I wandered in here and I guess, then I released Catra from her containment pod. Probably the same way I released that Etherian. With my First Ones DNA.” She stared down at her hand, as if it was a weapon.

“I was so little...Catra might have been my age. Hell she could have been younger.” Then Adora started to laugh nervously.

“On further thought, she is probably a hell of a lot older than me. ” Adora's laugh turned bitter. Taking a deep breath before continuing her tale.

“We were all alone, surviving together for days until Octavia found us. I guess that's why Catra hates her.” Adora laughed lightly.

“She dragged us both back to the Fright Zone and the rest I guess is the rest.” Adora sighed, the memories of that time were hazy. But the warm feelings they invoked were sweet. Little Adora and Catra must have had a wonderful adventure together, before they were taken back to the Horde.

Pushing Forward

Catra was once again adrift in the dreamscape of the golden plains. It was late afternoon and the sun had fallen low towards the endless fields of tall grass. The once bright blue sky was cooling to a duller shade. She had been wandering the streets of the village, enjoying the sight of people who looked like her going about their daily lives. The village was not small, the streets built in interlocking circles. Stretched across the savannah at least as large as the coastal city of Sea Worthy. The outermost battlements looked out over the wide plains. Of simple wooden guard towers with grass thatched roofs and swinging bridges. Cats in full leather armor walked the battlements keeping a close eye on the grassland. The barracks were long communal structures of dried clay and thatch, nestled in the outermost circle. With domed huts scattered amid the buildings as makeshift armories. Old warriors trained small groups of young adult cats, both male and female. All dressed in leather armor similar to the guards upon the battlements. Some were shooting bows, others trained in swords or hand to hand combat. It reminded Catra of her time as a Horde cadet. The rigid military structure of every day, the strict regime of training. She paused only briefly to watch the soldier's, then departed as the scene only brought back bleak memories of her childhood.

The smoke of the blacksmith caught her eyes and she headed towards the larger, stone and clay building nestled to the north of the barracks. Catra found herself lingering in the large open doorway. Watching a small army of blacksmiths work, smelting ore in the ovens, pouring molds or pounding out swords or axes upon anvils with heavy hammers. They wore heavier hide armor, with long sleeves and elbow length leather padded gloves. She smiled softly as she watched them work. Dreaming that perhaps if she had remained in this time, this is where she would have found a purpose. Not on the battlefield as a soldier, but as an artist of weapons.

The streets nestled in the middle circuit were full of small shops for merchants and crafters. The buildings were multi leveled structures, of wood, molded clay and woven grass roofs. Each with a unique design to house what lay within. She admired the wares inside the shops, threw the circular windows. Wandering through the potter's haven and the weavers' den. Appreciating the artistry and fine craftsmanship, noticing that the interlocking knots that adorned her parents' clothing was a popular motif for her people. Wondering if becoming a craftsman or a merchant might have been her life choice. An honest livelihood, a life without guilt or regrets.

While the center most circle was filled with quaint clay and thatch family homes, the sweet smells of cooking filled the air. Mother's stood outside their huts, wearing simple hide halter tops and skirts, or light cloth dresses, hanging laundry or gardening. While children of all ages, in little more than loin cloths, ran in the streets, playing the game she had understood best as a child. Tackling and wrestling, tagging each other in an endless round of laughter and cries of glee. Adora had been the only one she felt close enough and comfortable enough with to play this game. The other cadets never understood why she chased Adora all over the Fright Zone, why their wrestling had persisted even into adolescence. But to Catra it was a natural way to bond, to connect with another person...the only person that mattered. With Adora, she had felt truly safe to be herself. So had given into a lot of her more feline behaviors when in private with her. Kneading her when she was a kitten, when she was anxious or sad. Nuzzling her neck as a way to mark her as an adolescent, when she was overcome with a yearning for Adora, she had yet to understand. Bunting with her....in moments of sweet affection. Even some of her more violent behaviors such as scratching or biting were taken in stride. Adora had accepted them as normal Catra's things, when they were growing up. Characteristics that made Catra unique and special. To see all those behaviors on display among her own people, normalized them for her for the first time.

No one could see her or hear her, she was invisible among them. Free to laugh, as she finally found a sense of belonging. Or to cry

as she mourned the loss of never being a part of this forgotten world.

“How long..” Catra asked, glancing to her side. Finding her timeless, winged companion once again floating beside her.

“These people have been gone for a thousand years.” Her elegant voice responded sadly. “Among many other Etherian races as well. Those who did not submit to the Heart of Etheria Project were culled from the planet. So that their magic would have no vessels and be forced to be absorbed back into their artificial heart. Or transferred into colonists who would inherit their artificial Rune Stones. The First Ones were not here to save anyone but themselves.” She finished, her voice cold and full of anger.

Catra gasped, her mind racing with the understanding that she had somehow been imprisoned in that stasis pod for a thousand years.

“She-Ra!!!” Loud voices echoed in excitement from just ahead. The streets were more narrow here and led straight to the massive central courtyard.

“It's the She-Ra!” the voices of children, pure and full of hope exploded in the air. As Catra burst forward into a full run towards the end of the street. The faint warmth of the late day sun bathed her as she dashed into the large central courtyard of the village.

Women herded small children threw the square. While older women sat under squat structures made only of grass and long wooden poles, along the sides of the courtyard. Busy grinding wheat into large wooden bowls with stone pestles. While young women knelt before low tables, kneaded the ground wheat with water and spices into a dough. Then took the molded dough to a set of huge stone hearths built in a row just behind the long grass awning they were working under. Men stood at long tables, cutting and preparing meat in a similar structure on the other side of the square. Young men would take the freshly skewered meat to large pits lined with mortar that were dug nearby. Lifting up a

heavy metal hatch and sliding the poles of raw meat into the hole. Where a roaring fire inside would sear the meat and cook it slowly. A sweet smelling smoke that rose from those fire pits, was making Catra's mouth water.

Children and adolescence crowded around a small group at the very center of the courtyard.

Curious, Catra moved with purpose towards the crowd. Finding a hunting party dressed in leather armor, surrounding a tall, older man. He offered the growing crowd a tolerant smile. Dressed in very fine clothes. Wearing a deep purple suit and a soft white dress shirt. A simple black leather cape hung from his shoulders with silver goat skull pendants. His skin had a greyish blue hue. He was very muscular, with broad shoulders and thick legs and arms. With a head of dark hair, that hung low over his pointed ears, that was slightly peppered with grey at the ends. He had heavy brows and shaded, dark blue eyes that surveyed the square like a predatory bird. His sharp jaw line and square face was accented by a small dark mustache and goatee. He had a walking staff with a silver goat's skull as a hand hold. His long, elegant fingers coiled over the goats twisting horns.

The unmistakable glow of She-Ra illuminated a few yards back, surrounded by excited children and nervous mothers. This She-Ra was slightly taller than Adora, with tanned skin and long silver blonde hair. She had the most piercing blue eyes and a regal beauty that left Catra speechless. She commanded power and respect with every breath she took. Her armor and crown was different but just as majestic as Adora's. The children were offering her bribes, such as beads or shiny stones for stories, but non dared reach out and touch her. They merely danced around her eager and excited. While the adolescence who stood aloof nearby, were whispering in awe and preening to be seen by her.

“So good of you to come, Mara.” The old man cooed, moving next to She-Ra through the crowd as smoothly as a serpent.

“Not at all, Senator Keldor. It is my duty as She-Ra to protect these people. They must join the Heart of Etheria project if they are to survive. Every day our people are losing ground against the Galactic Horde. We can't afford doubts or stalling any longer.” Mara advised.

Catra followed them as they parted the throng of villager's, headed towards a semi- circle of wooden poles and grass structure. Set atop a carved stone dais in the middle of the square.

Four elders sat upon dried woven grass matts under the structure, waiting for the hunting party to bring them the Eternian's. They wore simple hide pants and were bare chested, except for one female who wore a leather halter top. That had tiny, black wool tassels accenting the bra line. The eldest of them, who's coat was mostly grey had a hide and wool cloak wrapped over bent shoulders. While the other two males, who were a bit younger, had various necklaces of orange crystal beads hanging low around their necks. Each had grim faces, worn and weathered from age. Their ears drooped and tails curled around their crossed legs. Their various fur coats were peppered with grey.

The children stayed a good distance away, as the Hunting party led the two Eternian's to the dais.

The old women halted their work to listen, along with the men preparing the meat. All fell silent to listen, as the children settled onto the dirt eager to find out what the future would hold for their people.

“Honor and Power to the She-Ra.” The oldest male offered with a nod, as he grunted in pain. Slowly rising to his feet to greet them, adjusting his cloak with old, trembling hands. His fur was a smoky grey with dark stripes. His ears and tail a deepest black. His amber eyes, warm and body relaxed. His voice was deep and cracked with age.

“Honor and long life to the Sunna People.” She-Ra offered back, with a warm smile.

He nodded, then turned to regard Keldor. The old cat’s eyes cooled and his back became more stiff.

“Strength to Senator Keldor.” He nodded towards the Eternian. The rest of the elders remained stoic, not even raising an eyebrow in greeting.

“Strength to Elder Bran.” Keldor nodded back.

“These are the Elder’s of the Four Prides.” Keldor waved a hand towards the four cats, a tolerant smile on his face as he greeted the elders.

She-Ra nodded and acknowledged the Elder who had stood to greet them.

“Elder Bran of the Western Pride.”

He merely nodded in turn, a small proud smile pulling on his thin lips at being acknowledged so formally.

Then She-Ra turned to regard the cat with all black fur, pepper with grey. His hands and feet were covered in white fur. His mane was a wild black, cut short enough to stick straight up. Creating a mohawk down his back. His yellow gaze was still fierce despite his age. Slightly blinded in his left eye by thick cataracts, that bruised his pupil.

“Elder Daga, of the Eastern Pride.” She nodded, curtly to the black cat.

Then She-Ra moved to nod curtly at the lone female elder who sat beside him. Who had a long white coat, with a patch work of black and orange covering her lower back. Her mane was a warm brown, almost orange. Pulled back into a hunters top knot, her black ears flickering attentively to every sound.

“Elder Neria, of the Southern Pride.” Then She-Ra moved to acknowledge the last Elder.

“Elder Tyr of the Northern Pride.” A light tan furred cat, with burly shoulders and an ample belly, gave her a brief nod. He had dark stripes and a black mane woven into a long braid down his back. His eyes were a warm hazel, full of humor and good will towards She-Ra. But his smile quickly tempered into a stern scowl upon acknowledging the Senator.

“Come sit so that we may discuss our future together.” Tyr stood and offered them a seat. He was younger, then the rest. His dark tan ears stood upright and his matching tail swished lazily behind him. His hazel eyes were shadowed with distrust in regards to Keldor, as the Eternian huffed and mounted the set of stair to the dais.

She-Ra moved and sat gingerly beside Daga, while Senator Keldor eyed the dirty mat briefly with disdain before reluctantly crouching beside She-Ra. Unwilling to sit and get his clothes dirty.

“I bring She-Ra, so that you may know that my intentions are honorable. We have little time left to discuss this. We need to start constructing your Rune Stone. Your magic is necessary to defend your planet.” He began, rushing forward with his intentions not really too interested in what the Elder's had in mind for the evening.

The elder that greeted them, Bran. Remained standing, eyeing Keldor with impatience.

She-Ra cast Senator Keldor a sideways glare then promptly grabbed his hand and pulled him down. Forcing him to sit on the mat beside her. He growled softly in frustration, as the first Elder to greet them nodded and sat down himself, followed by Tyr.

“It is my job to balance the planet, then and only then will the First Ones be able to bring peace to this part of the galaxy. Etheria's magic is vital to assure victory over the Galactic Horde.”

She-Ra reassured them, trying to bring the Elder's on topic quickly.

As women came with platters of meat, roasted vegetables and flat bread. The elders talked amongst themselves, offering She-Ra and Senator Keldor pointed questions about this Rune Stone project and how it worked and what the repercussions would be for the land and for themselves. Keldor answered their questions, but his wording was vague and confusing. His explanations so intrenched in technical speak, that the Elder's were quickly lost. Not wanting to look foolish, the four cats would smile and nod. Desperately trying to grasp what Keldor was explaining about magical syphoning, distribution and amplification.

Catra listened for a time, before catching sight of a small group of villager's standing around the furthest cooking pit. Casting She-Ra and Senator Keldor dark looks, from beneath the cowls of their hide and woolen cloaks.

Catra smirked and strode over to the group. She knew instantly that they were seeds of resistance, here in the village. They did not want, nor trust these Eternian's.

"She-Ra wants to balance the planet...these Rune Stones are the only way to do that?" One hooded figure laughed snidely.

"We have never needed artificial ampfili...cation.." Another stumbled out.

"Don't hurt yourself, Cadell." The third elbowed Cadell in the ribs, playfully.

"To protect our people..." Cadell waved a hand bitterly at the Elder's. "My own brother left to join the Tri-Solar Militia. He is part of Squadron Grey Skull and they are fighting the Horde right now...somewhere up there." Cadell pointed up at the stars vaguely.

"Lots of Etherian's have gone off world to fight, stop bragging." Another hooded figure grumbled.

“The Elder’s are fools to trust outsiders.” Cadell muttered bitterly, not confident enough to speak out too loudly, lest he be overheard.

“I see Ouroboros has not been invited to these talks.” Saladin strode out of the shadows on the far side of the furthest most fire pit. Leaning against the thick wooden pole, of one of the long grass structures, remaining out of view from the main dais.

The hooded figures cast the dais accusing glares.

“Shall we go and invite them?” Saladin offered with a mischievous grin.

The group laughed in agreement and left the square with Saladin. Catra followed at a discreet distance. Her father was causing trouble...but was it good or bad?

She followed the group soundlessly as they moved out of the village and into the grasslands. Heading over the savannah towards the massive stone at its center. The sky was filled with starlight, the moons hovering high above when they reached the stone monolith. Saladin guided the small group up a narrow dirt path towards a cave nestled in the northern most reach of the stone. The threshold was massive, barren and not natural. It looked as if it had been carved right out of the smooth stone by teeth and claw. The group cowered at the mouth, whispering excuses and muttering frightened oaths.

“Are you suddenly too scared to fight for your cause? Now that there is more required of you then just talk and petty bragging.” Saladin laughed.

The group of young men and women grew silent, casting their heads down in shame.

" When the time comes, the resistance will need more than just talk. Remember that!” Saladin gave them a dismissive wave before striding into the cave.

The mouth widened into a dark tunnel, glowing orbs of light floated in the air like dust motes. Catra followed her father as he moved deeper, listening for anything that might give away what lived in this cave. Her father seemed relaxed, completely at ease here in the dark. Strange orange crystals covered in lichen grew upon the walls as they moved deeper. The crystals glowed bright, as if the core was ignited by flame. The lichen crawling along the stone smelled sweet like nectar. It grew thicker as the tunnel twisted into a cavern. Then she heard the sound of water trickling above that could only mean they were beneath the waterfall, that was on the grotto side of the monolith. What sounded like the grinding of teeth on stone, echoed below. A hot wind howled up from the depths, blasting Saladin and making him squint and raise an arm to ward off the heat.

(Saladin! You reek of Eternian!) A deep rumble echoed from the darkness.

"Ouroboros! I come bearing more than just a foul smell." Saladin laughed, as he moved cautiously into the cavern. An immense orange glow dominated the center of the vast cavern, it looked like a giant campfire. It's mass flickering and snapping merrily in the pitch black void of the caverns depths.

As Catra drew near she felt the dry ground beneath her feet tremble as the living fire shifted. Her jaw dropped in awe and utter terror as she realized that the flames were actually long flowing strands of fur. That was growing out of an incredibly large serpent. It looked to be a hundred feet long, coiling and stretching until it filled the whole cavern. Millions of tiny coppery scales hid beneath the patches of glowing fur, gleaming as if freshly smelted from the forge. The sheer strength and power the serpent held in it's rippling musculature made all the color drain from Catra's face.

Ouroboros was immense.

Then she saw one massive eye, staring right at her. It glowed yellow like a lantern, the incredible amounts of magic it held onto

was staggering. Catra stopped moving, her heart was hammering in her chest in fear. She couldn't breath, could barely think as the beast's eye held her in place. Catra felt the wild flame she now laid claim to, leap inside her soul. Like a child eager to present oneself for praise.

(I have dreamt of you, Wildling) The serpent's eternal voice resounded in Catra's head. Causing her heart to lurch and her breath to leave her body in a whoosh of shocked surprise.

"The Elder's are holding council with the Eternian without you." Saladin stated, folding his arms over his chest. Standing tall, a few meters away from the stout muzzle of the serpent. T he massive eye flicked away from Catra to focus on Saladin.

Catra released a held breath, clutching her chest as her heart was fluttering against her rib cage like a frightened bird. She turned to look down at the serpentine shadow upon the floor, too overwhelmed to remain staring at the serpent itself.

"Let them have their little soiree, it means nothing. I will never allow them to erect an artificial Rune Stone on my lands." Ouroboros growled. "They shall not harvest my children's magic and gift it to their own heir. Use it for their own gain, their She-Ra be damned!" Its voice rising in fury.

"She-Ra is at the village right now." Saladin sniped, his tone surely.

"That sword..." Ouroboros snarled. "It forces Etheria's Heart to accept her. She is not natural...She has become nothing but a pawn, a tool to be used and discarded by her own people. Let her learn her own fate and live or die by her own hands." Ouroboros spat, curling it's massive head towards its pile of coils, laying its head down near its tail.

Saladin nodded. When he moved towards the side of the serpent, the sound of his toe claws scraping against the dirt alerted Catra.

Who looked up, following him as he made his way along the incredible length of the furry snake like beast.

Finding Aoi sitting on the ground, leaning against the serpent, fast asleep in it's heavy fur. A soft blue cloak very similar to Saladin's was draped over her.

"The Rune Bearer was tired, your Wildling keeps her up a night." Ouroboros voice rumbled the accusation at Saladin. As if the infant's needs were his fault.

"Where is Kaira?" Saladin asked, leaning down to brush his knuckles tenderly down Aoi's cheek.

"She is currently crawling up around my head." Ouroboros shivered, a broad smile pulling upon his toothy maw. As a tiny, naked baby Kaira, crawled into view upon the serpents massive forehead. She sat with pride just above it's huge orb like eyes. Her tan fur glowed in the serpents mystical aura, the darker brown stripes along her pudgy arms just starting to come in. Bright mismatched eyes, far too large for her small round face stared in wonder at the height she had climbed to. The smattering of freckles on her flushed cheeks were an adorable marker just like her mother. Her tuft of deep brown mane now hung wild and full around her large ears just brushing her shoulders. Her dark ears twitched happily, her matching tail swished. Flexing her tiny front claws into the Serpents fur, before slipping down it's stout muzzle. The baby's laughter was pure and full of glee and it echoed in the cavern like a bell.

Ouroboros laughed merrily and lowered it's giant head to the ground. Offering the baby solemnly to Saladin.

"She will inherit all of my powers one day." Ouroboros stated, staring right at Catra again.

Catra awoke suddenly, her mind was sluggish. Her memories of last night were slightly unclear. The impact of what she had done.

Still murky, as they remained hidden behind a fog of exhaustion. The veiled trauma and unyielding rage roiled in her gut but had no clarity. Her brief reflections upon the incredible violence she had inflicted and the crushing grief she had endured, was tempered, with grim resignation. Looking back now with a rational mind, no longer overwhelmed by her emotions. She felt ashamed and humiliated at losing so much of her control. But there was nothing she could do, what was done, was done.

With a heavy sigh that turned into a yawn. She stretched off of Scorpia's lap. Thrusting her arms out straight, planting her hands on the dry ground before crawling the rest of the way off her lap. She glanced around the chamber, finding the warm light of dawn was now cascading into the chamber threw a massive crack on the side wall. She found her baby blanket, discarded a few feet away and quickly picked it up. Clutching it protectively to her chest, resolved to place it securely in her pack.

Scorpia sat rigid, back straight, head nodded forward sleeping soundly.

“Scorpia...” Catra called tentatively, crouching low, ducking her head under Scorpia's chin to see if she was still breathing. She mournfully recalled having the most violent breakdown ever and Scorpia coming to her aid.

With a snort and a gasp, Scorpia snapped her head up and blinked her eyes open in surprise.

“Oh...Wild Cat, your awake.” She mumbled, still groggy and disoriented.

“Are you alright?” Catra asked, gazing mournfully at the scratched and chipped parts of Scorpia's carapace and pinchers.

“Oh...Yeah. My carapace heals itself over time, it's like your claws. Nothing a good buffing won’t fix. .” Scorpia rolled her stiff shoulder's offering her a reassuring smile.

Catra took a deep breath, offering Scorpia a small apologetic smile.

“Where's Adora?” Catra glanced around nervously as the intense memories of last night rushed through her mind. Flooding her with mortification and worry as to how freaked out Adora might be right now. After witnessing one of her most violent bouts of grief, to date. She had released her sorrow violently several times throughout her life. But it had always been done in private. The last time was when she had taken out the observation terminals while looking for Scorpia. This was the first time she had truly lost complete control of herself, so overwhelmed by her grief. Her cathartic release of violence on display before Adora and Scorpia had been so sudden and overwhelming. Her need to destroy, to rip and tear.... it was a part of who she was. But it also frightened her and filled her with shame. It made her dwell bitterly upon aspects of herself that she didn't like.

“She couldn’t sleep, so she headed back down to the Fortress to release the Etherian's.” Scorpia yawned and stretched, rising to her feet sluggishly.

“That sounds about right.” Catra sighed, her eyes dropping in embarrassment to the ground. “I made a complete fool of myself last night.”

“Don't you dare say that!” Scorpia chastised, placing both pincher's on Catra's shoulders. Making the cat look up and face her serious frown.

“You will not feel bad about being honest with your feelings!” Scorpia, eyes were stern. “You found out some really bad stuff last night. I doubt I would keep it together, if I found my parents dead bodies and that I had been sealed inside a stasis pod for who knows how long?”

“I completely lost it, Scorpia!” Catra shouted, pushing her pinchers off her shoulder harshly. Taking a couple deep breaths to calm her anger. Refusing to lash out at Scorpia ever again.

“I probably scared the hell out of her!” She growled, then took another deep breath.

“Thank you...for calming me down and I'm sorry.” She breathed out, her voice calm and regulated as she swallowed her self hatred yet again. Her flippant description glossed over the seriousness of what happened. Cringing with guilt at attacking Scorpia with the intent to kill.

“I would hope that if I ever lost control of myself that you would be there....to protect the people I love...to calm me down..too. Before....I did something truly awful.” Scorpia answered, reaching out and grasping Catra's hand softly with a pincher. While nervously rubbing the back of her neck where the chip had been.

Catra looked up when Scorpia held her hand, her eyes widening in understanding as she noticed how Scorpia rubbed her neck. It was a tell she thought only she did, when she felt uneasy about her own emotional control.

“Scorpia....if you ever need to talk. I'm here.” Catra gave her pincher a small pull, wanting to draw her back from her dark thoughts. She understood better than most the struggle Scorpia was going through dealing with the aftermath of Primes control.

“Yeah...not yet, Wild Cat.” Scorpia took a deep breath and squared her shoulders.

“I am going to be just fine.” She offered Catra a broad confident smile that did not reach her eyes.

Catra nodded, moving away from Scorpia when her blanket laying on the ground near by caught her eye. She swiftly snatched it up off the ground, holding her baby blanket against her chest with both hands. She nuzzled the ancient hide, hoping catch even the faintest hint of her parents scent As she strode towards the entrance of the chamber. When she was greeted with disappointment, smelling only the damp musk of the cave. She snapped her eyes up and refused look around as she left. Keeping

her eyes focused on the archway and headed down the earthen, outer corridor. Her actions spoke of moving forward of needing to leave all these sad revelations behind. Wanting to compartmentalize all the hurt and regret and deal with it all later.

“Lets go catch up with Adora. Knowing her, she has been working all night and I am going to have to force her to rest.” Catra's voice called back, Melog padded behind her. Their head hanging low, mane flowing somberly around their neck. Catra could not hide her emotions when her alien companion was in toe. She was grieving, embarrassed and remorseful over losing control last night and it showed on Melogs sullen demeanor like a beacon.

Scorpia took a deep breath. “Alright world, let's see what you throw at me this time. I'm ready.” She squared her shoulders and raised her head up high, forcing a bright positive smile.

The hanger was in a state of controlled chaos. Ex-horde soldier's under the command of Lonnie, after lengthy instruction from Entrapta. Had set up recovery and trauma stations for the Etherians on the far side of the hangar. Rows of cots were filled with confused or hurt Etherian's from all corners of the continent. Horde medics moved between the beds, accessing their condition. While others came with data pads collecting information as to where they came from or family contacts. The horde had a new mission and they tackled it like any other military maneuver. With highly organized precision and planning.

The pods had been reorganized, the more slender ones holding the Etherians on the right side of the hanger near the makeshift hospital. The larger, more varied pods pushed to the left near the stacks of makeshift cages, made from scrap found around the Fright Zone. The now empty pods were being pushed to the front of the hanger, loaded into cargo transport and taken to another location for storage.

Several squads with stun batons hovered around unconscious animals awaiting cages. Those that had already been caged were being stored on the opposite side of the hanger. It was a very busy but well organized effort. It looked like they were leaving most of the beasts to be released later. Since the cages were still in the various stages of being built. Catra watched the small army of blacksmiths that usually worked in the forge, welding metal bars. As workers from the manufacturing sector organized the scrap that could be used from the useless junk. She could not help but smile with pride at how efficient the Horde could be when given a task. Every soldier was trained in different ways, grouped into squads that would work together for the rest of their lives. Teamwork was as natural as breathing for the Horde.

The Fright Zone's utility and manufacturing sectors worked like a well oiled machine, they were like interlocking parts that could not function without the other. They worked behind the scenes to keep the soldier's out in the field, supplied and their equipment functioning. Keeping the fortress in good repair so the soldier's and cadets could live and train in a secure environment. Catra's musing took her down a strange and startling journey, as she thought about her own time as a cadet.

The clones now separated from the Hive Mind were starting to form squads...just like the Etherian Horde. Working together like interlocking parts to finish tasks for Entrapta and Hordak. She had never thought about it before...but Hordak's army worked very much like a rudimentary Hive Mind and she was raised to function as part of it.

Catra cringed and quickly shook her head to free herself from further contemplations about her indoctrination in the Horde. She really did not want to lose herself to such grim reflection right now.

After stopping by her old quarters and tucking her baby blanket away in her pack. Catra had headed to the hangar. She stood at the hanger bay's massive entrance in complete awe. Searching the massive crowds in vain for Adora.

“This may take a while.” She groused, sniffing the air briefly as she walked into the crowds.

Slipping smoothly through the throng of soldiers, Catra made her way deeper into the hanger. Scanning each row in search of Adora. The intolerable din of voices echoing throughout the hanger hurt her ears, making her fold them back to partially block out the irritating noise. Melog chirped behind her, glancing around nervously. They sensed something, an odd smell or perhaps a sound that was out of place here in the hanger. Melog narrowed their eyes, their tail lashing with agitation. As soon as their master found her mate, they were going to go patrol.

“Is everything alright?” Catra asked, sensing their unease. Turning to crouch beside them and caress their mane tenderly.

Melog mewed softly, ears twitching.

(I need to check the perimeter...something's off.)

“Ok, but be careful.” Catra gave their cheek a soft, affectionate pat.

Melog nodded and padded off, heading out of the hanger into the rising dawn.

Catra watched them go with a concerned frown. Then resumed her search for Adora, as always she was her priority.

“Eternia!” A sharp, high pitched voice taunted Catra from the girder above.

Catra's heart leapt into her throat in dread at the sudden sound of that planet's name. Catra glanced up, finding Hordak's imp hiding in the rafters. His beady black eyes staring down at her with that vile, toothy smile. With a shriek he leaped from the roof and glided down, to land on a nearby container.

“Skeletor...Eternia!” He crowed proudly.

Catra had long ago resigned herself to the imps' presence here in the Fortress. She refused to take his bait and allow him to anger her any longer. He was a vile little spy, who took great joy in reporting back to Hordak, all the little secrets he found. She still hated him and would never trust him. Glaring daggers down at the imp she finally regarded him.

“How are you not dead.” Catra moaned, this thing had annoyed her to no end when she was a part of the Horde. His meddling had gotten her punished severely after Shadow Weaver's escape and nearly killed. He was a sneaky, malicious little monster. Her last battle with Hordak had nearly levelled the Fright Zone, she was surprised to find the imp still breathing.

“Eternia is here....” He howled, leaping back into the air and flying away, only to land on an another container further away. His words are eerie and ominous. Making Catra shiver with dread, she had come to a strange conclusion after her last dream that it was not just a dream. That the glowing woman was real, that she was taking her back in time. To see for herself what the First Ones had done in the distant past. For what purpose that she didn't know...yet.

She turned her back on the imp not willing to play his games, she walked away. Leaving him crouching with a sour expression on the stasis container. As his report was blatantly ignored, by Hordak’s second in command.

She found Adora at the back of the hanger. Standing in front of a slender, blackened container, hand poised on the control pad. A couple soldier's hung back, ready to take care of whoever was inside. As the glass hissed and faded away. Adora merely strode away to the next container, as two more soldier's followed in her wake. They had gotten this recovery process down last night, now it was just a grueling routine.

The soldier's from the previous container guided a confused Salinean Sea elf away to the triage.

“Hey, Adora...” Catra approached her, with a warm, if nervous smile.

Adora turned to offer her a warm smile of her own. She was exhausted, her blue eyes were glazed over and grey discoloration was bruising the underside. She never said a word, merely pressed her hand on the panel. Then passed Catra, giving her hand a quick reassuring squeeze before moving quietly to the next container.

“How are you feeling?” She asked, her eyes soft with empathy for Catra's grief. As she raised her hand to press it down on the panel.

“Better.” Catra nodded. “Sorry about...whatever... that was...I was really upset.”

“I get it.” Adora started, “Losing your parents, I sometimes think about mine too.” But her words quickly trailed off. Sensing that Catra did not want to get into it here. She honestly didn't know how she felt about being kidnapped and forced to become a soldier herself. That was a whole ball of trauma she hadn't unpacked herself.

The glass on the container faded away and Adora moved to the next. As a long silence fell between them, until Catra took a deep breath and pushed on. Desperate for things not to be so awkward between them.

“You look terrible.” Catra teased with a smirk.

“I feel fine.” Adora muttered, unlocking the container with her hand and moving on.

“You need food and rest, dummy.” Catra reached out to place a comforting hand on her shoulder.

“I need to finish.” Adora stated, her eyes hardening with resolve. Then moved on out of her range, as the glass vaporized from the container.

Catra sighed and rolled her eyes. “They're not going anywhere! Adora. They can wait a few hours for you to take a break.”

“There is too much to do, Catra.” Adora shook her head, “With the Princesses Rune Stones out of commission. Our strongest fighters are weakened. I gotta finish this up and we got to get Entrapta to Mystacor. So she can figure out exactly what the Fail Safe did. We need to be ready.” She ranted, brushing a frustrated hand through the loosened hair from her pony tail that had fallen around her ears.

Catra stared at her in confusion and worry. Once again she could feel the stress of responsibility and destiny slowly crushing her. She hated it! She hated that Adora felt she had to take everything on and not share the burden with her friends...with her!

“Adora?” Catra called plaintively, reaching out for her once again.

“Go talk to Entrapta. She will fill you in.” Adora sighed, releasing another Etherian and proceeding on.

Catra watched her go for a moment, her arm falling to her side in disappointment then she growled and spun on her heel.

“Stubborn brat...but what did I expect?” Then scanned the hanger for Entrapta. Finding her sitting in reflection in the far corner, having climbed up the wall with her new magnetism powers. To sit high above the hanger on a set of wide, steel heating ducts, just below the hanger's solitary massive back window.

It had taken Catra a few hours to track down Adora. Now late morning light was cascading brilliantly through the glass, falling on Entrapta's hunched form as she sat in somber introspection upon a mound of her own lavender hair. Tapping on a data pad, completely engrossed in her information. She looked as worn out as Adora.

Catra nodded, following the duct work to find a lower ledge to leap onto. It took a bit of strategy but eventually Catra found

herself near the roof, crawling on all fours along the duct, up to Entrapta's perch.

“Hey, Entrapta.” Catra called, leaning against the cool metal wall and sliding down to sit beside her.

“Hey, Catra.” Entrapta offered absently, reaching out with a gloved hand and patting her on the top of the head in greeting as if she was a little kid.

Catra looked up, finding the height difference with her sitting on her hair, was rather annoying.

“Adora sent me. For an update.” She asked, swallowing her pride and not verbally retaliating for Entrapta's unconscious belittlement. Of treating her like a little kid just cause she was shorter at the moment.

“Well, I've figured out that these Eternian's have been on Etheria for quite some time. I think they snuck in through old portals, left here by the First Ones. That are still linked to their planet from ours.

I think the portals reactivated just after Etheria returned from Despondos.” She stated, swiping away a few screens and activating others.

“Or...perhaps they slipped in on Space ships...during Horde Prime’s occupation and then reconnected that portal to their planet…” She muttered to herself...but there was no data of alien Starcrafts yet to be found, at least by the clone squads she and Hordak had sent out to investigate.

“Sounds about right. The Eternian were the First Ones who settled here a thousand years ago.” Catra commented.

“How do you know that!” Entrapta snapped her gaze to Catra.

Catra shrugged. “It's a long story and I still feel rather crazy talking about it.”

“People think I'm crazy.” Entrapta spat out, not angry or resentful, just stating a fact.

“I don't think you're crazy,” Catra responded. “Anyone who really matters, is going to see the real you and accept you for who you are.”

“How very kind of you.” Entrapta smiled fondly down at her.

“Super pal trio.” Catra smiled, holding up a fist.

“Super pal trio.” Entrapta laughed and gave her a fist bump. Then sobered and got back on track.

“The ruins in the swamp might not be the only working portal on the planet. I spoke to Hordak...who was not very happy about having an Eternian infestation...as he put it. On the planet. So he has sent out several groups of clones to investigate the various First Ones ruins, beacons, outposts, and transmission spires around Etheria. If there are any more working portals, he wants to neutralize them. Adora's on board with that plan...but I can't help but feel we are losing a great opportunity for research by closing down all the portals. I would love to go through one and explore this Eternia...” She finished wistfully.

“As much as I loathed to admit it. " Catra choked out.

“I believe Hordak's got the right idea. We need to shut down those portals so no more Eternian's can cross over without us knowing about it. But maybe in time when we are ready, we can open a portal from our side and go to their planet for a little reconnaissance.” Catra smirked.

“Pay back is always so much fun.” She finished slyly under her breath.

High in the shadows of the heavy iron girders a small metal spy lurked. A drone, shaped like the head of a predatory bird,

hovering out of sight. The camera lens in it's eyes turned to focus on Entrapta and Catra, the microphones embedded into it's open beak recording everything they said.

A sudden weight struck, sending it off balance towards the dusty, wide iron girder. It twittered in alarm, as a huge grey head with sharp angled ears and beady black eyes filled it's view.

“Intruder!” the imp screamed. “Intruder!”

The Doom Seeker drone engaged its thrusters with a roar and went into flight, with the Imp hanging on for dear life. Flapping it's tiny wings to no avail, against the drones powerful rockets. Screaming in fright as the drone flew straight out of the hanger. Leaving only a thin trail of smoke, as it shot into the mid morning sun outside.

“What was that?” Entrapta asked. Watching with curious fear, as Catra bolted. Catra caught sight of the drone flying just overhead, in the metal rafters. She was quick to leap from the duct work, to the iron girders. The soldier's below looked up in surprise, as she leaped with great speed and agility across the roof of the hanger. The slight impact of her weight shaking the girders, making them vibrate and echo loudly. Her feet and hands brushing the dust off the metal. Sending the dirt down upon the people below in a cloud of dust and fine debris. Adora caught sight of her and was quick to react, charging down an alley of container's. Raising her hand above her head and summoning She-Ra in a flash of blinding white light. Catra leaped out of the hanger, keeping her head up and tracking the drone in the sky as she landed on the tarmac on all fours. A flash of light exploded in the mouth of the hanger and soon She-Ra was charging out of the hanger after Catra.

“Catra!” She-Ra screamed, as she ran astride the cat. Who was scanning the cracks of sky between looming towers for any sign of the drone or even the imp. The fortress was way too crowded

with towers and buildings making it harder to find. The sun was shining off the steel, blinding her every time she looked up. Catra snarled, feeling that they were wasting time.

“A spy..in the hanger.” Catra shouted, as they ran along a narrow alley between two massive buildings. She leaped up to a lower platform for an emergency ladder and climbed upwards towards the arching roof. She-Ra continued to run ahead, her sword glowing in the brilliant sunlight. Without the smog from the foundry the air was clear, allowing the sun to beat down upon the Fright Zone. Turning all that metal into a gleaming mirror. Reflecting back upon them in a blinding flare every time they looked up.

Catra leaped from rooftop to rooftop, climbing and flipping in an acrobats dance. Needing to get higher, so the towers couldn't obscure her sight. She crossed the Fright Zones haphazard metal structures with ease. That had been built from scavenged tech from around Etheria and Hordak's old starship, now overgrown with flowering vines. The sweet smell was heady but more welcome to Catra's delicate sense of smell than the grease and toxic chemical smoke that once dominated this place. She was heading to the highest point...the platform that her and Adora always retreated to, so they could be alone.

Leaping up onto the broken railing, that was now twisted and hanging slightly off the side. Her claws cut away several vines of blooming flowers that fluttered away into the shadows below. She took a deep breath, this place held far to many memories both good and bad. Shading her eyes with a hand she scanned the whole of the Fright Zone, as a hot wind from the Refinery blew against the back of her head. Tossing her short hair and snapped her leather coat against her sides. Her heart was beating hard in her chest, anxiety of losing the drone paramount in her thoughts. Then a sharp glint drew her attention to the north.

The trail of smoke billowing from the shiny spec gave it away, as it spun drunkenly between two narrow chemical stacks of the Foundry.

“Adora! To the North!” Catra screamed, racing back down from their secret spot.

Running the length of a flat rooftop, leaping up onto the rim. She surveyed the metal and tech labyrinth of the Fright zone, as it stretched bleakly towards the horizon. Keeping track of the shiny glint of metal just above the blown out remains of the Forge.

“It's just above the Forge, now!” Catra screamed, pointing further north.

She-Ra stopped mid stride several alleys away and pointed her sword towards the gleaming metal hovering just above the chemical stacks. Releasing several bursts of magical energy that flew like scythes towards the drone.

The imp was still hanging on to the upper fin of the drone when the energy blasts hit. It screamed in terror as the drone burst into a ball of flame and careened towards the ground.

“You got it!” Catra cried in glee, leaping from the roof and dashed off towards the Forge.

When she got to the bridge, leaping across the rubble of cement and bent metal. She found the Imp sitting proudly on top of the drone, singing merrily.

“Tri-clops! Tri-clops!” The imp called in a sing-song voice. Then laughed and giggled with pleasure.

She-Ra was standing nearby, searching the debris for anybody else that might be hiding. Maybe this Tri-clops thing. Her glowing blue eyes were fierce, the raw magical power she laid claim to hummed threateningly in the air.

Catra strode over to the imp and gave it a gentle pat on the head. “For once you were actually useful and not a complete pain in the ass.” She smirked.

“Ass pain?” The imp cocked its head to the side in curiosity.

Catra groaned at the imps choice of words.

“Are we good? Can we get this hunk of junk back to Entrapta?” She called, as She-Ra disappeared behind a huge chunk of broken cement.

“Do you smell anyone else?” She-Ra called.

Catra gave the air a good sniff, not picking out any scents that were out of the ordinary. The flowers that surrounded the buildings had the most dominant smell, along with rust, old grease and the residual spice of electricity.

“No...” Catra answered, slinging the Imp up onto her shoulders.

“Ok..” She-Ra strode back into view, casting the wreckage, distrustful looks.

Hefting the busted drone up onto her shoulder, She-Ra walked back towards the hanger with Catra keeping a close eye in case they were being followed.

A glowing red eye shone from beneath their feet in a sewer grate when they got to the other side of the bridge. A low, metallic voice grumbled from the sewer pipe. “How unfortunate.”

Melog had hung back in the shadows of the giant sewer pipe. They could smell their master above and her mate. They were moving around above, their feet making smart clipped sounds on the curved cement roof above. They had been keeping down wind, since prowling into the sewers after a grey cloaked figure. That had been skulking around the hanger bay. The large hood of the woolen cloak shaded the stranger's face, only a red glowing eye could be seen through the gloom. The hood was a dusky grey, made of a heavy, leather material that kept the stranger's identity unknown. Attached to the rest of the cloak was a simple leather hood attached by two large silver pins in the shape of a goat's skull. The stranger was big and moved beneath the old

grey cloak with a bulky, well muscled gait. The stranger had a heavy stride, its overly large feet clad in metal boots stomping upon the ground. Melog had followed the stranger deeper into the labyrinth of sewer channels as they made their way towards the Forge. Listening to the stranger's robotic voice muttering to itself as it gave commands to thin air. It wasn't until they had heard the buzz of thrusters overhead they had realized the stranger had been communicating to a spy drone. Now that their master and their mate were headed back to the hanger. The stranger reversed course and started stalking towards their hiding place in a sewer overflow pipe. Melog hunched low, narrowing their eyes as they cloaked.

“Tri-clops to Jitsu, I have confirmation of the She-Ra. It is just as Mudoluk had claimed, this planet was a weapon. The Doom Seeker has been lost, She-Ra has taken the drone. Self destruct has been activated. We will rendezvous at Arxia in three days.” He commanded, his robotic voice reverberating off the walls. “Lord Skelator will be very pleased...” Tri-clops muttered smugly.

Melog's ears folded back, their mind racing. A hunter's instincts wanted them to keep stalking this stranger back to their lair. But the other half of their mind, the rational, more empathic part, knew that they had to get back to Catra's side before the drone exploded.

So Melog remained hidden, allowing the stranger to get away. When this Tri-clops footsteps faded away in the distance. They broke cover and bolted down the sewer pipe back in the direction of the hanger.

Dealing with Destiny

As they took to the narrow alleys to get back to the hanger. She-Ra strode ahead with the drone tucked under an arm. Her long, powerful strides force Catra to jog, just to keep up. Her glowing blue eyes were alert to any kind of threat and kept darting around for signs of trouble. Every shadow, every slight movement caught the warrior's threatening glare. Catra shivered, at the tense, battle ready aura vibrating off She-Ra's eight foot frame. The imp was perched on her shoulder, casting She-Ra worried looks as well.

"Adora...calm down." Catra jogged up to the powerful warrior, reaching up to clutch her elbow. She stared up at She-Ra's fierce visage with growing apprehension. It had been so much easier to fight against this power house than trying to reason with her. She-Ra was itching for a fight, her muscles were tight and flexing with pent up energy needing to be released. Catra had sensed she had been in her head, overthinking and worrying ever since their encounter with those Laser Bears in the Whispering Woods. She hadn't helped by keeping secrets about the Ruin and the Eternian invaders. Her absolute freak out last night and the sudden appearance of this surveillance drone, had pushed Adora over the edge. She had been holding far too much stress and anxiety inside and was clearly ready to explode. The last thing Catra wanted was for her to get startled by some random civilian. Who would unwittingly become the focus of her rage and probably not survive the encounter.

"Calm down..." She-Ra scoffed, pulling her arm away sharply. "I have no time to calm down, Catra. I don't get to just take it easy. I need information...I need a plan, I have got to get a handle on things before they get any worse."

Duty...Control...Responsibility…they defined Adora and shackled her into servitude to an impossible ideal. To always need to be perfect, to be useful, to never burden others and to fix everything

all on her own. Catra knew this, had witnessed Shadow Weaver's years of conditioning on Adora. That had created this savior complex, this willingness to sacrifice herself for others. Catra had never been able to convince her that this way of thinking was wrong, unhealthy. But she could always refocus her, ease her stress and help her cope.

"Adora..." Catra tossed the Imp aside, it squealed in protest. But Catra knew from long experience in dealing with Adora. When things felt out of her control, when she was feeling stressed beyond what she could handle. She could hold it inside for only so long, before that mental dam she erected around her feelings started to crack....needing to find a safe place to release all that pent up anxiety, to punch out her feelings so to speak. She had found Adora countless times growing up, slamming all her frustration and rage against the punching bag in the cadets locker room. Her knuckles would be bloody and bruised and in need of first aid. Usually after dealing with Shadow Weaver and her long drawn out speeches about being disappointed in her. Or how she wasn't working hard enough or not living up to her full potential. Spitting veiled threats to take away Catra, who she blamed as a distraction and bad influence. How she was making Adora lazy or unfocused towards her training. Using her as a pawn to force Adora to obey. That woman was always pushing Adora to excel at everything. Adora had to be perfect..at all times. Catra never had to deal with that kind of pressure. Adora's abuse by Shadow Weaver had been very different then Catra's, it had been insidious with its subtlety. Catra was alright with punching it out, sometimes getting physical was more cathartic then a good cry. Scorpia had been there for her last night when she had been overwhelmed and needed to purge all the grief and dark emotions. Only another Horde orphan could understand punching out your feelings.

She jogged a few paces ahead and spread her arms wide, blocking She-Ra from proceeding.

"Let's deal with this." Catra stated, her eyes stern.

“Deal with what?” She-Ra questioned, adjusting the drone on her hip. Avoiding Catra's pointed question.

“You've been holding things back from me, too!” Catra shouted in annoyance, placing her hands on her hips. “I don't have a monopoly on problems, Adora. You're just as big of a mess as I am, thanks to Shadow Weaver. Took me a long time to get over myself enough to figure that out.” She laughed bitterly.

“Catra, We don't have time for this. I gotta get this thing back to Entrapta. It could have information about who we are dealing with.” She-Ra, pointed her sword at Catra threatening her to move.

“Eternia!” The imp chirped up helpfully from his new perch atop the broken electric rods of a busted communication tower nearby.

“What more do you need?” Catra shrugged with a lazy grin.

“Lots...tons...We are at a complete disadvantage here. Catra!” She-Ra roared in fury. “I will not allow another alien force to invade my planet or hurt the people I love!”

“There we go...that's a good start.” Catra's arrogant quip provoking her, as her smug smirk slid into place. Then she crouched low, shifting her feet as she narrowed her eyes preparing to feint She-Ra's coming assault.

“Get out of my way, Catra!” She-Ra shouted, charging for her. Catra ran for her, clearing the distance in seconds. Her agility and speed was unmatched, her movements fluid and as graceful as a dancer.

“So predictable.” Catra scoffed, leaping high and then chopping down with her foot on top of the drone. Knocking it out of She-Ra's grasp. It bounced away a few feet, rolling to a stop just in the mouth of the alley.

She-Ra had swung her sword wide, not wanting to hit her, just keep her at bay. So she could evade any more of her attacks and

retrieve the drone.

“Stop playing around Catra, we got no time for this!” She-Ra shouted in exasperation. When Catra barely landed on her toes before jumping to the side to avoid the sword and then rebounding off the alley wall. Deflecting the blade by leaping on top of the tip and using her weight to kick it into the ground. Catra laughed with amusement, as she somersaulted over Adora’s head. Landing lightly a few feet away on a narrow pipe. That ran the length of the alley wall a few feet above She-Ra's head. Then she ran the length of the pipe, back flipped off, landing back at the mouth of the alley. She nudged the drone with the tip of a toe claw. She was playing with She-Ra, taunting and teasing her in the same flippant manner she had during the war.
“I don't know, a good game of keep away sounds like fun to me.” Catra gave her a sly, satisfied grin, kicking the drone up with a foot and catching it.

“Give it back, Catra!” She-Ra exclaimed, pulling the sword out of the ground, sheathing it upon her back. As she rushed the cat at a full sprint, shoulders down, arms wide wanting to tackle her.

Catra merely grinned triumphantly, then turned around and ran. Laughing gleefully from the alley, drone in hand.
“If you want it, come get it!” Catra taunted, leaping up onto another metal pipe of a nearby building. Bounding up onto an adjacent larger pipe, making her way up to the domed roof of a chemical container. The plant stretched out around her, in several rows of domes and tall metal silos. Leading away towards the towering industrial complex of the Fright Zones Refinery in the distance.

Glancing down from the narrow ledge of the arching roof, keeping track of She-Ra as she ran and leaped from one massive container to the next. Until she reached the end of the chemical plant, leaping over a chain link fence and darting across the paved street. Disappearing into an alley, her ears swiveling as she kept track of She-Ra’s thundering pace, as she chased after her. Leading the mighty warrior into the labyrinth of narrow alleys that

separated several blocks of huge warehouses within a fenced off supply yard. Turning sharply as she reached the end of an alley, leaping onto the hood of a cargo hauler and then up to the cab, continuing her climb to the bulky storage compartment that dominated the back of the vehicle. She surveyed her surroundings briefly, staying low. Her chest heaving for breath, cheeks flushed, grinning ear to ear with the exhilaration of the chase. Ears flickering and then raising upward, as she picked up the clipped sounds of She-Ra's boots before she rushed out of the alley. Catra giggled then turned and leaped up to the fire escape that was set alongside the building. Just as She-Ra lunged straight at her. Her powerful arm pulled back, one of her huge fists raised, ready to smash Catra's only means of escape.

Catra screamed with glee, leaping from the railing. As She-Ra seemed to miss her target, punching the outer wall beside the fire escape. The metal screamed and buckled, as the brick and mortar exploded. The fire escape unmoored from the wall with a rending groan. The lower half of the winding staircase dangling in the air. But it did not slow Catra down, as she sunk the claws of one hand into the metal lip of the roof and scrambled up with the Drone under her arm. Dashing out of view, on the flat roof with a taunting cackle. She-Ra landed hard on the cement below, growled in frustration then ran down the alley she had just come out of. Casting her eyes towards the roof tops, following Catra. As she dashed across the roofs, leaping from warehouse to warehouse.

"Even as the All powerful She-Ra! You can't catch me?" Catra teased, as she vaulted over the alley above She-Ra's head.

She leaned down over the edge of the rooftop.

"That's just sad…" She crooned. Thrusting out her lower lip in a condescending pout. Before dashing out of view, on the warehouse roof. Laughing and taunting her with more snarky, smartass remarks. Acting as if she found evading She-Ra an effortless task. Knowing Adora was fiercely competitive and it would drive her to her breaking point.

She-Ra ground her teeth and shouted back in frustration, as she was forced to keep chasing her.

Finally, She-Ra got a little ahead when Catra got side tracked by a massive, rooftop water tank blocking her path. The feline was blinded for a few minutes. Giving She-Ra a brief advantage. She-Ra leaped up onto the lower roof top, of the partially destroyed warehouse next door. Finally cutting off Catras retreat. Who had just managed to navigate around the tank jumping blindly to the next roof. Only to find a very enraged She-Ra standing in front of her ready to tackle her. Catra was forced to skid and back petal suddenly, her eyes wide with surprise.

"I got you now, give up Catra!" She-Ra demanded, keeping her stance wide and loose so she could block Catra's attempt to evade her. Believing she would try and duck under her arms or side step around her to continue the chase.

“I thought you would be more of a challenge? You’re still as slow as ever.” Catra taunted, deftly back stepping to stay out of She-Ra's range. Doing the exact opposite of what Adora believed she would do. The mighty warrior swung her large fists, screaming in frustration and rage. While Catra kept a good eye on those huge fists, if one connected she would be out cold.

She-Ra kicked a loose stone at her, Catra raised an arm and deflected it.

“You're still way too overconfident and not watching your surroundings.” She-Ra smiled smugly, pointing behind her.

Catra glanced behind her, just as her foot lost its hold on solid ground. A huge hole had been blasted out of this building and she had nearly stepped into nothing.

“This works, for me though.” Catra stated sassily, digging the claws of her feet into the cement edge. Then jumped upward arching her back into a twisting flip, tossing the drone down into the hole as she sailed over to the other side. It fell into the dark

interior with a low whistle. Catra landed smoothly on the other side of the hole, sticking her tongue out at She-Ra playfully.

“Catra!” She-Ra roared, leaping over the hole. Her arms were stretched out wide, in an attempt to grapple the wily cat to the ground. She was too caught up in the battle now, to just give in and jump after the drone. She needed to win!

Catra jumped straight up, but She-Ra was faster, she grabbed her ankle and swung her down. Catra squeezed her eyes shut tight but the hard strike to the rooftop never came. Instead she found herself dangling upside down in front of She-Ra's angry face as the warrior held her aloft. The mighty warrior's chest was heaving, sweat beaded along her forehead, rolling down her temples and across her flushed cheeks. Her blue eyes were glowing, glaring at her with a heated fury. The intensity of the magic flowing within her, hummed like a live wire. She would have made a very terrifying sight, if not for the smug, self satisfied smile.

“Gottcha!” She-Ra declared, triumphantly.

“Talk to me.” Catra stared at her sternly, folding her arms over her chest stubbornly.

She-Ra glowered at her for a moment, panting for breath, before her expression softened into a worried frown.

“I'm not ready to do this all again...” She moaned, as her transformation broke in a flash of light. Leaving a very distraught Adora behind.

Catra squealed in fright, at the sudden height difference between She-Ra and Adora. Who was now the one holding her aloft. Adora was much shorter. Catra’s face had been near She-Ra’s stomach, now she had her face pressed up against Adora's crotch. Catra moaned in both arousal and embarrassment, her hands braced on Adora's hips. Valiantly trying to keep her face from brushing against Adora’s sex. Adora cried out in shock and humiliation,

blushing and promptly dropped Catra. Who landed squarely on her back, blushing a deep crimson.

“You could at least give a girl some flower's first.” Catra teased, smiling fondly up at her. Trying valiantly to ease the embarrassment between them.

“I'm not ready for that either!” Adora stomped her foot petulantly and stormed away, her cheeks flushed.

“Adora...come on...talk to me?” Catra rolled onto her stomach then leaped up, charging after Adora as she headed to the emergency stairwell attached to the far side of the building. Intent on retrieving the drone. Adora scrubbed her hands down her face as she jogged down the stairwell.

“I was just really hoping for peace...I was looking forward to just being able to live for a while without worrying about the end of the world. I wanted nice and I wanted normal!” Adora shouted, as Catra bounded down the railings. Crouching on the platform a level below her, watching her jog down the stairs, the hard soles of her leather boots ringing off the metal.

“But now I've broken all the princesses' Rune Stones and they can no longer use their powers. I'm worried that I've caused even more damage to Etheria with the Fail Safe, then we know. This is all my fault! I trusted Shadow Weaver! Which as always was a mistake! I knew nothing about the Fail Safe....I was desperate and had no other options.” She growled as she jogged down the stairs.

Catra blew air up into her dark bangs, her heart was still hammering in her chest. That fight had gotten her blood pumping and she was just starting to come down off that adrenaline high.

“I got invader's kidnapping my people....nearly kidnapping me!” Adora ranted into Catras face, as she jogged by her on the small platform. Taking to the stairs and heading down to the next floor. Catra smiled happily, now they were getting somewhere. She

turned and walked along the rail, kicking her legs out playfully as she balanced. Then jumped down to the railing on the next floor. Landing on the railing below on all fours, with a resounding clang.

“The Horde are being persecuted! How do I fix their relations with the rest of Etheria? We've got thousands of disconnected clones running around the planet. If our first night camping out by Prime’s Magic Syphoning Drill....thing... was any indication of their mental well being. Listening to them cry and bemoan their existence. They are feeling confused, lost and completely alone out there. And if we don't give them all a purpose...like what Hordak and Entrapta did. Then they are going to become angry and afraid instead...then I'm going to be dealing with all that! Whatever that turns out to be...” Adora growled, curling her fingers over her ears in complete exasperation.

“I wish you would get over this hero complex, Adora. Saving everyone is not your problem. Perhaps this time, you can take a step back and let others try and solve a few problems. Sometimes you need to just let people figure things out for themselves.” Catra sighed, watching sadly as Adora stormed by.

Adora turned and flashed her an accusing glare, “Stop talking so callously, like you don't care, when I know damn well you do! Wrong Hordak was like a frightened child after he got disconnected.! He felt confused, abandoned and then betrayed by Horde Prime. It took us months of patience, positive reinforcement, near constant instruction on how to function as an individual. To get him comfortable with himself. We have like thousands upon thousands of Wrong Hordaks, just running wild and free all over Etheria!..."Adora took a quick breath, then stared Catra down. " And how well did that work for you? Being alone? Not having anyone to help you deal with things?” She finished, her blue eyes burning with frustration and pain.

Catra squeezed her eyes shut and raked a hand down her short hair in frustration. Fighting to keep her calm resolve and not get angry with Adora. She could be so self righteous, Catra rolled her

eyes begrudgingly, but she was right. She had pushed everyone away. Figuring she was strong enough to get by on her own. Too scared and to hurt to let anyone in ever again. It had left her lonely and fatally depressed. She had needed friends, needed Adora. Who had asked several times for her to defect and join her. But she had been too stubborn, resentful and angry to comply. Now she had far too many regrets. When she opened her eyes, she watched Adora jog down another flight of steps. So she leaped down to the next railing.

“The Kingdoms haven't even started to rebuild from our last intergalactic invasion! We are not ready to defend ourselves against another enemy! I'm really, really scared. Catra! That this time I may not be strong enough to protect everyone.” She swallowed several times, as tears threatened. Staring at Catra for several moments looking so very uncertain and vulnerable.

“Adora...” Catra reached out for her, wanting to draw her in and comfort her. But Adora batted her arms away, still to emotionally raw to accept affection. She turned on her heel, heading for the next set of stairs.

“And my girlfriend is suddenly a princess!” She railed, casting her head to the sky and screaming in frustration.

“That’s a bad thing....really.” Catra offered with a disbelieving shrug. “Me...being a princess?” Her voice was soft, almost fearful. As she swung down to the railing below. Landing lightly on her feet, she crouched, waiting for Adora to catch up.

“No...it's not.” Adora admitted with a long drawn out sigh. Stopping in front of Catra with a resigned smile, pressing her forehead up against Catra's. As she placed both hands reassuringly on Catra's cheeks.

“It just complicates things. Like being here...in the Fright Zone. Having to deal with all the baggage this place has. Last night was scary...and life altering...and so very, very sad.” She bowed her head, tears now falling. “I am so sorry about your parents. About

what happened to you. It's all so unfair...and you must have so many questions and I don't know how to help you. I was completely useless last night! You needed me and I couldn't be there for you...in the way you needed....but Scorpia...Stars! Catra...she was amazing last night...she knew exactly how to handle you...calm you down...comfort you...” Adora was rambling now, her hands trembling and waving franticly as she verbally vomited all her feelings of being inadequate.

“Adora...I don't know yet how I got into that pod. But I am grateful it happened, because it allowed me to meet you.” Catra offered, guiding Adora's chin up with a hand. "Scorpia is a good friend...I appreciate what she did for me. But Adora...your everything to me..." She whispered, reverently, pressing a sweet kiss to her mouth. Seeking to alleviate Adora's doubts and her feelings of failure. Adora leaned in for a moment and enjoyed the intimacy. Basking in the reassurance and tender feelings swelling inside her heart.

“I needed that.” She whispered gratefully against Catra's lips. Who grinned foolishly, showing her fangs. As quickly as the soft moment came it was gone. Adora still had more to purge and Catra knew it. Could see it in the angry shimmer of her eyes and trembling of her lips. She drew away, giving Adora space to finish venting.

Adora huffed, scrubbing a hand down her face and walked on.

“I just want everything to stop! I need a break! Can the universe just give me time to catch my breath before throwing another world destroying Despot my way!” Adora growled, as she thundered down the last set of stairs to the ground.

“I've completely lost control of my life....again! Being a First One is a real pain in the ass!” She screamed at the top of her lungs then hung her head in sad resignation.

Catra smirked and leaped to the ground. “This is progress, we are really getting somewhere.” Catra quiped happily, placing a

comforting hand on Adora's shoulder as she walked up to her.
“Feel better?” Catra asked, proudly.

“Your sharing session is next, Princess.” Adora passed her a grim, sideways glance.
“Right.” Catra laughed. “Well, I've got a whole lot of crazy to share. But I'll tell you all about it when we are heading to Mystacor. Entrapta and Scorpia need to know too. Let's get that drone to Entrapta and finish things up here.” Catra walked briskly towards the broken, partially caved in wall of the warehouse. Just as an odd beeping sound struck her ears. Catra stopped at the threshold of the hole in the outer wall, her heart leaping into her throat. She had no time to react as the thunderous roar and incredible heat exploded from inside. The wall was incinerated, as it was engulfed in a vortex of flame and acrid smoke. Catra was airborne and barely conscious after the concussion of the blast hit her.

“Catra!” Adora screamed, shielding her face with an arm, watching in horror as Catra was sent into the air. Soaring over the warehouse buildings across the street, falling into the storage yard of the Chemical plant on the other side. Adora raced after her, bolting out of the alley and charging down the street. As Catra's limp body disappeared behind a set of smooth, steel tower silos. Flying several more yards, striking a pile of random pieces of industrial scrap left to rust. Then her body slammed into the unforgiving cement ground of the small junkyard she landed into. She hit hard and then rolled, lying prone on her back, groaning and struggling to breathe.

That explosion had hit her as suddenly and as brutally as Scorpia's lightning. Every part of her body was vibrating, a deep burning pain throbbed under her skin. Her ears were ringing and she was far too dizzy to try and stand up. So she just laid there, staring up at the clear sky and mulled over the last few days. Wishing for that break Adora had been dreaming about after defeating Horde Prime. A normal, war free life...that would be so wonderful. Then everything went dark as she lost consciousness.

In the darkness of her dream, Catra could see a flickering light. It shone in the distance, burning with a

familiar warmth. She wished to get closer, as it grew in brilliance. She squinted against it's growing light, as the hollow voices of her people filled with memory echoed in a chant.

Eternia...who once smiled at us with promises of protection, of peaceful co-existence. All while they colonized our lands gutted our planet and enslaved our magic…

They betrayed our trust...Sowed the seeds of rebellion.

It began with the raids, they stole our children, our mothers...our fathers.

Traitors...Rebels...enemies to all those loyal to the First Ones and their agenda.

The war drums thundered over the Savannah. The fire of revolution raged until all was reduced to ash.

Until there was nothing left but silence.

Then Senator Keldor was free to do as he pleased with our lands, with our magic...

The next year flowed over her dreamscape in brief, violent scenes of skirmishes on the golden plains between her people and the Eternian's military. The heavily armored Eternian forces, with their high tech war machines, made quick work of the feline rebels. Who's weapons, of swords or bows and arrows were severely outmatched. Ouroboros came to the Sunna's defense and wiped out the Eternian's army in a fiery blast that burned most of the savannah to ash.

Senator Keldor's plans to wipe out the resistance that had now spread to the four prides. Became more subtle, sending assassins to murder anyone who sought to speak against his plans. Raiding the villages and farms, stealing whole families that were involved with the rebellion. Until there was no one to oppose his plans.

The cold season came and went, returning to warmer days with a tragic finality for her people. The evening sky was blood red, as the last of the sun's rays disappeared beneath the stone monolith. The moons rose, their satellites drifting through the dark blanket of night as the stars began to shimmer. A furious howl rose from the lone stone formation in the middle of the plains. It's roar vibrated with malice, the very land itself shivered with fear as Ouroboros magic built. The great fiery wyrm flew from their lair in a fury of writhing fire and blazing vengeance. Its magic was a living flame upon the length of their body that allowed them to fly. As they slithered upon the wind itself. As soon as the Eternian's had erected the pillar and set their Rune Stone device on top. The great wrym had attacked, shattering the Rune Stone and burning the courtyard to the ground in their fury. Ouroboros wrath had been quick and merciless. With the Sun Stone destroyed, their people's magic would not be stolen and stored inside it's core. Thwarting Senator Keldor's plans to kill Aoi and steal the Fire magic. Link it to the First's Ones chosen Rune Bearer, their Fire princess. The Planet could never be balanced properly. All of Senator Keldor's work was now forfeit.

Then Ouroboros had taken its vengeance out on the First Ones beacon in the ancient Oasis beyond the stone monolith. He bathed it in a swirling vortex of flame from his maw, shattering it's defensive shield. Melting it’s outer walls in another blast of pure, elemental flame. That was as brutal and intense as the sun itself. The lake that surrounded the beacon evaporated and the trees were incinerated instantly.

A dozen star fighter's shot out from small hanger's in the now severely damaged obelisk. Sleek, arrow shaped craft that screamed and roared as they sought to out manoeuvre the great serpent in the night sky. The Guardian of Fire had exhausted

themselves, destroying the Sun Stone and then rendering the Eternian beacon useless. Their movements had slowed and their flame was sputtering. They could no longer evade the airstrikes. Laser's flared from the sharp noses of the fighters, was quick to slice into the Serpents flesh. They roared in agony, as the barrage of energy fire laid siege to their crippled body. Searing their eyes and eventually piercing their heart. Their mighty flame flickered and then faded away from their scales, as they crashed into the summit of the stone monolith below. They struck with such force. The crater they created upon their death, broke the massive stone in two. The devastated land shivered with the tremors of their impact.

Aoi had mourned Ouroboros Cursing the Eternians, Senator Keldor, She-Ra and the war. Her homeland was destroyed and her people were slaughtered all in a span of two seasons. Saladin had taken her and Kaira into hiding months earlier. The Rebels had warned him of Keldor's plans to kill Aoi and Kaira, so that the magic would have no where to hide. So he could force the Sunna's fire magic into a vessel of his own choosing. They had bounty on their heads now and n owhere was safe. Eternian soldiers, mercenaries, even off world bounty hunters were now after them. They ran from village to city, never staying long in one place. Eventually hiding in the Whispering Woods, able to remain hidden in it's very heart. Saladin had built them a home, from the bounty of the forest. Constructing a small hut built of cured hide, thatch and logs. The Rune Bearer of Fate, a moth hybrid from Elboron. Had been led to their home by the voice of the trees, late in the evening just as the warm season had set in. Etheria had given him a message for only Aoi' and Saladin's ears. Once huddled around the central fire, sharing the evening meal he gave Etheria's prophecy a voice.

'The two shall come,

one sleeping, lost to time

one stolen, lost to space.

Child of Time, Child of Space.

Each born of magic, given form through blood and bone.

One shall walk Etheria, upon the dawn.

The other shall greet the twilight.

Both reaching for and sheltered by each other.

They shall ascend upon the final day, becoming part of the stars.

To usher in a new beginning. Each gives sustenance to the other.

Space offers dreams of life-Eternity in Death.

Time offers the soul salvation-strength in the weft, elegance in the weave.

A tapestry made whole, so shall be one to the other.'

The prophecy made little sense, but they followed the Rune Bearer of Fate. Aoi couldn't help but feel a kinship with him, since she was the Rune Bearer of Fire. So they put their trust in him and his connection to Etheria. Having faith that the true Heart of Etheria. Had a Destiny for little Kaira far grander and more merciful, than what lay before them now in their mortal lives. The Rune Bearer of Fate would lead them across the plains of Thaymor into the sprawling kingdom of Scorpania. In the end they could not outrun the war or those hunting them. The Rune Bearer of Fate's final act was to bestow upon them a stasis pod. He had stolen from an Eternian Snakeman, who was trafficking Etherian's off world from the Scorpania Crown City. He commanded them to hide in the granite caves of Scorpiana's mountain range known as

the Stingers. There they waited and prepared for their final battle. Etheria was dying and rumors of Horde Prime purging the planet as he did on Krytis were mounting. Kaira was the heir to their people's magic and they knew Senator Keldor wanted revenge. They were out of options, trusting in the words of the Rune Bearer of Fate. They placed little Kaira who was still a tiny kitten, into that stasis pod. Then Aoi and Saladin awaited their fate, killing all who had managed to follow them so deep into the bowels of these treacherous caves.

Within the year all Sunna would become extinct upon Etheria, as the ultimate punishment for their betrayal. What remained of her people now scattered to the stars, their descendants never to know their homeland. The Savannah was unable to heal from the ravages of war and the devastation of Ouroboros's wrath. Becoming a barren wasteland in which nothing fertile remained. Mara's resistance grew beyond Etheria as she turned against her people. Refusing to become their weapon she had crashed her space ship into the Serenia Waste and stranded the planet with the last of her ships power in the Shadow Dimension of Despondos. So that the weapon could never be used and broke the She-Ra line for a thousand years.

The dreamscape faded away, into a quiet misty place, specks of pure magic floated like fireflies. Catra was in a realm beyond reality in which only magic lived. The living world still existed but it was muted just beyond the veil of mist. In this place between, an ethereal silenced reigned supreme. Catra found herself standing within the purest form of Etheria itself.

The true Heart of Etheria...

"Where am I?" Catra muttered softly, too scared to move, barely able to breath. She merely stood still, her eyes darting around in panic.
(Be at peace Wildling.) *A familiar, deep voice laughed.*
"Ouroboros?" Catra called, taking a step forward reluctantly. She

could barely see, the hazy clouds were billowing all around her like a heavy fog. Then a fiery illumination fluttered just beyond her fingertips.

Catra reached out and grasped the orange ribbon of light. Suddenly a soothing warmth washed over her, the panic and fear faded away.

(I have witnessed the death of one world and I will not stand by and allow it to happen again.) *The Serpents voice resounded in her head.*

"What do you mean?" Catra whispered reverently, clutching the ribbon close to her heart as its magic hummed against her chest.

(I did not know you still lived, until I felt your spirit within the Eternal weave of She-Ra's Magic…) *Their voice was low, full of hope and awe.*

Catra sucked in a breath, wondering how much the Guardian of Fire had seen or felt at that time. Being in that Eternian constructed...Heart of Etheria. Had been the most tragic, heart wrenching time of her life. She had never fought so hard, never cried so much, her heart had been shattered completely and then been reborn. When she had finally found the courage to say all the things she had kept hidden for years. Professed her love for Adora and been gifted with her love in return. When they had kissed, she had felt an incredible burst of magic flow from Adora and into her. She was quickly swept away by the swell of love passing between them. Was that when Ouroboros had sensed her? When Adora finally transformed into She-Ra and released all the magic of the Heart. She blushed and ducked her head. Suddenly overwhelmed by embarrassment, as if some great secret had been revealed.

"You saw us kiss?" Catra muttered softly, her whole face felt like it was on fire.

(Yes…, Wildling. I felt your spirit, when She-Ra's magic flowed with your own.) *Ouroboros laughed, answering her unspoken question as if reading her mind.* ***(You Etherian's are so emotional…please be at peace. Your love for her is pure and nothing to be embarrassed about.)*** *They finished, filling her with warmth and comfort.*

"I had magic then?" Catra was astonished. "I could have used it!" She growled, with agitation at the glowing ribbon in her hand. She had been in some really nasty pinches over the years. Being able to send pillars of flame at Horde Prime would have been really useful and sooo very satisfying.

(Even after everything I did to stop it…the Eternian Heart still stole our magic, Wildling. It still managed to absorb it in the course of a thousand years, until that thread of magic was no more. Sealed away within their artificial Heart. In the time of your awakening, when the First One released you from your prison. I had none to offer you, until She-Ra destroyed that fake heart and released all the magic it had stolen.) *They offered with remorse.* ***(The Eternian's tried to control our magic, weaponize it.)*** *Their voice rumbled,* ***(In the end I could not stop it.)***

"The tech running threw the planet, the Rune Stones…The Heart…" Catra nodded.

(There are thirteen threads of magic woven into the living heart of this planet.) *Ouroboros began, their voice soft and modulated. They were a teacher and this came naturally to them.*

Catra caught sight of thirteen streams of magic, floating amid the mist and fog. She could not grasp the other flows of magic and did not try. They were not calling to her, as this one of fire did.

(The greater elements of Fire, Water, Earth, Ice, Light, Wind. Then the lesser elements of Binding, Magnetism,

Dream and Foresight. Finally the most powerful of all the elements, the deep magic of Time, Life and Death.)

Catra watched as the ribbons twisted around each other forming elegant knots, in the middle where all the knots intersected it glowed with the same incredible power as She-Ra.

(The She-Ra, is chosen by the Planetary Heart itself.) *Ouroboros' voice was full of hope and reverence.*

"What is that?" Catra asked, pointing to the knot with three intersecting knots. Some of the interwoven knots of magic looked exactly like the knot woven into her baby blanket. Others she did not recognize but knew they must have a meaning, also.

(It is the Triquetra.) *Ouroboros voice was low and full of love.* ***(It is the oldest symbol of the Sunna People. It means eternal love, strength and family unity.)***

Catra swallowed the lump of grief now forming in her throat. The longing to have known her parents burning in her chest.

"I never knew them....but I miss them." She whispered brokenly, tears streaming down her face. Ouroboros's magic wrapped around her, soothing her with their warmth. Then visions of growing up with Adora flooded her mind. All the precious moments of her kindness, her silly antics and goofy smiles that made her happy. The small touches of affection, of comfort, they hid from Shadow Weaver as they grew up. All the dear memories she kept close to her heart. She missed her parents but ultimately she had known the unconditional love of a family. She had had Adora...

(That is why I asked the Immortal to guide you to me.) *Ouroboros stated,* ***(So that you may know them, know your own people and begin to honor your true self.)***

"What are you?" Catra asked, when she had regained her composure.

(I am known as the Guardian of Fire, an Elemental Wyrm who is in tune with an aspect of Etheria's magic. It is my responsibility to train a Rune Bearer, who will in turn teach her people. How to use that elemental magic for the benefit of all Etherians. Every one born on Etheria is destined to weld a part of its magic. Not just the select few sorcerers and sorceresses, or Princesses the First Ones choose to carry on the magic. The Eternian disrupted the natural order of our planet's magic. It is now time for all Etherian's to reclaim what they have taken away. The old world is gone, but thanks to She-Ra you have been given the power to create a new world. I wish for you to go forth into this future, with your head held high and love for all of Etheria in your heart. For you are a part of the whole and you are never alone. Always walk towards the sun, Wildling. And let your shadows fall behind you.)
The Guardian's parting words echoed in her mind. Like an eternal song of hope...

Catra could feel the moisture, trailing down her cheeks. This last dream had been the most painful to endure. Knowing that her people were lost in the war, that her parents had died protecting her. Then Catra felt a hand resting on her shoulder and slowly opened her eyes. It was Adora, in the dim light of twilight, she could see the blonde was kneeling beside her. The love and empathy in her beautiful blue eyes, drawing her back from the sad memories of her past. Melog was curled up beside her, leaning their bulk heavily against her legs. Reassuring her with their presence that she was safe.
"I am getting really tired of being blown up." Catra stated groggily, rubbing the last of her tears away with the heel of her hands, then attempting to sit up. Melog growled and shifted, setting two huge paws on her legs to force her to rest. They felt guilty for not getting to her in time.

Catra reached down and gave Melog a scratch behind the ears. Partially sitting up, as she leaned back on her elbow. Silently offering them reassurance with a genuine, if weak smile.

“You weren't hurt. So I brought you back to the hanger, but you've been unconscious for hours.” Adora's voice was gentle, sounding worried and tired.

Catra could feel the hum of an engine vibrating beneath her body. Glancing around she found Scorpia, at the rudder of a Skiff wearing her matching leather cut off vest from the Crimson Waste. She gave Catra a curt glance with a warm smile. The vest was a silent statement of loyalty towards her that made her smile.

“So glad you're ok, Wild Cat.” She spoke. Her voice, soft and relieved. “You sure like giving me a scare.” She laughed dryly and shook her head, as she briefly remembered all their close calls in battle during the war. Before returning her attention to steering.

“Oh, you're awake. Good.” Entrapta's voice was bright and hopeful as she settled down on the other side of Catra. Wrapping her hair beneath her butt like a cushion, tapping on a data pad with one gloved hand. “We were able to finish up while you were sleeping, we left the animals for a later date.” Entrapta gave Adora a concerned look. Catra shifted her gaze back to Adora with a knowing smile.

“You fell asleep on a container, didn't you?” She commented, with a dry, unimpressed tone.

“Fainted...really.” Entrapta offered. “Dropped like a bot without a power cell.” Entrapta pressed on in case it wasn't clear.

“After releasing the last Etherian, yeah.” Adora admitted proudly but with a guilty frown.

“Let me guess, you've gone without sleep, or food or water for almost two days now?” Catra chastised, finally sitting up and

shoving Melog impatiently off her legs. Confronting a very ashamed Adora with a stern, reproachful glare.

“Why do you do this to yourself?” Catra grasped Adora's chin and forced her to look up. “You continually push yourself past the breaking point...it's not healthy.”

“I don't know, I just get focused on the task and I want to finish. I just ignore everything else...until..” Adora sighed and rolled her eyes. Pulling up her knees and resting her chin on them, offering Catra a sad pout. Knowing the feline woman wouldn't be able to be mad at her, if she acted all cute and chastised already.

“Scorpia took care of her, Catra.” Entrapta placed a comforting hand on her shoulder. As Catra was still glowering down at her sulking girlfriend. Catra passed Scorpia a thankful smile. Scorpia gave Catra a brief nod and smiled back in response. It spoke wordlessly that she would always have Catras back.

“I loaded a skiff with supplies, got your packs and then brought you aboard. While Scorpia got Adora some food and something to drink. Right now we're headed to Mystacor, I think we are still a couple hours out of Plumeria if you want to share...your bit of crazy?” Entrapta coaxed with a wide, eager smile. Wiggling her eyebrows up and down meaningfully.

Catra laughed and nodded.

“I've been having some really vivid dreams.” She began, taking a deep breath as Adora got comfortable beside her. Clasping Catra's hands and urging her silently to stay strong, sharing was one of the hardest things for Catra. But she needed to let go of all that negative thinking, that she could not trust other people, that they were just out to use her, manipulate her, make fun of her. She was finally around people who truly cared about her and had her best interests at heart. Catra offered her a warm, trusting smile and squared her shoulders as she took a deep breath.
“I realized today that they are more than just dreams...somehow..” She pushed on with her story. “I was born

around this time of year, over a thousand years ago, my name then was Kaira." Adora, Entrapta and Scorpia listened avidly as she spoke of the plains where she was born. Describing with loving detail how her people, the Sunna, thrived on that golden grassland. She spoke fondly of her parents and how they had all been swept up in the war a thousand years ago. She stared right at Adora as she spoke of Mara and how she had once tried to convince her people to join the Heart of Etheria project and then how she had rebelled against her own people when she found out the truth. How her rebellion against the First Ones had gone beyond Etheria, to many other worlds.

Adora squeezed her hands seeking to comfort her, as tears began to pool in her eyes. As she spoke of Ouroboros and their wrath, the destruction of her homeland and being forced into that stasis pod as a baby by her own parents. They had felt like they had had no choice, they did not want Senator Keldor to get a hold of her. It had been the only way to keep her safe and out of his hands. They had put their trust into a Prophecy, given to the Rune Bearer of Fate. That she would not die inside that metal coffin, but be awoken far in the future. It had been the hardest, most terrifying thing her parents had ever done.

Catra's last memory of them was of her mother kissing her forehead, tears streaming down her face. As her father tucked her into the pod with her blanket, as if putting her to bed for the night. As the hatch pulled closed, the hiss of the lid locking in place, she was suddenly overcome with exhaustion. Too young to understand why her parents were so upset, crying silently down at her from beyond the glass. She closed her heavy eyes and fell into that timeless sleep to await her savior….

Tears were once more streaming down her cheeks, as Adora pulled her into her arms. Holding her close as she sobbed brokenly against her shoulder. Tucking her face away into the crook of her neck, seeking to hide her sorrow. Adora was rubbing her back in small soothing circles, kissing her temples and whispering soft words of gratitude, comfort and reassurance. Knowing how difficult and scary this was. Bearing her heart,

allowing them to witness her misery. It was a huge step for Catra. To be open and vulnerable like this, to trust….she had grown so much in the last few seasons.

When she calmed down enough to go on, she slowly pulled away from Adora to continue her tale.

“A woman made of light, with wings has been guiding me in my dreams?” Catra finished, staring at Adora with worry. “She talks to me, comforts me...wants me to let go of the past...to heal and find my true self.”

Adora looked at her with confusion at first.

“She was the one who first took me back to the Sunna people...to the past.” Catra muttered, giving Adora's hands a squeeze. Searching her soft blue eyes for answers or perhaps confirmation of what she felt, she had already figured out.

“Catra...” Adora breathed, her eyes flying wide in shock.

“She looks like the woman in the mural back in the War Room in Bright Moon.” Catra breathed out in a rush. They had spent only one night in Bright Moon before heading out to Dryl. She had been given a small tour, slept in Adora’s huge...overly opulent bedroom. With Finn curled up on a nest of blankets and pillows in the corner. As awe struck and uncertain of the luxury that surrounded him, as she was. It had given Catra enough time to understand what Adora’s life had been like during their three years apart. How vastly different their lives had been. It had been a sobering experience, knowing what she had given up by staying with the Horde.

“Queen Angela...” Adora gasped.

Catra nodded. “I think she is still alive?”

“She sacrificed herself to collapse the portal. She is an Immortal so it might be possible.” Adora offered, her mind running wild with hope and fear.

“She might not be dead, but trapped between time and space.” Entrapta theorized, tapping furiously on her pad. Creating a schematic of the collapsed portal from years ago.

“Can we get her out of there?” Catra was suddenly hopeful, letting go of Adora's hands and kneeling beside Entrapta looking eagerly at her screen.

“No.” Entrapta stated bluntly, scratching the bridge of her nose nervously. As the data proved that it would be impossible without tearing their own dimension apart.

“What, why!” Catra shouted, jumping to her feet. “It's my fault she's in there! There has got to be a way...” She rose to her feet and started pacing. Scrubbing a hand violently threw her short hair, her eyes stricken and darting frantically about the deck of the skiff. Her heart was beating hard in her chest and she was having a hard time breathing, again.

“Catra?” Adora was on her feet, grasping Catra's hands and seeking to calm her down.

Entrapta swallowed, sensing how upset Catra had gotten. She bit her lower lip and tapped more on her screen. “I'll look into it more, ok...” She offered softly, giving Catra a hopeful smile.

“Thank you.” Catra sighed, as relief washed over her. With Entrapta on the job, there was still hope.

“How did you know about Queen Angela and what happened with the portal?” Adora asked quietly.

“The Horde got intel that the Queen was missing just after the Portal was sealed. But I didn't know why, at first.” Catra sighed, heavily. “Sparkles and I used to have a lot of talks on Horde Primes ship. I used to visit her when she was in her cell. We had a

lot of time to hash it all out. She let me know then what I had taken from her.” Catra explained bitterly, then walked to the bow of the skiff and sat down needing to be alone with her thoughts.

Adora gave her some space, sensing she needed some time. When Melog padded towards her, Adora followed. Trusting that the cat knew when Catra was ready to be with people again.

Adora sat down, licking her bottom lip nervously. Glancing over to Catra, finding her staring off towards the shadow of the forest rushing past the Skiff. They were flying just on the outskirts of the Thaymor plains soon they would be inside the Whispering Woods within the Kingdom of Plumeria. Catra's eyes were clouded with troubled thoughts, she never noticed Adora joining her at first.

“Hey.” Adora leaned over and bumped her shoulder against Catra's.

“Hey.” Catra responded, bumping her shoulder back. Passing her a sad, if wistful smile.

“So, your real name is Kaira?” Adora smiled softly.

“Yeah.” Catra laughed, lightly. The sound was weak and airy, as if admitting to a long held secret.

“I guess when I asked you what your name was, after I released you from that pod. I must have thought you said Catra?” Adora laughed lightly at her childish mistake.

“Well, I was just a baby kitten.” Catra shrugged. “I hadn't even grown into my fangs yet. I doubt I was speaking clearly, if at all.” She chuckled, blushing shyly.

“Would you rather I call you Kaira?” Adora asked, glancing at her bashfully.

“No.” Catra smiled fondly, “I have no, real clear memories of ever being Kaira. The name has no meaning. I cherish the name you gave me, Adora. I prefer Catra.”

“Ok.” Adora's pleased grin was breathtaking. So earnest and full of love. Her blue eyes shimmered proudly as she gazed at Catra. Catra couldn't help but smile back just as brightly, before sighing and leaning her head heavily against Adora's shoulder. Her eyes lowered as she drew inward, with a pensive frown.

“It's hard...finally knowing what I had lost. When I was a kid, I never thought of them...my parents. Too busy growing up I guess and I had you.” She offered her a small nostalgic smile, as she lightly brushed her fingers across Adora's hand that was resting between them on the floor of the skiff.

“I get that, I never thought about my parents till Light Hope told me, I was taken through a portal...” Adora's voice drifted off as her eyes welled up with tears.

“Eternia...” Adora breathed, then raised her head up, no longer lost to her thoughts and confronted Catra. “I want to know where I came from too.”

Catra blinked, suddenly very overwhelmed. She released a held breath, curling her fingers around Adora's hand protectively. Suddenly very scared that she might lose her. To some crazy quest to find Eternia and her family.

“Hordak's closing the portals...if there even are anymore?” Adora began to mutter to herself, her heart was racing and an anxious lump had formed in her throat. She felt like she might be losing her chance to find out where she came from. Scrambling to her feet she dashed back to Entrapta.

“Adora!” Catra called, as panic set in. She couldn't lose her to some fools errand. She couldn't go to Eternia...could she?

Entrapta raised her head from her data pad as Adora's stricken face appeared over the top of her screen.

“Has Hordak found any more working portals?” She asked.

“Uhm....he hasn't reported back...it's barely been a day?” Entrapta stated, her brow wrinkled with confusion.

“I want to know...if the clones find any portals...I need to know. I don't want them to close them all, anymore.” Adora demanded.

“Ok.” Entrapta nodded, "I shall relay the change of plans to Hordak." She commented, quickly activating a communication link to the Sky Tree. As Adora took a deep settling breath and returned to Catra’s side.

“Ok, what was that all about?” Catra asked, her expression both concerned and perplexed.

“I had to talk to Entrapta about something. I just thought that maybe we could go to Eternia and talk to them? Get them to leave Etheria alone.” Adora shrugged.

“From what I know about Eternian's from a thousand years ago, Adora. They don't talk, they take. They will use any means necessary to get what they want.” Catra huffed, her eyes were cold and angry.

Adora sighed, slipping her hand back into Catras. Bowing her head in remorse. She might be an Eternian?

“I really hate to think I might be one of them.” She sighed, sadly. The guilt about what her people had done to Etheria, gnawing at her.

“You're not.” Catra stated, vemenantly. “Your our She-Ra, Etheria choose you, Adora.”

“What does that even mean?” Adora chuckled, bitterly.

“If you don’t figure it out, I'll explain later.” Catra smirked playfully, then leaned her head back and gazed up to the galaxy of stars sprawling high above. “Before my dreams, I knew nothing about my people...I had always felt alone. But now I know where I came from, I know who I am. “ Catra took a settling breath. “ I get that

you want to know where you came from, who your people were. But Adora, if you did come from Eternia. We have to be careful....they are dangerous people. I'll help you find your birth family, if that's what you want. But we can't rush into things." She amended, glancing over to find Adora near tears and nodding.

They sat in silence for some time, taking in the night sky and dwelling in their own thoughts. Catra finally broke the silence. "Thanks to Glimmer's mom....I finally know who I am. I was born to the Northern Pride in the Savannah of Serenia."

Adora's eyes widened in surprise. Mara had been trying to reach a place on Etheria known as Serenia? Was it the same place? She stayed quiet, listening to Catra's somber revelations.

"To the Sunna or the people of the Sun." Catra cast her a small, sad smile.. "She let me live a lifetime in those dreams, with my own people. All the unclean behavior's Shadow Weaver tried to beat out of me. Well, that's normal for Sunna." Catra smirked, licking her wrist and wiping it down an ear for emphasis. Then with a playful growl, she turned and lunged for Adora. Grappling her shoulders with her hands and pushing her down on top of the skiff. Holding her down, as Adora laughed and squirmed. Catra straddled her hips with her knees and leaned down, giving her cheek a quick lick then began to purr, loudly.

"This is how we play, how we seek to connect and how we show our happiness to those we love. You were the only one who accepted me for who I am, loved me, forgave me, never gave up on me. I could always count on you...no matter how badly I screwed up. You would always be there for me." Catra cupped her face in her hands, "Sunna, are fierce and cunning hunters. We are passionate and hot headed, we are stubborn and loyal, to those we love. You are my family, Adora and I will always protect you."

Adora stared up at her in awe, her blue eyes brimming with tears, that goofy lopsided smile spreading upon her lips. "You're my family too...I love you..." She stated, leaning up and pressing her lips sweetly against hers.

Catra smiled against her lips and then pushed her away. Feeling both Entrapta's and Scorpia eyes on them, she was suddenly overcome with embarrassment at showing affection. Clearing her throat nervously, she climbed off Adora and crawled to the side of the skiff, leaning her back against the short lip of the bow.

“It was just something I needed to say.” Catra shrugged then raised an arm up, inviting Adora to snuggle against her.

Adora eagerly crawled over to her side and leaned against her, resting her head against her shoulder.

“I'm really tired...” Adora mumbled, it had been a really hard couple of days. Now that she was finally able to relax, she could barely keep her eyes open.

“Then go to sleep, dummy.” Catra sighed, resting her cheek against the top of Adora's head.

Adora sighed languidly, wrapping her arms around Carta's waist. Cherishing this woman who was always there for her, in all the ways she needed most. She felt lighter, after their play fight and the much needed purge of negative emotions. Her work was nearly done in the Fright Zone and she was moving forward again. They would find their answers in Mystacor, there was still time to protect Etheria. Catra's low purr soothed her as she stretched out and rested her head on Catra's lap. Curling up in her cloak as she finally felt relaxed enough to sleep. Catra listened as her breathing became slower and more shallow, brushing the stray hairs that had pulled free from her ponytail behind her ear. Once Adora was asleep she glanced up, finding Entrapta curled up in her hair sleeping soundly. Scorpia stood at the rudder, her expression stern, eyes alert to the shadowed land lit only by dim moonlight. Taking her responsibility seriously to get them to Mystacor safely.

“In my dreams I went to your kingdom.” Catra called up to Scorpia, drawing her attention briefly.

“Really!” Scorpia blurted out in both awe and surprise. Her dark soulful blue eyes eager for more information.

“My parents and I were on the run from Eternian's. We spent a few weeks travelling through your lands. Back then it was called Scorpania. It was an arid land of rolling desert and rocky outcroppings. A small mountain range called the Stingers was where Hordak crashed. What you know as Horror Hall was built on the southern edge of those mountains, long after I was hidden. ” Catra leaned her head back, closed her eyes and fell into those memories. “During that time the Scorpion Empire was ruled by several minor royal families. The land was divided up into numerous provinces that stretched across the lower half of the continent. Those feckless royals spent most of their time bickering over resources, feuding amongst themselves over ancient grudges. Which made it easy for the Eternian to carry favor with at least one or two royal houses. So Scorpania was the first Kingdom to sign up for the Heart of Etheria Project...the Black Garnet was the first Rune Stone to be constructed. The rest of the kingdoms fell in line soon after. The crown city of Scorpania was known as Pandinus. It was the largest city on Etheria at the time and the hub for all interplanetary commerce.” Catras' voice was soft and full of nostalgia as she retold all that she knew of a world that had died over a thousand years ago.

Scorpia was riveted to every word, finally able to reclaim some of her history through her best friend. She was finally able to feel like she wasn't the only one of her kind, she felt a connection to her own people once more.

Mystacor

There was only darkness, an endless void of nothingness that stretched beyond her comprehension. Adora stood within that eternal night, her heart pounding with fear, eyes darting in a rising panic as she found nothing to get her bearings. She was lost...alone and had no way to control what was to come next. Galaxies blanketed the heavens above, millions upon millions of stars began to shine above her. Twinkling and glowing in different intensities, like tiny lanterns against the black backdrop of space. They seemed so close, hovering just out of reach. She might be able to reach out and touch them if she had the courage to move. The brightest stars began to tremble, as if shivering in fear. Then they began to fall, one by one. Streaking across the void until they faded out of existence upon some unclear horizon.

(Catch them! Before they disappear.") A gentle voice echoed to her, vaguely sounding like her own. But vibrating with deep primordial undertones, that made it sound ancient, timeless. As a radiant flash of light illuminated the void just in front of her.

(Hurry...you must protect them.) The radiant glow of She-Ra stood before her. Her wild flowing hair snapping in the ethereal wind now howling around them. The electric thrill of her presence echoed against Adora's skin as she stared in awe and wonder at her immensely powerful magical alter-ego.

Her urgent call to action, spurned Adora forward. Ignoring her fear, resolute in her purpose to always protect others. She ran forward, raising her hands up to catch them. The stars out of control fall, began to slow, as if she was beaconing them to her. They started to float towards her. Like snowflakes in the wind, the starlight began to flutter obediently into her open hands.

"I've got them! I've got them!" Adora spun in delight, to confront She-Ra with a beaming smile of confident self-assurance. She stared down at her hands now translucent, like they were made of the purest ice. She could see the shimmering lights of the stars

filling her palms. Slowly closing her finger's to keep them safe. Exhilaration replaced the fear, before the indescribable burning seared her palms. She screamed in agony but refused to let them go. Knowing that if she lost control over them they would float away and their light would die. So she held onto them more tightly, as suddenly all the tiny lights went out, the cracks between her fingers went dark.

"No...no,no...Please...I've tried so hard..." Adora sputtered out, tears falling down her cheeks. Slowly opening her hands, confronting the scorched holes in her palms, the smell of burnt flesh. The powerful essence of She-Ra began to fade. As she merely walked away. Head bowed with disappointment back into the timeless void. Leaving Adora sobbing brokenly on her knees in the darkness.

It was an old nightmare, one she had endured a few times during the final days of the war. When she was having trouble hanging onto She-Ra...when she had been filled with doubts and confusion.

Adora awoke with a gasp, sobbing. She rolled onto her stomach, burying her face into the velvety softness of Catra's breast fur. Startled, she pushed herself up finding Catra laying beneath her. She had been sprawled over top of her girlfriend, having pinned her to the deck of the skiff by draping an arm and a leg over her smaller, more lithe body. Her cloak had covered them both like a blanket and they must have fallen asleep that way.

Strong finger's brushed threw the loosened hair that had fallen out of her ponytail. Brushing it tenderly behind her ear. "I've got you....Come back to me." Catra murmured quietly, rolling her head to face Adora with a groggy half smile. Her eyes fluttered open for a moment, having trouble remaining awake they quickly closed again.

Adora released a weary sigh and complied. Settling herself securely against Catra's side, as Catra's arm wrapped around her waist holding her tight. Adora nuzzled her tear stained face against the crook of Catra's neck, seeking to absorb as much comfort as she could. It didn't take much for Adora to fall back to sleep, as Catra's low, soothing purr rumbled out in the grey pre-dawn light.

A cool breeze picked up just after dawn, carrying the savory scent of cooking. Catra's nose twitched at the delicious scent, her hold on Adora relaxing as she slowly started to sit up. Adora moaned in protest, but soon fell back to sleep. Catra shook off the lethargy of sleep, as she turned to find Entrapta at the rudder. The geek princess looked bored, yawing and glancing around the heavy forest barely focusing on her task. Scorpia was curled up on the deck fast asleep, near the stern. Entrapta must have taken over steering in the middle of the night, giving Scorpia a chance to get some sleep.

The ancient trees of Plumeria flanked the skiff on either side. Their heavy mantle of leaves hangs proudly from thick branches in bright orange and red hues. The cool season was settling into the woods more prominently every day. The Whispering Woods never experienced the cold like the northern kingdoms, they mostly got a lot of cold rain. But it wasn't unheard of to feel the crisp frost from the Northern Reach on a really windy day.

“I can take over, if you've been driving for too long?” Catra offered, as she gently adjusted Adora's leg off her hip and disentangled herself from the blonde's limp arm.

“Sure...” Entrapta nodded, offering the rudder to Catra as she closed the distance. Catra grasped the long handle of the rudder, as Entrapta walked to the side of the deck. Catra sniffed the air tentatively as the warm scents of wood smoke floated on the breeze. There were Etherian's nearby...a whole lot of them.

Entrapta wrapped her hair around her shoulders as she sat back down on the deck, feeling rather cold.

Melog mewled softly as they padded up to Catra. Sitting beside her and sniffing the alluring scents in the air as well.

“Yeah...I smell them too.” Catra acknowledged, turning the skiff deeper south towards a large clearing. The main sail snapped taunt as she veered the skiff. “Maybe, we should check things out.” With all the wandering beasts and stray Eternian's in the area, they might be in trouble, or at least they could offer them a ride to a nearby village were it would be safer.

The skiff burst threw the tall grass into a wide open clearing. Catra slowed the craft, by releasing the trigger that was mounted under the handle. As she approached a large encampment of cloth tents, covered wagons and carts. The haphazard collection of belongings and roughly constructed shelters. Resembled the many refugee camps she had seen during her time commanding the Horde. As her armies ravaged the coastal villages of Salineas. The survivors had quickly gathered what they could of their homes and recreated moving villages. Trying to outrun the Horde as they moved inwards towards the protection of Bright Moon. But these wagons and tents were covered with natural woven emblems of leaves, acorns and dried flowers that told her they were Plumerian's.

The braying of animals echoed from the camp as she cut the engines. She could see children hiding behind wooden wagon wheels and tent flaps. Several Plumerian's, dressed in layered, brightly colored clothing, rushed the skiff with spears.

“Horde Scum! You are not welcome here!” A smooth baritone voice shouted out in anger amongst the crowd. As a tall man strode forward to confront her. He had dirty blonde hair that hung long and unkept over his eyes. His face was rugged, tan skin weather worn from a life spent outside. With a square jaw covered in a fine down of scruffy hair. His shoulders were broad and he possessed a well defined muscular frame. He continued to

shout obscenities up at Catra, his steel grey eyes burning with hatred. He wore only a simple open grey vest and brown hide pants. A loose necklace of woven vines and flowers accented his thick neck. Along with a tight leather band, beaded with bones hidden beneath the flowers

Catra swallowed the hiss, growing at the back of her throat as she glared down at the man. She always held hope she wouldn't be recognized, but she had been Hordak's second in command for years and lead many attacks through out Etheria. These angry confrontations were inevitable. But she had headed here to offer aid if needed, not get into a fight. So she stood stiffly, jaw clenched absorbing the man's hateful slurs towards her silently. While Melog snarled, their mane snapping a brilliant red as they glared at the small armed force surrounding the skiff.

“What's going on?” Adora mumbled out groggily, as she swiftly became alert when she noticed the armed Plumerian's flanking the skiff. Moving on battle instincts long ingrained since childhood, she raised her fists, glancing around the skiff for her pack. Knowing her quarter staff would be set beside it, still in it's leather sheath.

Scorpia growled awake at the sudden threat, rolling into a defensive posture claws raised. While Entrapta cried out in alarm, gripping the pad she was looking at more closely to her chest.

“Conall!” Perfuma's voice shouted out, shrill and authoritative from the camp. Before her thin frame strode out of the last row of wagons and into view. She moved swiftly in her flowing pink dress, the hem of her thin green sleeved shawl fluttering briskly behind her. Crossing the glade in only a few stride's, her light blue eyes furious. Her long cornflower blonde hair was now elaborately braided with flowers, snapping like a corded whip as she moved with purpose towards the skiff. Her hands were balled into tight fists at her sides. Adora was battling with her self control. She wanted to deal with the threat before her. But she stood her ground, flexing her finger's that itched to grab her quarter staff

and kept silent. Knowing Perfuma was a force of nature when she was angry and it was best to stay out of her way.

The burly man turned to confront his princess with a cool, apathetic scowl.

“Princess, we were just protecting the camp. We didn't realize it was your friends.” He shrugged, pretending with fake surprise that he had finally noticed Adora.

Perfuma placed a hand on his shoulder and looked up at him with a small patient smile.

“I understand you are on edge, with everything that has happened. But the war is over. You need to move past your anger and distrust of strangers, Conall.” Perfuma sighed, side stepping the real issue. Knowing his anger was firmly directed right at Catra.

“Right.” He muttered, rolling his shoulder to toss her lightly restraining hand off. Then strode away with his guards in toe.

“My apologies, Conall has gone through quite a-lot during the war. He saw the skiff and of course thought it was Horde coming to attack the camp.” Perfuma shook her head sadly, “My people have changed… the war has left some very deep and ugly scars upon them…they are not as peaceful and trusting as they once were.” Her soft blue eyes turned distant and reflective. “I have been trying so hard to get my people to move past their fear and anger in regards to the Horde. But I'm afraid, time will be the only way for them to heal.” She sighed, folding her hands before her. As Bow waved eagerly from the line of wagons and jogged over.

Adora listened grimly to Perfuma's words, as the task ahead to integrate the Horde into Etherian' society seemed even more unobtainable.

“Adora, Catra good see you guys!” Bow called. “Hey, Scorpia, Entrapta.”

“Come, we are cooking breakfast. Please join us.” Perfuma offered with a joyful smile.

Adora's stomach growled in approval, making Perfuma laugh lightly. “Hungry as always, Adora.”

“Ah...well...I guess. That would be great.” Adora chuckled, blushing and slightly embarrassed.

Scorpia and Entrapta disembarked at Perfuma invitation. But Catra stood stoically at the rudder, her feet firmly planted. Keeping a close eye on Conall, as he never moved far. Leaning against a wagon, stacked full of chopped wood. His thick arms were crossed over his barrel chest and he was staring daggers back at Catra. He was itching for a fight, just biding his time until the rest were gone.

“Coming?” Adora intreated, offering Catra her hand.

“Naw, I'm good.” Catra passed Adora a weak smile, that never reached her eyes. “You go ahead, I'll stay with the skiff.”

Melog brushed up against Catra, glancing up at her briefly before locking their mournful eyes on Adora. Adora subtly cut her eyes down to Melog, gauging Catra's emotional state. Taking note of the somber tones of lavender in Melogs mane. How they hung their head meekly and swished their tail low and tucked between their legs. Catra was feeling guilty and insecure, she did not feel comfortable going inside the camp.

“Alright.” Adora nodded, giving her arm a reassuring squeeze.Before jumping off the skiff and walking after the group. She had noticed the whole silent confrontation between Catra and Conall. She aimed to end it before it got any more heated. She paid Conall a cool, threatening look as she passed him. His cold grey eyes cut to her for a moment, knowing that she was the vessel of their most sacred warrior. Quickly working out if fighting Catra...the ‘reformed’ Horde Commander, was worth having to take on She-Ra.. Who would most likely beat him into a fine

paste. He took a deep breath and blew it out angrily before storming off into the camp.

Adora glanced back at Catra with a smug, self satisfied grin. Finding the feline woman with her head bowed. Sitting in somber contemplation on the bow of the skiff, absently petting Melog. Catra had never seen the subtle confrontation that had transpired between her and Conall. Adora was slightly disappointed, she had wanted Catra to see her standing up for her. Adora's smile fell, as she took in Catra's melancholy.

Catra was lost in her dark reflections, again. Knowing she was not welcome among the Plumerian's. Hated, distrusted and feeling she was deserving of it all.

Unwanted and alone again, an outsider...

“Catra...” Adora moaned, turning on her heel, ready to go back to the skiff. When a hand gripped her shoulder and forced her to stop. She turned to find Perfuma, smiling sadly at Catra. Her eyes shone with understanding and empathy for what Catra was feeling. But she was also resolute, holding Adora back from going back to join her.

“Are you planning on beating up every Etherian who dares to hold Catra accountable for her actions?” Perfuma inquired gently.

“I...well...uhm...” Adora sighed, rubbing the back of her neck in shame. Perfuma made a good point and it made her think that perhaps she had overreacted.

“I doubt Catra would approve, also violence should never be your first choice.” Perfuma advised gently. “Catra needs to figure this out for herself, Adora. I am sure you have protected her from many things over the years. But you can't protect her from this.” Perfuma took a deep breath and let it out slowly.

Adora licked her bottom lip, in agitation. “I will always protect her.” She stated, glaring stubbornly down at Perfuma.

Perfuma never watched Adora leave, staring forlornly at Catra for a moment longer before heading over to the skiff. She leaped up and settled herself down beside Catra. Catra never looked up, glowering down at her feet dangling off the front of the skiff. “Walk with me, Catra.” Perfuma offered, sitting patiently for a few minutes, as a heavy silence reigned between them. Perfuma took a deep breath and gave Catra's somber profile a warm smile. When Catra never moved or even acknowledged her presence she finally stood up.

“Ok, then.” She rubbed her hands down her soft pink dress, adjusting her shawl indignantly. “I can not help those who are unwilling to help themselves.” She nodded and jumped off the skiff.

Catra fought with herself for a moment longer. Her fear, stubbornness and insecurities were still holding her back. Unsure if she could trust Perfuma with her secrets. Or even find the courage to open up to her about her troubles. But perhaps Perfuma would help, she had offered to teach her to meditate. Maybe that was the magic she needed to help her silence that horrid voice that always devalued her worth. Perhaps it could repair the broken parts of her she didn't know how to fix and finally be able to find peace with herself?

“Wait...Perfuma!” Catra jumped off the skiff and called out to her. When the flower princess had started to walk away.

Perfuma turned back to her solemnly. Melog padded over the edge of the skiff, curious.

“I'll be alright, stay with the skiff.” Catra turned back, content when Melog slunk back down to the deck to resume their sleep.

“Where are we going?” Catra asked, as she followed Perfuma out of the clearing and into the forest.

“A walk...” She smiled gently. “It helps to quiet your mind, when your thoughts are too loud.”

They walked for a long time, leaving the older primeval forest for thinner younger trees near the bank of a tranquil moving creek. It wasn’t very wide and several large stones jutted out here and there, that one could use to skip over the water. The water had a green tint to it, but still clear. Clogged in places with thick branches and soggy leaf litter. In time the creek became wider, the water deeper and moving more rapidly. The green fog in the water, cleared to a crisp clarity. Allowing Catra to see the bottom of the stream and all the numerous small stones that glittered under the surface. They walked along a well worn trail that was slowly leading them downward to the edge of the stream. This stream was known as the Singing River that wove through the forests of Plumeria. The water source originated from Half Moon lake, which surrounded Bright Moon Castle. The water was run off from the waterfall that cascaded down from Sky Dancer mountain. This powerful river also cut threw the Whispering Woods branching away into smaller streams that wove into Thaymor, near the Whispering Woods and around the forests at the base of Talon Mountain. Eventually flowing into Selineas at the southern tip of the continent and into the Growling Seas. Catra knew very little about its history, only that the water was supposed to sing. She had never heard it's song and figured it was just a tale told to children for entertainment.

The sky overhead was overcast, the heavy clouds obscured the sun making the day grey and threatening rain. The stream had widened even more as they traveled deeper into the woods. The water now roared below, as they moved along the lush bank of thick grass. The overgrowth hanging over the edge to skim the fast moving water. That was still pure and clear, revealing a sandy, rocky bottom. Crashing violently against larger rocks near the edge of the bank further ahead.

Perfuma had wandered down to a spongy beach, of wet reeds and mud. Crouching and scrutinizing small stones from time to time. Heading in a slow, meandering course towards the part of the

beach that held larger boulders. Catra had kept her distance, remaining on the firm embankment above. Glaring with disgust at the muddy beach, of pebbles and rotting weeds. With a groan she hopped down, her feet squelching into the mud. Trudging after Perfuma, casting the water foul, distrustful looks.

Perfuma soon had them scaling the slippery bank of scattered rocks and larger boulders. Climbing along the water's edge to a vantage point high atop an embankment of massive boulders. Beyond was even more huge rocks of every shape and size, all positioned in a massive circle that sprawled for miles. The stones butting against a set of hills in the distance. The cluster of huge rocks had blocked off a portion of the river, forming a natural dam. The overflow of water had pooled within their formation, forming a large placid lake that stretched just out of view. Beyond the gloriously shimmering lake. Catra could see the golden hue of the tree line that grew on the other side, which was the border between Plumeria and the Whispering Woods within Bright Moon. That ancient mysterious forest stretched out beyond the edge of the lake. Further into the trees, she saw the rocky peek of Sky Dancer Mountain. It hovered just behind that deep forest, far in the distance, covered by thick layers of cloud.

She knew the sprawling valleys and orchards of Bright Moon, lay at the foot of that mountain.

She always approached the more wild and untamed parts of Etheria with awe and a good dose of caution. Etheria was so ancient, so wondrous, so awe inspiring. It held so many secrets, some mystical and pure. Full of gentle grace, that left you near tears with how beautiful and ethereal it could be. Other secrets were dangerous, baring teeth that ripped and claws that tore. Secrets that lurked in the darkness, waiting to be freed. Secrets so old, so alien that they were absolutely terrifying. During her years in the war, she had experienced unearthing both.

Perfuma wiped her hands down her dress and sat down primely upon a flat boulder with her back to the shimmering water of the lake that stretched for miles. Facing the vast reservoir of tranquil

water, held captive in the circle of large stones. That butted against the sandy banks of the lake and the rocky embankment of the raging river.

Catra crouched beside her, giving her a curious look. Perfuma sat quietly for a time, rolling the three stones she had decided to keep between her two palms.
"Everything we say, think or do has consequences for ourselves and for others." She began, giving Catra a thin smile as she found the other woman glowering down at her. Then pressed on, tossing her stone into the still water. They both watched the ripples start off small and then grow ever larger as they moved outward into the lake. "They are like ripples, our actions, our words, they spread out and affect others. Because everything in this life is interconnected."

Catra nodded, thinking back to the threads of magic that coiled and knotted within the living Heart of Etheria.

"We also need to remember that our actions are irreversible." Perfuma stated more loudly, drawing Catra back from her stray thoughts.

"I know all that!" Catra barked her ire rising, but quickly took a deep breath to cool her anger. Perfuma's words were not spoken with accusation or malice, simply an honest statement. Catra slowly knelt down beside her. After the long walk the muscles in her legs were tired and were starting to burn.

"This tranquil pool of water is my mind, Catra." Perfuma stated, holding up another stone. "My mind is at peace and I can see the path forward clearly. Before I cast this stone, I am able to see the ripples and how they will affect my world." She tossed the stone, it struck the water smartly, disappearing into the murky depths swiftly. They both watched the ripples grow and multiply in reflective silence. Then Perfuma stood up and walked to the boulder's edge, climbing along the embankment of rocks, moving away from the lake. Heading back along the muddy outcropping that flanked the river. Catra followed, curious now as to where her

analogy was going. She showed Catra her final stone, then hurled it into the rushing current of the stream. It struck the water with a splash then disappeared. The water was so full of waves, foam and debris that no ripples could be seen. Catra stared at her in confusion, as Perfuma glared at Catra and pointed out to the raging waters. “That's your mind, Catra! It is so full of negative thoughts, they howl and rage against your peace of mind. How can you throw your stone? You can't see what kind of ripples it will make...how your actions will affect your world.. until it's too late? You have trapped yourself in a loop of reaction and regret...I want to help you break free of it...if you will let me.”

Catra swallowed hard, blinking with trepidation at Perfuma. Her reasoning was sound and came from a place of truth. She could not deny it, or belittle it. That is exactly how she had lived her life during the war, hell she’d been living that way since childhood. Every action, every choice she had made had arisen from a turbulent place of rage or desperation for survival. Trapped in that cycle...struggling for approval, for security that only power could provide. She had been so driven to prove herself, to win, so the ends had justified the means, every time.

Now she was tainted with so many regrets...

“What do you propose?” Catra inquired, softly.

“As I offered before. I want to teach you to meditate, help you work through your issues. I want you to find peace and through that peace...happiness. You deserve it.” Perfuma smiled warmly, then turned and walked back. Navigating them once more to the boulders that overlooked the shimmering expanse of the lake beyond. She sat back down on her large flat boulder and patted the dry stone beside her.

“Alright...Fine.” Catra huffed, settling down beside her. She mimicked her cross legged pose and rested her hands on her knees. Perfuma offered her a gentle reassuring smile, as Catra took a deep breath. Her ear’s twitching to the soft chorus of frogs

echoing from the lake. A small smile crept upon her face, it was nice here...peaceful.

The suns were high overhead when they finally made it back to the camp. Everyone was on the skiff, milling around the deck preparing to depart. Catra leaped up onto the platform, crouching low to catch Melog as they dashed up to give her a head butt and rub against her face.

“Where have you been!” Adora scolded, hands on her hips. “I brought you back some food, but it's cold now.” She sighed, glancing forlornly down at the wooden bowl, full of stew sitting on the deck by their packs.

“Around, hanging out with Perfuma.” Catra chucked a thumb at Perfuma. Who stood before the skiff, glancing nervously back at the encampment.

Adora huffed, giving her a fake pout by jutting out her bottom lip sadly. Catra chuckled, not taking her disappointment too seriously.

“Sorry, princess.” Catra offered, patting Adora's cheek tenderly. Then placing a sweet kiss upon her cheek, before heading over to their packs. She promptly sat down and gulped down the cold stew, refusing to make Adora sad...even fake sad.

Adora gave a startled cry, rushing to Catra to try and take the bowl away. Her words of warning coming out in a rush, attempting to convince her not to eat spoiled food. But it was too late, Catra had been starving and downed the bowl in record time. Growing up in the Horde, food was food. It was scarce and sometimes non existent, depending on your performance in training for that day. So a cadet learned quickly to eat whenever and whatever was offered, without complaint.

“Perfuma, your people will be fine. I think we should go ahead, make sure there is enough room for them at Mystacor.” Bow leaned down from the bow and offered Perfuma his hand. She nodded and let him haul her up onto the curved deck.

“Do you have my pack?” Perfuma inquired, looking around.

“Yes.” Bow pointed to the now growing pile of backpacks at the stern.

Scorpia stood at the rudder glancing back at Entrapta, who was crouched over the engine compartment. She had removed several larger panels and was now tinkering with the set of engines at the back.

“Entrapta...are we ready to go?” Scorpia asked.

“Did the skiff break down?” Catra inquired, nervously. She remembered Entrapta's tinkering with Darla, during their trip home. She had modified and turbo charged that old star ship obsessively, she could only imagine what she might be doing to this rusty old skiff.

“Entrapa got bored, waiting for you.” Scorpia responded, her eyes wild with fear.

With several sharp snaps, Entrapta put the panels back on the engines.

“Let's go!” Entrapta shouted, sitting cross legged at the back of the skiff, just in front of the main sail's heavy pole. The sail fluttered in the breeze, snapping taunt from time to time.

Scorpia nodded, turning the key on the ignition panel just behind the rudder, to activate the engines and finding that nothing happened.

She suddenly looked up at Catra in renewed terror. Catra back stepped and grabbed the safety railing with one hand. “Adora!” She beaconed with a terrified shout, offering the blonde her other

hand. Adora was still sitting on the deck and glanced up in confusion from the empty bowl of stew in her hands. Her eyes went wide with fear as she suddenly caught on to what was happening. Turning to regard Entrapta with rising panic, as she dropped the bowl. Catra bent down and grasped one of her wrists, dragging her closer as she hooked an arm around the railing to secure them both to the deck. As Entrapta began to laugh maniacally, her lavender twin tails gripping onto a curved sheet of metal, that was a Plumerian shield. Tucking it beneath her butt, like it was a seat. Using her magic to manipulate the polarity between the metal shield she was using as a chair and the skiff's metal hull. She sat cross legged, as she floated high into the air above the skiff, tethering herself to the metal with her magic. Then she slammed a gloved hand onto her data pad screen.

The engines hummed and then roared to life, the power and sound building into a howling drone as if it was Darla trying to break through the atmosphere. A brilliant glow grew from the back engines, followed by a massive shock wave, as the nose of the skiff was suddenly jerked up. Then the skiff exploded upward out of the canopy of trees, streaking across the sky like a rocket. With everyone screaming and hanging on for dear life! While Entrapta swung merrily on her magical tether just above the skiff laughing in delight!

Jitsu shook off his idle thoughts, at the humming in the distance. His senses alerted to the presence of an approaching aircraft. Glancing down at the crystal shard of Kaydak in his leather gloved hand. In the faint light of twilight, the deep facets shimmered softly with a pale blue hue. He quickly slipped the crystal into the inner pocket of his tunic where it would be safe. He had been sent to what was once an Eternian Space Port known as Arxia to retrieve this lost artifact for Lord Skeletor. It had been stolen during the Great Unrest, by the treacherous Squadron Grey Skull and hidden here. It would have been retrieved long ago if Mara had not stolen the whole planet next, hiding it away in a shadow

Dimension. But when it reappeared on Eternia's Celestial map months ago. Lord Skeletor's plans were back on track and he wasn't going to wait any longer to claim his prize.

Jitsu's return would be praised and many nights of celebration awaited him back on Eternia. He looked outward from his hiding place, on the highest point of the citadel. The slender, white marble tower that housed the distress beacon, jutted out of the central bastion of the massive school of magic known now as Mystacor.

A small craft was approaching, but it was still a long way off. So he waited, hidden in the shadows of the open beacon housing. The ball of magical energy used to call for help, swirling and thrumming behind him. It's strobing energies pulsing against his dull grey cloak, creating an eerie blood stained magenta shadow over the cloth. Pulling the cowl of his wool cloak further over his face with his large golden metal hand. He narrowed his dark brown eyes as he caught sight of the small craft whistling into view through the heavy clouds.

He recognized the antiquated design as a Horde skiff. He had been a low ranking soldier for the Eternos army, during the 'Uprising' on Eternia. Horde Prime had been biding his time since the 'Great Unrest' of a thousand years ago. Waiting for Eternia to grow weak enough. For him to easily force the planet into his light. It was during the 'Uprising' that Jitsu had switched sides. Finding a true purpose worth fighting for under Lord Skeletor’s banner. He had grown to despise King Randor and often fantasized about sneaking into the Eternian Castle to assassinate him in his sleep. King Randor was a merciless tyrant, who cared more for his own agenda than his own soldiers. Throwing them at Primes forces as if they were an endless resource, that would never run out. As he watched so many of his comrades die needlessly one battle after another. Primes war machine was relentless, as never ending waves of bots and clones slaughtered his friends. Scorched the sky with air raids, reducing the cities to rubble and destroyed the once fertile land. The war dragged on for far too long, leaving the planet damaged beyond its ability to

heal. Now Eternia was no more than a lifeless dessert, those that remained left to fight over the limited resources that remained. King Randor now ruled over a dying world...desperately trying to resuscitate the land by pillaging resources from other worlds.

Jitsu tilted his head as he crouched at the edge of the open alcove, keeping the craft in view. As it shot downward towards the golden arches, that were erected in the massive tranquil gardens. That stretched around the waterfall outside of the citadel's outer ramparts.

“Jitsu?” Tri-clop's robotic voice echoed through the static of his ear piece.

“Yes...” he snarled in a low, deep voice.

“I am getting close to the citadel. I'll wait for you in the forest just beyond Arxia. I was ordereed to escort you to the rendezvous point as quickly as possible. Sorceress Evelyn is growing impatient and wants to head off world as soon as possible with the Crystal.” Tri-clops snapped, over the com. “That gives you at least forty-eight hours to escape undetected. I do not want to have to come find you.” He growled, his threat more than obvious.

“It will be easy, the citadel is in a state of chaos. The crowds of Etherian's clogging Arxia are suffocating. It has been a very useful distraction. ” Jitsu whispered, a predatory grin spreading on his hidden face. His white teeth gleaming in the fading light.

The skiff sliced through the air, diving at a sharp decline as it passed the rocky peeks of the central mountain the citadel was built against. Slicing past the shimmering waterfall, that cascaded towards the lush, lower gardens. That descended in elegantly built steppes towards the sprawling main garden far below. The sail had long since snapped to shreds under the assault of the brutally strong winds. But the small craft had no more need of sails anymore, the engines themselves were powerful enough to propel

it more like a rocket then a boat. Its speed never let up as it descended, shooting through the golden arches. The engines burned away the grass as it roared through the immaculately kept gardens towards the huge ornate doors of Mystacor's main gates.

Everyone was still screaming as Entrapta finally applied the brakes. The engines cut out in an instant and the nose jerked upward once more.

“We're here.” Entrapta stated happily, hovering down in lazy circles from her perch above the skiff. Latching the metal shield onto her backpack. Then slinging it over her shoulder. Proud and content, she strode down the deck and hopped off the craft. As the shredded remains of the sail fluttered to the floor. The broken top half of the pole that had been dangling finally snapped off, following the heavy fabric onto the deck with a resounding clang. Entrapta was completely unaware of her passenger’s sprawled out over the deck, clutching valiantly to railings, or pipes, each other...anything to keep them on board during the harrowing journey to Mystacor. Their hair and clothes windblown, with expressions of pure terror on their faces.

Catra was sprawled on the floor, with a hand raised over her head. As she slowly released the railing, her claws leaving huge gouges in the now twisted metal. Her short dark hair was now blown back into a wild point at the back of her head. Her other hand clutched in a death grip onto Adora's forearm. The blonde had been desperately hanging onto her. With both arms wrapped tight around her biceps. Forced to lay flat upon the deck. Her hair tie had been pulled free from the fierce wind and her hair was now flying wildly around her shoulders.
“Are we dead?” Catra asked in a hushed, breathless tone. Her eyes darting over to Scorpia, finding the scorpion woman had hung onto the rudder with her pinches so tightly the rod was now bent and twisted into something unrecognizable.

“Wow....just,... wow...” Scorpia breathed, staring stunned and awestruck at Catra. "That was....that was...terrafunfying..." She released the rudder from her large claws with a sharp click. Her

short platinum blonde hair was just as wind blown, sticking up at the back in several sharp spikes.

Perfuma was still screaming in terror, as a shell shocked Bow guided her off the skiff. Adora slowly released Catra's arm. Rising up on shaky legs, her gait was uncertain and wobbly, but she made it to the railing on the other side of the skiff. Hanging over the side, dry heaving. She was so nauseous and dizzy, she was to scared to let go of the railing and attempt to walk any further.

Melog was cowering at Catra's feet, trembling and unsure about moving themselves. Their had hunched down, tucking their wings in tight to their sides. All four sets of claws had dug deep holes and grooves in the deck. Catra glanced with concern at both Adora and Melog. Offering the cat a few short pets behind the ears, before moving briskly to Adora's side. Rubbing her back soothingly, attempting to offer her comfort as well. She understood all too well how sick Adora might be feeling, she got the same way with Glimmer's teleports.

“What in the Seven Kingdoms!” Castaspella's voice exploded from the main gates, as she rushed out of the citadel.

“Hello.” Entrapta waved cheerfully, as Casta charged past her in complete panic. Followed by a small army of mages and sorceresses. Who rushed past the skiff, drawing glyphs in the air, summoning water spells. Entrapta turned, her eyes falling onto the inferno their landing had created within the gardens. Her magenta eyes widening in surprise.

“Sorry...” She called, her mind racing with ways she could help. “That may have been my fault.” She quickly turned away with a pained grimace from her destruction, whipping out her voice recorder from her hair. “Launch notes, the engines on the D.L.S(Darla's little sister) May need dampeners upon reentry. To mitigate the destruction of local flora...and perhaps fauna as well.” She finished with regret. She got so involved with her creations, she didn't always think far enough ahead to see what the

consequences of her creations would have on others. It was something she needed to work on.

Catra turned, along with Scorpia and Adora. Finding the entire garden behind them was now up in flames. The massive tongues of fire shooting up into the twilight sky. As the small army of magic users were positioning themselves around the flames, drawing massive magic glyphs of water, then pushing them towards the fire.

“You guys sure know how to make an entrance.” Mermista's less than enthused drawl echoed from just above. “You know I could have helped...if I still had my magic. But I am not going into that.” She glowered down at her hands, as if they were to blame. “But you know, my Rune Stones broke...and then my Guardian Beast ate it. So there’s also that...” She shrugged, her lips thinned slightly in irritation.

They all turned to find her standing on the edge of one of the tranquil gardens rock walls, arms crossed, watching the Mystacor's magic army put out the blaze. Her face was an inscrutable mask, dark brown eyes cold and apathetic. Adora cringed at the damage they had done and the brooding disappointment she sensed from Mermista. It must be killing her to not be able to help put out the fire. Her power over water was gone and she must feel so empty right now.

“Mermista...I'm...”Adora began.

Mermista held up a hand. “If one more person apologizes to me, I am going to scream.” She hopped down off the wall and walked to the front of the skiff. Standing with her hands braced on her hips, regarding them with raised eyebrows. The heat in her glare silenced any more apologies.

Adora clamped her mouth shut and nodded. Mermista was too proud to show her true emotions, hiding behind her casual

indifference instead. Adora moved swiftly to grab her pack and buckled her quarterstaff's sheath, before tossing Bows and Perfuma's packs over the side. Then jumping down herself. Catra and Scorpia followed with their own packs slung over their shoulders. Melog stopped at the edge of the bow, sniffing the air picking up on a familiar and unwelcome scent through the acrid smoke. This Jitsu might be lurking around the Citadel?

“Melog?” Catra questioned, sniffing the air as well. Catching that same strange smell, it was so faint it could be several days old.

(I need to go patrol the perimeter. I will find you.) Melog hopped off the skiff, to the higher ledge of stacked stones and then bounded off. Not waiting for Catra to offer to go with them. They had failed to protect her back at the Fright Zone; they were not going to fail here. They had kept silent about Tri-clops, as he was too dangerous. This Jitsu could be just as deadly. They had already lost one master because of Eternian's they were not going to lose another. They could handle these threats just fine on their own.

“Come, Glimmer has called a meeting of the Princess Alliance.” Casta rushed them up the grand outer stairs of the main gate and into the cavernous gate house. Glancing over her shoulder with a proud smile, her sorcerers had the fires well in hand now. Their combined magic has reduced the flames to sputtering smoke and ash.

Mystacor was one of the more ancient fortifications on Etheria. The citadel floated amongst the clouds, powered by some lost magic or perhaps first ones tech, since it was built from the remains of an Eternian outpost a thousand years ago. But no one tampered with the mechanics that kept it aloft, or even knew where the device might be hidden inside the bowels of the great citadel. They just trusted that it would always work.

Mystacor was the heart of all magical knowledge for all seven kingdoms. Harboring scholars, librarians and Makers from all over Etheria. Over the course of time, merchants and tradesmen were drawn to the citadel and soon a vast city was flourishing. The upper bastions in the center of the citadel were carved from the side of the mountain. The naturally flowing architecture was similar to Bright Moon. With tall, elegant towers and smooth, covered parapets blending into the natural rock formations. The grand keep and it's various levels of balconies and slender stained glass windows, dominated the upper citadel. The vast labyrinth of halls and hidden gardens curving around the lush steppes, butting against the rocky outcroppings that protected the massive waterfall. That fell into the main gardens that surrounded the outer ramparts of the fortress. The lower bastions were less elegant, the covered walkways and keeps were more simple in design. Built from quarried stone from the mountain range that sprawled below the floating island. The stone was dull and quaint compared to the majesty of the upper bastions.

The lower bastion housed the various Magic guilds, Maker guilds, classrooms and school libraries. The students' dormitories and teachers quarters as well. While the upper bastions housed the Headmaster quarters and the magic council's residences. The Masters Library, and the Observatory. Which had only been reopened to the scholar's in the last year, when the stars had returned. Along with several ancient chamber's used for sacred ceremonies held during certain lunar alignments. While deeper inside the mountain to the north, was the High Hall of Masters, the Lower Hall of Sorcerers. Many restricted vaults full of powerful relics and magic crystals.

The inner courtyards were filled with common libraries for makers and artisans. Buildings and laboratories devoted to particular schools of magic. Such as incantation, enchantment and herbology. There were huge training courtyards for glyph practice. Glass green houses and beautiful gardens were scattered throughout the various courtyards, growing all manner of magical herbs and flowers for magic spells. The outer enclosures held the guards barracks, the armory and the large merchant quarter.

Selling all manner of things from food to magic supplies, weapons and equipment. Various inns and trade guilds were scattered within the Merchant quarter, which took up an entire enclosure all in itself. Mystacor was a massive city, all enclosed within smooth stone battlement walls. The courtyards grew outward in size in half moon or circular shaped enclosures from the central citadel. The separating walls created a concentric pattern that resembled a magical glyph, drawn to a massive scale.

Casta led them through the gate house and out along the outer rampart. Leading them down a stone staircase into the eastern enclosure. The vast courtyard was filled with tents and makeshift structures of cloth and metal sheeting. All manner of Etherian clogged the huge yard, huddling around campfires and cowering in their tent shelters. The refugees from around the seven kingdoms had filled Mystacor to bursting, having scattered throughout all four of the outer courtyards around the main citadel.

“What's going on?” Adora was appalled at the sad state of these refugees. They looked tired, scared and starving. Horde Primes occupation and decades of war thanks to Hordak. Had left Etheria in shambles, it would take many years to get the kingdoms back into a place of security and prosperity again.

“Etheria is experiencing a resurgence of magic and the commoners are having a hard time dealing with it. Most that have flocked here have suddenly started to be able to use magic. They want to learn how to control it.” Casta folded her hands before her, “There are far too many for us to deal with right now. But Micah and the Council are coming up with a more realistic plan. To get these people home and learn safely in their own villages. Mystacor just does not have the resources to teach thousands and thousands of Etherian's.”

Perfuma frowned at the news, casting Bow a sad look. Bow scratched the back of his neck, moving forward from the group to speak with Casta about the group of refugees from Plumeria. That were still traveling towards Mystacor for the very same purpose.

Catra moved silently up to Adora and grasped her hand, the blonde was staring at the Etherians with such guilt and empathy it broke her heart.

“Adora, this is not your fault.” She stated, giving Adora's hand a shake to draw her gaze away from the pain and suffering she saw and back to Catra's earnest expression on her face.

“This strife and confusion will only be temporary, trust in King Micah and this Council to help them. We need to focus on bigger things.” She finished, offering her a warm, confident smile.

“You're right...” Adora sighed, sadly bowing her head. Thankfully, Catra refocused her yet again. She had a tendency to become rather scattered when confronted with too many problems to solve. She wanted to help everyone, but that just wasn't possible. She needed to trust others, trust her friends to help her keep Etheria safe and move forward toward a better, brighter future.

“Ok, then.” Catra pulled her along, as they made their way deeper into the fortress to the upper bastions of the citadel.

The last time Catra had come here, it had been in the dead of night so she never got a good look. Also they had been going down into the bowels of Mystacor through the lost tunnels that ran beneath the citadel on the less populated northern side of the island. Casta was now leading them through the long, elegant corridors of the upper bastions. High above the courtyards and battlements of the Citadel. Catra was struck by the subtle beauty of the place, with it's huge arching halls and long, elegant windows. They had passed thousands of tiny alcoves, carved into the marble halls. That held all manner of statues, vases and other strange mystical artifacts. All slightly hidden behind red velvet drapery.

Beyond the windows, past the lush gardens that grew upon the natural steppes just outside the bastion's walls, on the far side of

the island. She could make out radiant spires of the purest white, stretching to the sky above. The building that lay below, was a mystery. Curious and oddly excited by the hidden building, Catra couldn't wait to get some time away from the others to explore Mystacor.

The sun's rays were fading beneath the floating island. The clouds that hung just beyond the windows were glowing a brilliant pink and indigo. A gentle tranquility dominated the halls, as they walked in somber silence towards a grand atrium built at the apex of a large keep. When Casta pushed open the heavy double doors, ushering them inside. They moved silently, all lost in their own thoughts.

The room was enormous, carved from the purest white marble. Built in a huge circle, with a glowing fire glyph in the center. Instead of windows there were open archways with pillow covered benches inside that overlooked a balcony that seemed to ring the massive room. The ceiling curved high above into a crystal skylight that caught the last rays of the sun and cast them upon the marble floor in millions of prism colored shards of light. Long silver rods hung from the domed ceiling just above the benches alcoves. With tear drop shaped lanterns, that were just starting to glow within the coming twilight.

Glimmer stood just behind the massive fire glyph, her face pensive, patiently waiting for them to settle on the benches within the room. Frosta was already seated on a bench, her fur lined parka discarded beside her. Dressed in a white long sleeve shirt and dark pants, kicking her booted feet slowly. Her posture bent and soulful dark brown eyes reflective as she stared down at her boots. She was a few years older then when the rebellion began, but would always remain the youngest of the Princess Alliance. She was just entering into her teen years, as the rest of the Alliance became adults. She had always been a bit headstrong and reckless when in battle. Her personality could be a bit standoffish and a tad abrasive with her loud, rather rambunctious nature. To find her looking so quiet and down cast was alarming.

Adora released Catras hand and dashed across the atrium to sit sullenly beside Frosta. Who never looked up, her now shoulder length dark hair hung low over her round face.

“Are you ok?” Adora asked, cringing at how lame that sounded.

Frosta turned her head and gave her an incredulous look. Her eyes were moist from wallowing in her melancholy thoughts for so long.

“Ah, I guess not.” Adora chuckled, bitterly.

Frosta leaned back and craned her head towards the evening sky, watching the glowing sunset against the clouds. “I was eight years old when my parents died. I never got to really be a kid...I spent those years proving to everyone that I could be a strong, capable, and dependable Queen. Then I joined the Alliance, and finally made friends. I was scared but happy for those years. Then we had finally won...no more Horde. I was looking forward to the easy days ahead, no more fighting or worrying about my friends getting killed. I had made plans in my head that Glimmer would teleport to the Kingdom of Snows with all the princesses...Catra too.” Frosta smirked, casting Adora a small apologetic glance. Not wanting her to think of inviting Catra as an afterthought. “We would have a slumber party and play some ice ball...stuff our faces with sweets and just be...normal.” She laughed bitterly.

“I wanted that too...” Adora offered with a small smile.

“Losing my magic and having my Rune Stone...the Fractal Flake...eaten by a huge ice serpent...that was not my idea of finding normal...Now, I just feel too normal?” Frosta stared down at her hands in complete shock and frustration.

“I'm sorry, Frosta. But I'm positive you are going to get your powers back.” Adora smiled encouragingly. Reaching out and tapping Frosta just above her heart. “Cause your powers never really came from that Rune Stone, but inside of you.”

“What are you talking about?” Frosta chuckled, sarcasm thick in the undertones.

“When I broke the sword of protection, I couldn't summon She-Ra anymore. I thought I had lost her, forever. But that power was always inside of me. I needed to figure out how to access it without having to rely on a tool that forced that power out. I never needed that First Ones piece of tech and you don't need it either. Etheria's magic is a part of you.” Adora advised, her smile was warm and confident and Frosta couldn't help but smile earnestly as well.

“Ok, Adora. I'll trust you.” Frosta raised her head, as Glimmer cleared her throat.

The rest of the Princesses had found benches to sit on. Entrapta was sitting on the floor, her hair curled under her as a cushion. She clicked her voice recorder on and set it on the floor beside her and was once more engrossed in her data pad. Catra had found an open archway that led to the balcony to lean against, that was near Adora and Frosta's bench. She was distracted, her gaze shifting from watching Glimmer to watching the sunset. With her arms crossed and aloof posture, Catra licked and nibbled on her bottom lip nervously and half listened to the meeting.

“The head of my palace guard, Juliet. Has reported that after my Guardian Beast consumed the Moonstone, It has remained curled up on the dais sleeping, it hasn’t moved in days.” Glimmer shook her head bitterly. “Is it the same for the rest of you?”

Mermista nodded, along with Frosta.

“It came out of nowhere, some huge snake...tree...thing...” Perfuma sat on her bench, her eyes wide with horrible memories. “It just swallowed the Heart Blossom in one bite...” She grimaced and cowered slightly against Bow who had been sitting beside her. “It was horrible.” She shuddered.

“By the time I got there...I just found Plumeria's Guardian Beast.” Bow shook his head. “It was curled up in the ground around the roots of what remained of the Heart Blossom, sleeping.”

“Those snakes, your Guardian Beasts as you call them. They are Elemental Wyrms. They are a living conduit of your magic.” Catra explained, absently.

“How do you know this?” Glimmer turned, her tone perplexed and hopeful.

“I've been having some weird dreams lately, since gaining my own powers.” Catra shrugged. “I'll tell you all about them, whenever you want.”

“What powers?” Mermista huffed scornfully, she stood against an open archway on the opposite side of the Atrium. Mirroring Catra's posture and sour attitude.

Catra took a deep breath and closed her eyes, delving deep inside herself for that spark she had become very familiar with. It lurked deep in her soul, flickering just out of reach. She thought of Adora and how this power was meant...to protect her. Then the flame roared forth, consuming her hand and then her body. In a moment she stood in the archway, her eyes glowing a piercing electric blue and molten amber with her power. As her flames flickered and snapped over her body.

“Wow.” Perfuma gasped.

“That's awesome.” Bow offered his voice filled with awe. His warm brown eyes wide in shock.

Mermista sniffed and narrowed her eyes in disgust, averting her gaze and adjusting her stance in the archway so that she wasn't looking at Catra any longer.

“That so cool!” Frosta hopped off the bench, suddenly very excited and full of energy again. “Adora, you can teach me how to

do that, right.” She jumped a few times, curling her hands to her chest and smiling hopefully up at Adora.

Adora merely laughed nervously. Searching for Castaspella, needing guidance as to how to proceed, she wasn't a teacher. Casta was standing in the doorway to the Atrium, nervously ducking out into the hallway as if waiting for someone. She wasn't even paying attention to what was going on inside and completely missed Catra's transformation.

“Where's Finn?” Adora inquired to Glimmer, as Catra allowed the power to dissipate. The fire that once engulfed her body snuffed itself out in an instant.

“He is with Swift Wind down at the Elemental Basilica on the other side of the island. Aunt Casta is going to house us over there away from the Citadel during our training.” Glimmer shrugged.

“Why?” Catra challenged. “Isn't this where they teach all the magic user's?”

“Magic user, yes, not Rune Bearers!” Casta spat back. “That is a whole other level of magical power that I do not want getting out of control around a bunch of civilians.”

“Ok...” Catra raised her eyebrows in surprise and dropped any further complaints.

“Where is he?” Casta muttered in irritation.

“Well, let's keep this meeting going then.” Mermista demanded.

“We're waiting on a few others.” Glimmer sighed.

“Who?” Catra asked.

“Us, kitty, kitty.” Huntara strode into the room, along with King Micah, Netossa and Spinerella.

Catra hissed at Huntara, already not liking the burly leader of the Crimson Waste.

“Any luck?” Casta asked, hopefully.

King Micah shook his head, “Huntara tried to track him but she lost his trail, when he went down the Skull path.”

“I am not going in there.” Huntara raised her hands defensively and strode across the room. Leaning against the wall by Adora. “That path leads right into the Dark Edge...that Prince has a death wish. I am not going anywhere near those creepy canyons.” She grunted and rubbed the back of her neck, then unlatched a metal flask from her belt and took a long drink. Before rolling her neck and sighing heavily, returning the flask to her belt.

Catra narrowed her eyes threateningly, snarling under her breath, she did not like how Huntara just claimed a spot beside her girlfriend. How her huge bulk now blocked her view of Adora. She also took note of how she tenderly rubbed the back of her neck. The pained look she wore when she caressed her neck then the desperate need to have a drink from her flask. All of it sent warning flags in Catras mind. She was going to have to keep a closer eye on Huntara whenever she was around.

“Who were you tracking?” Adora stood up and moved to the other side of Frosta. Leaning against the wall, mimicking Huntara’s intimidating posture.

“Prince Peekablue.” Huntara stated, rubbing the side of her eye with the tip of a calloused finger. She looked absolutely exhausted, with heavy bags under her eyes.

“Why?” Adora asked.

“Ask Glimmer, it was her idea to try and track him down.” Huntara shrugged.

“He has the gift of Foresight, I had hoped he could give us some clues as to what is coming next.” Glimmer shrugged, “Kinda

feeling a bit unprepared for the future, right now.” She sighed, crossing her arms over her chest and lowering her head in grim contemplations.

“Can we wrap this up, Glimmer. I've had a really long ....life.” Huntara groaned, rubbing sand out of her eyes with a finger. She had been tracking Peekablue for days, following leads and scouring the barren wasteland just beyond the Fight Zone. She lost the man’s trail when he headed down the Skull Path that led into a massive labyrinth of sandstone canyons called the Dark Edge. She then headed to Mystacor to give her report to King Micha. She had run into Netossa and Spinerella on the way to the Atrium for the meeting.

“Right,” Glimmer nodded, with disappointment.

Catra's eyebrows raised in both surprise and suspicion. Did Adora just move away from her because she wanted space? Or was she mimicking the huge dumb warrior because she idealized her...there was no way she had a crush on Huntara?

Catra barely paid any attention to Glimmer's droning on about what Mystacor was going to do about all the civilians now gaining magic powers, or even what was going to be happening to the Princesses and their training to regain their powers. She spent the whole meeting glaring at Huntara, ignoring the fact that Mermista was glaring at her. Bow on the other hand was noticing all the friction in the room and becoming more and more unsettled by it. Perfuma was sitting beside him, listening to Glimmer attentively. While Scorpia, who was leaning against the wall next to Perfuma, was glancing at Catra with concern and then Huntara with confusion. Catra was leaning in an archway, scowling at Huntara, who was ignoring her completely. Frosta was oblivious to the tension bouncing on her butt, sitting on her bench staring up at the roof, obviously daydreaming. Adora was leaning against the wall on the other side of Frosta, arms crossed over her chest like Huntara, listening avidly to Glimmer. Nodding from time to time when Glimmer brought up a good point about moving forward. With the rebuilding effort now going on throughout the Seven

Kingdoms. While Entrapta sat on the floor, engrossed in her data pad. Her voice recorder whirling on the floor as it recorded the meeting. Whatever got Entrapa's attention, she was fully invested in it. Mermista was hiding in an archway near the massive double doors, casting Catra dark looks but mostly sulking. While Castaspella and King Micah stood in the doorway listening to Glimmer with proud and patient smiles. Netossa and Spinerella were huddling together on a bench on the other side of the door, paying attention to the meeting and holding hands.

Bow groaned, he had a lot of friendship work ahead of him when they got to the Basilica, making sure all these princesses got along during their training.

Painful Truths

Shortly after the meeting started, Castaspella and King Micah had taken their leave to make sure the sleeping quarters at the Basilica were prepared. Stating that Casta would be back to retrieve them later that night. They had gathered up all the packs in a levitation spell and left them for the rest of their meeting.

Catra leaned against the marble archway. The hard cold stone, pressing against her back, was grounding. As the darkening sky kept pulling her attention away from the proceedings, listening to the wind in the distance. This high up in the sky, the wind sounded different, more gentle and serene. Mystacor's silent tranquility was very similar to space. It was peaceful but not lonely, like she had found the endless expanse of stars.

Her expression was calm but her eyes resonated with worry and frustration. It had been hours and Melog hadn't returned to her side. Night had fallen and the soft light of the two largest of the Greater moons was falling upon the upper bastions. The three smaller greater moons still hung lower in the sky. The many lesser moons had yet to rise into the clear sky full of stars. Her mind was straying, onto many restless anxieties, each one distressing her more. Adora kept glancing over at Huntara, smiling softly every time the woman acknowledged her for a moment. Those little smiles were driving Catra crazy, she was jealous, she knew it! Adora was fond of the Sand Rat...it was more than obvious, it was down right obnoxious. The fact that Huntara was ignoring her possessive glares was even more infuriating.

She was so caught up in her spinning thoughts, she never noticed Entrapta was relaying to everyone the mission she had sent her on and the Etherian's Adora had saved. Dropping the bomb that they were being invaded by Eternia like it was nothing.

“Catra!” Glimmer spun on her, her shrill infuriated shout snapping Catra back to the present.

“Wha....” She gasped, taking a step back and raising her fists in defense. It was a Horde battle tactic ingrained in her since childhood when startled.

“Why didn't you tell me what really happened in the swamp!” Glimmer stormed over to her, her own hands balled into fists.

“I knew that you were keeping things from me, that lame explanation at the farm house was pathetic!”

“Whoa...you need to calm down, Sparkles.” Catra had backed up onto the open balcony, glancing anxiously around the barren deck for an escape route.

“I got things well in hand. Horde Soldiers have been sent out to patrol the seven kingdoms and pick up any stray Eternian that might have survived. Entrapta and Hordak got the portal situation handled, the clones are out investigating every First Ones ruin on the planet. They are going to close down any portals that may be intact.” She offered with a weak, reassuring smile.

Adora took a deep breath and blushed anxiously, casting Entrapta a short pleading look. Finding Entrapta's brow furrowed in confusion as to why Glimmer was so angry. She never noticed Adora's pleading look. Trying to process why Catra believed they were still closing all the portals when Adora had changed the plan.

“Wait..!” Entrapta rose to her feet, her long hair striding her out onto the balcony in seconds.

Adora ran after her, worried she was only going to make this fight worse. She had planned on explaining it all to Catra and the rest, but she just had not had a chance.

“Adora doesn't want all the portals closed, she wants one to stay open.” Entrapta offered.

“What!” Catra spun, her hands balled tightly into fists. She could feel her claws digging into her palms.

“We agreed that keeping them open was dangerous.”

“I want to talk to them, Catra.” Adora moved slowly, her blue eyes were shimmering with tears. Desperate for Catra to understand.

“What if Light Hope had stolen me from that Planet...It's my only way to find out where I came from.” She pleaded.

“Whoa....Blonde! If those portals stay open, even just one. Those Eternian's have a chance to steal more of our people. You are selfishly putting your own interests above protecting the people of Etheria? ” Huntara placed a steadying hand on Adora's shoulder. “ That is not like you?” She finished, her voice quiet with disappointment.

Adora turned and gave her a heated glare that quickly evaporated. Her expression heavy with guilt and disappointment. In herself for being so selfish.

“I know....I know....I just...want to know where I came from...” She whimpered softly, casting her face down in shame.

Catra was pleased at first to see that Adora was conceding that it was a bad idea. But then she was angry at Huntara at how callously she treated Adora's feelings. Throwing her rare selfish desire in her face with such self righteous impunity. But then she didn't want to lose Adora to some barely thought out plan to abandon Etheria for Eternia. On some wild hunch that Eternia was her home planet. So she was happy that Huntara had checked her morality. Either way her emotions were starting to swing like a pendulum and she was feeling rather dizzy.

Glimmer groaned, pinching her nose, “We need to concentrate on what is going on around here. Not some hypothetical future mission.”

“Scorpia's got the Horde getting those people back home. I don't know why your so upset?” Catra swallowed and licked her bottom lip nervously. She had been on the more violent end of Glimmer's rage, dozens of times over the years during the war. But the hurt

and betrayal she saw in Glimmer's eyes. Was far more painful to endure than any physical attack could be. Out of all the Alliance, she felt closest to Glimmer. They had bonded on Primes ship and found a common ground, in their shared universe destroying level screw ups. The fact that their hot tempers had pushed everyone they cared about away and that they were now both alone. Feeling terrible about how cruelly they had treated their friends and wanting to apologize and fix things.

“It is not up to just you to handle things, Catra! You're not a Force Captain anymore. I'm the one in charge and I need to know what is going on. Entrapta stated they have been here for months. They have stolen our people, Catra? How many do you think are on Eternia...right now?” She breathed, her eyes wide with trepidation.

“I don't know...” Catra took a deep breath.

“I could have put word out to the rest of the kingdoms. Sent guards from Bright Moon to patrol the villages. It's scary to think that they are still out there...going about their own agenda.” She was spiraling down a very frightening path in her mind. It was only making her more upset, more angry.

Catra groaned and rubbed the back of her neck, after her dreams she understood Eternian's. They were if the means justifies the ends sort of people. They would do whatever they wanted to other planets for the benefit of their own. Etheria was just a resource, just like so many other planets they had harvested before....like Krytis.

“I thought we trusted one another...after everything...we've been through.” Glimmer seethed, her words stuttering out between heaving breaths. “Keeping that a secret from me...from everyone...was incredibly dangerous. We need to work together to protect the people of this planet. Catra!” Glimmer voice steadily rose into a loud rant as the rage and hurt was rolling off of her in waves.

“Glimmer.” Adora rushed over, coming to Catras defense. “I could have told you as well, you can't just blame her. Catra was dealing with other things at the time. ”

“What other things?” Glimmer turned on her, brow furrowed, tears threatening.

“I can't tell you...they're personal.” Adora stated, softly.

“Then what stopped you when you found out, we have communication pads now?” Glimmer placed her hands on her hips in frustration.

“I was kinda busy for the last few days, releasing all the captured Etherian's.” Adora shot back. “I would have told you eventually.”

“Eventually?” Glimmer scoffed, rolling her eyes. “I should be the first to know these things, not the last!”

“Catra hasn't changed one bit.” Mermista spat from the archway, standing in judgement over Catra with her arms crossed. “She is as devious and manipulative as always. Why else would she hold back such important information. She played us, I bet she already cut a deal with those Eternians back in the swamp. So that she would be spared, when they do fully invade! I for one don't trust her.”

Adora spun on her heel, storming back to the archway and cracked Mermista across the cheek with her hand. Glowering down at her, her steel blue eyes fierce and full of tears. As Mermista cowered slightly, holding her bruised cheek and staring up at her in utter shock.

“Catra has proven herself time and again for months! She is one of us now! Glimmer wouldn't be alive if it wasn't for her! I would not be alive! This entire planet would be under Prime's control if it wasn't for her!” Adora shouted, her voice echoing through the atrium like thunder.

“Adora!” Bow blurted out her name in alarm, his voice heavy with reprimand. As he rushed over to Mermista, guiding her away. Mermista was trembling, her eyes moist, she was about to break down into tears but her pride wouldn't allow it.

Adora was panting, her teeth clenched as she seethed with rage. Yet her eyes had cooled, becoming wide and full of panic. She never acted this passionate or out of control in her entire life? She had always been able to control her temper, hide her emotions and just swallow whatever was bothering her whole. Until she was ready to deal with it in private. But after so many years of not having to hide how she felt. Feeling safe and validated for her thoughts and feelings by her friends. Maybe she had relaxed her emotional control too much. To the point that she had finally lashed out...or it was just her intense nature to protect Catra...that had been cultivated back in the Horde...either way. She had hurt Mermista...she felt bad about it, but she would also not apologize. Mermista had been way out of line and Catra did not deserve it.

“Catra...” Adora turned, her eyes were stricken, as dread pooled deep in her gut.

Catra, raked her fingers through her short hair in exasperation. Her whole body was tingling with the need to run. Her stomach was churning with acid and her eyes were burning. Glancing anxiously over at Glimmer who was now standing at the railing, gripping the edge shaking with fury. Glaring down at the evening glow of the lamps that lined the balconies of the lower bastion of the citadel below. Fuming over what she felt was a huge betrayal. Blaming Catra for her failure to protect her people and trying desperately to figure out how she was going to bring her lost people home. Catra knew without a doubt that this time, for sure...Glimmer hated her...no longer trusted her...it was one of her worst fears but she didn't know how to fix it.

“I'm sorry...” Catra whispered in a low raspy voice, raising a trembling hand weakly, seeking to reach out to Glimmer. Then she quickly dropped her hand, feeling self conscious, the insidious fear of rejection swallowing her courage. Glimmer had every right to hate her! She wasn't a good person, she was selfish and driven by an immoral sense of self preservation. She had kept quiet because she couldn't handle facing this exact situation of hatred and mistrust, but it had come to pass anyway.

Catra snapped her eyes back to Adora, finding she was walking towards her, offering her a comforting hand. Her blue eyes shone with sympathy. The look was infuriating and Catra's brow furrowed in frustration. Uncertain as to how to handle her fragile relationships with the Princess Alliance. Wondering bleakly, if the weak bonds she had started to develop during the final days of the rebellion were starting to unravel? Catra's gaze shifted to the rest of the princesses hovering in the archway and inside the atrium. They were looking at the drama happening out on the balcony with a mixture of confusion, pity and distrust. They were definitely not all on board with having her on the team. A couple season's ago she would have shrugged it off, pretended their opinions didn't matter. Masking her insecurities with a mean or snide comment or two. Or lash out with anger to ease the anxiety of being alone, valiantly trying to protect her fragile heart that got hurt far too easily. But she wasn't that person anymore. She had been trying to be better...for Adora and for herself. Except Catra had only managed to develop two modes of handling confrontations. To fall back into her rage and fight or become scared and run, seeking a hiding spot to lick her wounds.

Catra swallowed hard, as she took another step back. Able to see around the outside of the circular balcony, finding Mermista sitting on a bench cradling her cheek while Bow sought to soothe the situation. Adora might have ruined her friendship with the Water Princess, by overreacting, as she defended Catra's honor. She didn't want that...this was all her fault...Her heart was pounding in her ears, her vision was blurry and all she could hear was a dull roar. As panic and heart ache rushed over her, drowning the last of her courage. She didn't belong here...they really did hate

her...she had been such an idealistic fool to believe that maybe...maybe she had earned a second chance. She could never be one of them...she could never out run who she had been. She was a monster...just, like Shadow Weaver had told her. She just hurt people...she would always be alone. That's what she deserved!

"Wild Cat!" Scorpia had seen that tortured look so many times in the past. She had been hovering in the archway. An ally in the wings if needed. Now she understood Catra was about to flee. She raised a pincher and was heading towards her, her eyes full of concern.

"I should go...Melog isn't back yet...and I'm worried." Catra nodded, offering her and Adora a faint, sad smile. Then in one swift fluid movement she turned on her heel and leapt onto the railing

"Catra...wait!" Adora rushed forward, suddenly very worried that she wasn't going to see Catra again.

She knew that stricken expression, that scared full body trembling. Catra always got this way when she knew Shadow Weaver was hunting for her. That she was going to be punished severely for some minor transgression. She was heading off to hide in some dark corner of Mystacor and who knows when she would see her again.

Catra never looked back, heights never scared her and anywhere was better than here. So she just jumped, arms and legs splayed having faith that she would land on a ledge or manage to grasp onto something before she went splat at the bottom. But if she did.....would it matter? Adora might be better off without her anyway.

"Catra!" Adora screamed, rushing forward, slamming into the railing. Calling down desperately into the darkness, as Catra's lithe body disappeared into the shadows below. Her brow furrowed with anxiety, her blue eyes shimmering with tears but still hard

and determined. She would give Catra till sunrise, then she would go look for her.

When Adora turned back around, Glimmer was walking away from the railing with her head down. Lost in her troubled thoughts as she headed back into the atrium. Adora remained outside a little longer, taking a few deep breaths. She was still very upset and needed to calm down. Lashing out like that, feeling justified about it or not. She hadn't lost her emotional control in a very long time, not since that brutal fight she had with Glimmer. Over using the Heart of Etheria...and her failure to protect her mother…not being a good enough She-Ra. Glimmer had aired years worth of frustrations, resentments and disappointment at Adora, holding nothing back. Those truths hit Adora hard, broke her heart in all the same ways, Catra had during the war. That confrontation nearly destroyed their friendship. The sudden stress and emotional backlash had given her a headache and her heart would not calm down. When she had gathered enough of her composure she reentered the Atrium. Finding all the princesses sitting around on the benches in different states of contemplation. Some were pensive, others looked frustrated or sympathetic towards her.

Glimmer stood in silent fury before the fire glyph, glaring down at it as if she wanted to punch it.

Bow was pacing nearby and when he saw her, he started to come towards her.

Adora raised a hand to ward him off, she was not ready to talk it out. He stopped and nodded, taking a deep breath before retreating onto a bench himself. He clasped his hands between his knees and closed his eyes, needing to remain calm. Think through his words and coming actions. He might need to repair things between Adora, Catra and Glimmer. Adora and Mermista's friendship was on rocky ground now as well. Glimmer would also need him to be the logical voice of reason in just a few minutes.

She wasn't as hot headed and rash as she had been before Prime. But she was still as feisty as ever and she still let her anxieties drive her into a nearly crazed state. He would have to talk her down, refocus her on more productive ways to cope with her stress.

Entrapa looked guilty and refused to raise her head up from the floor. Scorpia knelt beside her offering her reassurances. She couldn't help Catra anymore so refocused her need to take care of her friends on Entrapta.

“I should not have shared my data with Glimmer about the Eternian's...or Adora wanting a portal left open...that was a secret?” Entrapta whispered meekly into Scorpia's ear. She moaned, flipping down her visor as her expression crumbled into tearful remorse.

“I don't know about that? I am glad you didn't say anything about Queen Angella being in Catra's dreams, though.” Scorpia responded quietly.

“Why...I thought that may be good news?” Entrapta whispered back, her voice oddly modulated as she sought to conceal her sobs.

“Glimmer thinks she's dead, if you can't figure out a way to bring her back. Why give her hope?” Scorpia whispered back earnestly.

“Ah...I don't understand secrets...” Entrapta frowned, before picking up her recorder that no doubt had a permanent record of the huge fight. With her head down in forlorn contemplation she quickly left the room.

Scorpia watched her go, heaving a great sigh and rising back to her feet.

Adora was so agitated she couldn't stay and quickly retreated out of the atrium as well. Following Entrapta. She needed to go punch out all these intense feelings, or just exhaust herself somewhere

by running laps. She doubted she was going to sleep tonight anyway.

Scorpia nodded and followed after Adora, she needed some air as well. She was not happy about how cruelly Mermista had jumped on Catra and discredited all the good she had done. Or how unjustified she felt Glimmer's frustration and rage was towards her. Both of them had been way out of line in her opinion. Catra needed a little understanding and patience, she wasn't the easiest to get along with but she had a good heart. She had not been sitting idle about protecting the Etherian's, she had sought help from people she trusted. Friends that she knew understood her better then it seemed these princesses did. She had been uncertain and scared of what the outcome would have been and needed to go about it discreetly. Before offering any information that might ruin her fragile friendship with them. She had been trying to do good on her own terms, Scorpia saw nothing wrong with it. Catra had been a Force Captain for years and a damn good one too. Catra wanted so desperately for the Princesses to like her, to give her a second chance. To feel worthy to stand with them. Scorpia understood all of that very well. She was feeling rather angry and disappointed with the princesses in general and needed some time alone to sort it all out.

It was Perfuma who broke the silence several minutes later. "It seems our Alliance has divided."

"What do you mean?" Glimmer questioned anxiously.

"Well, all the former members of the Horde have left." She responded, in a clipped tone.

Glimmer chewed her bottom lip, as a sudden wave of guilt washed over her. She couldn't help but fret that this fight might be the breaking point. Perhaps just like her mother, she had just broken her own Alliance.

"Perhaps at our next meeting, we could try to understand them more and judge them less." Perfuma instructed gently, casting

Glimmer and Mermista pointed looks.

As Catra fell, she could feel her tears floating away in the wind. It roared in her ears and froze the moisture to her cheeks. Squeezing her eyes shut, she stubbornly willed herself to stop crying. Even after all these years, rejection still hurts as sharply as ever. After the defeat of Horde Prime the Rebellion had an impromptu celebration back at their last camp. Which had been the Hordes' old hidden compound in the Whispering Woods. Catra had launched many bot strikes against the rebellion from that place just a year earlier. Until her fight with Glimmer that had torched a good deal of the inner structure. At first she had felt awkward and guilty about being with the rebellion in that place. But over time she was thankful for it's well hidden location and well armored walls. They could always count on that bunker, to keep them safe. As they had freed local villages and towns nearby from Primes clones. During that time she had managed to develop a tentative friendship with Frosta, which was more of a truce. The young princess no longer wished to punch her in the face, but she never really warmed up to her much either. Netossa and Spinerella had warmed up to her somewhat, as she had joined in their competition as to who knocked out more clones during their supply raids on Primes Spires.

But that night after the war with Prime, she met the consequences of her previous actions head on. Shedding tears both happy and sad as she sought absolution. By seeking to make amends with everyone she had hurt. Scorpia had been the easiest, she forgave her effortlessly. They ended up having a long, heart to heart in private just beyond the camp in a small glade. Her attempt with Mermista had been an awkward disaster. She wasn't receptive to any sort of apology or promises to help amend her past transgressions. Her words alone she knew were not enough. But had hoped to prove herself to the water princess in time. She had promised Adora that she would work hard to make things right. The task just seemed so daunting at the time.

Now...it just seemed impossible...

She snapped her eyes open, refusing to wallow in her negative feelings of being unworthy. Pushing away those terrible thoughts that Adora would be better off without her. She had promised Adora she would do better, be better. Perfuma had helped her see how blind her negative emotions made her. So she refused to give into the anger, the despair, or the indignity of having to retreat. Which meant not giving up, she had to keep trying to prove her worth to the others. She just needed some time alone to regroup, resurrect her courage to face them all again.

Catra landed a few stories down on a smaller balcony, taking a deep breath as she slowly rose to her feet from her crouched position. Taking in her surroundings in a slow circle, finding this balcony was carved from the same white marble as the one high above. A large wooden door dominated the back of the balcony, with two, narrow, open arching windows flanking the door. The door looked ancient, with deeply carved designs she understood quickly. They were the twisting threads of magic, woven into countless knots. All individual and distinct but also interconnected. All the knots held a central heart where all the threads intersected. Catra sniffled and wiped the cuff of her leather coat under her nose, the wind had been cold and it had made her nose drip a little. Then she brushed her fingertips down the designs thoughtfully for a time before she pulled open the heavy doors. She entered into a small, cozy room. A study of some sort, with a large, ornate fireplace carved into the marble walls. In which a fire was already burning quietly. It seemed to flicker in greeting as she entered, filling the room with a soft incandescence that set her turbulent emotions at ease. Walls of wooden shelves covered the last two walls, filled with books and odd relics, maps, scrolls. There was a small couch and two comfy chairs before the fireplace, all clustered around a low round table. A large, ornate carved, mahogany desk was tucked against the far corner with a finely carved wooden chair, with plush white cushions.

Catra moved through the room, quizzically touching the relics, pulling out various books and reading their titles before setting

them back. Making her way over to the fire and curling up on the couch. Tucking her tail protectively around her waist, as she contemplated the fire, a sense of calm descended upon her. Here she felt hidden, she felt safe...

“Melog...” She moaned, willing the magical feline to come to her side and soothe the heartache that was seeking to consume her.

Adora had been wandering the streets of Mystacor like a ghost, lost in her troubled thoughts. Moving through the refugee camps with the hood of her cloak pulled up. Concealing her identity while navigating through the huddled masses. She was far too messed up inside her head to offer them any sort of support. She had lived her life for others, duty and sacrifice had been the cornerstone that had defined her. She knew now that she could be selfish at times, that the way she was before was self destructive. That giving away all of herself to others was slowly killing her. She was allowed to want, to put her own needs first, to be loved...without having to earn it. Taking that step back and not trying to control...or fix everything...that self restraint was a little harder.

So she observed her surroundings at a distance, the people of Etheria were scared, unsure about the future and seeking guidance here in Mystacor. She needed to trust that others could handle this. So that she could move forward to handle other problems that were more She-Ra centric. But right now, she is focusing on being more Adora centric. Trying to figure out how to move forward and repair the damage she had caused by losing her self control. Her silent self reprimands burned in her gut, over how poorly she had handled her anger. The guilt had been chipping away at her all night.

Hours passed, as she wandered aimlessly. Somehow Adora had found herself standing in front of Light Spinner's statue in the Hall of Sorcerers. Her stone had been burned and desecrated when

she had been banished, illustrating to every student, teacher and visitor to this great hall of magic that she was disgraced.

“I will never understand you? " Adora gazed up, upon her burnt visage in sad confusion. “You raised me to be the perfect soldier. A cruel, heartless weapon you intended to use for your own ends. You would show me kindness only when I had earned it. Yet, Catra was capable and achieved all the same laurels I did. Yet, you never showed her an ounce of kindness or even a shred of validation for her own achievements. You were cruel and harsh and incapable of empathy for her. Why did you favor me, yet reject her? I will never understand? When we both got into trouble. You would verbally chastise me, your punishments were mild, restrained. But Catra would receive the full brunt of your anger, your cruelty was relentless towards her. Demeaning her, invalidating her... You constantly cut her down and made her feel worthless. I knew you punished her violently as well...tortured her with your magic. Marked her with your own hands, I saw the bruises on her wrists when you would drag her away. I found her crying many times in the barracks or her hiding places. I suspect you did far worse things to her, when you took her away, for what you called private instruction. It wasn't just that one time when we snuck into your sanctum...that you lost control and used your dark magic upon her. I think you enjoyed it! Releasing all your frustrations and anger out on a little, defenseless girl. When I had finally found the courage to protect her from you. You threatened Catra's life and told me that I needed to control her better. Told her that the only reason she was still around was because I was fond of her. That if it wasn't for me...she would have been dealt with already. Later in private you instructed me that her punishments were my fault. That if I could not teach her to control herself, then you would. That if I ever interceded upon your efforts to correct her behavior, you would take her away from me permanently. I didn't trust that you would merely assign her to another squad, I suspected you might just kill her outright. So I stopped protecting her and allowed you to hurt her, terrified you would take her away from me for good. You put me in my place, controlling me through threats and fear. So that I never fought

back again. My weakness...my cowardice...hurt her perhaps more than what you ever did to her. In the end, I could never really save her from you. Not then and not now...your broke her! She sees herself as a monster...who does not deserve love or forgiveness. She is incapable of ever being happy!" Adora bowed her head, sobbing quietly. "Yet at the end, you sacrificed yourself for us? Why? After everything...you chose to protect us and not claim the power you so desperately wanted. That one selfless act, helped save the world...yet. I still can't forgive you....and it hurts." Adora balled her hands into fists at her sides and wept before the stone effigy of the only person she had known as a mother.

Wanting to distract herself and pass the night, not wanting dwell on her recent mistakes or worry about Melog. Catra had moved to curl up on a flanking chair with a thick leather bound book. Finding that it was a tomb of ancient lore. She was quickly caught up in the myths and legends of Etheria. Some were short, mere fables and what seemed like children's tales, while other stories were longer filled with epic journeys and high adventure. These stories were far more enjoyable then those horror stories Shadow Weaver used to tell them about the Princesses or the fate of those who were sent to Beast Island. The Horde never read for pleasure, she was taught, reading was for gaining information or for training new skills. She strangely felt like she was breaking the rules, just sitting enjoying her imagination and the emotions the eloquent words were creating. So she instantly wanted to experience this again. Perhaps she would take this book with her when she left....she wasn't going to steal it, just borrow it until she was done with it. Then eventually...maybe... she would return it.

A strange smell caught her attention before she noticed the shadow, moving past the window. It was still several hours till dawn and the sky outside was dark. Starlight covered the sky, an eternal blanket of sparkling stars. The five greater moons and the four lesser moons, along with the three smaller satellites. Were

scattered across the sky outside the windows. Casting a faint glow upon the bastions, courtyards and battlements of Mystacor.

She lightly placed the book down on the low table. Before rolling off the chair, slinking low to the floor as she went up to the open window, brushing the pale white curtain aside. Silently crawling onto the thick wooden ledge, to peer discreetly out onto the balcony.

Finding a looming figure in a grey cloak, pressed against the heavy wooden door. He was scanning the edge of the balcony, deciding which way would be prudent to continue downward.

“Hey, there. Stranger.” Catra drawled, “You don't smell like you belong here.” She finished with a smirk. Leaping from the ledge and attempting to tackle the cloaked figure.

He was quick and light on his feet, side stepping her lunge with a twisting flourish. A sharp ring announced he had drawn a long curved sword from a wooden sheath at his hip.

“I do not care to fight...at least not yet.” He answered, his voice was low and smooth. Beneath the cloak, he wore a simple, flowing cloth tunic of a very pale yellow and a deep crimson sash crossed over his chest and shoulders. A leather armor bracer on his right wrist, that was also his sword arm. He did not wear boots but his feet were wrapped in leather bindings up to his knee with strange wooden shoes.

Catra was now standing before the heavy wooden door, bouncing on the balls of her bare feet.
“I really don't care what you want.” She shrugged, unfurling her whip from her hip with a snap. She flashed him her fangs and cracked her whip, intending to disarm him.

He laughed and raised a huge golden metal fist to catch the whip. Catra's eyes flew wide in surprise, as the stranger grasped her glowing whip cord and yanked it out of her grasp. His strength was incredible, closer to Hordak's when he had been in Entrapta's

power armor then She-Ra's. So she could work with that, she had been able to defeat Hordak. The Fright Zone had taken a lot of collateral damage but she managed to disarm and destroy his cannon and disable his armor. That may be a problem here in Mystacor, she hadn't cared how much their fight had wrecked the Fright Zone it had been a terrible place that deserved to be blown up. Mystacor though, it was beautiful and ancient. She would need to devise a new strategy that minimizes the damage.

“A gift from my superior.” He answered smugly, acknowledging his sword and gauntlet, as he tossed her whip over the balcony. “Triclops is an amazing weapon-smith.”

“Hey! That was a gift too!” Catra shouted indignantly. Dismally watching her whip disappear into the courtyard far below. Bitterly thinking that this outcome was so typical, she never got to keep anything she ever really cared about. Then took a deep breath, accepting the loss and refocusing herself.

“I know that name....the imp was screaming it back in the Fright Zone.” Catra narrowed her eyes in threat.

“It was a shame your She-Ra captured our Doom Seeker drone. But it is enough that we know she still exists. ” His tone was cheerful, smug.

“You will never get Adora!” Catra snarled.

“Adora...is it...your She-Ra...she is a First One...is she not?” He offered, as they circled one another on the balcony. Each trying to size the other up, calculating their next move.

Catra said nothing, grinding her teeth together in frustration. Already not liking how much knowledge he had about them. Angry at herself for stupidly blurting out Adora's name.

“That is so very interesting...she will be even more useful to my Lord.” He laughed. “What luck, to find Eternia's long lost princess....King Randor will be so grateful when we return her.”

The sudden revelation that Adora was royalty from Eternia struck Catra like a bolt of lightning. She gasped, then her emotional calm snapped.

“You will never take her!” Catra lost her control, screaming in rage. She rushed the cloaked figure, claws extended. He spun, using his cloak as a shield as he tossed it at her. Needing more ease of movement and space to evade. He flipped backwards and adjusted his stance as he landed. His long sword was held in one hand, across his chest in a defensive manner. His large golden gauntlet raised high to chop at her if she charged.

Catra batted the cloak aside, never taking her eyes off her opponent. She wasn't willing to play her trump card just yet, as she was still assessing his skills in combat. With his covering gone she could finally get a good look at him. He was tall, muscular but in a more athletic sense. His body was lean, built for agility and quick movements. Beneath the light cloth sash was leather armor dyed red and gold. His strong legs were wrapped in leather bindings, with strange wooden shoes on his feet. The soles looked to have two thin stilts that he balanced on. A thick utility belt adorned his waist, with an ornate wooden sheath on his left hip. He had deep, tan skin and a square jaw. With a black goatee and long moustache. Dark hooded eyes that were slightly slanted, stared at her in a calculating manner. Showing that he was a battle hardened warrior. His dark hair was tied up in a top knot, similar to how her father wore his hair. With two long sticks jutting out from the bun.

“You are the first Etherian aware enough to sense my presence.” he gave her a curt bow of respect.

“It wasn't hard, you reek of Eternian.” Catra wrinkled up her nose, waving her hands in disgust as a distraction. As she adjusted her feet, then jumped, swinging a leg wide, her attack was swift and smooth. Kicking the sword out of his grasp, it struck the heavy wooden door with a resounding thunk.

“Well played, young Sunna.” he chuckled, crossing his hand over his waist belt, producing a dagger.

“How many weapons do you have?” Catra complained, her ire quickly sobering. “How do you know my people?”

“There are Magicats on Eternia, they still call themselves the Sunna. The planet is infested with cats from many different prides. Your striped markings and tan fur speak of the Northern people.” He offered with a shrug. “But I have not seen any magicats here during my travels. It seems they have gone extinct.”

Catra was furious, her ears folded back and her tail bristled, lashing sharply behind her. She hissed and ducked low, rushing him on all fours. Changing course avoiding the dagger thrown at her, she rolled to the left, then charged, intending to attack low and take out his legs. When she noticed a magical ball attached to his belt, with a very familiar shimmering blue and deep lavender shade. As she closed into hand to hand range, the stranger struck down with his huge golden hand in a karate chop. The ball turned a brilliant red, sparking and flaring with her rage.

“Melog!” She cried in fright, changing her tactics in an instant. Instead of lunging upward with her claws, to attack the hand heading for her head. She thrust her hand along the stranger's hip, snatching the ball and curling into a defensive roll to avoid his strike. Rolling behind him and lunging forward into full sprint. Moving so swiftly, she was skidding along the other side of the balcony to slow her speed.

“What did you do to them!” Catra shouted, holding the ball protectively close to her chest.

 “The Melog....I have never encountered one, it is a rare treasure. It is said, they were once plentiful on Krytis, during the Great Unrest. Very impressive tools, if you know how to use them.” He smiled darkly, snapping his fingers.

The ball in Catra's hand popped in a puff of smoke, releasing Melog. Who stood before her double their size. They snarled and clawed at a smooth black collar that now adorned their neck. Staring down at her mournfully, pleading for her to save them. Catra narrowed her eyes, she had seen that collar before on the beast they fought in the Whispering Woods.

“It's too bad it has already bonded with someone, I had to force a command collar around its neck to get them to submit. With a bit of training they will obey.” He took in the concern Catra had towards the Melog. Coming to the realization that she was it's master.

“The Melog belongs to you then.” He observed, “ A Melog's magic is very versatile, it can become many things, highly adaptable tools. But also very mailable, collaring it was not much of a challenge. ” The stranger chuckled, “The Melog will be very useful to my Lord.”

“Release them!” Catra screamed, her heart leaping in terror. As she placed a comforting hand on Melog's neck, seeking to calm and reassure them.

“Alright, I am an honorable man. I will release this Melog only if you best me, young Sunna.” He offered, giving her a smug toothy grin.

Catra licked her bottom lip, worrying it a little with her teeth, as she slowly scrutinized him up and down with distrust.

“Will it be a fair fight?” She asked.

“As fair as any fight to the death would be.” He offered.

Melog whined and folded their ears back in dismay.

“Go sit, my pet!” The stranger shouted, pointing to the far side of the balcony.

Melog growled, then the collar hummed, shooting red lightning across their body. Melog howled in pain, forced to obey. Trudging over to the far side of the balcony and laid down. Staring at the stranger with loathing in their eyes.

Catra seethed, her tail lashing, barely holding back the flames that were threatening to burst from her soul. She was so furious at not being able to protect Melog. But she needed to wait, until she could use her magic to her advantage.

“Let's make this an even fight then.” Catra taunted, dashing for his sword and yanking it out of the door.

He made no effort to stop her, just stood smugly waiting for the inevitable outcome.

As soon as Catra grasped the hilt it sent a massive shock wave of red lightening, through her entire body. She screamed and released the hilt. The sword clattered to the balcony at her feet.

“That weapon does not belong to you, Sunna filth.” The stranger chuckled. “It was a gift to me by Lord Skeletor after I broke out of the Prison Star. It is proof that I am worthy to fight at his side. ”

“Skeletor...” Catra breathed, her whole body felt like it had gone numb.

“And what's your name then?” Catra rolled her neck and shook out her hands and feet. Needing to stall him long enough for her to feel her limbs again.

“I am simply called Jitsu, a humble warrior for hire.” he bowed, then charged.

Catra leaped up, rebounding off the marble above the doorway and aimed a roundhouse kick at Jitsu's face. The man blocked with his huge metal hand. Catra was unconcerned, twisting her body in mid air to adjust her attack. Landing both feet on his shoulders she spun and raked her claws down his back. Tearing

his shoulder blades to shreds and loosening the leather armor beneath his cloth tunic and sash.

Jitsu screamed and spun, lunging with his metal hand seeking to grasp her by the throat. Catra back flipped out his striking range, leaping onto a crouch on the railing.

“You're a little slow, warrior for hire...I guess your rates must be pretty cheap?” She laughed, casting him a cocky smile.

He was enraged that she had drawn first blood. He bellowed and charged for her again, his golden fist raised to pound her into the floor. Catra's eyes narrowed as she caught sight of a glint of a strange small object tucked in the inner folds of his tunic.

She needed to know what that was, it resembled a data crystal. Narrowing her eyes, she quickly devised a new plan to get in close and take it. As he struck down with his fist, demolishing the railing she had been standing on moments before. She leaped onto his giant fist, igniting her fire as she pushed his gauntlet downward. Leaping up and twisting in the air to stand on his shoulders, facing in the same direction as him. He screamed in agony, as his golden metal fist was engulfed in an inferno so intense it melted. The liquid metal was now dripping off his blackened fingertips onto the marble. His eyes went wild as he went into shock. Catra hung off his shoulders, foot claws digging into his sides, hooking an arm around his neck, burning his throat. Then she pulled herself up, digging a set of finger claws into his shoulder, as she leaned over his head, blinding him with her flames. She reached an arm inside his tunic and snatched the tiny crystal. Using her flames as a cover and a distraction as she picked his pocket.

She calculated her next set of moves, she was going to arch her back, into a handstand. Dig her foot claws into his shoulder blades. Then toss him the length of the balcony

But Jitsu wasn't going to fall for that. He was furious and beyond feeling any pain. He reached up with his burnt hand just as she finished grabbing the crystal, wrapping his thick fingers around

her neck. Catra gasped in fright at the incredible strength he still had after burning his hand so badly. With a roar of fury, he yanked her off his neck. Her flames intensified, as fear gripped her. He was a maniac? How could he still fight? She was burning his flesh to a cinder.

Jitsu ground his teeth, holding her tight in front of him. Her feet dangled off the ground, her hands clutching desperately to his seared fingers. The shard discarded to the balcony floor, forgotten. As panic and desperation set in. She had her back to his front and never saw the dagger he had pulled from his belt with his undamaged hand.

Her throat burned and she was struggling against his iron grip, which was slowly crushing her throat. Her fire sputtered and then went out. Then she felt the searing pain of the blade as it sunk into her chest just below her last rib. She tried to breathe but only produced a soft gurgle of blood. She knew at that point that the blade had gone deep, penetrating one of her lungs.

Jitsu sighed with disappointment, pulling out the blade and dropping it to the balcony. Then he dropped her as well. She struck the stone like a dead weight, clutching her side as blood seeped from the wound, staining her white shirt.

“Well fought, Sunna warrior.” He offered, striding over to Melog. “But you have lost, so the Melog belongs to me.”

“No!” Catra screamed in a strained voice, pushing herself up from the floor on trembling arms. Her voice fading as she coughed harshly, throwing up more blood.

Melog howled, their body turning black, mane snapping like a living blue fire. Jitsu merely snapped his fingers, a bubble expanded from the collar, enveloping Melog. Once imprisoned, the clear ball reduced in size forcing Melog to shrink.

Catra could barely see through the haze of tears and the searing pain now ripping threw her body. She screamed and curled up

into a ball, as her whole body began to quake and shiver. Every nerve was on fire, but this pain was bearable compared to the electrical current Prime had used in his purification bath. Catra quickly pushed beyond the pain, clenching her teeth she uncurled from her defensive position. She was struggling to take in enough air, her chest felt heavy. She was drowning slowly in her own blood. Her pride and her rage would not allow her to just lay there and die. She needed to keep fighting...until either Jitsu was dead or she was.

Her heart sank as she found both Jitsu and Melog were gone, but that small, dark blue crystal shard. She had stolen from his tunic lay hidden just beneath the window ledge. She quickly crawled over to the window, snatched it up and stood up slowly on shaking legs. Moving in a sluggishly unbalanced gait towards the outer doors of the study. With a cry of pain she yanked open a heavy door and slipped inside. She needed to find help, before she completely lost consciousness. She was bleeding out and could barely think straight. She needed to sound the alarm, that there was an intruder and that he had Melog. She couldn't lose them, she had to get Adora. She could still save Melog….there was still hope!

“Adora!” Catra screamed desperately, stumbling out of the doorway of the study and into the cavernous hallway. She felt unbearably hot, sweat was beading all over her body.

“Adora!” She shouted, clutching her side, feeling her blood soak through her shirt. Valiantly applying pressure to try and slow the blood loss. Her vision was blurry, reduced to a narrow pinpoint.

She was struggling to breathe. Panting in small, weak bursts as her throat filled with blood. The corridor stretched away from her, shapes she could not make out were moving towards her. She was succumbing to both oxygen and blood loss. Too stubborn and far too obstinate to just give in and die. Catra screamed as loudly and as forcefully as she could. Stumbling into the wall further down the corridor.

“Adora!” She wailed in fear, unable to continue to walk. She slammed her back into the cold marble of the corridor. Slowly slipping down the wall, faint wheezes whistled from her throat, as her violently trembling legs finally gave out. Panic and desperation was washing over her and she screamed as hard as she could again. Jitsu was getting away with Melog...she might never see them again.

She was going to die...right here, without ever seeing Adora again…

She crumpled to the floor, face pressed against the cold stone. A faint blur of someone finally came into view to hover over her. A thin, elderly man in an elegant robe of purple and grey knelt before her. His face seemed kind and overly wrinkled, with many heavy lines under his deep brown eyes. His hair was silver hanging around his shoulders in disarray, his eyebrows were bushy and unkept. His build might have been tall in his youth, but he was now hunched with age.

“Get the healers!” He commanded, his voice was deep and boomed in the wide hallway.

“Intruder....” Catra croaked out, her hands going limp.

The old man's eyes widened in fear as he saw the shard fall from her grasp.

“Alert the Guards! No one leaves the Citadel!” He bellowed, just as Catra gave up and allowed the darkness to take her.

Catra could hear Perfuma's gentle voice, it permeated the darkness like a soothing balm. She could feel the cool mist of the river striking the downy fur of her face and arms when the water crashed against the rocks beside them. The dull roar of the rushing water nearby was a dissonant undertone to Perfuma's guiding voice.

“I want you to focus on your breath. Feeling how your chest rises then falls, listen to your heartbeat as it slows, as your body begins to relax. Allow your mind to wander, do not stop the thoughts, but let them flow through you, then release them back into the nothingness they came from. Do not dwell in the past, learn from it, move forward from it. Do not fret over the future because it has not happened yet. Live in the present and be mindful of all the goodness that surrounds you. ”

The canteen in the horde barracks was a loud place, it hurt Catra's ears and she never liked to come eat when most the cadets were there. She usually planned her meals either at the beginning or end of meal time. But she had been brooding after getting into a fight with Lonnie, it had taken Adora's stubborn intention to miss supper with her. To get her to change her mind, she would never let Adora go without food because of her. They had promised a couple years ago to take care of each other, to always be together. She took that promise very seriously.

Now she was trapped sitting on the metal bench of a long table, with Adora at her side. Quietly eating her grey ration bar, keeping her ears folded to ease the loud buzz of too many voices echoing around her. Every time she glanced sideways, she would find Adora giving her that goofy, happy grin with the missing front tooth. The slash mark she had given her across her nose earlier that day in a fit of rage, looked angry and puffy.

She groaned and turned back to her ration bar, stubbornly. She would not say sorry, that would show weakness. She was not weak...but she felt really bad. She wanted to take that mark away from Adora to absorb it back into herself. She hated that she had lost control of her temper and hurt her.

“Adora....what happened to you?” Shadow Weaver's displeased voice floated above them.

Adora cast her face aside quickly so she wouldn't get a good look. "I'm fine, really. I just fell and hit some boxes."

Shadow Weaver would have none of it, her dark gloved hand snapped out and grabbed Adora's chin and forced her to look up at her. Adora swallowed and held back tears, her small hand fumbling under the table for Catra's seeking comfort.

While Catra dropped her ration bar to the tin plate, her eyes darting for a quick escape, twisting her hand out of Adora's grasp.

"Those look like claw marks." Shadow Weaver snarled, her mask cutting towards Catra in accusation.

"It was an accident..." Catra lied, eyes wide in fear. As dark energy enveloped her, red lightning binding her so completely she couldn't even blink. Her terrified eyes darted to Adora, pleading silently for her to save her.

"Please, Shadow Weaver, I'm fine...Please." Adora wailed, scrambling out of the bench, supper forgotten as she ran after Shadow Weaver, who was quickly striding out of the mess hall with Catra floating in tow. All the cadets at the other tables had gone quiet, they all knew that Adora and Catra had been caught only a few months earlier in Shadow Weaver inner sanctum, The Black Garnet Chamber. That those two were getting into trouble more and more often. Shadow Weaver's patience was thinning. All the cadets was terrified of her. Shadow Weaver found quickly that using Catra as a public reminder of her power, kept the cadets in line. It was a tactic she would come to use often over the years. Both verbally and physically putting Catra in her place in front of her peers, to re-enforce her power and to humiliated Catra.

"Adora...she needs to learn some restraint. She is not like you, she could really hurt you if you keep being so kind to her." Shadow Weaver heaved a disappointed sigh. When they had entered the dimly lit corridor just outside the mess hall. She crouched down and cupped Adora's cheek tenderly.

“I will get stronger....so she can't hurt me.” Adora offered, her blue eyes determined. “Please let her....go...” Her voice wavered and grew faint as Shadow Weaver stood up to hover over her in judgement then merely walked away with Catra in tow.

That commitment to become stronger, would come to consume her as she grew older. Needing to be the best cadet possible, valiantly trying to keep Shadow Weaver happy. To prove to her that Catra wasn't a bad influence or a distraction. Trying to keep her safe the only way she knew how. By being Shadow Weaver's perfect soldier.

Catra floated in Shadow Weavers magical prison, anguished tears threatening at the old woman's cruel but truthful words. Her heart hammering in fear as Shadow Weaver pulled her away down the dimly lit hallway. Watching in both dread and anger as Adora stood frozen in place, tears flowing down her round cheeks, allowing Shadow Weaver to take her away for punishment. Why didn't she try harder? Why didn't she protect me? It was one of many little betrayals that had slowly built up inside her, until Adora's defection at Thaymor shattered her heart. Then their trial inside the Crystal Castle broke their bonds completely.

It was the first time Shadow Weaver used the dark tendrils on her. Leaving her screaming and sobbing in the darkness of a small empty utility closet, deep in the forge, where no one could hear her over the sounds of the machinery. The magic fed off her guilt, her rage and insecurities, leaving her exhausted and far more compliant and easier to control...at least for a while.

The traumatic memory faded away, leaving Catra upon the crest of a small hill, face cast upwards to watch the heavy grey clouds part from covering the sun. The sun shone down in a brilliant pillar of light, warming her like nothing else could. She loved the sunshine..it reminded her of Adora. It was pure, warm and powerful.

She sensed her hovering just behind, that feeling of deep, penetrating scrutiny on her back was unmistakable. But Catra refused to confront the demon that had tormented her childhood.

"Why did you do it?" Catra asked, never turning around. She could feel the old woman's presence hovering behind her. She felt like a malevolent shadow, always standing in judgement. All the cruel words and actions bestowed upon her by this bitter, power hungry woman, had poisoned her heart. Making creating healthy, loving relationships with others near impossible. She was working very hard to overcome all her issues, to open her heart, trust others and try to feel she deserves happiness. But the venom of her youth, that told her she didn't matter, was useless, unworthy of love. Still lived inside her head, eating away at her soul like a cancer.

"As I have told you before." Shadow Weaver's voice whispered, in tired exasperation "I did what I had to do. I was trying to teach you, to make you stronger, smarter...more prepared to survive...no to conquer this cruel, unforgiving universe."

"But why, did my teaching have be so....different from Adora's" Catra swallowed, wrapping her arms around her middle as her stomach churned with anxiety. Her ears folded back, tail hanging low and tucked in supplication between her legs. This terrible woman was the closest person to a mother she had ever known. All she had wanted was a kind word, a little praise...perhaps a gentle touch that was honest and not manipulative.

"Because you are not like Adora...you were not born with power....you had to earn it!" She stated venomously. As if she despised Adora for it.

Catra sighed and rolled her eyes.

"You are also a magicat...your species. Does not behave, or think like hers, or even feel emotions in the same way." She began, her voice was strong and resolute in her convictions. That disdainful tone is thick in her words. She honestly believed that because

Catra was a hybrid she was less than, Adora. Nothing but an animal that needed training.

Catra's eyes narrowed in fury at hearing such a callous, totally unfounded bias. She was no different than Adora! But she ground her teeth and held her anger down, refusing to start an argument. She was honestly too tired to keep fighting with this vile woman, even after death.

"You required a firmer hand,...to ensure that when I have finished raising you. That you would be cunning, ruthless, unforgiving and capable of anything. Above all else, I needed you to conquer your rage but not extinguish it. It is your greatest strength if you could learn to harness it and not let it rule you. So I tried different methods to teach you, guide you, push you in all the ways I could. To invoke that anger, to temper it. I needed you to tame that demon, otherwise it would destroy you in the future." Her voice was soft and did not hold the snide, bitterness it used to when she spoke of her.

Catra huffed and rolled her eyes, unwilling to accept her explanation for abusing her.

"You loved Adora more than me!" Catra accused, in a desperate high pitched shout.

Shadow Weaver heaved a great, long suffering sounding sigh. "I couldn't love either of you." She stated, with a mild nonchalance.

Catra gasped, bowing her head and holding herself tighter. Shadow Weaver's affection for Adora had been false? It had all just been a ploy to hurt her? To make her angry and resentful? To train her to temper those feelings and not allow them to consume her...yet they had...she had not been strong enough...in the end. She had extended her own suffering for three long years in some vain attempt to feel worthy. To surpass Adora and win for once. Realizing too late that that was not what she really wanted.

“After the spell of obtainment, my soul was corrupted.” Shadow Weaver began, “You can understand that, can you not? I was lost to the portal's unstable reality for a time when the Fright Zone had been absorbed. Slowly, I regained my true memories. Fractured and out of sync as they were. I managed to put them together into something coherent. I found my magic was anchored to the both of you. I remained out of sight, within the Whispering Woods as you two confronted one another honestly, for the first time in years. Adora tried to get through to you, tried to show you how much she regretted leaving you and that she wanted you with her. But you were still so consumed by your rage and resentments. You allowed the portal's dark energies to devour you? Did you feel that ancient parasitic evil take over your soul and twist it upon your deepest, darkest desires. Just like it did to me, when I was devoured by the Deep Magic of the spell of Obtainment.”

Catra snarled, her claws pressing painfully into her skin at her elbows. “Yes...it turned me into a monster....I was consumed by resentments for Adora. My rage was out of control...and my pain and heartache defined all of what remained of me...I hated everyone, mostly myself, so much...I let that darkness destroy me...” Catra took several gasping breaths as she remembered feeling her body burn away into nothingness. Reliving the brutality of her time in the portal was horrific and she soon felt a panic attack pressing upon her chest. She labored to breathe, stubbornly focusing on her feet refusing to show any hint of weakness.

Shadow Weaver noticed how scared she was and offered Catra comfort. By placing her hand upon her shoulder. When Catra stiffened, she pulled her hand back. Slowly releasing a frustrated breath, accepting that her wards discomfort at her touch was her own doing. Squaring her shoulder she resumed her full disclosure, staying focused as always on what she felt she needed to do. “I was incapable of positive feelings for the longest time. I had been changed, twisted to my darkest desires for power and control. I fought that darkness as best I could, but it was a struggle that I did not always conquer. Unfortunately, you were the target of

those desires. It wasn't until Adora healed me with her magic, purging the parts of my soul that had been tainted. That I was able to reclaim more positive feelings again. She healed my soul but was unable to heal my body. My scared body was a reminder that I had over reached and messed with powers beyond my ability to control. So I retreated to my garden in Bright Moon to reflect and prepare for the end game so to speak. It was there I found clarity and began to reclaim who I once was....as Light Spinner..." Shadow Weaver's voice was soft and pensive. "In the end, I was able to resist the pull of my less than desirable qualities and choose what I truly wanted. I died so that you and Adora could live. Your future is not set in stone, remember that. I wanted both of you to find the happiness that was denied me." Shadow Weaver's confession left Catra stunned. She stared wide eyed down at the grass, her heart thundering in her ears. Silence reigned for a long time, as she listened to the old woman's heavy breathes as she struggled to maintain her calm resolve. Her despair and perhaps her own guilt was overwhelming her. She was having difficulty remaining stoic, but Catra refused to turn around. Too stubborn or perhaps too hurt to comfort her. She had tried several years back, a small gesture of verbal reassurance when Shadow Weaver had been chastised by Hordak. Her attempt at kindness had been promptly rejected and turned against her. As Shadow Weaver verbally tore into her yet again. There was just too much animosity between them, now.

"When I saw that you two had mended ties and were once again together, I had hoped you had finally gotten over your anger and was once again thinking clearly." Her voice was louder, stronger. Her words resonate in Catra's ears, urging her to finally turn around. But Catra did not turn to acknowledge her, too scared or perhaps too proud to give the old woman what she craved.

"I pushed Adora at the Fail Safe, I wanted to know how solid your relationship was again. She came to your defense immediately. I wasn't disappointed, until you ran." She growled. Catra released a frustrated breath, letting her arms fall and balled her fists at her sides.

“I came back, when it counted.” Catra defended, her voice wavering with regret. She remembered finding Shadow Weaver back at the Rebellion's hideout, drinking from a goblet. She hadn't thought too much about it, to worked up about the Primes virus and was desperate to get to Adora's side. But wondered now why she had been drinking? Was she celebrating or wallowing in her failure?

“I have carefully crafted a dynamic between the two of you, that would protect you both. Adora was my champion, she had the will and determination to always prevail. Her spirit is strong and resilient, like a shield. I taught her to never give up, to always protect the ones she cared for. You on the other hand were far too stubborn, cunning and disobedient. You would forever rail against authority. So I punished you to train you to overcome anything, physical or mental. To keep your head when in a crisis. To harness those more wild qualities that live inside you as a weapon and to always fight back! I sharpened you like a sword, Catra.” Shadow Weaver took a breath wanting her words to sink in. Catra stood mute, focusing on her breathing as the truth began to settle inside of her.

“I needed you two to stay loyal to each other. So I cultivated the us against them mentality that dominated your childhood. So that no matter what happens, no matter what transgressions or misunderstanding get in the way. I needed to know that you would always find your way back to each other. ” Shadow Weaver's voice was painful, but resolute.

“No....You abused me...abused Adora....I can't forgive that?” Catra growled out between clenched teeth. Refusing to acknowledge that this vile woman had instilled anything worthwhile in either of them.

“What you saw as abuse, I saw as training! I will not apologize.“ She stated, waiting for a moment, her reproachful stare boring into Catra's back. But Catra still refused to turn around, biting her bottom lip to stop it from trembling. Willing the tears in her eyes

to dry, never wanting to look weak or vulnerable around Shadow Weaver.

"I will admit, my methods were unconventional, perhaps a bit harsh. But I was charged with a very important task, one I could not fail." Shadow Weaver sighed. "Every move I made after cursing myself with the Deep Magic was calculated, my child. For the greater good. I joined Hordak, not because he had power. But because it is always better to stay close to your true enemy. I was able to gain his trust for a time and became his second in command. I held his forces in check for over a decade, so that the Horde could not overrun Etheria. When the first Princess Alliance fell into ruin. Placating that tyrannical shut in, with small victories, encouraging his vanity projects to distract him from advancing his troops. Maintaining our borders but doing little else to gain more territory. I was there to claim Adora, when Hordak would cast her aside to be forgotten. In turn, Adora would be alive and well to find you...and care for you in all the ways I could not. I did not abandon you in the Fright Zone, I had to guide Adora to her greatest truth. I had to guide Glimmer towards her true power...I was needed in Bright Moon. I did not come back just to save Adora and not you. I asked you to come with us, I pleaded for you not to fight against me. But you were still so angry. You left me no choice but to bind you and leave you behind. You had made your choice and I knew it was a trial you needed to conquer, so that you would be wiser and stronger for what is yet to come."

"What are you even talking about?" Catra snarled, shaking her head bitterly.

"Above all else. I have always wanted to protect Etheria. At first I felt I needed power to save it from the Horde. I paid a great price for that glimpse of great power and it scarred and haunted me for the rest of my life." Shadow Weaver's voice was barely a whisper, sounding profoundly sad.

"Shadow Weaver..." Catra's voice was soft, nervous. She was leading up to some even bigger truths and it made her very

unsettled.

“The spell of obtainment was dark magic, it was parasitic... When I devoured Head Master Norwyn, I absorbed his magic. He was a powerful mage, far superior in power then even me. I was shocked but intrigued that this righteous man hid such a dark secret. I was not the only sorceress in Mystacor researching forbidden magic. He was tethered to the deep magic of time....and so too was I. In the split second after I had consumed him. I saw the future and it was truly frightening. Me, Hordak...Horde Prime....we were all just stepping stones for you and Adora to conquer. A true evil still awaits you. Adora is a child of Destiny...One pushed through Space. Your destiny has always been tied to hers, as the child pushed through Time. I needed to prepare the both of you...one to defend...one to attack...the Nameless One is coming...it is inevitable.” Her voice was low and full of fear.

Catra stared down at her feet, her eyes full of confusion as a cold lump of foreboding grew inside her stomach. She started to tremble, Shadow Weaver's words had held such prominence it had truly scared her.

“Look at me, Catra?” Shadow Weaver pleaded, her voice stern and unapologetic.

With a heavy sigh, Catra finally obeyed. Turning hesitantly to find Shadow Weaver standing just behind her. With the sun beating down upon them, the taller woman seemed thin, frail and at peace. She no longer wore the red and black robes she had in life. But a long simple lavender gown, her dark hair fluttered behind her in the wind like a cape. Her soft blue toned face was no longer scared, or hidden behind a mask or even a veil. Her emerald green eyes were clear and untainted by dark magic. She looked more like, Light Spinner now, instead of the twisted, bitter woman she had become.

“That 'training' wasn't fair, it was cruel!” Catra spat furiously, as the tears she had been stubbornly holding onto started to fall

from her eyes.

"Catra...the universe is not fair or kind. You needed to learn that, to become strong. So you could be smarter and more ruthless than I ever was. So you could survive what is to come...and do not give me the excuse again that you were a child and did not deserve it." Shadow Weaver sighed and offered Catra a small, resolute smile. "We deserve only what we obtain ourselves, through hard work, study or ambition."

"You are never going to apologize to me. Are you, old woman?" Catra gave her a thin, disappointed grimace.

"I do not see why? I have done nothing wrong." Shadow Weaver shrugged, her pride refusing to allow her to concede any wrong doings. Yet she offered Catgra a weak, regretful frown that quickly faded away as she grew serious. Slowly reaching out and grasped Catra's hands. Catra cringed and tried to jerk away, it was instinct but it only frustrated Shadow Weaver. Who took a deep breath and stared down at Catra, her eyes stern and unblinking.

"The Deep Magic I absorbed gave me visions. When I first held Adora I felt incredible power, I saw where she came from, her future to obtain the Sword of Protection and onwards towards the very end of her life. It was the same when she brought you to me as a kitten. Except with you I saw backwards in time, where you came from and the destruction of the old world. But your future was not offered to me. I was able to put the pieces together over the years as I raised you both. So I had to prepare both of you for what is to come. Know that I may not have been kind, or just in how I raised you girls, but that I have always had the best of intentions. I am a teacher and I care for my students. Even if they are stubborn, hot headed, insolent brats who reminded me far to much of myself." Shadow Weaver smiled, fondly down at Catra. Who in turn began to smile bitterly up at her, her words were not a complement as far as Catra was concerned.

"I can never forgive you, for what you did to me, how you treated me." Catra stated, her thin smile vanishing in an instant.

“I would never expect you to.” Shadow Weaver nodded, her smile was accepting and full of pride. Just like it was in her final moments before she sacrificed herself for her children.

“Did you mean it?”Catra cast her eyes downward timidly. “Back at the Heart, did you mean what you said? That you are proud of me?” Her voice was soft, almost pleading.

Shadow Weaver pulled one hand free and placed it tenderly on Catra's cheek. Rubbing her thumb tenderly up and down the soft fur. “I meant every word of it, even back in my cell in the Fright Zone. When you finally fought back against me, shattered my power stone. I knew then, you were far stronger, braver and more capable than I ever gave you credit for. That you had overcome your fear, found the inner strength and resolve to protect yourself and those weaker than you.” Shadow Weaver smiled down at her fondly, Catra's eyes grew wide in shock. Her cheeks flared at the praise, the validation she had always wanted and she offered her mother a warm accepting smile. She would never be able to forgive Shadow Weaver for her cruelty but in the twisted woman's mind it had held a purpose.

“Your time is up, Light Spinner.” Angella shimmered into existence just beside Shadow Weaver. Her body was made of pure light as it always was in Catra's dreams.

“Do not leave her side...Catra...from now on. She is going to need you more than ever.” Shadow Weaver released her hands and faded away, as if she was just a trick of the sunlight.

Catra turned to Angella in confusion and awe. Angella smiled sweetly down at her, hands folded gently before her.

“I am going to find a way to get you back to Glimmer. I'm sorry for trapping you here.” Catra apologized.

Angella reached out with a hand and placed it upon her head. Her affection was honest and full of motherly love. “I am where I need to be, Catra. Please do not feel that this is your fault anymore. I

need you to move on...it's time to heal." Then she too faded into the sunlight.

The Weaving

Strong arms holding her close, a familiar warmth seeping into her cold, aching body. The soothing scent she trusted most, surrounded her. As she was gently lifted from the hard floor.

“Catra...stay with me...ok.” Adora's voice was trembling with fear.

Then the incredible power of She-Ra coursed through her. Catra could hear herself cry out sharply. Her voice falling into a strangled whimper as the heat of the magic pulsed threw her. The searing pain of the stab wound eased and then faded away, as the gaping wound mended. Her whole body was left tingling with the healing magic, as she slowly opened her eyes. Finding She-Ra's relieved face staring down at her, her brilliant blue eyes glowing fondly.

“Hey, Adora.” Catra sighed, smiling sweetly up at her savior. “This is kinda getting to be a bad habit...huh?” Catra jokes, reaching a shaky hand up to cup She-Ra’s cheek tenderly. Finding her flushed skin was wet from tears. “Sorry...” She muttered weakly, before falling unconscious. She was just too tired to stay awake. Her physical body felt whole again, but the burning deep inside remained.

Catra was unbearably hot, the sweat that was bathing her body roused her from sleep. She slowly opened her eyes, finding herself under a light cotton blanket in a large four post bed of dark oak. Heavy velvet curtains of the deepest lavender were pulled open along the sides of the bed. A small mountain of throw pillows had been tossed in the far corner. She could see a fragment of the starlit sky through a long arching window just beyond the bed. It looked to be past midnight perhaps, as all five of the Greater moons were hanging high, amid those stars. Long gossamer curtains fluttered in the cool breeze along the sides of the window. Catra closed her eyes waiting for the cool air to

soothe her, moaning in disappointment when it did nothing to ease her discomfort. Opening her eyes once again to continue her survey of the room. The window was deeply set allowing a cushioned bench similar to the atrium to sit beneath. The gentle tranquility of the night was not lost on Catra, she sought to bask in it. But her mind was still roiling with anxiety since her last battle and ominous dream she just awoke from, so she couldn’t enjoy it. She took a steadying breath, closing her eyes as she sought to clear her head. Valiantly searching for the peace Perfuma spoke about that always seemed to elude her.

A dull headache was pounding just behind her eyes, making her sick to her stomach. With a moan she turned her head to find Adora asleep beside her. Her face in repose was so very beautiful, with thick blonde lashes fluttering against her cheeks. Her long hair that was loosened from her ponytail, framing the gentle curve of her cheeks, her pony tail fanning out behind her shoulders as she slept on her side facing Catra. She hadn't gotten undressed, sleeping on top of the blanket with her clothes on. Her maroon cloak was discarded somewhere within the room. No doubt so worked up over everything she couldn't relax fully, wanting to be prepared for anything. Catra reached out with a hand and brushed her fingertips softly down her cheek, smiling faintly in the dim light cast by the moons. She was grateful for the time she had been given to be with Adora. This second chance... to repair and strengthen the bond that had been so brutally severed by her, during the war. She wanted to stay just like this, silently admiring the woman she had loved in secret for years. Knowing that she also loved her, needed her....just as fiercely.

Adora hummed and pushed her cheek into her fingertips unconsciously. Craving her touch even in sleep. Catra’s fond smile fell into a forlorn grimace, ...she didn't want to say goodbye. But she knew something was wrong with her. She-Ra's healing had not worked like before. An intense burning sensation still gnawed deep inside of her. Jitsu had stated it had been a fight to the death and she had lost...so...what had he done to her?

She looked down at herself, finding that Adora had undressed her, leaving her in just her underwear. Her wrap style bra felt wet, sweat was trickling through the soft tawny fur between her breasts. Pooling into the crevasse and soaking the thin garment. The burning flared deep inside her, she groaned and rolled over towards the outside of the mattress. She was suddenly very dizzy and nauseous. She felt like she was going to retch and she was not going to do it on the bed. With a small cry, she forced herself out of bed, stumbling into the cold stone wall of their bedroom. Slipping to her knees as the room tilted sickeningly.

“Catra!” Adora cried out in alarm as she heard the dull thud of a body striking the floor. Rushing out of bed to Catra's side, lifting her gently up from the floor by her underarms. Then wrapped a supporting arm around her waist.

“What's wrong?” Adora inquired, her steel blue eyes wide and fearful. As she gently guided Catra slowly towards a large wooden chair, with an elegant pillow on the seat. That sat near a small finely carved granite fireplace, on the far side of the room.

“I don't feel so good.” Catra moaned as she sat heavily onto the soft cushion of the chair. Her head slumped forward as she had no energy to even lift it up. Then her stomach lurched and she swung herself away from Adora, vomiting onto the slate floor. She hadn't eaten much today so it wasn't a-lot, mostly bile and water.

“Catra!” Adora gasped in shock, her voice filled with alarm and worry.

“Is she going to be ok?” Finn's small voice floated to her.

Catra's ears twitched at the sound of his sweet voice and she palmed her face with a hand as further nausea started to pull her down.

“Jitsu....he has Melog.” Catra moaned, her voice barely a whisper. Her body twitching with the need to move and hunt down that

Eternian bastard that had collared them.

Adora never heard her, as she turned to focus on Finn. Who was lightly shuffling towards them, not wanting to make much sound and disturb Catra. Since they were both Hybrids. He understood that when you were sick. Certain sharp sounds and pungent smells would make you feel worse. He had been sleeping on a bed roll in the other corner of their room. Having demanded to remain at their side now that they were back together. He stood in just his tight thigh length black underwear and a loose white tank top that he wore as a shirt under his parka. A thin silver chain hung around his neck with a heavy amulet, which was obscured by his shirt. He twiddled his fingers nervously, as Adora jumped to her feet rushing out of the door.

“I will be right back with a Healer!” She shouted, jumping into action. Leaving Finn standing perplexed and uncertain before the slumped form of Catra in the chair. Leaving him to take care of Catra until she returned. Finn moved cautiously towards Catra, leaning down to catch her eyes, offering her an encouraging smile.

“Tummy ache?” He offered, pointing to the vomit now steaming on the floor beside the chair.

“Yes...” Catra growled, trying to rally the energy to move so she could clean it up. Knowing that some little kid was not going to be of any help. The sharp smell of it hurt her nose and she was very embarrassed. With a groan she shifted her weight in the chair, preparing herself to get up.

Finn placed two small hands on her shoulders and pushed her back down.

“I got this, Grumpy Cat.” He gave her an earnest smile, then dashed away.

“You don't have to kid.” Catra called weakly.

“I know..” He offered, returning a minute later with a bucket of water and towels. He quickly mopped up the vomit with one towel, then dashed away to the pantry to throw it out. Returning a moment later to wash the floor with another towel before taking the bucket and wet towel away. His cleaning was quick and efficient for a little kid. Catra sighed heavily, he was more capable then he should have to be at his age. He really had been all alone in the world, working for the last few years.

“I'm sorry...” Catra muttered, when Finn returned with the cotton blanket from the bed. As he had noticed she was starting to shiver.

He wrapped the blanket around her front and tucked the edges behind her shoulders.

“For what?” He asked innocently.

Catra smiled bitterly, he didn't know she had been one of the Horde Soldier's that attacked his village.

“Nothing...” She slurred faintly, closing her eyes as the pain and dizziness dragged her down into a restless sleep.

Adora's boots were pounding down the long colonnade just outside their rooms. The ornate marble pillars and arches that ran the length of the arcade were a blur as she ran. Not noticing the loud noises her boots were making on the cobblestones, drawing the attention of the other princesses. Each one opened their doors in confusion as she ran past their rooms. Pushing herself to go faster, she had a long way to go to get back to the citadel on the other side of the island.

She-Ra’s healing had never failed her before? Was she losing her connection to the magic again? A cold ache of dread forming in her gut at that thought. What had that intruder done to Catra? Fear and anxiety screamed inside of her, eating away at her calm. Driving her into a frenzied panic. As she rounded the corner of the

Adepts Dormitory where Castaspella had put them. An old two story building of mortar and stone with outer colonnades on each floor that sat just south of Basilica. The simple peaked roof was covered by clay tiles. At each slightly flared corner of the gable, a stone snake was coiled. Tears were streaming down her face as she rushed across the southern courtyard.

The massive outer walls of stone and white marble of the Basilica stretched to the sky on her right. Built in the Forgotten Age just after Mara stranded Etheria in Despondos. It was the very first structure to be built on the ruins of the Arxia outpost. The massive scope and elaborate architecture was astounding. With a massive steeple at the eastern end, that rose like an elegant, pure white tower. Ascending out of view high into the night sky, like the gleaming point of a star . The basilica's giant central dome, was constructed of clear crystal. It shone like a burnished gemstone under the gentle light of the Etherians' many moons. The central hall with its overarching ceiling was beautifully carved, with elegant serpents, twisting and spiraling into intricate knots. Beyond the ancient cathedral, stretched the gardens and orchards that sustained this compound that was so far out from the citadel. Adora would have to navigate through that forest, in the dark and hopefully not get lost. Her task to get Catra help was looking more and more daunting.

“Adora!” Glimmer's concerned voice penetrated the fog of panic clouding her mind. Adora was flushed with stress and fear as she spun, refusing to slow her gate.

Glimmer came charging up to her, her face just as flushed and slick with sweat. Dressed in her night clothes of a thin lilac gown and soft blue shawl thrown over her shoulders to combat the chill in the night air. She lunged out and grabbed Adora's hand, forcing her to lurch to a stop and spin around to face her.

“She-Ra's healing didn't work. Catra's sick. I need to get a healer!” Adora screamed out in a rush, her face pale and eyes wide with panic. Her heart was hammering in her chest, fear roaring in her ears as every muscle was on fire with the need to keep moving.

Glimmer gripped her shoulder's her eyes flaring wide in alarm. Never in her life did she want her Rune Stone powers more, it was miles for Adora to run to get across the island. She never doubted she could do it and if she transformed into She-Ra she could run even faster. But if she could teleport they would be there in seconds. Glimmer squeezed her eyes closed, willing that empty place in her soul where the Moonstone's power used to be to come alive again.

“Glimmer...what are you doing?” Adora inquired, impatient to keep going. Glimmer looked like she was in pain, with her eyes squeezed tightly shut and eyebrows scrunched together. Her lips pressed into a thin, tight line.

“I'm trying to teleport us.” Glimmer ground out, trying to focus. Now regretting all the times back on Darla when she had harassed Adora while she was trying to learn how to summon She-Ra.

Adora bit her bottom lip, counting in her head. If Glimmer couldn't manifest her powers in the next minute, then she would just have to transform and leave her behind.

A loud cackling echoed out from the night sky. Both Adora and Glimmer looked up, as a wild streak of white energy went shooting over the crystal dome of the Cathedral. Landing in the courtyard that sat in the middle of their dorms.

Glimmer cast Adora a concerned look before running back to the dormitory. Adora jogged in place for a moment uncertain as to what to do. Then with a frustrated howl she ran back to the dorms as well. Finding Madame Razz dismounting her broom and shuffling quickly across the open air courtyard. Razz's wild white hair was windblown, with leaves and twigs sticking out of it. Her pink shawl and white ruffled, maroon dress floated over her feet as she moved briskly across the cobblestones. She had a large, old weathered bag, hanging over her shoulder full to bursting with things she may need. Holding her broom tight she quickly moved through an archway into the colonnade that ringed their rooms. Adora and Glimmer quickly caught up to the old woman.

“Madame Razz, what are you doing here?' Adora asked, bending down so the little old woman could hear her.

“Oh, dearie.” Madame Razz stopped and patted Adora on the cheek, smiling up at her with deep affection. Her dark fathomless eyes were large behind her thick glasses, blinking in slight confusion, before clarity struck. “It is so nice to have the magic back. Broom has never felt better!”

“Your...Welcome...” Adora offered. “But...what are you...”

“I am here to help, Kaira.” Madame Razz nodded, “It has been ages since I last saw her. “ She muttered, then turned to Glimmer.

“Glimmer, dear. Please go fetch your Auntie and the healers, we may still need them. ” The old woman's voice was low, speaking just to Glimmer, her eyes were warm but stern.

Glimmer had never met Madame Razz but the authority she held in her stare was familiar. She stood frozen for a moment before merely nodding, then jogged away. Adora stood a few feet away anxious to get to Catras' side, bouncing on her toes. The fact that Razz referred to Catra by her given name never even fazed her. It was not improbable at all for Razz to know who Catra had been a thousand years ago. Since she constantly mixed her up with Mara, who also lived a thousand years ago. Razz was a mystery, an enigma that you just accepted as is and Adora was grateful to have her in her life.

Madame Razz nodded and smiled fondly at Glimmer as she departed. Her eyes held a warm nostalgic gleam, of sweet remembrance. Then the old woman nodded and got herself back on track, rushing down the hall and into Adora's room. Adora was at her heels, closing the door behind them.

Adora was taken off guard for a bit at how coherent Razz was tonight. Usually the old woman was slightly confused but there

were times, only briefly, that Razz seemed to be in complete control of all her faculties.

Razz rushed to Catra's side, pressing the back of her hand against hybrid's forehead and muttering to herself.

“This will not do....this will not do....poor Kaira....” Then her gaze shot to Finn, who had been standing nervously on the other side of the chair. He cowered slightly as Razz's deep lavender eyes narrowed in scrutiny. She tutted in dismay and shook her head with disappointment. “You should not be here, Finn.” She stated sternly.

Finn swallowed hard, a small hand reaching hesitantly up to grip the talisman he had hidden under his shirt. Unable to withstand Razz's reprimanding glare. He quickly darted away into the small side room that held a tiny pantry for cleaning and food storage. Seeking to hide away from her, overwhelmed by their silent confrontation as frightened tears threatened.

Razz merely sighed and rolled her eyes, whispering epitaphs under her breath. She had been moving forwards and back in time for thousands upon thousands of years, now. Tasked with a sacred duty to watch over the shifting tapestry of time. It had taken a toll on her sanity, but she sought to ground herself as often as she could wherever or whenever she found herself. She had no control over how her body phased back and forth through the crossroads of worlds. Or what alternate dimension would carry her away for a while. There were so many...divergent paths...that she had to maintain.

Her grip on linear understanding was tentative at best, the past, the future, the present. It all just blended into her memory, leaving her uncertain and confused at times. But She-Ra had always been her anchor, she followed that thread of destiny back and forth endlessly. Threw countless incarnations, from the very beginning to the final days of existence. So she focused on that and made the best of each pocket of time she occupied, she was here to guide time along the best path. To help adjust the weft

and warp as the endlessly complicated tapestry was formed. That was her purpose...as an Immortal. As one of three Nemain.

“Razz what is going on!” Adora shouted, her voice pitched high with rising hysteria. Desperate to refocus the old woman back on task. Who had been glaring disapprovingly at the retreating Thaymorian.

Adora moved swiftly to the other side of the chair and knelt down, as Razz returned her focus back on Catra.

Catra groaned and her eyes fluttered open. She was really hot again and struggled to pull the blanket off. Her hands were trembling so badly she couldn't even grip the fabric. Adora helped, pulling the blanket down and dropping it into her lap. Seeing Catra so weak and fragile was unbearable. The storm of emotions that was rising inside of her was growing into a maelstrom of guilt and fear.
“She has been poisoned, my dear.” Razz sighed. “Move her to the bed.” She commanded.

Adora nodded, cradling Catra to her chest. Lifting her up fluidly with one arm under her legs and the other bracing her back around her waist, blanket and all. Catra moaned in protest, her breathing was raspy and quick as she curled into Adora’s embrace. Adora did not like how she was struggling to take in air. She set her down gently on the bed, tucking the blanket around her.

“So how do I heal her?” Adora asked, kneeling down again and clasping Catras cold, clammy hand tenderly to her chest. Her blue eyes were moist and stricken with fear, begging Razz for answers.

“This healing is complicated....it is in the weaving.” Razz stated, staring at her with sympathy.

“Why didn't She-Ra's healing work...I mean, I managed to cure the First Ones virus that was infecting me and Catra in the Heart?” She mused in vain. Casting Razz a confused frown.

Razz, sighed and scratched her head. “You knew what you were dealing with, Adora, dearie. You had held the sword of Protection for years. Mastering First Ones tech. Absorbing and purging your body of the Relic's magic. It had become as easy as breathing. So you knew perhaps unconsciously which threads needed to be pulled to cure their virus. Since it was infecting you and the Crystal Castle, which is First Ones tech as well. ”

“So I need to figure out what kind of poison is killing her...then I can heal her?” Adora nodded, her wet eyes full of hope.

“Yes...and no....you need to understand the weaving.” Razz repeated softly, setting her bag down with a clang. She began to rummage inside, pulling out a dented horde helmet and tossing it aside. Followed by a string of jade beads, a cracked vase and several long necked, glass potions.

“Can I help?” Adora offered, struggling to feel confident in the old woman's abilities, while she muttered in confusion over the completely random things she was pulling out of her bag.

“It's in here, I know I brought it.” Razz muttered, shoving her whole face into the bag next.

“He has Melog...” Catra spoke, her voice stronger but hoarse.

“Who has Melog?” Adora spun back to Catra in alarm.

“Jitsu....an Eternian.” Catra groaned, struggling to get up. Feeling a restless urgency to go and save them. She did not want to lose them, they had become so close...they were family. She could always rely on them for support both physically in battle and emotionally. When she could not deal with the intensity of her own feelings, they would always be there to soothe her, talk her down from spiraling into self destructive thoughts or just show others how she felt when she didn't have the words or the courage to show them. She couldn't lose them.

“Huntara, Bow and Swift Wind are tracking the intruder right now. The outer gates are locked down and the guards are on high

alert. He is not getting off Mystacor.” Adora assured her, cupping her cheeks with her hands and pressing her forehead to hers. Grimacing with worry when she felt how hot and damp the soft fur on her forehead was.

“I need to heal her...how do I heal her!” Adora was frantic, snapping her gaze back to Razz.

Madame Razz sighed, crushing a creamy pearl toned, marble shaped crystal in her palms then she moved to Catra's side and dusted the fine powder over her body.

Catra glowed a brilliant white for a moment then the light faded away.

“You cured her?” Adora smiled hopefully.

“I gave her time, dearie.” Razz patted her cheek. “The poison still courses through her veins.” She stated, her eyes dark and serious.

“How much time?” Adora demanded, her eyes firm yet frightened.

“She has until dawn.” Razz grimaced, her dark eyes behind the thick glasses were stern. Boring into Adora with the severity of her time limit.

“Then I will find this Jitsu and have him tell me what kind of poison he used. I'll be right, back.” Adora stood, her blue eyes fierce.

“I'm not going anywhere.” Catra quipped, thumping her head back against the pillow far too exhausted to move. It was a promise that went deeper than just words, after surviving and fighting for so long to be with Adora. To be free to love her how she had always wanted and to receive her love in return. She would not give up, she would not allow this poison to kill her. She had hope that Adora would find Jitsu and figure out how to cure her.

Adora bent down and gave her a gentle kiss, Catra smiled softly against her lips. She watched with pride as Adora stood and strode out of the room. Just as she crossed the threshold of the front door, she held her hand aloft summoning her sword. In a flash of brilliant light, She-Ra appeared. The raw magical power and sheer ferocious determination in her stride was absolutely terrifying.

Catra's smile faltered and she shivered at the same time. She-Ra had become more than just a magical warrior, she was pure power, unbridled and fearsome. With Adora's stubborn will and refusal to ever give up. This Eternian didn't stand a chance, she would have him in custody before dawn.

Catra's consciousness was swimming in a strange state of dull awareness. She could hear Razz moving around the room, speaking to Finn nearby. But their voices were slurred and she couldn't make out what they were saying. Then darkness sucked her in, sinking her down into nothingness.

“Finn!” Razz called their name in stern reprimand, thumping her broom handle against the child's forehead.

The old woman had the Thaymorian cornered in the pantry, against a wooden barrel near a small circular window. He had sought to hide behind the small wooden counter and cupboards built into the far side of the small room but Razz had found him. He had forgotten how good she was at seeking, all those years playing with Loo-Kee no doubt.

Finn cringed and took the hit with a whimper.

“I missed them, Gran-Gran...” He responded sadly.

“I am sorry, child.” Razz offered, placing a comforting hand on his shoulder. “It has been many years since they left you? Yes.”

“Yeah...” Finn glanced down in despair. “But this time I am going to save them. I'm going to save everyone.” He raised his head up with a broad, self assured smile. Pulling out his talisman, which was crafted from molded silver in the shape of a lotus blossom, the metal had a blood red sheen. The back was inlaid with five tiny shards of various crystals. He closed his eyes and focused upon the charm, lifting the illusion.

Finn's body grew translucent and morphed into a taller feline hybrid. They had a thin, athletic body, now taller than Razz. With shoulder length blonde hair, buzzed short along one side of their head. It was the very same shade as Adora's. They had dark cat ears like Catra with the same dark claws on both their hands and feet. A fluffy blonde tail swished nervously behind them. They looked on the cusp of adolescence.

Light brown leather gloves, with open fingers protected their hands. Their eyes were the same warm innocent blue as Adora's, but cat-like in shape with a narrow feline pupil. Still wearing the similar underclothes as before, with a black chest wrap underneath the loose white tank top. White cloth bandages were binding their left wrist and an angry pink burn festered underneath. The cloth was stained yellow and crimson from old puss and blood. Their feet were wrapped in leather binding all the way up to their calves. A familiar red bandana hung from their neck, with Adora's golden wing pin in the cloth. A deep orange, blue and red crystal fragments were embedded into the center of the pin.

“There you are Finn.” Razz smiled fondly at them. She reached out and grasped their wrist silently inquiring as to how they got hurt, she could just make out the burn festering under the makeshift bandage.

Finn abruptly pulled their arm back and hid it behind their back. “It's nothing Gran-Gran, it will heal. Had a run in with some Seeker drones before we all got off Etheria on Darla. ”

“You are reckless...just like your moms were.” Razz huffed.

Finn smiled proudly, seeing her words as a complement. “Horus has a plan, we are going to change our future.”

Razz stared at them sternly, tutting softly with her tongue. The intricacies of time were not for children to try and navigate. The weaving of such a deep magic was immense and delicate, this interference could cause more harm than good.

“Auncle Trouble gave me this charm so I could blend in.” Finn smirked, their tone mischievous. Finn’s voice was huskier than their Thaymorian disguise but had a lyrical quality that was rather feminine.

Razz groaned, Double Trouble was an adult. They should have better control of these children. Then Razz huffed and rolled her eyes in annoyance at herself. Double Trouble could never be considered the most responsible of Guardians. They would have aided in this crazy plan purely to enjoy the havoc it might create.

“Horus built a trans-dimensional portal...yes?” Razz sighed, not needing confirmation. Entrapta's child was as brilliant as his mother once was.

Finn merely nodded. “I used my magic to travel down a temporal thread, through the crossroads of worlds, to a nexus point. Set in this timeline. I am going to make things better.,,you'll see.”

Razz lifted an accusing eyebrow and took a deep breath.

“You have not mastered your magic yet, you are playing a very dangerous game, Finn. I feel you may have overreached.” Razz warned softly.

“But it's ok, we have a plan.” They affirmed with a confident grin.

“We?” Razz sighed, pushing her thick glasses up her nose in exasperation as the child's words struck her cold. This plan was only getting worse by the second...how many others were connected to this crazy attempt to change fate?

“Archer, Flora, Shoal and Cirri...they are powering the portal with their elemental magic and I used my own navigation magic to come back here.” Finn nodded, with a pleased smile.

Razz thinned her lips in disapproval, her heart slamming against her chest in rising fear. “You must go back, it is not for you kids, to tamper with what is yet to come.” She needed to regain control of the timeline. Or else all her and her sister’s eons of guidance would be for naught.

“Why...not!” Finn waved their hands up in frustration. “Anything is better than how it is now?”

“It could be worse.” Razz tried to hit them on the head again with her broom handle.

Finn hissed, their tail bristling and leaped up to the window ledge before the wooden stick to connect. They crouched on the sill scowling down at the old woman, their eyes burning with rage and resentment towards her. It broke Razz’s heart to see the child so ensnared in grief and loathing, towards the world, towards her...

“I won't go back!” They shouted, pushing the window open and then leaping out. “You can't make me! I made a promise!” Their voice was thick with sorrow but resolute, fading away as they ran off.

Razz knew the hell Finn had escaped from, she had traveled into their future from time to time. The hopelessness of those end times had scarred her, in ways she could never heal. Spurned her and her sister’s to unravel the knots of strife, adjust the weft and the warp of time. Slowly unraveling the threads of fate and begin to reweave the tapestry of time to a more preferred destiny. Yet the loom continued to resist their tampering, creating new knots such as Finn that would need to be straightened. Or else certain threads would have to be burned away by the void, to guarantee that one perfect timeline. Razz grunted and nodded with approval, as if chasing them off was exactly what she had intended. She

made her way back into the main room, gathered up her things and left. Her time here was up for now, but she would be back. She could feel the pull of time as it drew her away, shimmering out of existence as she walked out the front door.

Catra became aware again, as she heard Castaspella's urgent voice speaking nearby.

“What's wrong with her?”

“I don't know, Adora says she's sick? Razz sent me to get you and some healers.” Glimmer responded, her voice was more calm but just barely.

Then Catra felt strange hands, touching her forehead, grasping her wrists momentarily and then strong fingers pressing into her pulse point on her neck.

“She has a fever and her heart beat is fast and erratic.” A gentle voice spoke near her ear.

Catra moaned in protest at being touched, rolling her head away in discomfort.

“I believe she threw up earlier?” Another voice answered from further away.

“I was told by Master Elys that he found Catra in the corridor outside his study with a stab wound. That she was mumbling about an intruder? ” Casta inquired.

“Yes, the Citadel is on high alert and all the outer gates have been secured. There is no way out of Mystacor. But She-Ra healed her, she should be fine, but she's not.” Glimmer stated in disbelief.

“Magic is not a cure for everything, Glimmer. It's a tool like anything else, one must know how to use it. Adora has had no formal training in magic. I have no idea what training Light Hope

had been giving her. But it seems poor Adora has been left to learn about her powers on her own, we will amend that shortly. You will all be receiving a proper education in magic....as soon as this new crisis is over." Casta moaned in frustration.

"Thank you, Aunt Casta." Glimmer stated, her voice warm and bright with hope.

"So...she has a fever, increased heartbeat and nausea?" Casta mused. "Sounds like poisoning to me."

Glimmer called, "Razz...Madame Razz! Where did she go?" Her voice floated in volume as she moved around the room and pantry searching for the missing old woman.

Casta watched her niece flutter around the room searching for the old recluse of the Whisper Woods. She had never met the woman but the strange tales of her existence were spread far and wide. She had heard stories from both Adora and Swift Wind about her connection to She-Ra. That she had once known Mara and had guided Adora on occasion. She had theories concerning the old woman, but until she met her she had no way to test them.

Catra slowly opened her eyes, gripping the side of the mattress as the room titled. The fever was raging through her body. The burning had become a penetrating ache, as if acid was running through her muscles. She tried desperately to hang onto consciousness, but she slipped away back into darkness.

Catra moaned as a cold wet cloth was placed on her forehead. Someone was pressing the cloth lightly against her head, brushing her short hair back tenderly. Their touch felt so good, comforting, soothing. The care and love was unmistakable. Catra wanted to cry, no one but Adora had ever shown her such compassion. But she knew it couldn't be Adora, she was gone...hunting for Jitsu.

So who was taking care of her? She weakly lifted a hand, reaching for the pink blur sitting beside her next to the bed.

“I'm here.” Glimmer spoke softly, smoothing her damp hair back as she placed a freshly moistened cloth on her forehead.

“Glimmer...” Catra muttered in surprised confusion.

“Yeah, Aunt Casta and a couple Healer's are here too. They are making some kind of potion to help your fever and settle your stomach.” She advised gently.
“okay...” Catra smiled weakly up at her. “Sorry, I lied..I'm a bad person...” She slurred out, her smile crumpling into a miserable frown, as if she was on the verge of crying.

“What..?” Glimmer stammered, suddenly very concerned by her remark.

Then Catras' ears twitched when she heard rustling beside her bed.

“We got to make her drink this.” Casta demanded sternly.

“Catra, I need you to drink this. ok?” Glimmer took the cloth away and Catra missed it's cool comfort instantly. Then she felt Glimmer's arm slipping behind her back and pushed her forward. Catra moaned in discomfort at being moved, as the blurry world she existed in tilted sickeningly. She suddenly felt dizzy and the overpowering need to vomit washed over her. She was not given the chance to try and purge her stomach. As a small bowl was tipped to her lips. She complied at first, opening her mouth slightly, expecting something liquid. But it was a wet, dusty mixture that struck her tongue. She gagged and retched, spiting it up all over the blanket. The harsh, tasteless substance had been so jarring.

“No...she has to drink it!” Casta shouted in alarm. “Hold her down!” She commanded harshly.

“No!” Glimmer screamed back, knowing a little from Adora. How Shadow Weaver used to punish Catra by binding her with magic. She did not want to trigger any childhood trauma, Catra was dealing with enough right now. So she jumped up to defend her

friend from further harm. Glimmer was standing up, arms outstretched and guarding the bed. As Catra hissed and tried to roll away. Her ears were flat and tail lashing at the sudden threat of being held down.

“I got this...” Glimmer spoke more calmly, taking the bowl from her Aunt and moved quickly around the other side of the bed. Catra couldn't stay on all fours, the world was spinning and her stability on the shifting mattress was not trustworthy. She groaned and flopped onto her stomach, pressing her face into Adora's pillow and taking a big, comforting sniff.

“Catra, I really need you to try again.” Glimmer's voice infiltrated her pleasant wallowing in Adora's scent.

She rolled her face towards the pink blur with an unimpressed frown.

“It tastes like dirt...liquid dirt..” Catra made a disgusted face and stuck out her tongue petulantly.

“Yeah, I know. But it will take away the nausea so we can get some water into you.” Glimmer offered sweetly.

“I'd rather be dizzy...” Catra moaned, rolling onto her back, away from Glimmer's reach. Then gripped the sheets in fear as the world shifted sickeningly. Her foot brushed up against the wet stain now soaking into the cotton blanket. She should care but she didn't.

“Stop being difficult!” Glimmer growled, the sound of her feet shuffling away to the other side of the bed echoed in Catras ears. Catra had her eyes closed, seeking to settle her nausea. As soon as she smelled Glimmer getting close, she rolled to the other side. Pressing her face into the mattress, stubbornly thwarting Glimmer’s second attempt to administer the potion. Chuckling and smiling with satisfaction as Glimmer growled in frustration.

“How are you such a nightmare?” She huffed, her strong fingers gripping Catra's shoulder and pushing her forcefully onto her

back.

“Years of practice” Catra shot back, sliding her lip up on one side, in a teasing grin. To reveal the tip of a fang. Then rolled out of reach to the other side of the bed.

Glimmer sputtered indignantly for a moment, then pinched the bridge of her nose. Their bickering back and forth is an aggravating deja vu. She knew this game, had endured it before, when she had captured this insufferable cat years earlier and tried to take her back to Bright Moon. She learned then, that you could not make Catra do anything she didn’t want to. Catra was stalling, stubbornly refusing treatment like an obstinate child. She needed reassurance, or more of an incentive to do what Glimmer wanted.

“You need to be able to hold down water, Catra. You will only die faster if you become dehydrated.” Glimmer ground her teeth in frustration, standing up and tossing the ruined blanket to the floor.

If you can’t do it for yourself...do it for Adora.” Her tone softened into a desperate entreaty. As she moved around the bed, sliding in strategically close against Catra’s side. Hoping to stop her from rolling away again. Glimmer hovered beside Catra, her expression stern, offering her the bowl again.

Catra growled and then nodded, sitting up and taking the bowl with trembling hands. Glimmer placed her hands over hers helping to keep the bowl steady as she slowly raised it to her lips.

Catra sipped the tiniest bit and swallowed. Making a disgusted face as the dusty mixture slid like mud down her throat.

“More.” Casta demanded.

Catra groaned and took another drink, as Glimmer tipped the bowl against her lips more firmly. Forcing her to take a bigger sip.

“More.” Casta sighed in frustration.

“Auntie, you're not helping.” Glimmer shot back in exasperation.

Catra growled low in her throat, her ears folded back and her tail curled protectively around her waist. With her claws digging grooves into the ceramic bowl, she downed what was left in the bowl in one stubborn gulp. Coughing and gagging as she forced herself to swallow the nasty liquid. Scowling, she flopped back onto the mattress, stretching her arms and legs out.

“I'm going to go get you some water.” Glimmer offered.

Catra nodded, closing her eyes wondering how the hunt was going?

She-Ra stood rigid upon a marble balcony, high atop the upper bastion of the citadel. This had been the balcony Catra had fought the intruder on earlier that evening. The Eternian called Jitsu...

A good portion of the stone railing had been demolished, the broken remains littering the edge of the balcony. A huge chunk of wood had been gouged out of the balcony door from a sword. She had found the melted remains of a golden gauntlet. It had cooled and fused to the stone and could not be removed. The marble floor had been burnt in several places, cracks running to the edges from the incredible heat of Catra's magic. Droplets of Catras blood were splattered near the gauntlet and trailed into the study and out of the room and down the hall. She-Ra cupped a trembling hand over her mouth at the sight of Catras blood, physically holding back her scream of rage and fear.

She had no idea where to begin her hunt, so she had decided to start from the beginning. The cool wind blew through her long, pale gold ponytail, tossing it like a whip back and forth across the small of her back. Her powerful shoulders shook as she pressed her fingers tight over her mouth, stopping her lips from trembling, refusing to cry openly. Holding back the tears, shimmering in her glowing blue eyes. This was where Catra had fought her last

battle...this was where she had lost...She-Ra swallowed hard. Setting her jaw tight, she pulled her hand away from her mouth. Balling her hands into fists at her sides instead, refusing to give into the panic eating away at her. Her eyes hardened with resolve, as she turned from the balcony and stepped back into the study.

“What have you found out?” She inquired, her eyes narrowing in scrutiny at Mermista. She-Ra had been surprised to find the Sea Princess already investigating the scene. Writing notes on a tiny paper pad. Mermista tossed her notepad on the low table and picked up two daggers. Approaching her from the now smoldering hearth. One blade was covered in Catras blood. It had dried and turned the metal a rusty color. She-Ra couldn't look at it for long, the sight only amplifying her rage.

“There is no doubt that this blade was what poisoned Catra. But we need to know what kind of poison he used. Perfuma had come by earlier and offered that she might be able to help with that.” Mermista schooled her features into a cool, calm mask. Not allowing any hint of her excitement to show, this was neither the time nor the place for frivolous emotions. She had been investigating the grizzly crime scene, spurred by her need to find the truth, to ensure the culprit was caught and justice would prevail. She was honestly still on the fence about Catra, they weren't friends, but they weren't really enemies anymore either. Catra had tried to apologize during their impromptu party after Horde Prime had been defeated. But it had been very awkward and rather unsatisfactory in Mermista's opinion. She didn’t trust her...yet. But could not deny what Adora had said up in the Atrium. Catra had helped to save all of Etheria. Catra might die if she didn’t solve the clues and help track down this Jitsu character by dawn. In the end she was an Etherian who needed help and Mermista would do everything she could to save her life.

“I've already interviewed the mage who found Catra. This is Master Elys, he is on the magic council. ” She nodded over to the old man, sitting at the wooden desk in the corner. He was holding a tiny crystal shard in the palm of his hand, raising it up to his eyes to look more closely at it. It was clear like glass, but deep

inside it's facets an icy blue aura glowed. One side of the shard was chipped away, leaving the end jagged.

“Your friend...Catra is it? She had this in her hand when I found her.” He stated. “The ancient relics vault had been breached several days prior. I am guessing that man had stolen this piece from the vault.”

She-Ra nodded, “That explains the explosion I heard on Casta's communication back at Bright Moon.”

“We believe this is a shard of an Etherian star seed.” He sighed, “A thousand years ago, the First Ones were harvesting the planet for all manner of magic crystals. ”

“What is a star seed?” Mermista inquired, jogging back to the low table setting down the daggers and picking up her notepad and pen.

“Star seeds grow deep inside the planet, they absorb all aspects of magic in crystal facets. The First ones learned to adapt these crystals for their own purposes. They can store and enhance magic, power weapons and starships. ” He finished, setting the shard down.

“That is what they took from all the planets who had magic.” She-Ra stated. “When they took too much, those planets died.” the furrow on her brow was deepening in her growing anger.

“So what kind of magic does that enhance?” Mermista asked, her eyes hopeful.

“This shard has always been an enigma to us, so we sealed it away. We never could figure it out. Most crystals have colors that would determine what kind of magic is stored inside. This one is mostly colorless, if it contains magic it isn’t much. Which makes me wonder why this thief thought it was so valuable? I believe it's just an empty star seed that never had a chance to absorb any magic.” He tapped his index finger against it sharply.

Mermista sighed and rolled her eyes. “That does not help me.” she muttered. “Or answer why it was so important to that Eternian?”

“You will find your powers again.” She-Ra offered with a small reassuring smile.

“I don't need hollow words of encouragement, Adora.” Mermista huffed, placing her hands on her hips.

Adora rubbed the back of her neck, they were acting like everything was alright between them but it was strained.

“I have to go find this guy.” She-Ra chucked a thumb at the front door of the study. Eager to be away from the tension.

“He will come back here.” Mermista crossed her arms, confidently nodding towards the open balcony doors.

“He is not going to skip town without his prize.” She crossed over to the desk and grabbed the star seed, tossing it towards She-Ra, who caught it easily. “We just need to hide and wait, he'll be back. I'm sure of it!”

Catra was roused awake gently by a hand shaking her shoulder. She moaned and sought to roll away out of reach.

“Catra you need to drink.” Glimmer's insistent voice penetrated the fog and Catra sighed and complied. Rolling back towards the voice. Her mouth was dry and her throat was starting to hurt. The burn she had felt inside had grown into a cramping ache throughout her body. She felt stiff and clumsy as she reached for the glass, having a hard time focusing her eyes.

Glimmer slid in beside her on the bed, a hand on her back propping her up, while her other hand helped guide the glass of water slowly to her lips.

“Thanks, Sparkles.” Catra gasped after taking several deep swallows. Savoring the cold moisture now coating her, sore, parched throat.

“Anytime, Horde Scum.” Glimmer jested back, but her voice wavered. Betraying how worried she was.

“Do I really look that bad?” Catra inquired, her voice was hoarse and raspy, barely above a whisper.

“No...you look...” Glimmer started to lie but quickly sighed. “You don't look great, the potion managed to settle your stomach. But you're still sweating from a fever, still very pale and your muscles are starting to spasm.”

Catra sighed and thumped her head back against the wooden headboard with a tired scowl.

"Aunt Casta and the Healers have returned to the citadel to research poisons and other methods of detoxification." Glimmer shrugged.

“Relax, Glimmer. It's not my time yet. I am way too stubborn and angry to let this poison kill me. That Eternian's got Melog and I am not going to let him get away.” She growled.

“How are you going to fight him?” Glimmer chuckled.

“Force Captain, Catra always has a plan. I already sent my best soldier! She'll be back soon, with him and Melog.” Catra rolled her head towards Glimmer, her tone upbeat. Offering the Queen a small, if confident grin, a shine of hope gleaming in her eyes. “I am never going to give up, Sparkles.” She reached over and patted her hand encouragingly.

“Ok.” Glimmer nodded, offering her more water. Catra drank it greedily.

“I'm sorry for not telling you what happened in the swamp.” Catra sought to atone for her mistake. As Glimmer slowly pulled the

glass away.

“Why did you do it?” Glimmer asked, setting the glass down on a small night stand. Wanting to get to the bottom of her hateful comment about herself earlier.

“I was scared.” Catra turned her head away in shame. She wouldn't have the courage to confess if she was looking at Glimmer's compassionate eyes. “That if you knew what I had done.... I thought I had killed all those people...I figured that you would hate me. That you would finally realize that I'm not a good person. That deep down I don't deserve any of the kindness or forgiveness you've shown me.” Her lips were trembling and she quickly thinned them into a tight line, fighting not to start sobbing. Even though she could already feel the moisture falling down her cheeks. Thankful that she had turned her face away and Glimmer couldn't see how upset she was.

“Catra?” Glimmer was honestly worried about her. That was such a tragic kind of thinking. “I'm sorry too. I was out of line. I should not have yelled at you like that, you didn't deserve it. When I get scared, I kinda go a little crazy and I say mean things that I don't mean...I'm working on it.”

Catra laughed. “When I think I messed up, or when I'm scared, I kinda go into self preservation mode... which is why I lied and hide the truth. Growing up with the threat of pain always hovering close by...doesn't make a person very trusting or very honest. If I get into a confrontation I can't handle. I can get violent or I run and hide, or I say mean things too...whatever needs to be done to protect myself.” She started to chuckle nervously, she couldn’t believe she just opened up like that. Her distressed laughter slowly died away. Her eyes grew wide in horror at how open and honest she was being with Glimmer. She suddenly felt very vulnerable and shaken, swallowing hard she wrapped her arms around herself and held on tight. Her tail had unconsciously tucked itself between her legs, as she started to shiver.

Glimmer was quiet for a second, absorbing the abusive reality Catra had endured as a child. Then quickly pushed down her sympathy, Catra did not want it. I made her feel weak, like she was some pity project for others to fix. Glimmer had come to understand her that well at least, over the last few months. This information about her was a moment of trust and she would honor it. So she put on a bright smile. “I'm rash when I'm mad or scared....I can get myself into a lot of trouble. I sorta get kinda violent too.” Glimmer admitted, with a smirk.

“Oh, yeah. Never noticed.” Catra rubbed her cheek ruefully, where Glimmer’s fingernails had scratched her. Also remembering being on the receiving end of a fist to face sparkles long ago. Getting zapped along her whip cord that one time at the Horde Compound sure hurt like hell, too. Which brought a whole other messy ball of regrets. Catra finally turned to face her, reaching out and clasped Glimmer's hand.

“I'm sorry about your mom...I wasn't thinking straight back then...wrapped up in my own selfish desires and all that rage...” Catra sniffed as more tears threatened. “If I could go back and not pull that lever...I'd do it...in a heartbeat....”

“Please, Catra, we've already dealt with all this back on Primes ship.” Glimmer patted her hand, the compassion and forgiveness in her eyes was really making Catra want to cry, now. It took a supreme effort on her part to keep more tears at bay. In the end she offered Glimmer a sincere, if watery smile.

“Have you ever seen your mom, since, I mean?” Catra breathed, pushing out the question before she lost her nerve.

“Once.” Glimmer's smile was bitter sweet. “She came to me when I was fighting my dad during our last battle with Prime. I was ready to give up. He was just so powerful, I didn't think I could win. I don't know if I had lost consciousness, or if she came to me in a dream. But she stood over me, all white and glowing and smiled down at me. She was so full of love and encouragement that I was able to summon the magic I needed to save my dad.”

“If you could bring her back...would you?” Catra asked, pressing her for more.

“I don't know, maybe?” Glimmer considered, “She didn't look unhappy...I have no idea what lies beyond death, though?”

Catra swallowed hard and squeezed her eyes shut. She just couldn't bear to speak anymore about Angella or the portal. The last time she had spoken to the late Queen of Bright Moon, she had stated she was where she needed to be. That she had forgiven her and wanted her to heal and move on. Her guilt was tearing her up inside and she needed to take a breath and find some clarity. She did not want to hurt Glimmer anymore, by saying anything more...she didn't know if it was right to give her hope?

Master Elys had left the study, too old to get involved in any battles. Adora had lost her hold of She-Ra's magic hours ago. Mermista cast Adora a sympathetic look. They had found a hiding spot behind the old man's desk. They sat in awkward silence for a long time. Mermista kept her gaze averted to the coals of the fireplace, relaxing against the desk with one arm braced on a raised knee.

“Mermista...do you want to talk about what happened? Adora turned to regard her soberly. Sitting squarely on her butt with her legs stretched out, scratching the marble floor absently with a fingernail.

“No, not ready to deal with that drama just yet.” Mermista quipped back. She turned and gave Adora a pat on the leg, reassuring her that they were ok. She knew her words had been spat out in a fit of jealousy and anger and that she never really meant them. But she also was not ready to apologize just yet. Catra had destroyed her whole world and it was very hard for her to offer the Magicat forgiveness, even though she knew how desperately Catra wanted it.

“I just...” Adora started again, having a hard time letting go.

Mermista groaned and rolled her eyes dispassionately towards Adora. “Adora, we're good. We can talk it all out later. We got bigger fish to fry right now.”

“ok...” Adora responded in a small voice, then sighed heavily.

There was a sound, it was small, soft and rustling. Catra cracked an eye open and groaned. Her vision was still blurry, but now she could make out three more people around her bed. Scorpia sat in a wooden chair near her head, dressed in her night clothes of a simple black breast wrap and loose black shorts, her pincher's flexing nervously in her lap. Frosta paced on the other side of her bed, in pale blue leggings and a long white t-shirt. Perfuma sat on the bench by the window, staring out the glass in grim contemplation. Still in her pink dress and green long sleeved shawl, having yet to go to sleep. She had been searching the markets all night for herbs and medicinal plants to create an antitoxin. She had several bowls of crushed powders set out beside her. The light of dawn warming their muted colors to something almost edible. Glimmer moved closer out of the corner of her eye, pouring more water from a clear pitcher into a glass, When she noticed Catra was awake again. She had been force feeding her liquids all night, Catra groaned and closed her eyes. Perfuma moved lightly towards the hearth, which now had water boiling in a kettle. She poured a bowl of powder into a ceramic teapot, set on a nearby wooden table. Then went to the hearth and removed the kettle. She poured some of the boiling water into the teapot, too steep. Returning to the hearth and setting the kettle to the bottom stone lip to cool.

“We are not doing this...” Catra complained loudly, refusing to open her eyes again and confront the small crowd of worried women.

“Wild cat!” Scorpia exclaimed, jumping from the chair. Every muscle tensed to hug her but she stopped herself in mid lunge.

Catra cringed expecting a bone crushing embrace and thankful not to receive one. The burning had become excruciating. It felt like her insides were liquifying. It took everything she had to school her features and not cry out or grimace in pain.

“I found them outside your room. When Perfuma came in, they just barged in too.” Glimmer shrugged, offering her more cold water. Catra had no choice, as Glimmer gently pushed upon her back. Forcing her to sit up and then to swallow as she tipped the glass to her lips. She was getting good at forcing her to drink. Patiently waiting for her to relax her lips and then giving her no choice but to swallow, again. Catra had managed not to throw up anymore since the nasty liquid dirt so that was good. But having all this company to observe her looking so miserable. When she felt so weak and vulnerable, she found it highly stressful. She couldn't help how frustrated and angry their concern was making her.

“Look, I appreciate that you're all worried, but I'm going to be ok.” She smiled and waved Glimmer away angrily. Being coddled and force fed by Glimmer in front of them was not making things any better. She couldn't show weakness, her pride was at stake, she had to fake that she was doing better. “I am already feeling better.” She swung her legs out of bed, willing them not to tremble. Her whole body felt as if a live wire was coursing through every muscle.

“Catra...what are you doing!” Glimmer grabbed her shoulders forcing her to stay sitting.

“Get off!” Catra snarled, elbowing Glimmer aside roughly and stubbornly stood up. She took a couple uncertain steps, focusing stubbornly on her feet as she painfully shuffled away from the bed. She would never be someone who needed pity or sad, sympathetic looks. She was a fighter! She was strong! She was resilient. She could get through this!

“See....doing better.” She stated, cheerfully. As the pain struck her like icy water coursing through her veins, she faltered on her next step and then sank to her knees. Crying out in agony, as her body began to convulse. Shaking and trembling violently against the cold stone, foaming at the mouth. As her next scream came out as a gurgle, when her jaw clamped shut, beginning to choke on her own tongue.

Perfuma and Frosta cried out in fear and alarm as she collapsed.

“Wild Cat!” Scorpia was at her side in an instant, rolling her over onto her side so she could breath and not choke on her tongue. She cradled her head tenderly, allowing her body to tremor violently as it needed. Soon blood was mixing with her saliva as her convulsions intensified. Dripping out of the corner of her mouth. As her eyes stared in unblinking terror as her body began to fail her. Then her eyes rolled back into her head as her convulsions intensified.

Glimmer cried out, rushing to her side and dropping to her knees. She draped herself over Catra’s spasming body, closing her eyes and focused deep inside of herself. Picturing Adora, her sweet, goofy smile and how happy and content she had been. Ever since Catra had joined them. She needed to get Catra to her side! Determination coursed through her, filling her with power. She needed to get Catra to her side now! She-Ra needed to heal her...she would do everything in her power to keep that smile on Adora's face, to save Catra's life...she owed her that much if not so much more. Catra had become one of her closest friends. She did not want to lose her! Then a powerful calm fell over her as everything faded away. She felt the familiar buzz of her teleportation surround her, then in a flash of light she felt solid ground fade away. She had always needed a mental image to direct her course when teleporting. This time her magic was so much more powerful, all she needed was the image of Adora. Her magic pinpointed her location without knowing where she was going and transported her there.

Adora sat stiffly against the drawers of the desk, her knees drawn up to her chest, a hand raking anxiously threw her loosened ponytail. Her poof was pulled free and her long bangs cascaded around her face. Her eyes were wet and full of fear, as she kept glancing over to the windows. The moons were starting to set and the stars on the horizon were fading into the pre-dawn light.

"He didn't come....I only had time till dawn...he didn't come..." She cringed, wrapping her arms tight around her knees. Squeezing her eyes shut, releasing frustrated tears. She had felt that staying here was her best bet, that he would come back. But it had been the wrong decision and would cost her everything...

"Adora..." Mermista reached out, never seeing her friend look so broken.

Then a low scratching sound echoed from the balcony, followed by a snarl and yowl of pain.

Mermista wasn't even on her feet, by the time She-Ra was exploding from the heavy wooden doors.

By the time she got to the doorway, trident in hand. She-Ra had a grey cloaked man pinned to the broken railing, her broad sword was crossed with his more slender blade across his chest. She had her other hand to his throat under his hood, lifting him off his feet. His burnt hand hung limply at his side, wrapped in torn cloth from the hem of his tattered cloak.

"Give me the antidote!" She-Ra screamed, her eyes glowing an intense blue with rage.

The cloaked figure laughed harshly. "What kind of warrior would I be if I carried an antidote for my poison. If I am clumsy enough to cut myself with my blades I deserve to die!"

The broken scream of wrath and agony that ripped from She-Ra's throat was terrifying. Mermista stood frightened for only a moment, before catching sight of Melog cowering against the railing a few feet away. Red lightning very much like Scorpia's

power was rippling over their body from a metal collar around their neck. They were fighting against the collar's magic, their eyes glowing a deep crimson.

Mermista figured she would be a hindrance with the Eternian so she ran to Melog, hooking a trident prong under the collar impulsively. It proved to be a bad choice as it only conducted the electricity up her rod, shocking herself in the process. Her body went rigid, her back bending at a sharp angle backward as she screamed in fright and agony.

“Mermista!” She-Ra shouted, as she snapped her gaze to the right at the sudden flash of red lightning. Finding Mermista standing, her hands locked to her weapon's rod, expression frozen in horror as electric bolts cascaded over her body as well as Melogs.

“Free them! Turn that thing off!” She-Ra demanded in a venomous snarl.

“Fine, but I want the crystal shard in exchange.” Jitsu countered, his voice raspy and weak. As She-Ra took a step back, releasing his neck, allowing him to move off of the railing.

She-Ra flicked her eyes towards the study. “It's in there, on the desk.”

Jitsu nodded, pulling his hood back revealing his battle hardened face. Before striding arrogantly into the room. True to his word, as soon as he pocketed the shard the lightning ebbed and faded away. The collar made a clicking sound and fell from Melogs neck, clattering to the floor. Melog and Mermista collapsed on the balcony in a heap.

She-Ra charged into the study, but he was already gone. She collapsed to her knees, pressing her hands to her face as heartbreaking sobs rocked through her body. Then a glittering flash of light exploded near the hearth.

“Adora!” Glimmer's voice shouted out, penetrating her fog of grief. She-Ra raised her tear stained face, finding Glimmer standing before the fireplace, her bed clothes soaked with blood. She-Ra cried out in horror, scrambling to Glimmer's side. Finding Catra curled up on the floor, pale and unmoving. Blood and spit seeping over her lips from the corner of her slightly open mouth.

“NO...no,no,no.” She-Ra fell to her knees as the weight of her grief pulled her down, gathering Catra up in her arms. Pressing her against her chest, her body heaving as she sobbed, screaming in agony at losing the one person who had made her feel whole. Catra was so cold, her face was drawn, her complexion grey. Her lips parted softly on the cusp of death. She had been in this heartbreaking position with Catra before and never wanted to relive it again!

“You can't leave me...you can't...” She-Ra pleaded, brushing her hand down the back of Catras head. Rocking her back and forth, her grief stricken blue eyes unfocused as if in a trance. “We just started our life together.” She-Ra whispered, sliding one arm behind Catras back, cupping her cheek with her other hand, pressing their foreheads together. “I refuse to let you go...” She clenched her teeth and closed her eyes, refusing to give up.

Razz's words echoed to her as she focused deep inside herself, clasping the pure white light of healing. Then pushing her magic outward towards Catra. Feeling the firmness of her body pressed up against her. The electric hum of her power enveloping both of them.

(You must understand the weaving...) Razz's voice echoed.

What she had done in the heart to purge the virus from both of them, she had done on pure instinct. She had been so full of adrenaline, grief and exhilaration. Catra had confessed her love and she had responded to it with a kiss. That had held all of their passion, yearning and wishes they had kept inside for years. She needed to find that unbridled power again, she needed to push

that cleansing love into Catra and bring her back. Just like she had done back on Darla...after rescuing her from Prime.

“Catra....I love you...please....stay...” She whispered brokenly into Catras neck. Her eyes snapped open as she pierced that final magical barrier, glowing a brilliant white.

She could see thousands of threads of all different lengths, widths and colors.

(You must understand the weaving) Razz's voice instructed.

She could see herself as the glowing vision of She-Ra she had always seen in her dreams since breaking the sword. She was floating in a void, filled with mist and glowing orbs of light. Then threw the swirling fog she could see, and could sense the threads. A thicker thread that flickered both blue and orange like Catra’s magic. Interwoven with so many other threads of various colors and tones. They twisted and knotted together in an intricate design that was beautiful, ferocious and kind. Adora reached out and touched each thread, tenderly. They hummed and sang at her touch. She could feel them, understand all the glorious aspects of Catra they defined. There were so many shades of color woven into her tapestry that it was breathtaking. Then another thread caught her eye. It was woven into the design, but it wasn't natural...it looked like it was forced into the weaving. Adora brushed her fingers lightly against it, it pulsed like a throbbing vein jerking away from her. It had a strange vibration that did not fit with the rest of the threads, discordant and other worldly. Adora snapped her hand out, grasping the thread and sought to pull it free. As soon as she touched it, it glowed a pure white and vaporized.

The sensation of warmth and the steady beating of Adora's heart drew her back from the edge of death.

She had refused to give in, stubbornly forcing her own heart to beat, her lungs to breath. She would never leave her side again, not without one hell of a fight.

“Catra?” Adora's voice, broken and raspy, whispered against her ear.

She moaned in response and her ears twitched happily at the sound.

“It's too early...I want to sleep a little longer...princess...” She whined, clutching Adora's shoulder as She-Ra's magic faded away.

“Ok, you sleep as long as you want.” Adora smiled in fond relief, pressing a thankful kiss to Catra's temple. As the feline curled up on her knees, wrapping her own knees around Adora's waist, snuggling her face against her breasts with the most self-satisfied, blissful smile Adora had ever seen.

“That was close...” Glimmer breathed, falling to her knees beside Adora. Leaning against Adora and resting her head against the blondes shoulder. Adora leans her cheek against the top of Glimmer's head and sighed deeply. They both stared at the dying coals of the fire before them for a long time, eventually falling asleep. With their backs braced against the low wooden table behind them.

Arxia

“Seriously, you guys.” Mermista's exasperated voice roused Adora from her slumber. She slowly opened her tired blue eyes. To find Mermista crouching in front of her. Her long, dark hair was standing up slightly and frizzy on the ends.

“Glad you're alright.” Adora muttered with a faint, lopsided grin. She was sitting, half slumped against the low table. Her arms wrapped around Catra, holding her tenderly against her chest. The Magicat was curled up on her lap, with her head resting heavily upon Adora's shoulder. Her face tucked serenely in the nook beneath the blondes jaw, purring softly. Glimmer was asleep, leaning against Adora's side with her head resting upon Adora's other shoulder. Both young women were breathing deeply, content and comfortable using Adora as a pillow.

“Me too, what I did was incredibly dumb.” Mermista stated bitterly, reaching up and fingering her staticy hair.

Melog mewed softly, bunting Catra lovingly with their head. Catra hummed and turned her face into the cat’s attention, wrapping her arms around their neck and laughing happily with relief.

“I am so glad your ok.” Catra sighed, rubbing her face into the dark, soft velvet fur along Melog’s slender neck. In seconds both cats were purring, their rumbles echoing throughout the study.

(I was reckless...I am sorry for putting you through that. But we must be vigilant....he is still not captured.) Melog hummed into Catra's mind. Catra merely nodded against their neck.

“What's going on...” Glimmer moaned, half alert and groggy as she pulled away from Adora. Rubbing an eye with a knuckle. Squinting up at Mermista, her eyes bleary, offering her a weak, exhausted smile.

“Let's get you guys into your own beds.” Mermista offered.

“Wanna see my new trick!” Glimmer came alert in seconds, bursting with excitement. Reaching out and grasping Mermista's hand and Adora's shoulder. Catra who was curled up on Adora's lap, holding onto Melog's neck. Had no time to protest, merely yelping in surprise as Glimmer teleported them back to the Basilica.

A pink flash and sparkles announced their entrance in the courtyard of the Adepts Dorms. Scorpia, Frosta and Perfuma rushed from Adora's room to greet them. The morning light was just starting to warm the cobblestones, casting the courtyard in a soft, tranquil glow.

“I am so happy to have my powers back!” Glimmer cried out in glee, as she hopped to her feet, thrusting her fists into the air in triumph.

“I'm not...” Catra groaned piteously, rolling off Adora's lap to lay face down on the flat cobble stones. Needing to take a long minute to settle her stomach, she had had more than enough of feeling like crap.

Melog mewed worriedly, nudging the side of her head with their cold wet nose. Catra alleviated their worry with a giggle and rolled onto her back. Staring up at the beautiful morning sky, with a thankful smile. Her eyes warm and full of relief at being alive and having Melog back.

“Thank you...Adora.” She lolled her head towards Adora. Her voice thick with love and gratitude

Adora sat beside her, brushing the backs of her fingers down Catra’s cheek. “I love you...please don't do that to me again.” She responded in a husky whisper, tears threatening.

“I promise..” Catra sighed, returning her gaze back to the softly warming sky trying to calm down. Seeing Adora near tears was bringing on her own.

“Are you alright, Wild Cat?” Scorpia's concerned face loomed over her, blocking the faint morning light and casting her in shade.

“Yeah, all better.” She grinned, “Just tired.”

“I am so relieved, jeez you had me so scared last night.” Scorpia poked the tip of her pincher into Cara's forehead in the same manner Catra used on Adora with her claw. Catra smiled fondly at the familiar touch of affection. For Scorpia to adapt one of Catra's subtle mannerisms, to make her feel more comfortable meant a lot. Scorpia knew she could be rather overbearing with her affection in regards to Catra and that she didn't always appreciate it. She was now starting to restrain herself around her Wild Cat.

“Thank you for taking care of me last night.” Catra offered sincerely.

“Anytime, Wild Cat. Want me to carry you to your room?” Scorpia offered, crouching down and preparing to slip her pincers under Catra's legs and back.

“No, I've got this!” Adora shouted out, her voice was urgent and a bit possessive.

Catra turned to her in confusion, then yelped in fright as Adora boldly slipped her arms under her legs and lower back and swooped her up off the ground. Holding her close against her chest and walking proudly away towards their room. Catra wrapped her arms around Adora's neck, not feeling secure.

“I can walk.” Catra growled low against the shell of Adora's ear.

“Give me this....” Adora whispered back pleadingly.

Catra sighed and thumped her forehead against Adora's shoulder. She had really scared her last night, she understood and pushed her pride down. Adora needed this, to know she was safe and sound in her embrace. Melog padded softly after them, exhausted and eager to curl up in their room and sleep.

Scorpia laughed nervously, rubbing the back of her neck with a pincher. Blushing profusely, realizing that she had been out of line there. But old habits are hard to break. When Adora was gone, Scorpia had taken on the role of protecting and taking care of Catra.

“What was that all about?” Catra asked quietly, as Adora kicked the door closed.

“Nothing.” Adora gave her a warm smile, dropping her gently on the bed.

Catra gave her a strange look, wanting answers. Adora had never acted like that with her before. She had always treated her like an equal, not like a frail damsel that needed coddling. She understood that she really scared her last night and she might need a bit of reassurance, that she was alright. But to sweep her up and walk off with her had been so possessive. Scorpia didn't mean anything by it? She was being her normal overbearing, over protective self. Catra was used to it and had told her in the past to back off when she needed to. Adora had nothing to worry about in regards to Scorpia...why was she suddenly acting so assertive and refusing to answer her question?

“Let's get some real sleep. Ok.” Adora sighed, pulling off her long sleeve shirt and pants and tossing them aside.

Catra nodded, she wasn't going to press the point just yet. It had been a long and rather painful night. She just wanted some sleep as well.

Adora crawled onto the bed, in her loose tank top and grey shorts, glancing around in confusion for the blanket.

“I threw up on it.” Catra stated, bitterly pointing to the soiled blanket balled up against the hearth.

“Not a problem.” Adora nodded, slipping back out of bed and snatching her cloak from the floor nearby. She returned with a triumphant smile, settling down next to Catra and tucking the smaller woman in under the cloak. Pulling her close, Catra nuzzled contentedly against the nape of Adora's neck. Curling her hands under her chin and weaving her legs with Adora’s. As Adora curled her taller body around her, wrapping her up tight in her arms. Catra snuggled into her warmth with a satisfied smile and a tired sigh. Adora rested her head atop Catra's, slowly closing her eyes finally at peace and content enough to sleep. Melog had followed them into the room and had settled atop the small mound of pillows near the window. Their content purr rumbling through the room.

Perfuma had seen the disconcerting exchange between Scorpia and Adora. She was not going to pry, but she felt Scorpia may need a little support. Transitions like these could be messy, painful even. Scorpia had walked off down the colonnade, so Perfuma headed off in the direction she had gone. Finding her leaning against the main archway that led into the vast courtyard that held the massive basilica. Scorpia was staring at the ancient cathedral, lost in her thoughts. The morning light was warming the glass dome, it glowed like a small silver sun. Illuminating the courtyard beyond in shards of brilliant white light. Making the worn, grey cobblestones shine like a broken sheet of ice.

“It's so serene here.” Perfuma stated softly, coming up beside Scorpia. Taking in the many potted plants and manicured hedges that lined the courtyard. A large fresh vegetable garden sat on the far side of the courtyard, that also held a lush grove of apple trees and berry bushes. The basilica was completely self contained and could support itself without the aid of the Citadel.

“Yeah, this place is nothing like the Fright Zone.” Scorpia smiled wistfully up at the sky. “It was loud, and grey and the air smelled foul most days, leaving this weird after-taste in the back of your mouth. It was from all the factories and the refinery...and the

Forge."Scorpia started to ramble, cutting her losses she quickly finished her thought. "Honestly, nothing is like the Fright Zone...not even the Fright Zone anymore." Scorpia laughed. "Thanks to She-Ra all the buildings are covered in flowering vines."

"Really?" Perfuma smiled, her eyes bright. "I'd like to come see that, when this is all over."

"It's gotten to be rather colorful now. Cheerful, even." Scorpia smiled fondly. "It is a great start to rebuilding my kingdom." She nodded.

"It's nice to see you've mended your friendship with Catra." Perfuma redirected the conversation, gently.

"Yeah, I really missed her." Scorpia smiled ruefully, refusing to look at Perfuma as her cheeks flushed. "I know you won't understand."

Perfuma laid a reassuring hand on the hard exoskeleton of her shoulder." She is starting to open up to me. I am beginning to see who she truly is. So I do understand...to some extent your fondness for her." Perfuma bit her lip, nervously. Not knowing how to tread just yet and needing to gather her thoughts.

"My Wildcat..." Scorpia began fondly then frowned, shaking her head. "I mean, Catra. I was supposed to keep her in line, at least that's what Shadow Weaver had instructed me to do. But Catra...she always did as she pleased. She didn't listen to anyone, not even me. She always had a plan, a strategy to rise above all of us. I don't know if it was because she wanted the power or just thought it was the only way to stay safe, stay alive? Growing up in the Horde, you learn to get strong fast, how to do what you need to, to survive. After the Fright Zone blew up and Prime occupied Etheria. I had no idea where Catra was. I was scared at first, I felt so guilty about leaving her, when she needed someone so badly. But I knew no matter what had happened to her. She would pull through, I never lost faith in her. Catra will always be a survivor." Scorpia sighed, her eyes distant with dark memories. "She was a

real mess after Adora left. I tried to be a good friend. But she was hurting too much and kept me at a distance. She really had a hard time trusting anyone after Shadow Weaver abandoned her too. I only saw her truly happy a handful of times. She was so angry, so heart broken and troubled...I couldn't fix her. I tried...but I wasn't what she needed." Scorpia's smile was bitter sweet. "But I see how honestly happy she is with Adora. She always needed Adora. So I need to take a step back." Scorpia nodded resolutely. "I think I've overstepped a bit."

"I think you were just being you." Perfuma took a claw lightly in both her hands. Drawing Scorpia away from her inner turmoil. "You're kind and loyal and caring to a fault. You have nothing to feel bad about wanting to care for Catra."

Scorpia turned and offered Perfuma a warm smile, taking note of her once again holding her claw so sweetly. She never pulled her claw back, enjoying the closeness between them.

"Want to go for a walk?" Scorpia inquired, "The morning is really beautiful." Staring out over the open courtyard and it's small gardens wistfully.

"Yes, I would like that." Perfuma smiled, pulling her out of the shadows and into the warm morning light.

Mermista stood silently, brooding at her own hands. When she felt a comforting hand squeezing her elbow. She turned to find Glimmer smiling up at her, her eyes were warm and earnest.

"You will find your powers...when you need them most. Do not lose heart, they are still inside you."

Glimmer encouraged softly.

"It is just so frustrating." Mermista growled.

“Are you hungry?” Glimmer chucked a thumb towards the dormitory. “It's morning, so I bet the kitchen already has breakfast cooking. I bet we could find something to eat or drink. You never came with us when Casta took us to the Basilica. I could give you a tour, show you. Your room?”

Mermista gave her a small smirk. “You're trying to distract me from sulking.”

“Already survived one of your sulking sessions, Oh, Princess of Ice cream.” Glimmer commented jokingly.

“Ha, ha, ha.” Mermista mocked. “Alright let's go get some food then a tour. Maybe that kitchen has some ice cream....I could really use some ice cream.”

“Sounds like a plan.” Glimmer wove her arm into Mermista's and led her towards the colonnade.

“Can I come too...” Frosta asked hopefully, dashing up alongside Glimmer.

“Of course!” Glimmer raised an arm, inviting the shorter princess to duck into her side. Frosta grinned and moved into Glimmer's side. As the older girl wrapped her arm around her shoulders and pulled her in. So she could walk alongside more comfortably. Frosta’s smile was beaming with pleasure, she had never dreamed of having such close friendships.

“You're going to change first though, right?” Frosta pulled away, glancing nervously down at Glimmer's ruined bedclothes.

Glimmer looked down, noticing the blood soaked into the front of her night gown.

“Right.” She nodded, picking the garment away from her waist in disgust. “It's been a crazy night.”

“Agreed.” Mermista huffed, crossing her arms as Glimmer slipped into her room to change.

It was a soft creak of the door that roused Adora from her slumber once again. She slowly raised her head, finding Finn creeping into the room. The little Thaymorian, had a huge platter of food in his hands. His tiny pink tongue was sticking out of the corner of his mouth. As he concentrated on keeping the heavy platter level. Glimmer was right behind him, holding a pitcher of juice and two glasses. Both of them were tip toeing softly, as they made their way into the small pantry set beside the main room.

“What are you guys doing?” Adora called softly, a smile spreading on her face as she smelled the goodness lying beneath the large metal lid of the platter.

“Well, this was Finn's idea.” Glimmer grinned, “He came into the kitchen a little while ago and started filling up the platter with food. I offered to help him carry it back for you guys, since he was so intent on bringing you breakfast.”

“Well, that sounds good to me.” Adora agreed, trying to move away from Catra as gently as she could. She had barely moved an inch before Catra's hand that had been curled near her chest, turned and clutched onto Adora's shirt and held firm.

“Where are you going?” Catra inquired drowsily.

“Glimmer and Finn brought us breakfast. Come eat.” Adora leaned down and placed a sweet kiss on her temple.

“Ok....give me a moment...” Catra rolled onto her back and stretched languidly with her arms over her head. Arching her back and moaning in a long, low, sultry manner. When she opened her eyes she found Adora staring down at her. Her blue eyes were burning with desire and cheeks flushed.

“I swear you do that on purpose.” Adora breathed, giving her a playful slap on her bare stomach.

Catra giggled mischievously and rolled away. “Maybe.” she hummed playfully, gazing innocently over her bare shoulder, while on all fours, her tail swishing happily. Adora’s eyes flared wide in arousal, slowly taking in her girlfriends toned, finely shaped ass that was now very obviously near her face. “You are such a tease.” Adora growled, her eyes bright with desire. Resisting the urge to slap Catra’s ass, she quickly cleared her throat and left Catra on the bed. Ignoring her girlfriend's pleased laughter. Ducking her brightly flushed face as she focused on grabbing her clothes from the floor. She slipped on her long sleeve shirt and grey pants. Proceeding Catra into the small pantry, leaving the cat to rummage into her own pack to find suitable clothes. Catra was grumbling to herself as she surveyed the pack's contents. Yet another shirt was ruined thanks to getting stabbed and she would have to find a new one.

When Catra entered the pantry in her torn black leggings and a white training shirt, it had the same grey patches on the sides and red accents on the shoulders as Adora's. Except her sleeves were much shorter, hugging her biceps. She found Finn and Adora sitting at a small round wooden table on the far side of the little alcove. Glimmer was sitting on a wooden barrel near a circular window. Finn smiled in welcome when she entered and hopped off the wooden chair.

Catra gave him a small nod, as he moved to stand next to Adora. Who was eagerly picking plump sausages off the mountain of food on the platter with her fingers.

Catra sat down and stared in wonder at the heaping pile of food Finn had packed on the oval platter. She couldn't name much of it, since she hadn't had much experience with food beyond ration bars.

“How much do you think we can eat?” She was aghast at the amount of food.

“Relax. I got you. I am going to take that frown right off your face. Grumpy Cat. ” Finn smiled eagerly, shooting smug little

finger guns at her.

Catra chuckled softly, feeling sorry for the little kid. It seemed Adora's dorky mannerisms were rubbing off on him. Watching avidly as Finn, moved to the quaint wooden cupboard along the back wall, pulling open a couple doors. Taking out a plate and then some cutlery from a drawer. He set them down in front of Catra. Then proceeded to stack her plate with several flat pastries from the breakfast platter. Picking up a simple white earthen bowl from the platter next, adding some glistening red berries on top of the flat pastries and then scooped an ample dollop of heavy white cream on top from a dainty silver bowl. His assembly of the rather fluffy and opulent looking breakfast was full of regal pomp, as if he was serving a Queen. Replacing the bowls back on the platter with a overly dramatic flourish he then backed away with a huge, proud grin.

Catra stared down at the strange confection Finn had just served her, with barely held restraint. She could smell the heavenly sweet and creamy scent and her mouth was watering.

Adora was grinning, knowing exactly what Finn had created and how utterly delicious it was. She had eaten strawberries and cream on pancakes countless times over the years back at Bright Moon.

“Try it.” Glimmer coaxed, laughing eagerly.

“Fine.” Catra huffed, trying to act nonchalant. Slowly she took up her fork and knife and cut a very small portion of the cakes, fruit and cream. Popping the tiny morsel of food into her mouth with an uncertain frown.

Finn's smile grew into a broad joyful grin, as Catra's eyes dilated in bliss. As the sweet, creamy substance melted in her mouth. She then dug into the plate with gusto, polishing it off in record time. Eyeing the last three cakes on the platter, eager for more.

When she had come down from her food euphoria. After her second helping, having finished off the cakes, fruit and cream. Adora was laughing happily, Finn was smiling smugly and Glimmer was beaming. Catra leaned back in her chair, licking the leftover cream from the sides of her mouth, humming in satisfaction.

“That was the most delicious thing I have ever eaten.” Catra grinned, her eyes shining cheerfully.

“I know, it's your favorite.” Finn giggled, then slapped his hands over his mouth. Eyes flying wide in horror, he had been so wrapped up in the sweet moment of pure joy, he had slipped up.

“What do you mean, this is the first time I've eaten this?” Catra frowned in confusion.

“Uhm...” Finn backed up a step, taking in Adora's inquiring look with a pained grimace. Glimmer had hopped off the barrel and was moving towards him.

“I guessed it...yeah. I just remembered Swift Wind promised to teach me a new song. Bye!” Finn turned and ran, dashing out of the front door as fast as his hooves could carry him.

Adora sighed and popped another sausage in her mouth, chewing thoughtfully.

“That was strange?” She mused, picking up the last sausage.

“Strange is starting to be the norm with you guys.” Catra stated with a disapproving shake of her head, leaning over the table and snatching the last sausage from Adora's hand. Popping it smugly into her mouth before sitting back down to finish chewing it.

Adora stared at her in shock for a second then shrugged, finding a couple biscuits covered in jam to fill up on.

Glimmer resumed her seat upon the barrel. A bemused smile gracing her sweet, round face. As she silently enjoyed watching Catra and Adora bicker playfully over the last few morsels of breakfast.

Food was a big deal to both of them, she figured it was because of their shared upbringing in the Horde and the limited variety of food they got to have.

"Tell me about your dreams? Glimmer asked quietly, as Catra finished chewing her last bite of buttered toast.

Catra nodded, her eyes falling to the slate floor as she gathered her thoughts. Not willing to divulge anything about Queen Angella. She sought to exclude the late Queen of Bright Moon's intervention in her dreams.

"I was born over a thousand years ago, to the Northern Pride on the Serenia Savannah. To the Etherian People known as the Sunna. We were called the People of the Sun. Oroboros, the Guardian of Fire, taught the Rune Bearer, my mother, Aoi. How to wield that element of magic. My magicat heritage is ancient...there is so much I still do not know. I hope to find my answers here in Mystacor." Catra tapped a claw thoughtfully on the table top for a moment gathering her thoughts, then continued. Speaking in length about being taken back in time over a thousand years ago. How her people had lived in fortified villages throughout that golden Savannah. The grassland had been as wondrous and dangerous as the Whispering Woods. But her people had cultivated a natural give and take relationship with the land that benefited them both. Traveling and trading with three other Prides, sending caravans of goods beyond their borders into other kingdoms. How the Sunna were renowned weavers and tailor's of crystal beadwork. Their hunter's were fierce, tireless, tracker's that were coveted throughout Etheria.

Then the Eternian's came...

They colonized the planet for countless years before her birth. Building Beacons, military outposts and settlements that slowly encroached into every territory. All while professing promises of protection against the threat of the Galactic Horde. Seeking peaceful co-existences as they began to mine the planet. Building their own settlements, erecting watchtowers to survey the land, beacons rose tall within their own villages and towns to send messages and intel back to Eternia. How slowly, Etheria was dragged into the First Ones war with Horde Prime. The Heart of Etheria Project, was forced upon her people. By the Eternian She-Ra, Mara and an Eternian Senator, called Keldor. Pandering the hybrids with lies and half truths, about how the Rune Stones would make them stronger. Promising them that their magic was going to be used to protect the whole galaxy. Enticing the four elder's to comply with extravagant gifts and heady compliments that the Sunna were meant for greatness. That their magic was going to free the entire Tri-Solar system from the scourge of the Galactic Horde. Never knowing that this magic weapon would kill Etheria and everyone on the surface when it was fired.
"Mara was a good person, honorable and brave. When she realized what was going to happen to Etheria. That she was a pawn...a weapon, for Keldor to wield. She rebelled…." Catra quickly sought to soothe the heartache her honesty may have caused Adora. Glancing up to gauge Adora's reaction to the harsh truth about Mara. She hadn't gone into much detail about Mara in her first retelling of her dreams back on the Skiff. Adora had spoken about Mara with her many times in the last few seasons. She idolized the previous She-Ra, and saw her as a misunderstood hero. But a hero non the less. Catra never wanted to tarnish that, but Mara had been a pawn for years, denying the irreversible damage her people were causing the planet. She had aided Senator Keldor in enslaving many kingdoms to Rune Stones. She had awoken to the truth to late and her fate was sealed...she did everything she could in the limited amount of time she had to save Etheria. Desperately trying to right her mistakes, with the aid of her loyal Squadron GraySkull. Those years of blind loyalty had lead to her downfall. She was no hero and she would not be remembered as one. Forgotten by the survivors...until Adora.

Catra offered her an encouraging smile. "Mara’s Rebellion was known as the Great Unrest and it stretched far beyond Etheria to other Eternian occupied worlds. Soon Etheria was embroiled into a Civil War.” Catra sighed heavily, as she delved into the final days. When her people were stolen and shipped off world for profit. Or slaughtered by the Eternian Army or other Etherian's loyal to Keldor. Oroboros scorching the Savannah in their rage. How Senator Keldor put a bounty on her and her parent’s heads. That led them to be on the run for nearly a year. Desperate and exhausted, trapped in the deep caves of the Stinger’s Mountain range. As an army of bounty hunters and the Eternian Military searched for them. With no other choice to keep her safe, but to put her into a stasis pod when she was still a baby. They had hidden her in the catacombs beneath what would become Horror Hall.

“All those years of stasis made me forget my past life..” Catra admitted, sliding her eyes back to Adora with a warm, nostalgic smile. “ My first memory is of a little blonde girl..she’s rather cute..and kinda grabby?” Catra chuckled, Adora was quick to giggle and nod in agreement. She had been rather possessive, never allowing their care giver's in the nursery to scold or punish Catra when she lashed out. Overbearing with her affection, constantly hugging her and hauling her off to play away from the other kids. Always so very protective of the kitten she found as a little kid.

"My Catra!" Adora spouted, with a knowing grin. As a toddler, she had always made a clear statement who Catra belonged to, before picking the kitten up and hauling her off. Catra laughed and nodded in remembrance. Happy tears falling down her flushed cheeks. Adora's fond smile wilted quickly, soured by her anguish over what her people had done to Catra's.

Catra continued to describe how wonderful it was to be found by Adora. That it was hard to wake up after such a long sleep. How scared and confused she was. Adora even at such a young age was so compassionate and kind. The blonde had instinctively sought to care for her. How she had climbed into the pod and

cooed and cuddled her tenderly. Until she felt safe and alert enough to climb out. Catra glanced up at Adora, her cheeks warm with cherished nostalgia., As she reviewed her dearest memory in her mind. Finding Adora grinning just as much, with shared empathy towards the sweet story of finding Catra. Her blue eyes shimmering with tears, as she nodded and lightly reached over the table to clasp Catra's hand tenderly.

"I remember…" Adora whispered as she gazed lovingly towards her.

Catra smiled back, giving her hand a firm, affirming squeeze.

The story brought Glimmer close to tears and Catra soon found herself avoiding eye contact with her. Picking bashfully at the wood on the table top, not able to endure the Queen's sorrow or sympathy at what happened to her. Glimmer understood her grief, having lost each of her parents for a time. She had her dad back, but that relationship was still rather awkward. He had been lost when she was so young, that now it was more like two strangers getting to know one another. Her father had always been an idea, a heroic bedtime story her mother would tell her about before bed. She was now getting to know the real person. She loved him, but having him around in the role of her parent was still rather strange. Their bonds were re- forming, but it was slow progress.

"I dreamt of Shadow Weaver last night." Catra muttered, her voice tentative, nervous. Flicking her eyes up at Adora briefly. She had brought up Shadow Weaver once before, just after her death. During their time in Erelandia. Adora had been less than receptive about speaking about the old woman. Whenever Catra brought her up, Adora would seek to politely change the subject or distract her with more self indulgent endeavors. Catra quickly learned Shadow Weaver was a forbidden topic for Adora. She wasn't ready to deal with the confusing mess that lived inside her heart in regards to that vile, manipulative woman.

Adora took a deep breath, her eyes cooling instantly at the mention of their late superior officer.

“We had a...talk.” Catra huffed, “About how she raised us…” She couldn't hide the bitterness that was thick in her tone. Swallowing several times, to clear the bile that ate at her throat when reflecting upon her childhood. She would never tell Adora the truth, that Shadow Weaver never loved her, couldn’t love either of them with all that darkness corrupting her.

Adora crossed her arms over her chest, with a sour expression, her jaw working as if she was chewing on something unsavory. But she never said a word.

So Catra continued. “She spoke about the Spell of Obtainment, how it had corrupted her.” She turned to regard Adora, with an empathic glance. “She said you healed her.. purged the darkness out of her soul.”

Adora's eyes went wide, “I couldn’t heal her body though?”

“That was the price of channeling the deep magic.” Glimmer commented. “My father has scars on his arms from incanting the Spell of Obtainment with Shadow Weaver. The magic they summoned...attacked them both. He got scared and ran away. Stopped incanting the spell half way through...and left Light Spinner to be devoured by the dark magic. He was saved by the Magic High Council. ”

“Shadow Weaver absorbed a fragment of Time magic, when she devoured Norwyn.” Catra pushed on, “ She saw your future and my past. That’s why she raised us the way she did. She was creating a Shield from the Child pushed through Space and a Sword from the child pushed through Time…to protect Etheria from this Nameless One.” Catra was quiet for a moment reflecting upon this greater destiny she never believed was possible. Adora stared at her with a mixture of confusion and fear. Wary of any revelation given by Shadow Weaver. Her version of the truth was never trustworthy, nor did it turn out well...for anyone involved.

“That is a-lot to take in...I...I gotta go get some air.” Adora huffed, rubbing the back of her neck roughly. Then abruptly stood up and

practically ran from the room.

An icy ball of dread lay heavy in Catra’s belly. She had pretty much just vilified Adora’s hero and resurrected a whole mess of unresolved feelings from their childhood. The tortured expression Adora wore upon her face as she hastily left Catra's presence was painful to bear. Catra blinked slowly at Adora’s retreating back, seeking solace. But Adora never turned around, grabbing her cloak from the bed and jogged out the front door. Needing to be as far away from Catra as she could be. Catra's heart was beating to fast, her chest felt heavy and she was struggling to maintain her composure.

Adora felt like she losing control and she needed space. Shadow Weaver raising her to be a weapon wasn't a surprise, she had always known that the woman was grooming her to be a ruthless warrior. It hurt to realize that the woman had never seen her as a person, but as a tool to be used for her own purposes. But Catra's revelation that she had been trained to destroy some ancient evil...This Nameless One. It was so much like how Light Hope had tried to use her to finish the First Ones Mission. She was not a weapon! Once again, she felt used and betrayed. The rage seething inside her was constricting her throat and slowly suffocating her.

“Adora! Where are you going!” Glimmer shouted, ready to dash after her.

“Leave, her Sparkles, she needs to blow off some steam. I’m not worried.” Catra lied, rubbing the back of her neck nervously. Her hopeful stare never left the open doorway, yearning for Adora to reappear just so she could apologize for...speaking the truth? No, for hurting her...even if it wasn’t intentional but inevitable. She was still sorry...

“We need to be ready...Shadow Weaver was extremely terrified of this Nameless One. That fear drove her to train Adora and I… rather harshly...” Catra couldn’t vocalize the brutal upbringing she and Adora received at that woman’s hand. All in the name of

protecting Etheria from some unspeakable evil that was going to come some time in the future. “This Evil is coming.” Catra finished, her voice a trembling hush as she barely reigned in her panic. She turned to look up at Glimmer, her expression concerned and imploring.

“I’ve never heard of this Nameless One.” Glimmer muttered, “But I’ll ask my Aunt Casta...I’m sure she has, or at least there got to be some information in one of the dusty old books in the Citadel’s libraries.”

Glimmer had stayed for a little longer, asking Catra particular questions. About all that she had learned about these threads of magic, she saw in that place between worlds, from the Guardian of Fire. Who she came to know as Oroboros. She was wondering now what the Guardian back at Bright Moons name was? Curious about these Elemental Serpents and this Ancient Evil...the Nameless One. She planned to visit the Masters Library, to start her research there. Then work her way through the other libraries if she couldn’t find her answers. Glimmer took a deep breath, her eyes burning with determination. This was just one more trial to overcome. She would tackle each problem and solve them as she went. Freaking out about the amount of fires she had to put out, would not help anyone. So she left a few minutes after Adora,.to see if Bow had come back from patrolling the Citadel. Her heart was beating fast with both excitement and fear. At the new level of power she now had a claim to. None of them truly understood what releasing Etheria's magic was going to do. They had lived in a world in which their magic was shackled to First Ones tech. The Rune Stones had been set with limiters to the amount of magic each Princess could have. Balance had to be maintained between all of them so that the Weapon could work. Yet the weapon had been compromised in the past and would never work like it was designed to. According to Catra, The Heart of Etheria needed thirteen Rune Stones online, but after the Great Unrest..only five Rune Stones remained. Yet Light Hope still went through that

elaborate plan to kidnap Adora just to complete her prime directive? Why? It didn't matter now anyway, there was nothing left of the Heart of Etheria project and they were all free. There was nothing holding them back, each Princess could use their powers to whatever extent they wanted. Each one is capable of drawing their magic from the source, instead of a Rune Stone. Which left another question? Her magic was light… or more specific...Moonlight? Perhaps one of Etheria's moons was the source or perhaps all of them...it left Glimmer many more unanswered questions. Perhaps her Aunt could help guide her to the true source of her magic?

Glimmer could now feel that light shining deep inside of her. It filled her with a sense of unlimited power, like a star had ignited in her soul. The magic hummed on her skin, tingled deep in her muscles as it coursed through every vein, every pore of her body. She had finally made a link more pure and raw to her element then anything the Moonstone could ever offer. She cherished this connection that was so much more powerful than anything she had ever felt before. Now she had to learn how to harness its full potential...without causing too much collateral damage...

She was staring at her hands as she walked around the corner of the colonnade, reveling in the thrill of what lay ahead, when she bumped right into a solid wall of muscle.

"Ow...." Bow's deep voice shouted out in pain.

Glimmer shot her head up, finding him stumbling back a step. She had made him spill his cup of hot coffee all over the front of his tunic. The white was now stained brown and dripping onto his bare, scalded abdomen. He held his Tracker pad in one hand away from his body and a dripping ceramic mug in the other.

"Sorry..." Glimmer cringed, mortified by the hot mess she had just caused.

Bow gave her a tired smile, moving off the colonnade and onto a stone bench set in a small flower garden, nestled just before their

dormitory. Glimmer followed him, as he set his half empty mug on the ground beside the bench.

“I was heading back to our room. It's been a really long night.” He stated, his voice soft with exhaustion.

“Tell me about it.” Glimmer agreed, as she sat down beside him. Turning to regard his inquiring look with a smile. With a sigh she told him all about Catra getting poisoned and nearly dying. How she got her powers back and teleported them into a study in the upper bastion of the Citadel for She-Ra to heal her.

Bow sat in stunned awe at her story then wrapped her up in a tight hug.

“That's great Glimmer!” He shouted cheerfully. “My night has not been that successful. I had hoped to be able to track that Eternian with my Tracker Pad. Maybe lock onto his magic or even the tech he uses. But basically I just walked around the Citadel all night.” Bow sighed and slumped with exhaustion. “I will need to catch up with Swift Wind, see if he saw anything last night during his aerial patrols. Huntara was scouting the Tranquil gardens and the caves and trails along the northern side of the island. Maybe she had some luck tracking down where that Eternian is hiding out.”

Glimmer rubbed his back soothingly. “We'll find him, Bow. Stay positive.” She offered.

Bow passed her a small smile and nod, threading his fingers with Glimmers. Enjoying the quiet morning and the encouraging comfort of her company. The serenity of the morning was short lived, as his Tracker pad began to chime. Of a communication coming in.

“Bow!” Entrapta's voice echoed out of the speakers, from Bow's Pad.

He quickly picked it up from the ground, as Entrapta's excited face filled the screen.

“Entrapa where have you been!” Bow stated gruffly. “I have been trying to reach you all night.”

“I've been exploring the secret tunnels under Mystacor.” Entrapta stated in a matter of fact tone. “They are actually ancient vents and corridors of a First Ones Space Port...but that's data for later.” Her voice trailed off as she sought to stay on track.

Bow’s jaw dropped in awe for a moment as he registered what she was saying.

“Entrapta that is way too dangerous!” Glimmer chastised shrilly. Her eye’s flaring in recognition that she had just sounded exactly like her mother.

“I told you I wanted a chance to study the Fail Safe and access the data it might contain?” Entrapta sighed, her bottom lip protruding in a pout. Not liking being reprimanded at all.

“But it’s too dangerous to go through those tunnels alone, there are magical barriers and traps. How far did you even get?” Glimmer asked incredulously.

Entrapta turned the screen to show her the looming crystals of the Fail Safe.

“Wow....” Glimmer breathed in awe. Entrapta's brilliant ingenuity was unfathomable. If she set her mind to something, nothing was going to stand in her way, not even magic.

“I still wish you would have told someone.” Bow grumbled.

“I did....I told Catra, Glimmer and Adora...days ago?” Entrapta was confused.

“I mean when you were going specifically, last night.” Bow pinched the bridge of his nose in frustration. “We care about you Entrapta and if you had gotten hurt no one would have known where you were?”

“Oh...sorry...” Entrapta finally got what he was getting at. “I am just so used to doing things on my own...I never thought. I am sorry, I made you worry.” She paid him a quirky smile of gratitude.

“No problem...” Bow smiled back.

“Can you bring everyone to the Fail Safe. I've found some very interesting data on what is going on with Etheria right now.” Entrapta asked, tapping on another keypad beside her.

“Of course, I will gather them up and we will be there shortly.” Bow nodded, ending the communication.

Glimmer gave him a concerned look before rising off the bench to help him gather up all the princesses.

Entrapta had disabled all the traps on the way in. So the inferno that had once dominated the walls of the hallway that led the chamber was gone. Without the menacing crackle and snapping firelight. The long, narrow halls held a strange otherworldly silence. That hung over the them all like an omen. So no one had dared to talk on the way to the Fail Safe. Entrapta had also cleared away the remainder of the debris, when She-Ra had collapsed the archway during their escape. It was now nicely piled up on either side of the broken archway. They all filed into the Fail Safe chamber, the pale glow of the crystal pillars cast their faces in an eerie light. The chamber held a somber atmosphere, as if they were entering a long lost crypt.

They all quietly encircled Entrapta who was sitting on her knees in front of the glowing crystal monolith. She had set up her three monitor computer station she had used to hack into, Horde Primes clone network during their final battle. This time she had her cables plugged into a small panel at the bottom of the Fail Safes dais. Her fingers were flying on one keyboard while her hair was working two additional keyboards beside her. She never even

lifted her eyes from the data scrolling on her monitors. Her Tracker pad was propped up in front of her knees, with Hordak's grim face filling the screen, watching her work.

“We don't have much time. I have been working all night with Hordak to decipher the Fail Safes encryption code.” Entrapta glanced up at Adora, Glimmer, Bow and Catra as they moved to stand in front of her screens. Melog had come along as well, hovering around Catra's legs. Perfuma, Mermista, Frosta and Scorpia stood by the crystal monolith, anxiously. While Netossa, Spinerella and Huntara remained at the doorway.

“Will Castaspella and King Micah be joining us?” Entrapta asked in a distracted manner, her eyes falling back to her readings.

“We are here, Entrapta. What is so urgent that Glimmer had to call me away from my meeting. I have got more than I can handle right now. ” Casta inquired, crossing her arms over her chest in worried irritation as she entered. Micah sighed heavily, as the guilt at what he had done in this chamber to his own daughter and her friends weighed heavily upon him. Mystacor did not hold many good memories for him. From being manipulated by Light Spinner as a child to the terrible things he had done while under Primes control. But he was resolute, to remain by his sister's side for as long as she needed him. He had lost so much time with his family, thanks to being banished to Beast island by Hordak.

Glimmer caught sight of the pain crossing her father's features and rushed to his side, grabbing his hand and giving it a reassuring squeeze. He passed her a small, thankful smile giving her hand a squeeze back.

“Ok, Good, everyone's here.” Entrapta smiled then took a deep breath. “I was able to hack into Arxia's mainframe and managed to download a few ancient communications from the First Ones and some encrypted messages from a rebel Squadron called 'GraySkull'. I am still working on decrypting them. But I do know that this was an Eternian Outpost, A spaceport to be exact! It was a military hub for space craft and interstellar supplies during the

colonization of Etheria. But it looks like the Fail Safe was more than just a code to shut down the Heart. It was coded to shut down Etheria's Super Computer! Taking down the Planetary Mainframes and all First Ones tech on Etheria. We all know that the First Ones had literally wired the whole world, so long story short. Etheria is going off line one system at a time." Entrapta stated, her eyes firm with how serious this was.

"I'm confused..." Castaspella pressed her fingers to her forehead.

Adora's mouth fell open in surprise, her face growing pale with dread. Catra moved to stand in front of her. The slightly shorter feline, gripped Adora's shoulders, staring up at her with concern. She could see the inner struggle of guilt and fear running through Adora's shifting expressions. Catra wanted to offer her support, comfort, anything to help her deal with the irreversible damage she had unintentionally done to the planet.

Glimmer turned to the Crystal's rising up towards the ceiling in confusion. While Bow dashed around to crouch behind Entrapta to verify the information. His face went pale as he realized the full extent of the damage the Fail Safe would be causing. By taking all the tech that they had come to depend on off line.

"We don't know how the planet will be affected...what was regulated by First Ones Tech and what's natural?" Bow breathed in horror.

While Entrapta nodded. "Exactly, We are moving into untested waters." Her face was full of grave excitement. "With the loss of all the Rune Stones. Our plant could become unbalanced... the weather may become hostile...whole ecosystems could die off...We have no idea what Etheria had been like before the First Ones started tampering with it. Or how all their changes over the last thousand years have affected our planet...." Entrapta stated, her eyes wide and brimming with exhilaration at all the experiments she could run.

“The mainframes in every First Ones structure, Outpost or Beacon will go off line.” Bow groaned.

“What does it really matter? So we gotta learn how to do things without tech” Mermista huffed, crossing her arms over her chest. “Our Rune Stones are gone, the Sea gate is already destroyed.” She glared at Catra. “Thanks for that, by the way.” She finished bitterly. “So what, we have to adapt.” She grumbled.

Catra took a deep breath and closed her eyes, refusing to rise to the bait. She deserved whatever snide remark Mermista threw at her. She had no right to retaliate verbally or otherwise.

“Well, it matters...big time.” Bow threw back, brushing his hands threw the tight curls on his head in frustration. “There are many places on Etheria that depend on First Ones tech. Like Alwyn....depends on their transmitter beacon to run the machinery that works the land to grow the crops, harvest the orchards. We might be able to adapt, with different technologies in place. But that would take time....” He took a deep breath. “But some places need that tech to stay alive. Such as the Kingdom of Snows.”

“What are you talking about?” Frosta huffed indignantly.

“The Kingdom of Snows is an Arctic Wasteland, no one could survive up there! Your entire Castle is built on a First Ones Citadel, when it's mainframe goes offline. All the power that was once being channeled throughout the Castle and your villages will be gone. No power, no heat, no kingdom.” Bow groaned.

Frosta’s jaw dropped in surprise. Her sullen expression slowly fell into fear as a grim understanding set in. Her dark blue eyes shimmering with despair.

“Does that mean all our castles are built on First Ones Citadels?” Glimmer asked, fear wavering in her voice.

“Not all, one of the Castles was far older, it was always Etherian. Bright Moon...I believe it is powered by magic alone. ” He stated,

“Plumeria doesn't have a castle, don't know if it even did.”

Perfuma merely shrugged. “We are known only as the Forest People, we have always been somewhat transient. We have never needed a Castle, the Heart Blossom was our place to gather.”

“Salineas Castle was built by Etherian's but it is powered now by First Ones tech....but it's mostly destroyed now...” Bow mused.

“Thanks for that!” Mermista shouted at Catra, her voice full of venom.

Catra squeezed her eyes shut and ducked her head as if she just got slapped, taking another deep breath at the painful dig.

Adora had enough and cut her eyes threateningly at Mermista.

Mermista ground her teeth, having a very hard time keeping her cool. She stormed off to the doorway, she had had hopes of rebuilding her kingdom. But now it seemed there would be no foundation to rebuild her kingdom from.

“Netossa and Spinerella's kingdoms don't have castles, they are just fiefdoms to Bright Moon. Scorpia's kingdom is powered by Horde tech so it should be alright.” Bow was working through the information slowly. Entrapta has retrofitted Dryl with her own tech, I doubt it will be affected."

Entrapta tapped a portion of the screen insistently. Bow groaned. “But Mystacor is going to fall out of the sky when the Arxia Mainframe goes off line.” He looked up in fright.

“We have several thousand people living on the island and thousands more have flocked here over the last few weeks!” Casta exclaimed in terror.

Adora looked like she was going to throw up, she was very pale and a dull sheen of sweat was covering her face.

“Adora?” Catra moved in front of her again, shielding her coming panic attack from the others. Holding her shoulders and forcing her to keep eye contact. As Adora began to breathe more rapidly, struggling to take in air. Her blue eyes were glossy and she was staring blankly at Catra. Quickly ducking her head and casting her stricken eyes to the floor. As staring at her girlfriend's worried expression was more than she could handle on top of everything else.

Catra understood what was happening as it had happened to her on numerous occasions growing up. Every time someone she cared about left her, it got a little worse. The worst breakdown she had ever had was after Scorpia had abandoned her. The stress and anxiety got to be too much to handle. Leaving you in this hopeless fog, you just couldn't pull yourself out of.

“I'm sorry....I'm so very sorry...” Adora whispered brokenly. “I can fix this...right...She-Ra can fix this?” She raised her head, tears flowing down her cheeks. Her shimmering blue eyes, yearning for hope. As she silently pleaded for Entrapta to tell her what to do.

Entrapta met her stricken gaze with a concerned frown, her mind spinning through countless scenarios’ desperate to find the solution that could save them.

“No, this is not for She-Ra to fix.” Hordak's voice echoed out from Entrapta's pad.

“Hordak?” Entrapta shot her gaze back down; she had been working with Hordak since leaving the meeting last night. To hack into Arxia and find the data she needed to prove her and Hordak's theories.

“My brothers and I have been working on a way to router the Super Computer's many functions through the Sky Tree's elaborate mainframes. In theory our Hive Mind, could temporarily replace all the planetary mainframes the Super Computer supports and could also be taken off line a piece at a time. Giving Etheria time to rebuild a new technological infrastructure. So your people

can acclimatize to the new way your planet wants to function without First Ones tech.”

“What...wait!” Bow interjected, as Glimmer cast him a terrified look.

“I don't think that's a good alternative?” Glimmer sputtered, moving anxiously towards Entrapta's monitors.

“What are you talking about Hordak?” Entrapta asked, her voice wavering slightly. “It would take an incredible amount of code and power to replicate the Etherian Supercomputer....to run all of Etheria's Mainframes?”

“No, Entrapta. Horde Primes Hive Mind network is more than capable of replacing the Super Computer and the Planetary Mainframes.” Hordak stated his voice was strong, a firm resolve to what he proposed as the only way to save Etheria.

“I don't want a bunch of clones....and Hordak controlling the planet! He will try and take over Etheria again!” Mermista shouted, rushing towards the monitors as well.

“That's not how it works...” Entrapta shot back over her shoulder, her eyes burning with righteous anger. “The clones will have no power to do anything....Hordak’s consciousness will become enslaved to the First Ones tech...it means they would have to give up their freedom?” Entrapta stated in horror.

“Yes, my brother's compliance this time will be their own choice. This is also my choice...You and She-Ra have given me so much. She-Ra purged Prime from my body, freed me from his control for good. I was able to defy Prime because of your friendship Entrapta...you meant so much more to me than his approval. I was able to resurrect who I had become in Primes absence, reclaim my own identity. I was finally able to accept myself all because of you. Entrapta. I will do everything within my power now to keep you safe. " Hordak declared, moving out of sight for a moment. “I have discussed what is expected of them, they

know what is at stake. They agree that protecting the people of Etheria is a worthwhile purpose for them."

Wrong Hordak came into view. "I was elected to oversee my brother's well being while they are connected to Etheria's Super Computer and the thousands of Planetary Mainframes. So I shall be staying on the Sky Tree for the time being." He smiled proudly, before moving off screen as well.

"You never told me any of this!" Entrapta shouted in anger towards her Tracker pad screen. "That was the project you were so obsessed over for the last few weeks. Why you were so adamant about repairing all the systems in Horde Primes Ship."

"I am sorry, but I never wished to worry you or make you feel sad unless this was our only chance at saving the planet." Hordak's face came back into view, he looked grim but determined. His warm yellow eyes were shimmering with affection towards Entrapta.

"I will hack into the Super Computer, and download my consciousness into its core. Overwrite the security systems so that Etheria will recognize me as the Planetary Facilitator. I will then give my brothers access to all the planetary mainframes. As I do this, my brothers will reconnect to the Hive Mind, their combined consciousness will be beamed down to the planet. So we can take over the Super Computer and all the mainframes almost at once." Hordak moved back towards the dais with the newly repaired view screen. That was now scrolling with First Ones glyphs. He sat down heavily on Primes old, utilitarian style throne. While several clones began to attach ports to his shoulders and the back of his neck. He quickly began to look more like Horde Prime than Hordak.

"No...you can't do this!" Entrapta picked up her Tracker pad, screaming desperately into the screen. Her heart was breaking as she watched the clones preparing Hordak to become the Hub of all of Etheria's computer systems. Her further protests were silenced as the island began to shake violently. Everyone

screamed as they were tossed and thrown across the room as the island lurched and fell several feet from the sky.

“I am sending Darla to you.” Hordak instructed with a nod and a snap of his finger's to a couple clones that were out of view. “Try and evacuate as many people as you can. In case, I can not make my connection to the Etherian Super Computer in time to save Mystacor.” His voice was low and determined.

“Hordak....” Entrapta swallowed, flipping down her mask to conceal the tears as they began falling from her eyes. “I just got you back.” She whispered brokenly.

“I believe in you, Entrapta. You will figure out another way for Etheria to go forward without the need of Eternia's loathsome tech. Then my brothers and I can be released from our tasks.” Hordak gave her a warm, reassuring smile. “I must do this...I owe She-Ra so much. I need to repair the damage I've done to this planet, to its people. In this way, I can protect them...I can help them rebuild all that I have destroyed...I can begin to atone for my hubris...”

He cut the transmission, unable to watch Entrapta cry over him and his chosen fate.

“Hordak!” Entrapta screamed in despair, shaking the Tracker pad furiously near her welding mask.

Catra glanced nervously at Adora who still looked rather shell shocked, but she was gathering her resolve. Catra could see her pushing her guilt and fear aside as her blue eyes hardened with determination. She had orders to focus on, a duty to fulfill. She needed to save everyone!

“Ok, Let's do this!” Adora raised her head from the floor. “We need to make a plan, to get as many people loaded onto Darla as we can in the next few minutes. We don't know how long we have until Mystacor falls...If Mystacor falls...” She was already in motion, striding for the door, refusing to give into negative

thinking. She would do everything she could to fix this, to protect the innocent and save Etheria. The princesses rallied behind her, along with Casta and Micah. While Scorpia and Catra remained behind, as they crouched behind Entrapta. Melog moved towards the doorway, glancing at the retreating princess and back to Catra anxiously.

Scorpia placed a pincher on Entrapta's shoulder, but she ignored it. Sniffling and wiping her nose with the back of her gloved hand beneath the mask. She was now very busy typing away on her keyboards, switching her monitor feeds to Mystacor's mainframe readings and the Sky Tree's outputs. She had no idea where the Super computer was, but had a theory it was somewhere in the Northern Reach. Hordak must know, he must be able to infiltrate its systems from the Sky Tree. She needed to track what progress she could, as Hordak and his brothers sought to connect with the Etherian network, in case they needed help. She understood that they had no other options, that this was the only way to save the planet. If they allowed the mainframes to go offline, then chaos would reign and millions of lives could be lost. She morbidly wanted to watch the exact moment Hordak and his brother's consciousness was logged into the technological grid of the planet.

“We gotta go, Entrapta.” Catra coaxed.

“I am not leaving, Hordak may need me, in case he hits firewalls within the security system. I might have to help him hack into Etheria's network.” She stated, her voice firm. Her emotions hidden behind her mask. As she began to set aside her personal feelings for the greater good. There was still hope, she just needed to be patient. This was just another problem for her to solve, she would figure out a way to power Etheria with just magic then Hordak and his brothers could be free again.

“I'm sure Hordak's got it all figured out on his end.” Scorpia stated, but her stinger was poised, shivering with the intent to strike. She never liked stinging her friends but if she had to, to save their life then she would do it.

“Doesn't Darla have a much more powerful computer then those little computers of yours? I think you would be more useful to Hordak from there. ” Catra crossed her arms, passing Scorpia a knowing smile.

“You're right! Darla's processing power is much faster and her communications relays can go much further. I would be able to connect to the planetary network much better. Thanks Catra!” She was on her feet, her hair carrying her out of the room faster than they could run.

“Sly, Wild Cat...sly.” Scorpia chuckled, as they ran out of the Fail Safe chamber together.

Catra paid her a satisfied smile. “I have my ways of getting people to do what I want.” She stated smugly.

“Nice to see you using that cunning mind for good.” Scorpia responded, grinning happily.

Catra nodded with a thin smile laced with bitter humor.

By the time they got topside, moving down the covered passage and into the courtyard. The princesses were nowhere to be seen.

Catra sniffed the air wanting to catch Adora's scent. As the ground shook, thin fissures opened in the cobblestones all along the courtyard. They could hear several loud explosions in the distance, smoke billowed into the sky. As huge chunks of debris fell from overhead. That once belonged to the inner courtyards, near the lower bastions. Catra and Scporpia ran for cover beneath a stone archway.

“We gotta find the others, stat!” Scorpia shouted, dancing on her toes anxiously.

“I know...” Catra growled, “We gotta get to a high place, so I can get a good look around. There are just too many smells, I can't pick them out.”

Melog pranced in front of them, then grew in size, stretching their wings and paying Catra a firm look.
“Alright, get on Scorpia.” Catra commanded, climbing up onto Melog's back.

“You sure about this, Wild Cat...I mean, things could get dicey up in the air with me...”

Scorpia chucked a warning pincher at the stinger on her tail nervously.

“We both know how to keep our tails to ourselves, now get on. I trust you, Scorpia.” Catra patted Melog's back just behind her. Offering Scorpia a confident grin.

“Ok!” Scorpia smiled broadly, climbing on and wrapping her pinchers lightly around Catra's waist.

“Scorpia...I need you to actually hang onto me! Or you are going to fall off.” Catra scolded.

“Right....right...” Scorpia swallowed hard, very nervous about pressing herself up tighter against her. But she did not want to disappoint Catra by endangering herself. Her face was a blaze with silent yearning. As she felt Catra's supple body against her front. It was sad and frustrating that her crush on Catra had never ebbed. Even now when she knew she didn’t stand a chance with her. Her body just reacted whenever Catra was close, with those same fluttering butterflies in her stomach and electric current pulsing through her skin as she held her.

Melog pumped their wings and shot up into the sky, Making wide circles over Mystacor as both Catra and Scorpia kept their eyes focused on the four main courtyards, bastions and buildings attempting to track down their friends. They could see the ground shaking, cracks spider webbed over the courtyards. Fissures tore up the sides of several larger buildings, compromising the structures, as the beautiful outer facades crumbled away to the cobblestones. Fires had started to spread throughout the refugee

encampments and the Merchant quarter, as the terrified sounds of panic began to echo throughout Mystacor.

A brilliant red light shone from the highest tower on the upper bastion. It's light strobed like a beacon through the late morning light. Catra and Scorpia were both drawn to it for a moment, taking note of Mystacor's distress beacon.

“Do you think anyone will come?” Scorpia asked quietly, ducking her face near Catra’s ear. So she could hear her over the rush of the wind.

“With the kingdoms as beat down as they are after Horde Prime, I really don't know.” Catra called back, narrowing her eyes as she caught sight of one of the princesses.

She pointed to the Eastern Courtyard, Scorpia followed her line of sight. Finding Perfuma riding a giant vine, with hundreds of citizens on board headed at a great speed towards the main gate.

The low roar of Darla's engines echoed in the distance. The ship would be landing in a few minutes.

A growing crowd was already gathering just outside the main gates within the outer Tranquil gardens.

“Looks like Perfuma found her powers again.” Catra smiled coyly up at Scorpia. Catching how enraptured the Scorpion was by Perfuma's powerful display of magic. Her gentle strength was amazing to behold.

“That's great, put me down there. Wild Cat!” Scorpia pointed to the worn stone battlements that flanked the eastern gatehouse. She would be able to catch up with Perfuma from there.

Catra nodded, as Melog dove towards the large, ancient stone watchtower to the east of the Citadel.

As Melog landed, trotting along the wide stone and mortar battlement. Catra caught sight of that familiar glow of She-Ra's sword, deep in the refugee camp that sprawled through the Eastern Courtyard. Many fires had broken out and were raging out of control, devouring the makeshift village of tents and ramshackle buildings in record speed. Smoke clogged the courtyard, billowing in rancid grey clouds down below. Holding her sword aloft, She-Ra was leading a crowd of Etherian's through the smoke and wreckage. Catra climbed off Melog preparing to head down to the gate house with Scorpia to meet up with Adora.

Mystacor shuttered and lurched, just as Scoripa and Catra managed to get to the winding stairs in the upper reaches of the gatehouse tower. “Hang on!” Scorpia yelled from a stairwell below, as the whole structure began to tremble and shake. The sinking feeling in her gut of Mystacor losing altitude made her growl in distress. Catra ground her teeth and dug her claws into the wooden railing, as her stomach roiled in protest as the island plummeted again. A flash of pink light just beyond the ramparts on the outer wall, caught her eye. She glanced up as she rode out the quake. Gazing intently through a simple narrow window, finding Glimmer teleporting away from a large group of people just beyond the gates below them. As the tremors eased, they moved quickly down the rest of the stairs and out threw the main gate.

The sharp glow of Darla's engines shone through the clouds just above the cascading waterfall that dominated this side of the island. The familiar hum of her engines grew louder. As Darla hovered for a moment, before finding a patch of bare ground several yards away to land. Darla had barely made it down, before her ramp extended. Perfuma was quick to start leading her groups aboard. Scorpia ran to catch up to her, leaving Catra searching the massive crowds for She-Ra. It didn't take her long to figure out, Adora had never left the courtyard, merely guiding her group to the main doors before dashing back into the fire storm the Eastern Courtyard had become.

Catra heaved a great sigh, not looking forward to the acrid scent of the blaze burning her nose, dulling her sense of smell. Or the smoke stinging her eyes, making it more difficult to see. Finding Adora again in that massive fire could be difficult, but not impossible.

“Com'on Melog, let's find our girl.” Catra climbed up onto her cat companion. As they rushed back threw the empty main gates.

Saving Mystacor

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Melog rushed through the fire shadows, alert to all kinds of danger. Their ears swivel, attempting to keep vigilant to any sounds of fiery debris that may come crashing down upon them. Their eyes, glowed with a fierce aura in the murky, semi-darkness created by the rolling clouds of smoke. As they kept their eyes narrowed, blinking rapidly to keep the smoke from burning them. Catra huddled on their back, pressing her face against their cool, iridescent mane. She could barely breathe through all this acrid smoke. Her eyes were burning and her vision was full of tears, streaming down her cheeks, moistening her fur. They were treading cautiously through the inferno, her heart beating fast against her chest with rising fear. She may be the fire princess....but could she control natural fires? Or just the magical fire she created? The thought plagued her as they dashed through the flames, taunting her with its possibility. Her hearing was the only sense she could depend on. So her ears twitched back and forth seeking to listen for threats.

Most of the eastern courtyard had been consumed by the blaze, it had not been selective at all. The makeshift tents and haphazard shelters of scavenged material had been easy fodder for it to devour. Now great walls of flame burned all around her. Licking at the sky high above, as it's fuel was not yet extinguished. It was the faint whimper that got her attention first. Catra turned her head, her ears twitching. Finding the remains of several wagons piled up against a soot blackened stone wall. Then soft crying floated out from behind the debris. The voice was weak and strangled by the choking smoke. The sound could have easily been ignored over the roaring flames that surrounded them. But her hearing was keen, far more than an average Etherian.

“Melog...wait.” Catra patted their neck, making them stop. She climbed off their back, as a tent nearby burst into flames. The sudden explosion rocked the ground as what lay within the tent was ignited, it’s contents sent skyward. Catra wrapped her arms over her head, ducking and running towards the wagons. As flaming debris rained down upon them. Melog moved swiftly around the back of the busted wagons, nose down tracking a scent.

(Behind here.) Their voice called sharply in her head.

Catra picked through the debris, tossing a broken wooden wheel aside, pulling the tattered remains of a tarp away. Revealing two small children huddled in a small cavity amid the debris. They looked barely five years old, dressed in tattered, well worn clothes that hadn't been washed in a while. The larger child had her arms wrapped securely around her smaller companion. She had shoulder length light brown hair, once pulled into a braid that was now loosened and wild around her soot smudged face. She started up at Catra, her wide hazel eyes filled with fear. The smaller child moaned and pulled themselves closer into her chest. His pale blue skin covered in fine downy grey fur, with short black hair, cropped close to his neck. With the drooping, fluffy ears of an Elberon moth hybrid. His tiny, fragile wings were covered in soot, hanging limply down his back.

Catra swallowed hard, they reminded her far too much of her and Adora. Back then, Adora would have protected her just like this. Holding her tight and keeping a close eye, as the world ended all around them. She would have held back her fear and dealt with whatever came their way. While Catra cowered in her arms, overwhelmed by her own fear. At that age, Catra had been scared of everything and everyone. Adora had been the strong one, her steady rock to hold onto.

“Com'on, you two. Let's get you someplace safe.” Catra leaned down over the small wall of broken wood, offering them her hand.

The girl stared up at her with uncertain eyes, refusing to let go of her friend.

Melog moved in on the side, catching the child's eye. She jumped at the sudden appearance of a giant cat moving through the smoke towards them. She pulled a knife from a belt sheath at her hip, pushing the little boy behind her as she scowled up at Melog. Brandishing the knife threateningly at their intruding muzzle.

"Whoa....wait. That's Melog, they are going to help. " Catra cried in alarm.

"Go away!" The girl screamed back, waving the old, pitted blade at Melog. Brave and headstrong, she put herself between the threats and her little companion...shielding them with her own body... Just like Adora would have...

"You can't stay here." Catra pleaded impatiently, leaning over the broken wood attempting to reach for the smaller boy.

"Stay back!" The girl screamed, her voice rising in panic. Pushing the little moth boy who was now so frightened he was sobbing, further back against the stone wall behind them.

"I don't have time for this." Catra growled, rolling her eyes. The little girl was being stubborn and completely unreasonable.

"Momma said, we are to stay here....how will she find us if we leave?" Her bravery finally broke, as she started to hiccough on the verge of tears.

"We will find your momma, when this is all over. I promise!" Catra called urgently, reaching for the girl. She stared up at Catra for a moment, her eyes darting around the inferno surrounding them in terror.

"ok.." She finally agreed in a small voice a few moments later. She turned and crouched down before the young boy. "We gotta go, ok."

He nodded, his round face was marred black by soot, tear tracks clearly visible on full, round cheeks. His deep blue eyes were wet and trusting as he stared up at the older girl. She gave him a comforting squeeze before she moved aside. Pushing him forward towards Catra's waiting arms. His tiny feet stumbled, tripping into Catra's arms. She grabbed him under his arms and lifted him out of the rubble. She reached in again and helped the girl out next. When Melog disentangled themselves from behind the debris, Catra placed both kids on their backs.

“I need you to get these two to Darla and protect them until I get back.” Catra demanded, pulling off her leather coat. She draped the heavy material over the kids heads. “This will protect you from the flames.” She offered kindly, now dressed in only the torn black leggings and the white Horde training shirt.

“Thank you...” The little girl smiled warmly down at her, holding the coat firmly over her and her companions head.

(Be careful.) Melog growled.

“Always am.” Catra grinned, giving them a smug two finger salute and a confident lopsided smile. That showed off a fang. Before rushing off threw the smoke and flames to find Adora.

The ground was trembling, she could feel it shifting and cracking under her feet as she ran. Could hear the screams of terror and cries of anguish on the hot wind. Mystacor was falling out of the sky, at a slow lurching gait. As Arxia went offline one system at a time. Catra was racing through the smoke and flames, desperate to find Adora. Her gaze darted around the burning remains of the eastern courtyard, anxiously trying to find a higher perch so she could get a good look around.

“Where are you?” Catra growled, her claws flexing nervously.

“Catra!” Perfuma's voice thundered over the roaring of the flames.

Catra spun around, finding a massive collection of slithering vines, that she now recognized as roots. Summoned from beneath the ground, from the orchards that surrounded the Citadel. The mammoth proportion of thick, twisting, roots moving through the empty corridor was awe inspiring. The bulk pushed flaming debris aside like it was nothing, protected by a layer of thick sap. The damp roots glistened with a golden sheen. Some twisted away from the main column, grasping burning chunks of mortar or giant pieces of blackened wooden beams and tossing them aside. If a root caught fire, it merely broke away turning to ash as it hit the ground. While another root slithered from the column to take its place. Perfuma was making the corridor that led to the main gate, wider and more secure for larger groups of people. Catra's eyes widened in understanding that the debris free corridor's she had been using to navigate from one end of this courtyard to the other had been created by Perfuma. She was a one princess demolition crew!

"Perfuma!" Catra shouted, racing up to her and climbing onto the roots. As soon as she started to climb, the heady smell of wet earth assaulted her nose. She sneezed a few times, rubbing a finger under her nose to clear away the fine mold and dust she had breathed in. But it did not slow her down, she continued to reach up and grasp roots over her head and pull herself up.

"Do you know where She-Ra went?" She asked, as she climbed up behind Perfuma.

Perfuma glanced back, then raised her arms. The part of the roots they were standing on, ascended into the sky.

"So glad you got your powers back." Catra smirked, giving Perfuma an admiring pat on the shoulder. As she widened her stance to maintain her balance as they shot up into the sky.

"Well, it is quite the story." Perfuma grinned. "But perhaps for another time." She finished, pointing to the south. Catra followed her directions, finding that same brilliant glow of She-Ra's sword cutting through the smoke of the merchants quarter in the central

enclosure. She was moving cautiously through the narrow streets, filled with rubble and smoldering remains of shops. Entering burning buildings to rescue people, or digging through debris, pulling out others. She had a small band of able bodied people to aid with the evacuation. She would direct those who could walk towards the eastern gates with her sword. The groups of survivors followed a couple guides back towards the eastern gates, those too injured to move were set in makeshift travois of cloth and wood. She-Ra was moving swiftly, following cries for aid through the back alleys. Already a small crowd was moving down one of Perfuma's plant-made corridor's towards the stone wall that bordered the outer eastern enclosure.

“Be careful, the ground is becoming more unstable.” Catra offered, before leaping from the cluster of roots.

“Scorpia is calling in reinforcements from the Fright Zone!” Perfuma screamed back. Catra merely nodded as she landed gracefully upon the wooden slatted roof of a central watchtower that separated the two courtyards. Dashing around the curved bell of the slate roof and leaping into the air, rolling into a somersault as she dove into the smoke and flames on the other side.

Finn was still in his Thaymorian disguise. He sat cross legged on a grassy ledge, deep in the outer Tranquil gardens that stretched beyond the main gates of Mystacor. The cascading waterfall that carved down the natural, rocky peak of the island. Roared a few miles off. He could feel the cool spray of the water on the wind. He looked back at the burning chaos that lay beyond the main gates, with a grim frown. Crowds of Etherian's were boarding Darla, ushered aboard by Frosta. Who was keeping the evacuation orderly, by brandishing two absurdly large ice fists. Threatening those who tried to argue with her authority, or merely punching out the ones who tried to fight her. Then dragging their unconscious bodies aboard, screaming epitaphs of further punishments to anyone else stupid enough to try pick a fight with

a Princess. It didn’t take long for the crowds to concede that they couldn’t stay on Mystacor, but had to board this strange alien vessel. Whether they wanted to or not.

Over to the North, he had caught sight of several Scorpion Air Carriers, hovering behind the waterfall. He had caught sight of Swift Wind circling the mountain’s peak, searching for more survivors on the northern side of the island. The evacuation was split into two. Half of Mystacor was being usher out to Darla on the Eastern gate, while the other half was being sent out of the Northern Gate to board Scorpion Air Carriers. What he knew of this timeline's history, this was a pivotal point. To better their chances at improving their own future. He had used his magic over space and time to tether himself to this thread of existence, to go back to change this outcome for the better.

Finn leaned back on his arms, craning his head up in somber contemplation. Heavy clouds were gathering, the smoke and ash from the massive fires was filling the air. He felt the low rumble of the ground, as the island shook. His stomach lurching upward as Mystacor fell several feet from the sky. He knew from the historical records that Entrapta was on board Darla. She had hacked into the Arxia mainframe and was desperately rerouting systems to keep the island's descent as smooth as possible. While also keeping track of Hordak's progress in downloading his and his brethren's consciousness into the planetary Super Computer. That ran Etheria's massive network of mainframes scattered throughout the Seven Kingdoms. The First Ones had wired the whole planet, at this point in time the Etherian's still needed that tech to survive.

Movement just below the ledge caught his eye. Finn took a deep settling breath, this was it! He might have been just a kid, but his mom’s had taught him how to fight. With his heart beating fast against his chest, he leaped from the ledge. Landing in a crouch before a grey cloaked figure that had been attempting to slip away from Mystacor during the chaos.

“What a cute little deer boy, you lost?” Jitsu's voice was snide, pulling down his hood to cast his eyes more clearly around the burnt remains of the garden. He was looking for something, but the sky ahead was barren. Absently crossing his one good hand under his cloak. “The end of the world's back there kid, why don't you go die somewhere else. I've got no time to fool around with you.”

Finn smiled defiantly, pulling his sling shot from his belt. “Looks like my mom's already gave you a good beating.” Finn chuckled, taking note of his badly burnt right hand and the large ugly bruises that wrapped around his neck.

Jitsu's eyes narrowed in malice, a low growl of rage building in his throat.

“You gotta death wish kid!” He growled

Finn merely shrugged, he swiftly unslung the leather sling from the slingshot and stuffed it into his poncho pocket. Then pressed a button on the side of his slingshot handle. The two arms retracted into the main column of the metal weapon, seamlessly. Then with a soft clicking sound the thin hand held metal pole extended into a quarterstaff. The leather bound hilt of the sling shot becoming the middle handhold of the staff. The pointed tips on either end of the staff began to glow a brilliant orange.

“Horde tech.” Jitsu spat.

Finn adjusted his stance, spreading his legs apart to better his balance. “Actually, it's Etherian Tech. Aunt ‘Trapta made this special for me, for my birthday, when I was still just a little kid.” Finn stated smugly.

“You're still just a little kid.” Jitsu scoffed.

“You have something I want. So we can do this the easy way or the hard way.” Finn snapped back, glowering defiantly up at him.

Jitsu rolled his eyes in annoyance, not taking the little deer boy seriously.

“Go away, kid.” He snarled gruffly.

“Hard way it is then.” Finn ducked low and charged with his staff. Thrusting it low to try and trip Jitsu.

Jitsu laughed and spun to the left, easily dodging the strike. In the next few minutes, Finn began to maneuver Jitsu around with feints and strikes. While the much taller man, blocked with his arms, adjusting his stance, desperately trying to go on the offensive.

“You fight like a Horde soldier.” Jitsu commented, curiously. “All controlled and calculated with your attacks. Rather easy to forecast what you are going to do next.” He jeered, countering Finn with a low sweep of his legs.

Finn hissed in fright, leaping into the air and swinging wildly with his staff at Jitsu's head. Jitsu was taken off guard at the sudden hiss coming out of a deer Hybrid and took the hit to the head. When the tip of the staff struck his face. It instantly singed his skin, leaving a nasty burn across his temple. His head struck sideways into the stone wall that held up a grassy ledge. The stone chipped and cracked on impact, sending fine shards of stone and dirt into the air. Blinding Jitsu, who stumbled back snarling in frustration. Jitsu pulled away from the wall with a menacing glare, rubbing the blood off his cheek with the back of his hand. He now sported a nasty gash along his temple that was oozing blood down his face. He gave Finn's body a mildly curious look, catching sight of the metal links of his necklace.

Jitsu huffed and slid his feet into a wider more defensive stance, raising both of his hands up. His fingers were locked firmly in a knife chopping position.

“Rang your bell!” Finn laughed merrily, hopping on the cloven tips of his hooves. “Are you seeing double?”

“I am seeing an imposter.” Jitsu slurred out, not admitting that it had been a good hit. Even though he did feel a bit light headed and off balance now. He quickly cleared his throat, spitting out blood, then dashed forward. His hand strikes were swift and powerful, chopping and blocking as Finn attempted to defend himself with his bow staff. Forced to take one step back after another, losing ground as Jitsu maneuvered him around against his will.

He had no chance to deflect the dagger coming for his throat. He yelped in terror as the blade sliced inches away from the side of his neck. Gasping in fright, as the hilt of the dagger blade hooked on the metal chain, snapping it. The daggers momentum, pulling his amulet off his neck and sending it flying across the grass. Jitsu charged for him, Finn yelped and spun out of his way. Watching in horror as Jitsu promptly stomped on the amulet, breaking the lotus in two, loosening a few of the magic crystals embedded into the back of it.

Finn's Thaymorian disguise flashed out of existence.

“Ah...another magicat.” Jitsu nodded, a smug smile creeping over his face. “No, not pure….a half breed...” He mused, his dark eyes scrutinizing Finn's true form. Surveying every aspect of their body and clothing with a keen eye for detail.

“Give me the Shard of Kaydak!” Finn roared, they were losing their advantage fast. Jitsu was stronger, faster and far more trained in combat than them. Finn's eyes darted franticly around the grassy slope above them and barren patches of burnt grass. That remained in the Tranquil garden surrounding them. They were now on the defensive and running out of options fast.

“Ahhh..you seek the power of Gorta as well?” Jitsu laughed, mirthlessly.

“I seek to destroy all aspects of the Nameless One. So he can never be summoned back into this dimension, again.” Finn snarled.

“Well, that was quite a mouthful for such a young child.” Jitsu sighed, his interpretation of Finn becoming less like a nuisance and more of a threat. As the kid divulged far too much sensitive information about Lord Skeletor's plan.

What remained of the afternoon's sunlight had long departed behind the rolling clouds of caustic smoke. Catra glanced fearfully up at the ominous grey sky, as a rush of billowing heat rolled over her. She squinted, her eyes burning as she ran blindly through the narrow alleys of the Merchant Quarter. The simple beam and post buildings on either side that had wooden walls within were blackened by fire. The stone and mortar walls on the outside cracked and collapsed. The heavy debris and shattered glass had fallen onto the street, blocking it completely at times. Forcing her to find another way around, darting down alleys, leaping and climbing over the rubble as she valiantly chased after her true love. Desperately following the blinding glow of her sword or the flash of her shield.

As She-Ra the Immortal savior of Etheria followed the calls for help, the screams of fear, the wails of the dying. Drawing the survivors of Mystacor to her side, leading them back through the burning streets. She was so deep into the southern enclosure, having rescued so many people, the small group of guides she had with her were now gone. She was now left having to protect another large group of people she had gathered. She led them every step of the way through Perfuma's root-created corridors, holding her sword aloft. Igniting the blade so that it flared like a beacon amid the blinding smoke. The now massive crowd was following her back towards the main gates, at a steady pace.

Catra rounded the corner of a burnt out street, finding herself at the twisted, melted remains of an ornate iron gateway. Beyond lay the charred vegetation of a large park. The dead trees, blackened to ash, still stood like dried out skeletons amid the smoke. Their bare branches clawing upwards towards the gloomy sky. Catra quickly took stock of her position and where she had last seen

She-Ra. If she cut through this now dead green space then she should come out pretty much on the same thoroughfare She-Ra had been moving down. With a resolute nod, Catra dashed through the melted gate on all fours wanting to cover as much ground as she could. Her claws clicked on the flat, winding, cobblestone paths that were still warm from the inferno that had just roared through a few minutes before. The fire had consumed all that it could before either being snuffed out or leaping onto other flammable material across the thoroughfare on the other side of the park. Continuing it’s feast as it burned through the shops and cafes that lined the other side of the street. Fire was her element, she had a strange understanding about it since her dreams. It was wild, uncontrollable and so very destructive...it's resemblance to her persona from the past was rather frightening. Yet it was also a protector against the dark, a source of heat that kept other's warm and alive against the cold. It's ambiance could be rather passionate and intoxicating, bringing others closer, offering comfort and reassurance that no matter how bad things got....there would always be light. Could she really consider any of that to be a part of who she was...right now?

Catra swallowed hard, shaking her head to clear it from dwelling so deeply upon her own magic. She was not really ready to deal with any of that right now. Quiet sobs floated out from behind a stone border wall a few meters ahead. Catras' ears twitched at the mournful sound as she slowed down to a jog on just her feet. Reluctantly coming to a stop as the half wall of stacked stones ended, she hung back for a moment. Hiding out of view behind the wall, ducking her face around the smooth edge cautiously. Finding bitterly the source of that sorrow. A simple courtyard lay behind the stone wall, with sturdy iron gilded benches lining the circular enclosure. In the center was a massive, if elegant water fountain of carved white marble. Mermista was sitting upon the wide edge of the fountain. Her knees pulled up to her chest, her arms wrapped tightly around them. Her face pressed against her crossed arms, crying miserably.

Catra was honestly quite unsettled with the whole situation. She wasn't the comforting type...at least to anyone but Adora. Least of

which to a woman who hated her! Catra groaned in distress, scrubbing a frustrated hand down her face. Pressing her back against the wall fighting with her instincts to just run away. To leave Mermista to her misery and not get involved. Taking several deep breaths as she tried to find some courage to move out of hiding. Listening to the loud, broken sobs, soft moans and agitated hiccups of a woman who had just given up all hope. Catra had been there, she had heard those very same broken sounds, coming from herself not too long ago in the Fright Zone. After she had lost everything and everyone...including her will to live.

“Ok....you can do this.” Catra clenched her fists, seeking to reassure herself with a little pep talk. She took a deep breath and then promptly marched into view.

“Hey, Mermista?” Catra called and waved stiffly. Flashing the Sea Princess a toothy, nervous grin.

Mermista slowly raised her face from her arms, her expression was dark and unimpressed. Her eyes were wet, red rimmed and puffy from crying. Tear tracks could be seen clearly running down her face, as it was dirty from soot and ash. It seemed perhaps she had tried to help, but quickly lost confidence in her abilities without her magic. Hiding away in this garden, feeling sorry for herself and brooding over what she had lost.

“That is just my luck...isn't it.” Mermista grumbled bitterly, rolling her eyes. “The one person who I never wanted to see me this way, is the one who shows up. Honestly....! The universe hates me!” She snarled and grabbed her trident from her hip, rocketing off the fountain towards Catra with murderous intent.

“Maybe I can't do this...” Catra yelped, raising her arms in defense to meet Mermista's charge. Cutting her eye sideways to the security of her hiding spot. Debating if she had enough time to run.

“I hate you!” Mermista screamed, thrusting her trident at Catra’s face. Catra took a step back and batted the prongs off course with the backs of her wrists. Cringing as she felt her bones vibrating upon impact.

“This is all your fault!” Mermista roared, twirling the weapon high and then cutting down to sweep Catra off her feet. Catra leaped and rolled away a few yards, jumping back to her feet and raising her arms once again.

“You destroyed my kingdom!” She shouted, her voice breaking. Thrusting and swinging her weapon repeatedly at Catra, trying to slash or impale her. But Catra was agile and light on her feet. She was able to dance and sway just out of reach.

“I'm sorry!” Catra screamed back, as the flat of the prongs struck her other arm. As she was forced to parry with her bare hands. She refused to fight back, keeping her claws retracted as she sought only to defend herself. She knew she had this coming, that she deserved Mermista's rage and this beating. She would endure the bruises and abrasions if it meant they could move past this hate. She just wanted to prove herself, that she was no longer that cruel, ruthless Horde Commander. That in the last few months since her salvation from Horde Prime. She had grown, gotten a little wiser and more compassionate. She was no longer driven by fear or rage....or even hell bent on her own destruction. She wanted to leave that dark past behind her. She wanted forgiveness...she wanted to do what was necessary to atone for her role in the war.

“Sorry! Does not repair all the villages you ordered burned to the ground. As your forces advanced down the coast. Or fix the sea gate or even my palace, your warships destroyed! It doesn't bring back the dead! Or heal the pain and sorrow you caused my people!” Mermista snarled, her more blunt attacks becoming more desperate and uncoordinated, as tears flowed unchecked down her cheeks.

Catra's arms throbbed from deflecting the flat side of her trident, she felt that perhaps Mermista might have even cracked or even broken a few small bones on her wrists. But she never showed even a hint of weakness, clenching her jaw every time the trident struck her arms. Masking her physical pain behind a well practiced facade of firm resolve. Glancing behind, keeping an eye on where she was backing up making sure not to get cornered against the border wall or the fountain.

“If I could go back and change things. I would! I hate that girl too!” Catra screamed back, cringing as her bones vibrated painfully from another fierce impact. But refused to evade Mermista's attacks, resolved to take each blow. To absorb Mermista's rage. To let her exact justice for her people's suffering.

Mermista was gasping for breath, teeth bared as she continued to seethe and strike again and again.

“You are ruining this for me!” Mermista growled, clenching her weapon close to her body. Her dark brown eyes glaring down at Catra, full of resentment and unresolved fury.

Catra was taken aback and stared up at her in awe and confusion.

“Fight me!” Mermista screamed, adjusting her stance and threatening Catra with the sharp points of her trident.

“No!” Catra shouted back stubbornly, dropping her arms, keeping her claws retracted.

Mermista raised her face to the sky and screamed, long and loud in exasperation. Throwing her trident aside in a fit of unfocused rage. She stormed off back to the fountain, as her weapon clattered on the stones, the heavy iron ringing through the calm stillness of the courtyard.

“I hate you more now, then ever.” She muttered bitterly, sitting down on the wide edge of the fountain's reservoir in a huff.

Catra heaved a great sigh, shaking out her arms. “You and pretty well all of the Etheria. “

Mermista slowly raised her eyes up from the ground in grim reflection. “ Do you hate yourself?”

“Yes...” Catra cut her eyes towards her briefly, slowly bowing her head. Her expression, submissive and remorseful. Before all her raging emotions could overwhelm her, she began to pace, tucking her tail between her legs. Holding herself tightly, by crossing her arms around her stomach. As if that was the only binding, keeping her from falling apart.

Mermista groaned, “Seriously?”

“I had plenty of time while on Primes ship to reflect on my faults, my mistakes, my destructive choices and cruel actions.” Catra then crossed her arms defensively over her chest, feeling rather vulnerable and unsettled by this conversation. But it needed to happen, Mermista deserved her honesty. Perhaps if she came to understand that all Catra wanted now was to atone for her sins, then perhaps she could find some closure. Give her a second chance to make things right....eventually.

Mermista merely raised an impatient eyebrow, wanting her to continue.

Catra sighed and gave her a bitter smirk. “You want an itemized list of all my bad choices....that led to even worse consequences...for everyone...even me?” She muttered, bowing her head in shame.

“No.” Mermista offered her a thin, sarcastic half smile, before scrubbing a hand down her face in frustration.

“I was hurt and full of rage at everyone...But that's no excuse for what I did. I was everything Shadow Weaver raised me to be. A ruthless, remorseless, monster, hell bent on ruling the world at all cost. I will spend the rest of my life trying to fix the damage I've

done.” Catra’s shoulders were bowed with remorse, her eyes had grown distant and brooding.

“I am so jealous and angry at you, Catra. I can't even think straight when I see you.” Mermista groaned.

“The angry part I get...jealous of what?” Catra laughed, mirthlessly.

“You of all people have elemental powers.” Mermista stated, “How in the Seven kingdoms does that make any sense.”

Catra started to laugh. It was a weak, nervous sound that floated through the silent courtyard. “It's a really long story, but if you want, maybe I can help you summon your own power again?” Catra moved a bit closer, but remained out of reach. Sitting on the cobblestones a few paces away in case Mermista decided to have another go at her.

“I'm desperate, so yeah, sure.” Mermista shrugged, adjusting her posture, she turned to sit cross legged on the fountain's edge facing Catra.

“Well...” Catra cleared her throat, glancing anxiously around the burnt out courtyard.

Mermista's stoic expression went from unimpressed to a sneer of distrust, as Catra stalled.

“I really don't know how I summoned my magic...” Catra cringed, feeling very nervous and on the spot to find an explanation.

“ughhhhh!” Mermista groaned, rolling her eyes in disgust.

“I was really scared!...ok.” Catra shouted back, desperate to prove herself. “I couldn't find Adora in the swamp and the dark magic was poisoning me...I....I...couldn't lose her again. “ Her anxiety was roaring in her ears at her bold honesty. As she finally opened up about what she had endured in that swamp. Laying herself bare before Mermista. About how she had felt weak, powerless

and frightened out of her mind as the magic overwhelmed her. “I was struggling to stay awake...then I started thinking about Adora. How badly I had screwed things up for us, for all those years. How grateful I was that she hadn't given up on me, that she saved me from Prime....that I didn't deserve a second chance to make things right but she had given me one...that all I wanted to do from now on. Was to protect her! Like, I promised when we were kids!” Catra was screaming, holding herself tight, rocking back and forth. Her tail wrapped around her waist protectively, her ears drooping in embarrassment.

“Wow....” Mermista breathed, she had never seen this side of Catra. It was refreshing to see her being so genuine and so very, very vulnerable.

Catra opened her eyes slowly, finding that her whole body was once again on fire.

“I am no hero...not like Adora. But I am trying....to be a better person. What's your reason...Mermista...why do you fight, who do you fight for?” Catra breathed, her head cocked to the side, eyes pleading for Mermista to understand. Then she slowly rose to her feet, needing to reclaim some of her personal power, she felt so weak and submissive sitting on the ground. Her stomach was roiling with frayed nerves and anxiety. Admitting her fears and insecurities to a complete stranger had been difficult for her. She now felt raw and laid bare. She was very nervous about it. Would Mermista use this information later on to hurt her, use her, manipulate her? She had such nasty trust issues...

Mermista heaved a great breath, closing her eyes slowly. She began to simply sit, her hands resting on her knees, contemplating silently what Catra had told her.

Catra stood awkwardly, watching Mermista sitting silently upon the fountain. Shifting her weight on her feet, taking stock of the various emotions moving over Mermista's face. Her faint frown of contemplation, growing more stern, her brows knitting together more prominently.

“What are you thinking about?” Catra asked, unable to keep her peace any longer as her growing anxiety got the best of her.

“How much I hate you.” Mermista growled back impatiently.

“Whatever works, I guess...” Catra moaned, rubbing the back of her neck and returning to pacing. Worried she had just spouted off about her honest feelings for no reason. That what she had said hadn't atoned for anything or helped Mermista find her powers.

Then with a mighty roar, Mermista's eyes snapped open glowing with power. She stood and called her trident to her hand, raising the weapon over her head. All the water that was once held in the reservoir of the fountain rose up and came crashing down upon Catra. The feline screamed in fright as the wall of water slammed into her at full force. Just like before in the Fright Zone when Mermista had attacked her with all her magical strength. All the air was crushed from her lungs, as the freezing water burned her skin. Panic set in as she felt herself drowning, trapped within the rushing current, suspended in the air and at Mermista’s mercy. Then the column of water carried her up into the sky, then released her by cracking like a whip, sending her flying into the air and across the burnt out remains of the park. Mermista smirked proudly as she watched Catra soaring out of control, then out of view into the grey sky. The cat hybrids desperate curses and screams of fright, a perfect apology for her actions during the war.

Finn kept their distance from Jitsu, moving swiftly on the balls of their feet. They had lost their bow staff in the last bout, as Jitsu had snapped it in half with a chopping strike. Now, Finn circled Jitsu, their claws raised defensively. As the larger man stood smugly gloating. Enjoying the fear in the little magicat's blue eyes.

“I am not without honor, I shall make your death quick.” Jitsu nodded, adjusting his stance and raising his hands to deliver the killing blow on his next attack.

Finn's heart was beating hard in their chest, tears blurred their sight as their legs trembled with fear. They had fought and clawed for survival for the last few years. Only to be killed in the past? Without any hope of fixing the hell the future had become? Finn refused to give up! They crouched low, hissing in defiance as Jitsu charged.

(Move to the left, child.) A deep, velvet soft voice echoed in their mind. (Now!)

Finn leaped to the left, as a deafening roar rumbled behind them. Jitsu's eyes widened in fear and alarm.

Finn glanced behind, feeling the cool mist against their face before noticing that the waterfall itself was moving, the immense body of water had pulled away from the mountain. Rushing threw the air in a torrent towards them. Finn grinned in triumph, then leaped upon Jitsu's front, ripping their claws through the front of their cloth tunic. Shredding what remained of their leather armor and it all fell over his shoulders, hanging around his waist. The tiny shard of crystal flew from the torn material. Finn clasped it in mid flight, as it sought to tumble to the ground. They bounded off Jitsu's bare chest, leaving slashes over his bare skin from their foot claws. Propelling themselves upward with the natural agility and strength of their magicat heritage. Landing with a triumphant grin on the grassy ledge above, watching gleefully as the powerful rush of water swept Jitsu away. Carrying him back towards the main gate of Mystacor.

Finn watched in fascination as the massive waves of water parted around Darla, rising into the air and raining down upon the flames of the inner courtyards for a long time, snuffing them out instantly.

Finn felt a strong hand grip their shoulder softly. They turned to find a tall, thin looking man. Dressed in the plain clothes of a commoner. Wearing simple brown traveler's pants and a loose cream colored shirt, with flowing sleeves and a lace frilled collar. Tucked smartly into the pants, that were held up by a wide black leather belt sporting a bright gold buckle in the shape of peacock feather. An open, navy blue overcoat hung off the man's shoulders. That the had a wide black leather hood sewn onto the shoulders. The underside of the coat shimmered like a multi colored jewel. The man had pale blue skin that was leathery and weather worn from years of travel. He might have looked frail and unimpressive. If it wasn't for the twin rapiers sheathed on either hip. Honestly, to Finn he looked like a roguish Pirate from one of Uncle Sea Hawks adventure books.

He had a thin, aristocratic face with high cheekbones and piercing green eyes. Slender pointed ears, adorned with several gold studs. A wide leather headband wrapped around his forehead, holding his long hair back. His dark emerald green hair was pulled back into a loose ponytail that trailed down his back.

“King, Peekablue?” Finn gasped.

“Not yet, I'm afraid.” Prince Peekablue glanced down at Finn, his eyes were warm and tranquil. Drawing Finn's gaze in and holding it firm.

“I never knew you had telepathy?” Finn tapped his head lightly.

“It’s just a spell, I learned, nothing more.” He smiled tenderly down at them. “ But your time here has come to an end, you must come with me now.” His soft expression grew serious.

“I don't want to...” Finn whimpered, tears threatening as they held the shard protectively to their chest.

“I know you don't, child. But they can not see you, as you are now. That would raise far too many questions and affect the future in ways even I can't foresee.” Peekablue stated softly,

crouching down to offer Finn some degree of comfort. He reached his hand out, towards the discarded remains of Finn's amulet and their broken staff. A glowing ball of light shot out of his palm, casting a simple levitation spell. He grasped the amulet pieces and broken staff then floated it all back into his hands. He quickly pocketed the broken trinket into his coat and offered Finn the two pieces of his metal quarterstaff.

“Can you see my future...” Finn moaned, taking the two halves of their staff mournfully. “Did I manage to change anything?”

Peekablue smiled warmly, “You keep that shard safe for now, ok. The future is never set in stone, let's just have faith in the ones we love.”

Finn nodded, allowing Peekablue to guide them away with a gentle hand on their back.

She-Ra was leading a large group of civilians down a wide thoroughfare, nearing the central gates that bordered the Eastern enclosure. That would have transported carts and wagons of supplies throughout the merchant quarter. When a water logged Catra sailed overhead, cursing and screaming in dismay. Unable to twist her body in time to land on her feet, she struck the rooftop of an abandoned merchant shop hard. The ceramic tiles that covered the slanted roof shattered upon her impact, sending shards of clay down upon She-Ra and her crowd of civilians.

“Catra!” She-Ra shouted, preparing to leap through the broken window of the shop to find a way to the roof.

Catra groaned and flopped her arms over the ornate wooden gable at the top of the roof. Staring down at a stricken She-Ra with a tired, if smug grin. “Helped Mermista get her magic back.” She gave She-Ra a thumbs up with both hands and then promptly passed out.

Within seconds Mermista had been able to collect enough water from the waterfall to create a rain storm, that she directed to fall squarely over the lower courtyards and snuff out all the fires at once.

The rain came down hard and fast, pelting Mystacor and soaking everyone in minutes. She-Ra held Catra close against her chest as she led her now drenched crowd of civilians towards Darla.

The steady roar of rain beating against steel, drummed in her ears for a few long minutes then went silent. Catra flicked her ears in irritation as she slowly came to. She felt the itchy warmth of a wool blanket wrapped far too tightly around her whole body. Blinking rapidly against the sharp pain of very bright lights, Catra groaned and turned her head to the side. Seeking to shield herself with the edge of the blanket that was curled around her head.

“Oh, Wild Cat!” Scorpia's relieved voice boomed next to her ear. “You were unconscious and soaked to the bone. So I took care of you, as per She-Ra's orders.” The scorpion kept rambling nervously, her voice high pitched and fueled by anxiety. Sluggishly Catra began to squirm and open her eyes, finding Scorpia was cradling her in a blanket against her ample chest. Holding her close and sighing with happy relief when she opened her eyes again.

“Ok, I'm good. Put me down.” Catra moaned, as Scorpia quickly complied. Setting her down on her feet. Catra stood before her, still wrapped very tight in the blanket. Resembling more of a grey, woolen caterpillar with pointed ears, then a magicat. With a disgruntled scowl on her face, she glared up at Scorpia.

Scorpia made a sweet, moaning sound. She sighed, her eyes bright with joy and approval, pinchers held together against her chest.

“If you say I'm cute, I will scratch you.” Catra groused, stubbornly hopping away as her feet would not budge and she was unable to extradite herself from the woolen bonds. Glancing around as much as she could, finding she had been brought back to Darla. No doubt by Adora, who wanted her tucked away someplace safe while she continued to save the world. Scorpia had wrapped her up in a blanket from the cargo hold and carried her up to the command deck, while she had been knocked out. Entrapta was at the control panels, every hand and every pony tail tapping away at the keypads. With a half dozen or more holographic screens surrounding her.

“She's hacking the planet again, isn't she.” Catra stated in a mild, matter of fact tone. Then promptly lost her patience at being bound. With an irritated growl, she unsheathed her claws and shredded the blanket in a few well aimed strikes. The tattered confines of wool folded off her body and fluttered to the floor. Finding to her surprise, that Scorpia had also wrapped up her sprained wrists in cloth. Her wrists were starting to swell slightly and she could feel the bruises, forming on the tender flesh of her arms.

“Yeah, she had to break through some really heavy encryption in the planetary Super Computer, to get Hordak and his brother's network inside. As far as I know, they are downloading themselves into all the mainframes right now. From the Sky Tree, they should be able to spread throughout the planet and take over every First Ones installation.” Scorpia stated, with a mild shrug repeating exactly what Entrapta had told her only a few minutes prior.

Catra stood mouth agape at how detailed Scorpia had paid attention to what Entrapta had explained to her earlier. Considering the last time, Entrapta had given them an overly complex speech about what she was doing. Scorpia was drawing stick figures holding hands instead of listening.

“Well, I better get back out there.” Catra chucked a thumb for the door, turning on her heel and heading out as swiftly as possible.

Leaving Scorpia startled and unable to stop her. Catra only made it a few feet down the corridor when the ship began to tremble and her stomach lurched into her throat. As Mystacor fell several more feet out of the sky. She heard Entrapta screech in fright. Then the power in the corridor dimmed momentarily. Catra groaned and turned and dashed back into the command deck. Scorpia was sitting on the captain’s chair, several holo screens hovering around her head. She tapped rhythmically on several holo buttons with her pinchers. Cursing under her breath when she accidentally closed several screens, she still needed to use.

“I don't know what I'm doing!” Scorpia hollered in terror at Entrapta.

“Just hit the sequence of numbers I give you!” Entrapta screamed back, “I need you to divert power from Darla's engines into Arxia's power cells. I need to configure the ship's crystals to vibrate at the same frequency as Arxia.”

“You want me to do what now?” Scorpia muttered weakly in confusion.

“First Ones tech is powered by magic crystals, they can resonate with each other and pass energy.” Entrapta sighed in exasperation.

Catra glanced at Scorpia, her face was incredibly pale and she was sweating profusely. Her dark blue eyes shot to Catra. Pleading with her to intercede, she was so overwhelmed and full of terror. She had zero confidence that she could pull this off. Her pinchers made her clumsy and unintentionally destructive for small tasks that needed precision and finesse.

Catra nodded and without thinking, merely hopped onto Scorpia's lap.

“I got this!” Catra shouted, raising her hands, claws extended, as she activated the engines, system screens. Her wrists felt stiff and sore but she ignored the pain.

Another deafening rumble vibrated from the depths of Mystacor. They watched in horror, out the main view screen as a massive crack rippled up the sides of the central bastions of the sorcerers citadel. Just before the island lost even more altitude. They were now hovering below the clouds, the rocky landscape of mountains and forests were clearly visible just beyond the main view screen.

“That's not good.” Scorpia breathed.

“Entrapa...ready...” Catra called, impatiently.

“I have to test the frequency stability first...gimme a sec. I need to know if Arxia's ancient thulite crystals can take the load from Darla. We don't want them blowing up! " Entrapta called back, the tendrils of her left ponytail typing like mad on a nearby screen.

“Well, yes, that is sorta a bad habit for you too.” Catra growled under her breath defensively. Not appreciating the reminder of her last screw up with the portal.

Scorpia's pinchers gripped the armrests of the command chair, her back rigid, cheeks flushing a bright crimson. As Catra wiggled her butt nervously in her lap, creating an arousing friction that was highly distracting. Catra's tail was lashing anxiously as she waited for her orders, the tip of her tail brushing lightly against Scorpia's nose and cheeks like soft caresses. Making the scorpion moan softly with both yearning and discomfort. Catra had no idea what she was doing to Scorpia, so worked up by the dire tasks that awaited her in a few moments.

“Ok, this is going to be risky...but Hordak needs a little more time.” Entrapta muttered, pulling several screens in front of her and pushing others to the side.

“If my math is correct...which it always is.” She kept affirming herself. “I need you to put these equations into the engine's output, then match the output in Arxia's engine core. I need to recreate a parallel resonance between, Darla series resonant frequency and Arxia's series resonant frequency.”

“Fine, fine....let's go!” Catra pushed, her eyes snapping in fright to the main view screen as Mystacor plummeted another half dozen feet towards the ground.

“Well, do I need to calculate these equations? Or do you know math?” Entrapta called, her voice inquiring anxiously.

“Yes, I know math!” Catra shouted back with rising impatience. “One of the benefits of being raised by a military operation run by an intergalactic tyrant-clone. Hordak made sure our math classes were pretty extensive, otherwise we would never be able to understand how to run, let alone fight with all his advanced tech.”

“Alright, your left screen's Darla, right is Arxia's engine core.” Entrapta, took a deep breath.

Catra huffed anxiously, as another holographic screen came alive beside Darla’s engine output screen.

“Darla series frequency...” Entrapta began tossing out linear equations.

Catra was quick to realize it was algebraic and needed to pull up a calculator on another screen. She had spent months on Darla and instead of being bored senseless, she and the rest of the Best Friend Squad had learned all the ship's systems. From navigation to the engines. She could even fly Darla manually if needs be.

“Arxia series frequency....” Entrapta spat out another series of equations. Catra began to type on the other screen.

“Got it.” Catra stated, in a clipped tone.

“Parallel frequency is over 100mhz....” Entrapta moaned. “Gotta work out any overtone variables...now.” She muttered.

Catra waited for a moment before Entrapta began to toss her more equations for both sets of crystals.

Catra's fingers danced over the screens, inputting the equations with a deft precision Scorpia could never do with her two sets of pinchers. She merely sat in awe, at Catra's unparalleled competency at whatever was thrown at her. Catra never backed down from any challenge, her mind was sharp and she could solve problems quickly. Scorpia's admiration for her only increased, as she watched her handle this crisis so effortlessly.

“The crystals have harmonized! They are now oscillating together!” Entrapta clapped the ends of her pony tails together excitedly as she jumped and turned to grin triumphantly at Catra and Scorpia.

“Go team...” Catra sagged against Scorpia, pinching the bridge of her nose. Her ears were buzzing from the high pitched vibrations coming from Darla. She now felt mentally and physically exhausted.

“Way to go!” Scorpia raised her pinchers in the air and whooped excitedly. “Super Pal Trio for the Win!” She declared in celebration.

Catra merely leaned against Scorpia's chest and heaved a great sigh, smiling faintly, as her tail curled languidly around her thighs. As the low hum from Darla was quickly echoed from deep inside Mystacor itself. Within seconds the island's engines came to life once more, glowing a brilliant red from the rocky underside of the island. A deafening hum filled the air as the island began to ascend back into the sky.

Chapter End Notes

Well, that was the first story arc. I hope you enjoyed it! Thank you all for your kudo's and comments. I shall start posting the next story soon.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!